I LOVE BEING AN UNDERPAID SERVICE INDUSTRY WORKER!

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/65510140.

Rating:	Explicit
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	M/M
Fandom:	崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)
Relationships:	Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice & Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Cipher & Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice & Polyxia (Honkai: Star Rail), Cipher & Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice & Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Anaxa & Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea & Cipher (Honkai: Star Rail)
Characters:	Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Castorice (Honkai: Star Rail), Cipher (Honkai: Star Rail), Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail), Anaxa (Honkai: Star Rail)
Additional Tags:	Past Rape/Non-con, NOT BETWEEN MYDEI AND PHAINON, Past Suicide Attempts, Suicidal Thoughts, Self-Harm, Past Child Abuse, Past Domestic Violence, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Drug Use, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Eventual Smut, Top Phainon/Bottom Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Top Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Bottom Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, Soft Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Soft Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Slow Burn, Developing Relationship, Mutual Pining, The Mortifying Ordeal of Being Known, Cyrene and Phainon are Siblings (Honkai: Star Rail)
Language:	English
Stats:	Published: 2025-05-12 Updated: 2026-03-10 Words: 155,142 Chapters: 13/?

I LOVE BEING AN UNDERPAID SERVICE INDUSTRY WORKER!

by icarian__carrion

Summary

> Introducing: Phainon! Our latest edition state-of-the-art customer support analyst! He doesn't tire! He doesn't complain! He doesn't feel pain! He doesn't bleed! He doesn't need anything! Use him! Abuse him! Aren't you tired of being on the other side of hell? Call now! 1-800-FLAMECHASE-INC

Phainon is an overworked call center operator. Mydei is the new hire.

Notes

This is my first Phaidei fic. If any characters are out of character, ah well-- I did my best to transcribe their struggles into a mundane modern setting. What if the flamechase journey was instead about being an underpaid, overworked worker abused by the system?

!IMPORTANT!

Phainon is dealing with the passing of his sister, Cyrene. He is very unwell, and very mentally ill. He is suicidal, and this fic will deal with the implications and reality of that. It is implied he drinks.

Mydei is a **rape survivor**. This fic will also deal with that. **This is not sexualized or fetishized or a kink; I want to explore the very real horror of sexual assault.** I cannot stress this enough. This is what the **"Past Rape/Non-con"** tag is referring to. It will be handled respectfully.

There is very light gore towards the end of the fic. Phainon has a vague flashback to Cyrene's death, and then a disturbing dream. It's not very explicit, but such images will be all throughout the fic.

Chapter 1: dolphinsamurai

FLAMECHASE INC. is Amphoreus' top outsourcing company, providing a top notch customer support experience to companies all across the country. Founded by Khaos Petridis in 2004, it has been the most well-rated company in Amphoreus for the past 20 years, boasting all sorts of awards and countless accolades. *'Excellent Customer Service 2018'* , *'Team Performance 2007'* , *'Operational Efficiency 2012'* , just to name a few. The work environment is friendly, productive and stimulates their workers' creativity. They are truly one big family, where no one is treated better than another. FLAMECHASE INC. prides themselves on equality, benevolence, and a above-industry-standard pay.

That is what it says on their website.

The reality of the truth, however, is that Phainon is chained to his desk, slaving nine hours per day answering calls to pay off for the loan he took out for his sister's funeral; and his failed pilot school stint, but that's besides the point. His breaks are scheduled, and if he needs to take a piss, the whole Google Teams chat must know. His current project is for a Belobogian company called DolphinSamurai, formerly two companies (*Dolphin*, specializing in vacuums roombas, hairdryers, steam mops and air purifiers, and *Samurai*, specializing in kitchen appliances) that have recently merged into one. What it means for him is that he has intimate knowledge of every gear and screw that goes into making a vacuum or an air-fryer, and that he spends the better half of his day teaching elderly people how to remove their vacuum's floor nozzle. What *that* usually leads to is him biting his knuckles trying not to cuss out a clearly dementia-addled grandma.

"Alright, ma'am, is there anything else I can help you with? Alright, in that case, thank you for choosing DolphinSamurai. If you want to take the survey, please don't hang up. Goodbye!" With unimaginable speed, Phainon takes off his headset and changes his status to *On Break* – it has been three hours since he's had his last cigarette, and his scheduled break is coming up. As the fog of an exhausting forty minute call with a confused elderly woman starts to clear up from his head, Phainon begins to register a faint buzzing sound next to him. When he turns to face it, he's reminded of his *very best number one kirakira love and peace desk neighbour work best friend*, as *she* likes to call herself. Cifera seems unbothered, not sitting at her desk but rather walking leisurely on a treadmill because of *course* she's the type of person with an under-desk treadmill. Phainon is still not sure how she convinced their department managers to let her get it. She's typing away at her computer with one hand, playing with a fidget spinner with the other, talking into her headset with a customer, all while sparing no glance to the computer screen and rather looking at her phone– Phainon knows that, most likely, she's watching the baby monitor installed into her house. Which is not used for any baby, mind you, but rather for her seven cats.

"This is Bartholos and this is Arson and this is Tax Evasion and this is Grand Larceny and this is Drug Trafficking and… " he remembers her trailing off on his first day as she showed her pictures of all of her cats– all rescues, some with special needs. The repeating motif amongst these pets is that they were all incomprehensibly ugly and incredibly fat.

"Why does Bartholos have a normal name?" he asked then, and Cipher made a face. *"My ex-wife got it for us. Bandaid baby. I took the kid in the divorce."*

Now, she's putting to work her best skill as a customer support analyst: bullshitting.

"Yes, ma'am, of course~ Say, I've heard some dogs barking in the background– do you have pets, hmm? Oh! Did you know that your Dolphin NC756 has a special motorized FurBegone accessory? Yes, yes, it's like an attachable floor nozzle *specifically* made to clean pet hair. Let me tell you, ma'am, I have seven cats and that thing is a *lifesaver!* Yeah? Yes! Of course I can order it for you, ma'am, let me just do that real quick~ And since you're such a *loyal customer* , how about I throw in a 10% discount for ya? That'll bring the total down to *29.99* Balance Coins. Alright… Boop! Aaand it's all ordered, ma'am! Your new accessory should be with you in two to three business days."

Phainon watches in awe as she finishes up the call. Her voice is feline and honeyed and *utterly shameless* . She lies like it's her mother tongue– Phainon knows, for a *fact* , that she does not have a FurBegone and that it is not a lifesaver. He knows those things break at the first gust of wind because they are made of very cheap plastic, and that they clog up like a motherfucker after two uses. And, most importantly–

"What do you mean, a 10% discount?"

Cipher looks at him with a knowing, shit-eating grin, like he's just waiting for him to stumble onto her scheme. He likes this game with her, so he plays.

"You know, a discount. For 10%."

"But you said that would bring the total down to 29.99."

"Cooooorrect!"

"But a FurBegone *costs* 29.99 at *full price* ."

Cipher grins, and puts her hands on her hips– proud. Phainon snickers at that, and leans back into his chair. He brings his hands to rest on his stomach, fingers intertwined. "You know, she can always go on the site and see the real price."

"She's a sixty-two year old grandma, she's not going to do that."

"It's going to break, like, right away."

"It sure is."

"Accessories aren't covered by the warranty."

"Nuh-uh."

"So when it breaks, she has to purchase a new one."

The woman winks at him, mischievous, and waves her hands like a magician would. *"Bingo~"* Phainon laughs, because how could he not? Some of the tension from his shoulder eases, and he sits up with a slap on his thighs. "Cigarette?" he asks, already digging through his pockets for his lighter. Cipher basically leaps to the occasion, grabbing her bag as she goes.

He is not sure how he has become so close to Cipher, but she has a way of getting under your skin– that, and spending 9 hours every day essentially shoulder to shoulder, has helped. She sees right through him, and that scares Phainon. The difference, however, between Cipher and any other person, is that she sees the rot and shrugs her shoulders. Makes a joke out of it. Teeters on the edge of a dangerous blade, close to breaking skin and spilling blood; she, however, wields that blade bravely. Grabs it by the sharp end and twists it further. She's ruthless, and relentless.

It was a Saturday night hazed in the after-glow of several hours of drinking– things do not go well when he drinks. It was only a few months after he started working at FLAMECHASE– a company team bonding event. Too much alcohol, too little water. He was in the office's kitchen, head in hands as he sat at the table, and the clock struck well past midnight. Cipher was leaning against the counter, watching him with careful eyes. He started lamenting about his sister, flame extinguished too soon, because all roads eventually lead back to Cyrene. She let him talk, until he mentioned having to work this miserable job to pay off her funeral, and how suicidal it's making him. At that point, Cipher raised a sharp brow and tutted her lips.

"Nobody made you bury her in a bed of pink flowers, dude. Ya kinda did that to yourself."

"She would've liked it."

*"**She** was dead on impact. She doesn't like much of anything anymore."*

He should've gotten mad and maybe slapped the make-up off of her face then, but he didn't– because she was right. A small revelation. He has no one else to blame. The grand, opulent funeral– it was for him. It was his apology to Cyrene, and one that fell on deaf cold ears. He knew, then, that Cipher could be trusted to give him exactly what he needed– acid.

So, they smoke together. Every break, on the benches in front of their office building, fifteen minutes every three hours. They usually go through at least two cigarettes, but more often than not it's three. They talk shit about their customers, about management, and Cipher shares funny and gross stories about her seven monsters. Every time he tries to press further into her own past, she pulls back gracefully. It's almost enviable. A friend, but more of a stranger. A comfortable kind of distance that Phainon can use to lash himself with. Humiliation looks good on him.

"You know, putting money in FLAMECHASE's pockets doesn't necessarily mean more money in *your* pockets. You don't need to lie to grandmas."

"Oh but Phainon, you *wound* me. You think I do this for profit? My dear boy, I am simply lying to grandmas for the love of the game." she smirks, sharp like all of her edges. Phainon is thoroughly entertained. "And, either way, HR takes notice." she winks, "Who knows, maybe I'll be promoted to Escalations one day."

“I’m sure you will, Cipher, and then you’ll have even more bargaining power against women with Alzheimer’s.” She throws her head back and cackles, then recoils back to take a greedy pull out of her cigarette. A car pulls in near them, and her eyes instantly shoot towards the source of the sound.

Castorice steps out from a white Honda, a slight and shy girl. Beautiful like a butterfly, though in a way that resonates a quiet sort of strength. Her long floral-patterned summer dress swishes behind her as she closes the car’s door; she looks troubled. Her eyebrows are knitted together tight. Wordlessly, she sits next to Phainon on the bench and digs through her braided bag for her e-cigarette. Phainon open his mouth to greet her, but Cipher is quicker.

“Now there you are, Princess Homebody~” she calls out, turning to look at Castorice from where she’s standing up in front of Phainon. “You’re three hours late, miss. That’s unlike you.” Castorice sighs, and rubs her forehead. Her shoulders are stiff. “My sister’s carer had an emergency, so I had to stay with her for a bit more. I talked to management, I’ll make up for the lost hours.” Phainon knows that means working for twelve hours in one day. Gently, he grabs her hand, a subtle motion. Gives it a small squeeze.

“How is she?” he asks, and his voice is soft. He can practically hear Cipher checking out of the conversation now that it took a serious turn. In his peripheral, he sees her turn around and pull out her phone.

“She’s, well– She’s…” Castorice struggles to find words, and settles for sighing and leaning back against the bench. “We’re trying to keep her comfortable. It, uh, won’t be long now. Maybe a few months? I don’t know. She’s starting to, you know, have difficulty, uh. Breathing.”

Phainon nods slowly. Castorice’s sister has amyotrophic lateral scoliosis. It hit her out of nowhere, and it hit her hard. Going from two paychecks to one has taken its toll on Castorice, so she works part-time night shifts as well to support their living expenses. He gives her a moment of silence, not saying anything (*what is there to say?*) but also not moving his hand from hers. A quiet support, grounding. Castorice takes a drag out her e-cigarette and moves her face upward to face the sky– she stays like that for a bit, looking at the birds flying overhead, thinking. After a moment, she closes her eyes, takes a deep breath, and looks at Phainon.

“I spoke with Tribios.” she starts, and Phainon does not like her tone; it’s inquisitive, expectant.

“Right.”

“When her mother died, she went to a grief recovery support group.” *There it is*. Phainon’s face twists despite his best efforts. “I want to go when Polyxia passes away.”

Phainon nods absent-mindedly, and tries to pretend like he doesn’t know what she’s asking of him. “That sounds great, Castorice.”

She frowns a bit, barely perceptible. “I want you to come with me.”

Phainon presses on with his act, and laughs. He retreats his hand from hers– this does not go unnoticed by Casotrice. Her frown deepens. “Why? As your like, support buddy?”

Her face softens, and she presses closer to him. Now, *she’s* holding *his* hands. Her touch is feather-light and gentle, the way everything about her tends to be. Quiet support. Something that borders too closely on pity; it’s bitter in his mouth. Castorice’s voice drops to a whisper. “I mean for you, Phainon. For your sister.” Phainon squirms in his seat, and puts some distance between the two. He can feel his heart tightening in his chest. He laughs again, and this time it sounds very nervous. “Nah, nah, I’m good. I’m dealing with it well.”

”No the fuck you’re not!” Cipher says all of a sudden, because of course she’s been listening in. She is damn near omniscient. “You’re dealing with it like shit.”

“Cipher, please…” Castorice chastises, and gives Phainon a small timid smile. “Look, you think about it, okay? Really, I’m serious, give it some thought. You have time.” She looks hopeful in a way that makes Phainon want to scream; *there is no hope here* .

“Okay,” he says, because he can’t say *no* to Castorice when she looks so kind and so worried. “I’ll think about it.” She smiles at that, wide and bright, pearly teeth and all. She’s too good for this job; too good for him. Wasted niceties.

He *will* think about it, that is not a lie. What he doesn’t tell Castorice is that he already made up his mind. It’s not for him.

They spend the last five minutes of their break with more leisurely talks. As always, it turns into a gigglefest over Cipher’s phone as they watch videos of her cats being funny or stupid or mischievous. When it’s time to go back to work, Castorice looks to be in a significantly better mood. She is his work neighbor too, in a way– her desk is directly behind his, so they’re back to back. Sometimes she taps his shoulder so he can help her with a procedure. Other times, he taps on *her* shoulder and makes funny faces at her so she’ll laugh.

The next two and a half hours pass by a lot smoother than the first three did. Most of the calls are quick and boring– product registration, questions about the warranty, and common fixes. He teaches people how to remove their vacuum’s floor nozzle, how to empty it’s dust cups, what the lights on the motor mean. He orders replacements for steam mops, air-fryers, and toaster grills. Nobody yells at him.

His last call comes in eight minutes before his lunch break. Phainon picks up the call, does his introduction, and waits for the customer to state their grievance, but is met with nothing. There is silence and heavy breathing for ten seconds, and Phainon starts to think it’s a buttdial. “Hello?” he tries.

“Uh, yeah, sorry, I…” a man, probably in his fifties, starts talking. “I cut myself on one of your electric woodfire grills.” Phainon can’t help but smile a little– this is perfect, because *this* case reads **“None Of My Business”** in bold letters. *This* is a case for Tribios or Cerydra or whatever unlucky motherfucker over at Escalations takes up the call. “Alright, sir, I’m very sorry to hear that. Unfortunately, since I’m just a call center agent, I am not allowed to deal with this situation, so I’m going to send it forward to one of my higher-ups at

Escalations. However, to speed things up, we can go ahead and start a video call so I can get a picture of your injury in case you need to press a claim."

FLAMECHASE offers a video call option for customer support purposes– using a third party app, Phainon sends a text message with a link to the customer's phone. When he accesses it, he will be able to see through the phone's camera; just like FaceTime. Phainon leans back and waits, Snipping Tool at the ready to take a screenshot of the injury.

The camera turns on. He is not sure what he expected– a scrape, maybe a surface scratch. What he sees, instead, is a deep red gash across a man's palm– half an inch, maybe an inch deep, cutting across the entire surface of his hand. It still gushes blood, red, terrible. He gasps, and seizes still in his chair. A brief image: his car beeping, his chest crushed between the seat and the airbag, a wound across a girl's forehead. He does not recognize her. Blood trickles like spoiled honey down her beautiful face. Her eyes are blue, perfectly crystalline, and unseeing. He knows those eyes from somewhere, maybe from his own face. Maybe from his mother's. She does not answer when he calls for her.

Phainon starts to sweat. His fingernails dig into his office chair. His clothes are too tight for him. It is entirely way too warm in this room. A fan buzzes somewhere in the back of his mind. He thinks his eyes might pop out of his head why is it so hot here oh god he's still bleeding. His heart threatens to beat out of his chest and impale itself on his monitor. Is he crying? He feels a warmth on his face, under his eyes. Someone is speaking to him from his headset. He calls her name, softly under his breath, but she does not answer. She broke all of her teeth on the dashboard.

Cipher takes notice of the scene next to her, her attention piqued as she was just finishing up the call. She steals a glance at his monitor where the man is still showing his wounded hand, then at Phainon's unmoving face, teeth clenched, eyes big with horror. She cringes, entirely way too violent of a spectacle for her, and puts down her headset. *"Escalations!"* she calls out in the office, "We need Escalations, quickly! It's an, uhhhhh, claims situation. Some guy hurt himself."

He's breathing hard. There are hands on his shoulder, firm and strong. "Come on, Snowy, get'a hold of yourself," Cipher says somewhere above him. Tribios from Escalations, his team leader, swoops in with dexterity and urgency. Wordlessly, he's maneuvered off of the chair as she sits down and takes over the call. Castorice, mid-procedure, has noticed; she's turned around on her seat. *"Is he okay?"* she mouths to Cipher, and Cipher just shakes her head. He's sitting up now. His knees are weak. He's going to throw up. Tribios is finishing up the call, and it took all of two minutes. She's taken the picture, written the ticket, and has promised she will personally forward the case to DolphinSamurai's management and their legal team. She closes the call. Disconnects his computer from the system. She turns to look at him.

"You should go home, Phainon." He does not like the way she said it. Like he's small. Like there's something wrong with him.

"I can't– um," he starts, and his words choke in his throat. A moment. "I still have three hours left."

“You can go home,” she repeats, firm. She is judging him, certainly. He wants to scream at her.

“Yeah, bud, you really should, I mean– you *totally* freaked ou–” a stern gaze from Tribios is enough to silence Cipher, and for once she seems to retreat and look ashamed.

“I can’t– I don’t want to make up for it, I…” He cannot spend twelve hours in this place. He will kill himself. He will shoot his brains out in front of the building and his brains will spell *FLAMECHASE* on the sidewalk.

“You won’t.” Tribios touches his arm. “I’ll speak to management for you. You won’t.”

She’s already handing him his jacket. He looks to Cipher, lost. She shrugs, grins, and makes a *’shoo’* motion with her hands. Behind him, Castorice is still in the middle of a call– but she spares him a glance full of pity.

It’s always *pity* with these people. He clenches his jaw. Grits his teeth so hard he thinks they might shatter *justlikehers* . A gummy smile flashes in his mind. She was all that was good in the world and what’s even left I mean is it just this? Is it just this until he dies? His feet are moving without him willing them to. He is out of the building, cold summer wind in his face. He does not feel his fingertips. Static under his skin. He thinks the world might be spinning around him, and he’s at risk of being thrown off of its axis. Somewhere along the way, Tribios has called him an Uber. He gets in, wordlessly, and the driver does not ask where he’s going. She knows his home address from HR.

It does not feel real. Life after Cyrene. A half-formed dream, maybe. An aborted fetus. He gets home. It is the same little apartment it’s always been. They rented it together. Rent is bearable still, even with Cyrene’s paycheck gone. The apartment is a piece of shit anyways, in a dilapidated little neighborhood at the edge of the city. The landlord practically begged them to rent it, and it felt like it was free of cost when she was around– it was never about sharing rent, however. They have never been apart, not since he was born. Older sisters; grains of sand on the beach. Too many to count. Too few words to speak. Her immensity can not be matched. There will be no poems. He leaves his key on the table, next to a bottle of water that he has not moved in eight months– her gloss, pink and glittery, is still on it.

He moves through the small hallway, and makes a mental note to get cockroach repellent– the thought stops him in his tracks. He slumps against the wall, runs a hand through his hair, and lets out a wheeze. He laughs, bitter, chortled. Your sister is dead and you need cockroach repellent.

Phainon passes over his bedroom, into the next room over. It’s her room. With shaky hands, he turns the doorknob and opens it. It is utterly untouched, and has been for eight months. He hasn’t even vacuumed. Thick dust gathers on every surface like a wedding veil, painting the room hazy and grey. Her bed is still unmade, purple flowery duvet thrown aside in a rush. A pile of clothes rests by her closet; she did not know what to wear that day. She must’ve picked something nice, nonetheless. Something feminine and flirty, probably, because she liked to get the attention of cute girls. Phainon doesn’t remember.

He dares not enter her room. It is far too sacred for him. His feet stay planted on the threshold, and he looks– for a minute, for two, then for six, ten…

Every time he enters her bedroom, he is expectant. Hopeful. As if he will open the door one day and see her bundled up under her covers, tapping on her phone. Sometimes, he would walk in on her practicing her dance moves. There are countless posters of Robin on every wall. She had such big dreams. She was going to make it out– be somebody. Somebody more than this. More than him; better than him. A singer, an idol, somebody loved and adored the way she deserved to be. She had a modelling contract to sign the next week. Her big break.

It's funny how those things work.

He does not know how long he stays in her room, but by the time Phainon retreats into his own bedroom, the sun is setting. He does not eat; he never really eats anymore, only to stay off the hunger. Sleep takes him as soon as he lays his head on his pillow. He does not remember a time before the tiredness.

Like every night, he dreams of Cyrene. Her pallid face framed by carnations, eyes white and milky like the bottom of a sink. She goes to speak, but chokes on blood. It spills out of her like bile, red and sticky. Her mouth is rows upon rows of black splinters, viscous, viscera. She smiles, wide and gummy, and stretches out her arms like she did when they were younger; when he used to jump in her arms and she would spin him around. *"Nini~"* she calls to him, but she has the voice of screeching hawks and bellowing alligators. She beckons to him, open, naked on the embalmer's table. She looks cruel. Phainon runs up to her and goes to hit her.

The dream always ends there. He wakes up clammy.

Your sister is dead, and it's a new day.

Chapter 2: four and a half months

Chapter Notes

!!IMPORTANT!!

The first half of this fic has a big suicide TW. Phainon has a big suicidal breakdown and has very explicit suicidal fantasies. If you wish to skip it, it starts with **"He is so ashamed. He is so so little and so so very ashamed."** and ends with **"On the fringes of his consciousness, somewhere boundlessly far away from him, a conversation unfolds, ignorant of his own presence in the room."**

Please keep in mind that the above is only for the explicit suicidal fantasy. He continues being suicidal for several paragraphs and, yeah, as I've said in the previous chapter, this fic is going to deal with his suicidal ideation heavily.

Big shoutout to my bestie kind-of-beta reader kind-of-editor Gael who listens to me infodump about HSR and Phaidei and Castorice despite knowing nothing about any of this shit. They actually wrote the last part of the fic, the one with little Cyrene, and I added onto it to make it fit the scene.

▶ Their original scene.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon uses the rest of his paid sick days, all three of them, to stay home after the incident. The hours of the first day blur into each other, melting like candle wax under a flame. There is nowhere to go. He stays in bed for thirteen hours, scrolling on Tiktok. It's mostly animals. Some new workout plans that he bookmarks for later. The occasional anime edit. He goes to the bathroom once, and only because he absolutely needs it. He does not eat. He sleeps the other eleven hours, but in bouts and fits of unconsciousness– never restful.

Cyrene haunts every corner of the apartment. He would be laying under the covers, feeling as if his bones have turned to iron, the sound of cars speeding outside his bedroom lulling him to sleep; and just as he is about to pass into unconsciousness, he hears her laugh down the hallway. Other times, he catches a flash of pink in the corner of his eyes, swift as a will-o'-wisp. The smell of her perfume, cotton-candy sweet, is so deeply ingrained into his nostrils that he doesn't think he's smelled anything else since her funeral.

She comes to him in her white burial dress, sometimes. Rarely. Silent in the dark corners of his room. Toothless, a finger raised up in accusation.

Phainon opens up their text messages. Reads through them, rushing through the barrage of "I miss you"s and "I wish you were here"s of the past eight months. He goes back to the time where she had a voice;

get milk when you come home

look at the girl i matched with

Attachment.jpg

isn't she so cute?

bet ur jealous lol

[a tiktok of a bunny bothering a big dog]

us lol

ur the bunny tho

takeout?

ughhh work is killing me

then i have the audition

(╥﹏╥)

He scrolls lower down their messages, to the day before the accident.

im so excited for christmas ☆(≧▽≦)☆

🎅 🎄 🎁

cant wait for you to get your present ur gonna love it

I FINALLY GET TO BE PASSENGER PRINCESS AGAIN

taking the subway makes me lose braincells

What else is there to say? She has always been the prophetic kind– intuitive, damn near an empath. Always knew what to say, how to say it, her hands gentle on the top of his head– a redemption of some kind when he cried in her lap, when the world was too loud or too mean, like a priest absolving him of his sins. He sought out her reassurance, her validation; she gave them out like they were free. Like he was worthy of it.

Who can forgive his sins now?

Phainon thinks he should delete their chat history; it's been eight months, and it's not healthy to keep texting her like that. What Phainon does instead is start typing.

hi. i'm thinking about you today. i'm always thinking about you. i miss you.

you left a big hole cyrene. i don't know how to fill it. i don't know how to move on or like. start living again

it's like we both died. it's like i died idk. so many times. it's like i keep dying every time i wake up and you're not here

i keep looking at your selfies. you were so beautiful.

you were like the sun. like you gave warmth to everyone around you. everybody stopped and looked when you walked into a room. you just had this gravitational pull.

it's like you were a planet, and i was your moon. always orbiting you. i loved being in your shadow. i wish i could still be in your shadow. because that would mean you're still here

we buried you with your roots growing in. you would've hated that. i tried to tell them you would've hated it but they said it could make your hair fall out if they bleached it

fuck i should've just done it myself or smth

you were the most beautiful girl at your funeral btw. nobody could outshine you

i just. idk

i miss you

i love you. i'm sorry.

Phainon is about to put his phone down when, on the other end of the conversation, a typing bubble pops up.

Cyrene 💖🎵 is typing…

For the first time in seven hours, Phainon sits up– fully alert, focused, clear-headed. It's foolish. He *saw* her dead, has thrown the first fistful of dirt on her coffin. He has made all the arrangements. Spent all the money– and it was a lot of fucking money.

And yet. Maybe. *Maybe* . From beyond the grave, or maybe– it wasn't Cyrene. It was a doppelganger, an impostor. Some grand conspiracy to replace his sister, and now she's back from whatever hole she's lived in for eight months.

The bubble appears and disappears over the course of the most gut-wrenching thirty-five seconds of Phainon's life. Then, a message pops up.

This is a little awkward. I'm really sorry for your loss but somebody else has this number now.

Phainon stares at the message as if *it* is the one that killed Cyrene. He is angry– why is he angry? How dare they. It's her number. It's hers. She left so few things behind, infinitely unremarkable in things of material remembrance besides clothes and pictures. All he has are memories, a closet full of pink, and an old water bottle. They're gonna take this from her, too?

i hope you get into a car crash and die like actually. i hope your brains pour out of your head like mac'n'cheese. i hope–

Phainon stops typing, closes his eyes and takes a deep breath. In through your nose, out through your mouth, or however that breathing exercise Cipher taught him went. He hits backspace on the text, and holds the phone in his hands for a moment, cradling it as if it was a small, wounded bird. The person on the other end is still typing, doubtless more platitudes and condolences and *pity* always the fucking pity.

He blocks them instead, denies them the satisfaction of a good deed done to a poor miserable man. He locks his phone and throws it across the room. Phainon hears a tiny shatter from the direction where it landed, akin to a small dying child's wail, but he ignores it. He turns around in bed, heavy like a heart disease, and lays down facing the sterile white wall yellowed by nicotine.

She's in his dreams again, standing on a sharp rock at the edge of the sea. The waters are tempestuous, wrathful, crashing onto her back like a lashing. Through it all, she stands still, unmoved by the storm. The sky is gloomy and the sea is black, murky. Sleek, horrible creatures unlike any other on this earth scurry underneath the surface, their skin oily and their scales glittering like jewels. Their teeth are the size of his arm, as thin and sharp as Quincke needles. Their eyes glow like red-hot suns, and they are many times bigger than blue whales. Cyrene opens her arms– this is how it always goes, in his dreams. The invitation. It seems like she is saying " *Come by my side. Come to me. Join me. Let us swim together. Come to me."* Her cruel sterile smile like a dentist's office, pink tongue gushing in a bed of red blood– she has her teeth in this dream. Phainon is scared, so he does not move. In an instant, her clear eyes turn hazy-gray, reflecting the gloomy clouds above. A gust of wind blows past them, and it sounds like the howl of hungry wolves, twisted in this landscape to a high and guttural banshee's scream. She reaches into her mouth. Grasps one of her teeth, and starts pulling. Swanlike and graceful, she plucks them all one by one with all the ease of picking daisies. Her mouth overflows with petroleum, an infernal miscarriage staining her white dress. She presents them to him, face twisted into an elated grimace, and then drops them at his feet– droplets of pearl, twinkling as they fall, rattling beneath his frozen body.

This is when he goes to hit her, and that is always when the dream ends. It always ends right before his fist connects with her jaw. Phainon does not know why he always wants to hurt her in his dreams.

He's awoken by a heavy soft weight being dropped on him. Bleary from sleep, he comes to with a groan and starts trying to blink himself backing into seeing. He hears a low, comfortable rumble next to his head, and then a much heavier weight sitting on his bed. He

sits up on his elbows. A shapely figure clad in black, gray-haired– and for a second he thinks it's the Grim Reaper coming to finally take him.

"Come on, pretty boy, rise and shine~"

He recognizes that voice, feline and loud and bordering on manic. One last blink, he rubs his eyes, and then looks again. Oh. It's Cifera. Of course it's her.

"Cipher, what did you put on me? A tank?"

The rumble grows louder, until it is right next to his face.

Meow~

Phainon turns to look, and he's suddenly face to face with– well, it's kind of like a tank. If a tank was a ten kilogram English Shorthair cat with stubby legs. Its so fucking ugly. The cat is happily bumping its big dumb head against Phainon's hand. The horror must be easy to read on his face, because Cipher breaks into laughter. "Surprise~!"

"Fuckin' *Bartholos* , Cipher? You brought me your ugly ass cat?"

More giggles from Cifera, who's so tickled she's turning pink. "C'mon, man, I thought he could keep you company for a bit! You always get all out of sorts when you're alone, which is, err… Like all the time? You're welcome, by the way. He was a gift from my ex-wife."

Bartholos rolls over on his back, showing off his massive belly. Phainon simply has no choice but to pet it. Fuck. The fucker's really soft, and he's instantly in a better mood, and he hates to prove Cipher right.

"I don't have–"

"You don't *need* anything. I got you his food, and his bowls, and his litterbox *and* his litter. Little Cifera thought of everything."

"Dude, I can't have pets in the apartment. The landlord was really strict about it."

"You can't have pets that the landlord *knows of* . I can't *have pets* either, and I got seven of them!"

"What if he does a surprise visit, huh? What then? He's gonna send Bartholos to the glue factory."

"Right, and when's the last time a surprise visit happened?"

"Well–"

"Yeah. Never. Nobody's gonna check up on this dump, and speaking of dumps– You have guests, by the way. "

“You and Bartholos don’t really count as gue–” Phainon is struck dumb when his gaze shifts towards the door frame, and Castorice is standing there looking content and amused. Her hair is braided and she’s smiling warm, as if she’s infinitely endeared. Phainon is *horrified* . And shirtless. He immediately grabs the blanket and brings it up to his neck.

”Castorice!”

“Good morning, Phainon. I came with Cipher.”

If looks could kill, Cipher would be dead right now with the visual daggers he’s shooting at her– not that it would matter, since he’s pretty sure she has about six lives left. She’s so damn pleased with herself, and Phainon wants to strangle her. The place is *filthy* . He doesn’t remember the last time he’s vacuumed, or washed the dishes. It’s crawling with roaches. And that’s all *fine* when Cipher comes by, because they’re both self-destructive messes spiraling towards an early grave, probably by way of liver failure or suicide. They smoke weed and play video games together on their days off and when they get drunk they play *count all the bugs in the kitchen* and *list all the creative ways to kill yourself* .

(His personal favorite is taking two fistfuls of sleeping pills, grabbing his blanket and his pillow, and falling asleep on some train tracks. But that’s besides the point.)

Castorice is a different breed from them. She’s the good kind, the kind with potential. She has two jobs and dreams of a mortician’s apprenticeship, for fuck’s sake, she’s got a *future* . And she’s a good friend. A really, really good friend– and he’s a really, really bad one already. She doesn’t *need* to know he’s a dirty bum on top of it all. All he touches turns grimy and nasty. She cannot be one of those things.

“Don’t look at her like that,” Castorice adds with a chuckle, stepping into his room and *shit* she’s not wearing shoes. He cringes– she’s gonna get her pretty white socks all dirty. Phainon is so red he looks like a traffic light, and he contemplates hiding in the bathroom and not coming out. “It was my idea. She mentioned wanting to come by to help you clean up, and I offered.”

Phainon looks between the two of them, struck dumb. He plays with the frayed edges of his blanket. A fat cockroach climbs lazily up the wall behind him. “Clean up?”

“Yeah, man. Clean up.” Cipher makes a broad gesture with her arms, as if showing off the entire room. “These aren’t *safe living conditions* .”

The shame spreads through his chest like a viral infection, clawing up in his throat and coming out of his eyes. It is dirty. It’s miserable. It’s incredibly unhealthy and it’s unsafe. He *has* been getting sick more often.

But he can’t. He just *can’t* . He used to *love* cleaning, to Cyrene’s endless appreciation. He used to make a whole day out of it, starting with the floors and then the counters and then the windows. He was the type of person that cleaned door frames and went in between the radiator and the wall. He would put on old music on the speakers and pick up his vacuum and just. *Clean* . For several hours a day, while Cyrene cooked. Sometimes, if she was done before he was, she’d come over to bother him while he was perched up on a chair wiping

down the windows. She would poke at his ribs or pinch his stomach. Sometimes she would just stand in front of him and do a silly dance, trying to make him laugh. One time she accidentally bumped into him, and he fell and twisted his ankle– she made up for that for a month, taking on his dust-wiping duties. He doesn't think he's ever seen a bug in this apartment before Cyrene died.

She passed away, and somehow, *he's* the cadaver while she lives on in small fragments of recollection. Forever encased in pink amber.

"Phainon," Castorice's gentle voice cuts in. As he's violently pulled away from tending to his garden of memories, he looks towards the sound and finds her sitting on his desk chair. "Please don't cry."

Castorice scoots closer with the chair, and he sees her hand moving towards him and– *fuck* , he *is* crying. Phainon goes to touch his cheek and finds it moist. She reaches to touch his shoulder, but he is faster on the draw; he pulls away quickly, as if he were a man burned. As if her touch could kill– or worse, heal.

He is so ashamed. He is so so little and so so very ashamed. Not the fun type of shame, like when Cipher teases him or when Anaxa used to chastise him during training for laughing too hard with Castorice; not the boyish, charming kind of shame, the sort that makes you go *'awww shucks, what a little guy'* . It's the bad kind. The very bad kind. The kind that has pressed on his chest in matters big and small for the past eight months. The kind that makes him go on the building's rooftop and stand at the very edge, looking down, getting dizzy and drowsy and drunk on the view. Shame so unbearable that it sends him out of the door and into the liquor store, asking for their strongest shit and mixing it with his pain meds. It's the kind of shame that finds him waking up in a puddle of his own vomit after a bender, alone, desolate, with not even the excuse of a crazy party night to save him. The kind that knocks on the door and doesn't wait for an answer. Invasive like the roach nymphs on his cutlery. Violating every boundary he's ever been brave enough to put down. Vivisection of his dignity, without anesthetic, probing at his insides to see just how much a man can be humiliated before he just says *fuck it* and kills himself.

And yeah. Yeah. It's kind of like that now, and Phainon is so ashamed and so *angry* that he can feel his head shaking. His vision goes partially blurry– all he sees is the very upset, and very concerned, look on Castorice's face. Cipher looks unfazed and *yeah he would really like to faze her right about now* . There's a beer bottle somewhere under his bed and if he's quick enough, he could get to it. Smash it on the wall and cut across his arm, right down his wrist, splitting it in two like a beautiful flower blooming, reopening the old scar. His blood would spray everywhere, wicked confetti of the body, and maybe some would get on Cifera's smug fucking face; get all into her mouth so she can taste the price of her " *kindness"* . The smell of iron would fill the room with all the delicacy of the finest miasma, and it would be so pungent and disgusting that they would both be smelling nickels for days after. He would love to wipe that sweet little look off of Castorice's face, the one that says *"Oh my God look at me I'm such a good person! I'm so nice and sweet all the time and everytime I shit butterflies come out! Did I tell you guys I'm just so gosh darn concerned, I'm just really concerned Phainon I'm so worried I just want the best for you!"* He would love to reach his dying arm, devoid of feeling and numb to pain, and just smear her pretty face with his gore.

It probably wouldn't be enough to kill him, but it would be enough to *teach them a lesson:*

Arrête! C'est ici l'empire de la mort!

Phainon would lay down his life as the last swansong of his pride– singing, *if I go, I go by my own terms . And fuck you both .*

On the fringes of his consciousness, somewhere boundlessly far away from him, a conversation unfolds, ignorant of his own presence in the room.

"I told you we should've called before we came."

"And I told you, Cas, that we can't do that. Because if we did, he's the type of person to just say 'Oh guys don't worry, I'm fine, don't bother' and then go hit up some pub and drink 'till he passes out. Don't fucking tell me how to handle him."

"Why do you even have the keys to his house, that's weird–"

"I just can't take it anymore." and his voice comes out smaller than intended, pathetic in the way whiny bitches like him tend to be. Cipher and Castorice's little argument dies down, and they both turn to find him on his back, splayed boneless on the bed. His hands are fists, covering his eyes, and his throat constricts around a stinging hornet's nest. He is crying riverfuls down his face, a waste of water that he cannot afford considering he has not consumed anything in close to thirteen hours, and his chest feels heavy– a heaving creaking of his ribs. Breathing feels impossible. The exchange of oxygen becomes a toil that he is ill-equipped to perform, a broken ox dragging a dead body across a field. Stretching moments of time, trying to find meaning in the labour and coming up empty-handed. An ugly mule beaten one too many times, and now finally collapsed. Air gets stuck into his trachea and hurdles out like vomit, coming out in broken sobs and quivering gasps. "I just– I can't, I can't take it anymore. It's just too much, it's *too much* . I just, I want to die, Cipher, I just really want to die. Please, just–"

Castorice moves first, and she is well and truly *shaken* , as if she's never had the pleasure of seeing a suicidal man have a nervous breakdown. She moves towards him with both of her arms open, but Cipher stops her. Pushes her away gently, without any malice. This is uncharacteristic of her, who's made of all sharp edges. Wordlessly, she reassures Castorice with just one look: *"I got this. I know this."* Castorice backs down, and gives Cipher her space.

She gets all in his personal space, sitting on his legs. She grabs his arms and tears them away from his face, bearing his ugliness for all the world to see. Cifera then crosses them on his chest, a pharaoh in a sarcophagus, and puts all of her weight on them, pressing down on his ribcage. Confusion sets in first, then follows a weird sense of relief, as if being crushed is helping him. His face is accusatory, but not unkind– more like a wounded animal looking in fear at his rescuers. His primal reptilian brain identifies Cipher as an enemy that's got him all caged in, and he is too scared to move. He expects the pain. It never comes.

"I need you to calm down, Phainon," she starts, and her voice is even; it lacks its distinct feline drawl, its playfulness and its teasing. "Phainon, do you understand? You need to calm

down. You need to take deep breaths and I'm not– don't look at me like that. I'm not fucking around. Breathe, like actually *breathe* ."

And then just something *clicks* in the back of his head. *"Okay,"* is all he manages to say, and then Cipher starts to lead him through breathing. Deep breaths, and it's hard at first, like his lungs have closed shop for the day. "I can't–" Cipher shakes her head, stubborn little cat, and she presses down harder on him. "You have to. Come on."

It takes a while. It takes a while, but it *works* . With Cipher guiding him, Phainon finds the entrance of airflow back into his lungs. With it, he feels a metaphorical weight being lifted and, at the same time, he feels heavier too. Like he's sinking into the bed, and it feels a thousandfold softer beneath him. The post-breakdown comfort sets in, stinging like a shot of vodka.

It's kind of embarrassing, but hey, what's a little cherry on the shitcake that's Phainon's life? When he looks at Castorice, she's fully turned around from the scene and dragging her hands down her face, as if this is physically painful for her. Cipher lets go of him, but the weight is immediately replaced by Bartholos. He makes a little nest on his belly, and presses all ten kilograms on his bladder. Phainon sits up with a low groan. *"Fuck* , I need to– I'm going to the bathroom." He picks up the cat and sets it aside, scurrying out of the room. He's pretty sure a cockroach follows him like a loyal dog.

He takes a good gander at himself in the mirror after pissing– and it's been, fuck, maybe ten hours? Closer to eleven, probably. At least part of that mental breakdown must've been because his bladder was so full it was one Corona away from rupturing. But he looks in the mirror. Really looks. The dark purple bags under his eyes dig ravines across his face, aging him tenfold. When did he start looking this old? His nose is flushed pink, his cheeks swollen, and his dark eyelashes are heavy with tears. Hey, all in all, he looks kind of good. A little pretty, like dying Victorian women. Tuberculosis would look good on him. Yeah. No, this is fine. It's okay. He can joke his way out of it– and to show both of them how okay he is, he's going to wash his face *and* his teeth. In one sitting! This is practically unheard of. If he's feeling a little bold, he might even take a shower, and– yeah, no. That's pushing it.

Phainon prepares his best boyish smile and his repertoire of casual jokes. It's fine. He's basically got this all figured out and if he plays his cards well, he'll have both of these women out of his house in twenty minutes. He clears his throat as he grabs the doorknob to his bedroom and, when he enters with just the *perfect* amount of flair, he is beaming from ear to ear. "Wow, well, that was– certainly something, huh, ladies?"

Castorice looks like she's been through hell and back. Phainon has never seen a grown woman look so much like a wet, miserable cat. When her eyes trace upwards to gaze at him, there are small tears gathering at their corners and– ah, fuck, he made Castorice cry. That should be a capital punishment crime. Firing squad, most likely. Cipher is fussing over one of his pillows, and Bartholos is lazily pawing at a wrapper on the floor. "Yeah, no, that won't work, Phainon. Sit down."

He sits.

“Phainon, I need you to listen to me very closely, okay? Actually listen to me,” and she’s got that voice, the one she uses when she thinks she’s better and wiser than him, like she’s in *any* position to be lecturing him. If he wasn’t utterly mentally exhausted, he would be angry. Instead, he lets her have this. Maybe she needs to act holier-than-thou to actually feel *good* about herself right now. “Today is my day off. So is tomorrow, yeah? Castorice–” and she points at her for emphasis, “Used *two* of her days off. Like she took them off, and she doesn’t have many left. And you know, Phainon, she could be at home with her sister, who’s *dying* by the way. But she’s here. With you. And before you get all guilty, because I know you *loooove* going to that place, she wants to be here. She has chosen *this* –” another broad gesture at everything around them, “Over anything else. Chose *you* . Like, on purpose. She did that on purpose. And so did I. I woke up today and I fed my cats and I put Bartholos in a carrier and I *chose* to come here to *you* . Talking about Bartholos, by the way, I have been contemplating for the past *four* – count ‘em, one two three *four days* whether I should drop him off or not. Okay? I’m giving you my pet. My first cat. At least for the time being. You know why? Because I think you need a little something around the house, and because I trust you to take care of him.”

He feels like a stupid child. Phainon hangs his head, and his hands come to cradle through his hair as Cipher speaks. She’s so much like Cyrene sometimes– Castorice is too. Her voice, small and a little broken, is the next to speak up. “She’s right, Phainon. I really want to be here right now. Seriously, I don’t want to be anywhere else. We’ve been talking about this for a while now, you know, about cleaning up. Um. We know it’s really hard, and I don’t– I’m not judging you, Phainon. I’m not gonna judge you for… not feeling well.”

Oh, poor little Castorice, she doesn’t even know *half* of it. He’s tired. He’s too tired to be vindictive, but the seeds of it *are there* . They are there, and that matters. *Not feeling well* my ass. Phainon wants to splatter on the pavement below in one last bout of suicidal splendor. The final glorious Jackson Pollock. A suicide unrivaled and unmatched for years to come. Something so violent that it shakes the earth to its very core, screaming and clawing on its way down to hell, yelling *I was here, once.* Nebulae colliding and erupting, downward spirals into deep black holes, swallowing everything around them and leaving behind naught but the deafening silence of nothingness. That is how Phainon wants to go– in a way that takes everything else down with him.

His eyes wander to Cipher’s face, and he is shocked by the kindness that they find there.

She jokes about this sometimes, when they’re together on their *girl’s night out* . Pokes and teases him about his dirty apartment. Phainon likes Cipher because there’s something mean about her, something brutal and unforgiving. Her honestly is blunt. She bites him sometimes, sharp needle teeth, and claws at him with those golden talons– he likes that about her. He loves how she has all the ammo against him, and he has none. All of his most embarrassing moments, his lowest of lows, late-night calls from the rooftops of Marmoreal Market or the bridge ledge. His sputtering words, his snotty face, eyes bloodshot red with salty tears. Her nice, half-formed platitudes. *‘Just come over to my place’* and *‘Let me pick you up’* and *‘Let’s get something to eat’. ‘I’m here for you.’* – and he loves that one the best, because there’s really nothing to be there for anymore.

Her– enigmatic, elusive, otter-sleek and slippery like an eel. Him– the remnants of a failed abortion.

Phainon is looking at her now and– he sees her, for the first time. The furrow in her brow exaggerated like a muppet, the small scrunch in her nose where it wrinkles like a lion's. Her eyes, now blue now green, are clear and beautiful volcanic lakes, overflowing with strange grief and sorrow. She looks scared, small, not unlike a kitten with its legs broken; unable to run, and tethered to something terrible. She is fidgeting with the edges of her sleeve and Phainon notices that her acrylics have grown out, chipped in some parts. Her bottom lip is red from where she's bitten it, and she looks like she lost some weight.

Momentarily, the shroud is lifted from his eyes. This is Cifera, who brings him takeout when she knows he can't afford it and is too tired to cook. Who has woken up in the night and rushed to his side, multiple times. Who has the keys to his apartment. Who– when…

No. That wound is too raw. Not yet.

There's something luminous about her visage right now, in front of him. Something almost saintly. The light from the window behind him hits her face and dresses it in patterns of sun and shadow. She looks as if she came down from a painting, woeful and miserable the way muses tend to be. It is unbearable to look at her– she looks little. Younger, almost.

"I'm scared, Phainon," she says, and the emotion is too much for her– she cannot bear to look at him when she says it. She turns her head the other way, her whole body twisting with it, bearing her back to him. "You're my best friend, and I'm just… scared. Of losing you. And I want to help."

This is new. This is shockingly new. She's never like… this. Open. Vulnerable. In their eleven months of friendship, he doesn't remember a time where she's talked about *her* emotions. It comes hard to her, he knows. The way she's saying these words– it's as if she's actively fighting against throwing up.

"It's just…" he starts, and his voice is coarse. He coughs once, and it falls to a whisper. "It hasn't been cleaned in… Four and a half months."

Four and a half months. This is a vitally important timeframe. Cipher knows. Castorice doesn't, but she doesn't have to know. She is perceptive though, and can sense that the conversation has shifted to a dangerously intimate territory. So, with that knowledge, she backs off a little. Gives them their space.

Four and a half months. He sees Cipher physically cringe at the memento. Her whole body shudders. It takes a lot of bravery for her to look back at him, but she *is* brave and so she *does* look. She's blinking back tears, too prideful yet to let them flow. Phainon has managed to make both of his friends cry in the span of thirty-five minutes. It's kind of his talent; letting people down. Her face twists with heartache. "I know." she manages, and Cipher says it with so much goodness that it hurts. She swallows through the pain so well. "I know, Phainon, and that's okay, yeah? That's okay. I'm not mad at you."

This is coded information. A conversation that they're having actively *around* Castorice, and that only they can understand. Four and a half months. If Castorice feels excluded, she doesn't show it. But this is something that's between him and Cipher. Sacred and defilatory, like a cursed idol that they both carry in their pockets. This is not a burden that Castorice has to bear as well. Phainon's shameful little secret that he has roped Cifera into keeping, shoved in cabinets and under the sink, where it can only grow exponentially bigger and more powerful; black mold.

(Castorice has come to expect exclusion; something has always been fundamentally wrong with her. She can't quite put her finger on what, however. There is something wrong with her that is not wrong with anybody else– not even with Polyxia, whom she shared a womb with. Boys liked Polyxia. Polyxia had friends, and Castorice– well, she had Polyxia. So she takes this exclusion, the slow emotional push away from her and towards each other, with a straight face. Because they are her friends, but something is wrong with Castorice– and it's not their fault. A sea of flowers separates her from other people. She reaches out, and they fade into flakes like faraway memories. In the face of Cipher and Phainon's cryptic veiled words and telepathically understood sentences, she turns away with respect, and starts rubbing her hands together.)

There is a beat of silence. None speak. A magpie chatters outside the window, gaining Bartholos' attention. Lazily, he struts to the window and immediately, all eyes are on him. His claws make small clinking sounds against the hardwood floor, and his big orange eyes are filled with determination and ambition. He cuts through the distance to the window, tiger in the bushes, and lays low on his belly. His pupils triple in size, swallowing around the iris. Anticipation fills the room like the finals of the World Cup. He chirps back at the bird, who's oblivious of the danger barely contained between a sheet of glass. Bartholos shakes his butt once, twice, and pounces at the window.

Naturally, he misses it. And it's not even close. The thing barely gets off the floor before it crashes down with a thud– and no, he doesn't land on his feet. In shame and embarrassment, Bartholos pretends like *he didn't even want that stupid bird in the first place* , and instead goes to wash his face.

Castorice is the first to snicker from where she's retreated within herself. Her face lights up with glee, and she goes to coo at Bartholos. "Aren't you the best little hunter in Okhema?" she crouches down to scratch under his chin, which the cat accepts happily. "Yes, you are. Yes, yes you are!" Cipher took her phone out the moment she caught a whiff of Bartholos' shenanigans, and now she presses the button to stop recording. She leans back and laughs. "He does this all the time," she says, "Doesn't know how fat and rotund he is, but he's still got that hunter's instinct. I'm telling you, Phainon, the roaches are not safe with Bartholos around."

Phainon's eyes crinkle painfully when he smiles, sore and swollen from all the crying. But he smiles, bearing teeth a little crooked. "Should I take the roaches off the lease then?"

Cipher slaps her thigh at that and guffaws. "HA! Yeah, you better! Cas, come on," she shuffles off the bed and puts a hand on Castorice's back. "I'm gonna go get the bags. I'm starting with the bathroom. You get the living room."

“What do I get?” Phainon rises from the bed, heavy-boned, exhausted.

Cipher has already made her way to the kitchen *(how is she so fast?)* , and her voice cuts through the apartment as she speaks. “You get some Luofu food from that place you like. Zhuming cuisine. Very yummy. We got you like four big takeout boxes.”

Perplexed, Phainon turns to Castorice for an explanation. She pets Bartholos two more times before she straightens up. Her expression is weightless when she looks at him, and her shoulders are relaxed. “You don’t have to do anything, Phainon. You can just rest while we clean. Please.”

“Whaaat? I can’t let you girls work your asses off while I’m twiddling my thumbs in bed.” Castorice giggles, then hums.

“Then… maybe you could get the dishes, when we’re done?”

“And until then?”

“Just keep us company. And put on a shirt.”

Phainon grins, big, genuine, loud. “Deal.”

So, Cipher and Castorice clean. At first, Phainon retreats to his bedroom, a twinge too embarrassed and too well-behaved to get in their way. Slowly but surely, however, small requests come pouring in.

’Can you get me a new roll of paper?’

’Where’s your tile cleaner?’

’Where’s your vacuum?’

’Bring me a new bag.’

’Can you wet this for me?’

’Take the trash outside, please.’

When Phainon retrieves the vacuum (which has been gathering dust on the balcony for four and a half months) for Castorice, her mouth falls open as if she’s struck dumb.

“Phainon, this is like… professional grade.”

“Hah, yeah. Cyrene and I saved up a lot to get it.”

She seems genuinely excited for some reason, and takes to it like a child with a new toy. When she turns it on to vacuum the rug, Castorice exclaims with excitement. “It can handle the carpet like it’s nothing!”

Cipher is *fast* . Impressively fast. She's done with his mangy bathroom in under two and a half hours. When he sees her walk out triumphantly, Phainon has the nerve to be a little *suspicious* . As she moves onto the kitchen, he goes to check.

And yeah, no, it's clean. It's hotel room clean– it's probably cleaner than it's ever been, even back when he used to love cleaning it. The tiles look as if they're brand new, shining bright and baby blue. The bathtub is pristine, and Phainon has forgotten it's supposed to be white and not a yellow-y light brown hue. He can practically see his reflection in it. It smells *good* . A little citrusy. The toilet actually looks inviting for once. There are still bugs scurrying around, but they will be dealt with as well. He puts the toilet seat down and sits on it. Just sits, taking in the nice smell and the cleanliness. It's nice. It's really, really nice to just *sit* in a clean room. As his eyes wander around, they settle on the bathtub curtains– and he realizes, a little perplexed, that Cipher changed them. She got him brand new ones, with cartoon cat patterns.

And, ah– that's just really kind of her, isn't it? His previous curtains were fine, a little old but not torn. These, however… Well, they're just very nice. Phainon goes to feel them with all the reverence of touching the Golden Fleece. He thinks these curtains are infinitely more precious.

Castorice has a difficult task with the living room, considering it's the most spacious room in the apartment; at the same time, however, it's the least lived in. So while there's a lot of *dust* , there's not much *filth* . She convinces him to have some of the takeout they brought over while she goes dustbunny hunting. And, well– as previously stated, he can never really say *'no* ' to Castorice when she looks so kind. So, he eats, perched like a gargoyle on the sofa with his feet planted on the cushions in case she needs the room to move. When Castorice turns around, she takes a look at him and snickers. "You look like L."

"Hm?" is all Phainon can answer through a mouthful of noodles.

"You know, from Death Note?"

He chews a bit faster and swallows.

"Hah. Yeah. 'Cuz of the way I'm sitting?"

Castorice beams. "Yes! You're sitting just like him!" Phainon laughs at that, though it comes a bit weak and forced. The tiredness from a suicidal breakdown has set in heavy on his bones– Castorice is starting to look a little awkward, a bit disappointed by his reaction. *Disappointment* is not exactly the right word– Phainon knows she struggles with social interactions, and she tends to beat herself up for making 'mistakes'. Every time she's not met with the "appropriate response", like laughter or lively conversation, she gets scared. Becomes small, and retreats a bit into herself. Phainon can see it now on her face, the way her smile falters a bit despite her insistence to keep it on her face. She shifts her weight from one foot to the other, a little stumped, as if unsure of what to do next.

"I'm just tired, Castorice," he says, and he tries to be gentle. "It's been– well, it's been. Hm…"

“I wish you would talk to me, sometimes. About this stuff,” Castorice replies, and her voice is very hushed.

“You… don’t really want that, Cas, seriously.”

“I do.” she insists, “I really do, Phainon. I want to help.”

’Sweet girl.’ His heart breaks a little bit, and he wants to tell her that there’s really no helping *this* . But that would break *her* heart, and she’d certainly find herself at fault for it. “You’re already helping,” Phainon says instead. “You’re cleaning my shithole. That’s huge, Castorice. I can pick up the rest.”

“I wish you’d let me carry some of it.”

“You’re already carrying a lot.” She opens her mouth to argue against that, but Phainon keeps talking. “I’m really sorry. About earlier, I mean– the crying, and the things I said. I’m sorry for scaring you.”

“I wasn’t… scared. More… worried? I’ve talked a lot of people out of suicide, so I wasn’t like. Scared, you know. I was just concerned.”

Phainon blinks, because what– *when* did Castorice talk people out of suicide? *What* people? She’s talked at length about how she never had any friends besides Polyxia, and how he’s her first friend. He looks at her strangely, then decides it’s not appropriate to press on. “That’s… Well, I’ll keep it in mind. For next time.”

Castorice gives him a smile and oh *it’s heartbreaking*– it’s big, hopeful, all charmingly crooked teeth, and full of sweetness. “There won’t be a next time, Phainon. Don’t worry.”

There will be a next time. And there will be a last time.

A beat passes in silence as Castorice resumes the dust wiping; at some point, Bartholos trots in lazily and jumps in Phainon’s lap, pawing at his takeout box. As he’s wrestling with the grey beast, he hears Castorice clear her throat. When she speaks up, her voice is quieter, almost timid.

“I’ve been meaning to ask, um… Why does Cipher have the keys to your apartment?”

Phainon’s hand freezes on his chopsticks as the frosty fingers of an icy hand run down his spine. He chews at the inside of his cheek. Castorice does not turn around, simply waiting with her back to him. She has stopped any action. He has too. The expectation of an answer hangs heavy over his head, and lands heavier still on his shoulders. His first, knee-jerk reaction, is to tell her *’it’s not any of her business’* – because really, *it’s not* . His rational thought, however, tells him *this is Castorice, and she doesn’t deserve his bad temper* . Phainon chews on his bottom lip while he mulls the question over, trying to find his best escape route. Then, he decides to appeal to Castorice’s common decency. “It’s… I don’t really wanna talk about it right now.”

Her shoulders slump, but he sees her nod. “I get that.” is all she says.

Castorice finishes the rest of the living room in silence. It's not exactly *awkward* but it's– charged, in a way. Tense. It wasn't a *lie* – he really doesn't want to talk about it now, or ever. But she can certainly tell that there *is* an answer that he is withholding from her and…

Really, it's simply too heavy and shameful. And Phainon has had his daily share of shame already. He will tell her one day, or maybe he will never tell her because– he really, really wants Castorice to like him.

It's 9 PM, almost 9:30, by the time they're done. Phainon is washing the dishes, as he promised to do, while Castorice and Cipher are smoking at his tiny dining table. "Ya got any plans tomorrow?" Cipher asks all of a sudden.

"Uh… probably just rotting in bed and refusing to pee for ten hours at a time?"

" *Charming!* That's not happening. Castorice and I are taking you out on a girl's night out." Phainon can practically *hear* the smirk on Cipher's face.

"A girls' night out…? Like… one of *our* girls' night outs or…?"

Their , meaning Cipher and Phainon's, girls' night outs include spending upward of 250 Balance Coins on drugs probably laced with baby powder and downing shots that are 80% alcohol in cheap nightclubs. Then getting kicked out of said nightclubs for starting fights with creeps that were grinding and grabbing on Cipher. Then purchasing more cheap alcohol from a corner store and consuming it in a park. Then crashing Phainon's place and drinking some more. Then having a sleepover (more drinking included) and waking up for work the next day with legendary hangovers.

Not quite Castorice's vibe.

"Nah," Cipher waves her hand dismissively. "Something more Castorice's speed. Coffee and cakes, brunch and then a movie."

"So like… a girls' afternoon out? Am I one of the girls now?"

Cipher and Castorice both laugh at that, but ultimately Phainon agrees to their little date. Just as he's finishing up the dishes, Castorice excuses herself to go to the bathroom. He sits down heavily in her seat and pulls out a cigarette.

"Can't believe you gave me your damn cat, Cipher. Is it permanent?"

Cipher shrugs, plays with her fidget spinner. "Just for as long as needed."

Phainon huffs at that, a little amused, and goes to light up his cigarette. "Now I actually have to keep on top of the cleaning," he muses half-mindedly, more to himself than to Cipher. "Don't want old Bartholos getting sick."

His eyes dart to Cipher and he finds her sitting there with a smug grin on her face, like she's a cat who finally caught a mouse. She raises her eyebrows a little bit, and Phainon groans.

“ *That’s* why you gave him to me. You’re giving me a responsibility. You fucking babytrapped me.”

Cipher howls at that, thoroughly entertained, and puts out her cigarette. “That, and to keep you company. Don’t forget about the insecticide I got you, yeah? Instructions on the label, and it’s pet safe, okay?”

Phainon nods, and there’s not much to say after that. It’s squeaky clean and the air is actually breathable now. He didn’t let them go into Cyrene’s room however– that remains untouched, like a sanctuary to a cold God. He snatched her old water bottle, smeared with lipgloss, before either of them could get to it and throw it away– it’s in his room now. Much like a serial killer keeps trophies of their victims, fingers and pieces of scalp, so does he keep trophies of Cyrene; little trinkets of a past life lived only in half, perhaps a little mundane, and maybe if he prays over them enough, if he loves them enough, they’ll come to life in the shape of a real girl.

Phainon watches as Bartholos struts into the kitchen, stretches, and plops down on the floor with his belly up. He wants to go and pet his tummy, but suddenly his hands feel very heavy.

Cipher offers to drive Castorice home, and she accepts because it’s already very late and Polyxia’s caretaker’s shift is gonna end soon. She’s riding passenger princess in Cipher’s black car, watching how the cat-shaped air freshener swings back and forth on the rearview mirror. Her mouth is dry when she opens it to speak,

“Cipher, why do you have the keys to Phainon’s apartment?”

The answer comes quickly, not hesitated, as if Cipher expected her to ask this and has rehearsed her answer, “That’s none of your business, Castorice.”

Yeah, Castorice thinks as she deflates, leaning her head against the window. *I’m starting to think it’s not.*

When they arrive at her apartment building, Cipher offers to walk her to her door and Castorice politely refuses, already feeling a bit tender and very sad. The climb up the stairs to her apartment seems like it will never end, stairs stretching endlessly, until finally she hears the sound of *Love Island* playing from one of the apartments; Polyxia likes trashy TV, and the sound of couples bickering pulls Castorice back into her own body.

She walks in and says goodbye to Polyxia’s caretaker. Castorice looks towards the living room and catches her sitting there in her wheelchair, watching the TV with rapt attention. She joins her, laying on the couch, and doesn’t say anything– simply turns her gaze towards *Love Island* , watching without paying attention, giving her eyes something to do. Just puttering.

They’ve always been very different, her and Polyxia. Castorice was really into Harry Potter and Polyxia was really into Twilight. She was an awkward, gangly highschooler with acne while Polyxia won *Miss Freshman* . Castorice is into staying at home and writing fanfiction, and all of her friends that aren’t from work are autistic queers on Discord. And clearly, as today has proven, her IRLs don’t like her *that* much; which is fine, she doesn’t like herself

either. There's something very wrong with her, she's come to accept this. Castorice chews on her bottom lip anxiously.

"You're upset."

Polyxia's text to speech startles Castorice, and she actually jumps. Polyxia chortles in response, because she can't quite *laugh* anymore, but where there's a will to tease your little sister there's a way.

"How could you tell?"

"I can read your mind, remember? Come on. Tell me what's wrong."

So she does tell her, because Polyxia is kind and easy to talk to and very very lovely. The night ends with Castorice sitting on the floor, weeping with her head in Polyxia's lap, the way she's done since she was little. She takes her sister's hand and places it on her head, because Polyxia can't move it on her own anymore and Castorice *really* needs the physical contact right now. She feels her fingers twitch weakly on her scalp, almost imperceptible.

She feels very stupid, because Polyxia's life was uprooted last year and everything she had was taken away from her -her job, her make-up artist side-gig, and her friends- and here's Castorice crying to the *Dying From Motor Neuron Disease* girl because her *fwiends don't wike her vewy much* .

"... This is a little stupid, Polyxia, I'm sorry," she says after she's calmed down a bit, "I shouldn't do this to you."

When she cranes her neck to look at Polyxia, she finds a question dancing in her eyes– *"do what?"* she asks without asking.

"This–" and Castorice gestures broadly at herself, red faced and puffy-eyed, "It's kind of a non-issue, right? Like yeah, maybe they're closer to each other than they are with me, but they're still my friends and– you know, they invite me out and stuff sometimes, so that's nice. It's just– I'm sorry. You have a lot on your plate, um, I shouldn't put my silly little problems on you."

Polyxia has lost nearly all of her movement, but some of her facial muscles are still working. She frowns a little, and her eyes dart to the screen mounted on her wheelchair. She blinks at it for a while, before her robotic voice sounds out again.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"You know, um," Castorice shies a little, "The ALS? It's kind of the elephant in the room. You're– y'know. It's hard, I mean… I imagine it must be. I imagine you must be feeling a little scared. Very scared maybe."

She hears Polyxia hum, actually hum, because she can't talk anymore but she can still make little sounds. It's a wise, thoughtful sort of *hmm* . A long while later, she speaks again.

”No, not really. I’m not really scared for myself, not anymore. I mean, I’m more scared for you. I made peace with this, you know, and once you make peace with it, it becomes bearable. It’s just life, and I’m enjoying it to the fullest. I don’t really think about dying anymore. It’s no use, so I just make the most of my time here. Besides, I have you. I just worry about what you’ll do after I’m dead more than I worry about the death itself. I don’t think this is stupid at all. I know you’re lonely, and I wanna hear about it.”

“But… don’t you get sad, at all?”

”Of course I get sad. I get sad sometimes and if I had a choice, I’d rather not be sick. But I don’t have a choice, and the point is, Castorice– my sadness isn’t more worthy of being Sadness than your own sadness just because I’m sick and you’re not.”

Castorice just listens. Her sister went to a lot of therapy in the early stages of ALS, and it shows– perhaps Castorice should’ve joined her. Polyxia blinks at her screen some more.

”Honestly, I’m mostly just bored. Mrs. Elena is nice, but she’s not much of a conversationalist. If I feel well tomorrow, I’d like to join you and the others.”

Polyxia doesn’t really have friends anymore, and that shit makes Castorice feel homicidal. She got diagnosed and every person in her life kind of dipped– her long-term boyfriend, her college friends, all the people she used to buy drinks and gifts for. Castorice is not proud to say that she got blocked by all of them because she went into their DMs and told them off. Polyxia really didn’t appreciate that, said *’I don’t need a knight’* , but she still found it very funny. *’Just, y’know, fuck them.’*

Yeah. Fuck them.

So, Castorice wipes her tears and agrees that it would be lovely if Polyxia were to join them tomorrow. She texts her group chat with Phainon and Cipher and they agree as well.

The next day is good. It’s really good actually– it’s so good that Phainon is getting a little paranoid and he thinks that he’ll get run over by a car or hit by a meteorite or something, because nice good days just don’t happen to him.

They all meet up early for brunch at a nice local place, the cozy sort with vines growing on the red brick wall. It’s one of those hot hipster places for self-important assholes with twirly moustaches that are a little too performative about liking *’big tiddy goth girls’* . But hey, credit where credit is due– their drinks are top notch and they make a mean frittata.

Which is exactly what Phainon orders, a tall glass of mango lemonade and a frittata. Castorice orders an XL chocolate oreo milkshake and a huge portion of french toast, because she *really* wants diabetes and is on a quest to go into a diabetic coma before age thirty. Cipher is more normal about it, ordering a rösti and a macchiato.

Polyxia, on the other hand, orders three bottomless mimosas in glasses as tall as her head– to Castorice’s desperation.

”I already ate at home,” she says when Phainon teases her about it, *”And I don’t like anything on the menu anyways. What the fuck is a quiche Lorraine?”*

Phainon loves hanging out with Polyxia, and has done so *many* times before. Most recently on her and Castorice’s birthday, one month ago, when he got a little drunk and let Polyxia bum one of his cigarettes. He held it to her lips while she smoked. Polyxia joked that the hardest part of having ALS was having to give up smoking. When Castorice found them like that in the kitchen, she just sighed all disappointed and walked out.

Polyxia is funny, like *really* funny, and she’s a bit daring, a bit of a wildcard. He met her in the earlier stages of her ALS, when she was wheelchair bound but still had movement. She always teased him, leaned with her cheek on her hand and called him *’pretty boy’* and said she’ll *‘take him for a ride on her wheelchair if he sits in her lap’* .

Honestly, she’s exactly his type, because he likes people that he can volley with and that bully him a little. He also likes people he can bully, so they have to be able to take it. All of her flirty teasing got to him at some point, and he had a little schoolyard boy crush on her for a bit. It was some nine or ten months ago, so not long after they met. When he told Polyxia about it, she just laughed.

’That’s nice and all, but I’m gonna die and I’d rather not waste my time.’

’Don’t you mean, you’d rather not waste my time?’

She grinned then, all toothy. *’Be serious, Phainon. No time spent with me is time wasted. I’m a fucking catch.’*

They spend a good several hours at the brunch place, chatting and laughing. Cipher seems to be in a good mood, and Castorice is… trying her best. Something seems to trouble her, but Phainon doesn’t want to put her on the spot. Instead, he chooses to let her be.

The waiters are getting a little bit antsy when it becomes clear they’re not gonna order anything else, so he asks for the note. Phainon ends up fighting with Cipher about who’s gonna pay and comes out victorious.

“Come on, I can’t have a lady paying. That would be ungentlemanly.”

“Tastefully misogynistic, Phainon,” Cipher chastises with a roll of her eyes.

The brunch place is pretty close to Phainon’s place so, with the sun setting slowly behind them, they decide to walk to his place and watch a movie. The weather is perfect; one of those lovely July afternoons, where it’s warm but not *too* warm. Every so often, a breeze blows and ruffles Castorice’s long hair. It gets all in Polyxia’s mouth. Phainon is very content and very fond.

They watch *Five Nights at Freddy’s* when they get to his apartment, because that movie sounds positively stupid and very funny.

And by God, yeah, it's awful. It's *so* bad. Polyxia laughs so hard at some point that she chokes and gives her sister the scare of a lifetime. Cipher can't stop making dumb comments, and at some point she starts imitating the actors in the movie. Phainon laughs so hard he's crying, and even Castorice looks less troubled than before, all tickled pink.

After the movie, they hang around for a bit more. Bartholos walks out from Phainon's bedroom, does a big big stretch, and jumps up in Polyxia's lap. She makes a little surprised sound, and then demands that *somebody* help her pet him. Phainon grabs her wrist and strokes Bartholos' back with her hand, making him meow and purr.

They file out not long after, because it's getting late and it's really dark out now. They say their goodbyes, he sees them out of the apartment, and then Phainon is left sitting alone on the couch, and…

He feels good. He feels really, really good actually. It was a nice day. He laughed a lot. It was nice seeing Polyxia again, and it was nice spending time with Cipher when they're both sober and not suicidal.

His apartment feels like a home again, at least for now, and he's kept his promise– he swept the floors today, because the insecticide worked and there were a bunch of dead bugs on the ground. He fed Bartholos, changed his water bowl, and even made his bed. As he goes to retreat to his bedroom, he does not linger by Cyrene's room anymore. Doesn't even think about it, honestly, as if it's just some room in an apartment and not the womb holding all he's ever loved.

Phainon is half-asleep as he lays in his bed, stuck between wakefulness and dream, when he hears the wooden boards outside his bedroom creak. A little dazed, he cracks his eyes open. The light on the hallway is turned on, though he can swear he turned it off. Golden light rushes through the door, a little cracked, sending a perfect luminous stripe towards him.

She stands in his doorway like she used to when he was small and needed comfort from a nightmare. Cyrene looks barely seven years old, dressed in her Disney princess pajamas, clutching the plush blanket given to her as an infant. She asks him, softly as if not to wake anyone at all, to protect her from monsters. She says she's scared; he can save her.

For a moment, he can almost convince himself he's still the best brother in the world, invincible and protective, smart and capable, and now, finally, bigger than her. Older than he was when she was seven, just like he always wanted to be. He thinks that it's his turn to be the older sibling, the big brother, and so he pushes away his covers and invites the specter into bed.

She presses up against him, small and cold like a cut of pork hanging from a hook. She sleeps, or so he thinks, because her breathing gets very steady and very slow. Phainon's hands come to comb through her short hair, and he gazes up at the ceiling because he knows that if he looks down at her, she will be gone. So, he looks the other way, as he's always done, and thinks of nothing. Polaroid caught in time, a perversion of a memory from some twenty-two years ago– Cyrene, seven years old, much braver, and him, five years old, suffering from night terrors after their parents' divorce. She always pretended to be the scared one, always asked *him* for comfort so that he'll still feel like a big strong boy at the end of the day.

He is making it dirty, somehow, by indulging this. He knows it's wrong, and fake, and a sure sign that he's completely lost his mind. But she is so small, so precious, as she cuddles up to his chest, sucking on her blankie, her tiny hands fisting into his shirt. She is very, very cold, but if he pretends very, very hard, he can almost trick himself into thinking it's her. If everybody believes a lie, then it might as well be reality.

He tries very hard to believe this lie, and he tries very hard to love the little Cyrene. He rubs her back and tells her all the things he never did when she was still alive. Perhaps he can love her back to life.

And as he sinks into this moment, falling asleep with the twenty-two year old ghost of his sister's child self, he thinks can almost forgive himself for killing her.

The thought of it has him heaving into the trash for the rest of the night.

Sometimes, if you're unlucky, your sister dies and it's all your fault. Sometimes, you go a little crazy about it and you end up hallucinating her child self.

You still have to go to work.

Chapter End Notes

Right, so, this took longer than expected, and this *chapter* was longer than expected so I had to break it down further. Being 15k words into a fic and not having the other half of the ship even show up is kinda crazy but I promise you this IS Phaidei-centric. However, a lot of things have to be set beforehand, most importantly the relationship between Phainon, Cipher and Castorice and the one between Castorice and Polyxia, since those 2 are foils to Phainon and Cyrene.

- ▶ Some tags have been added. Click here to see them.
- ▶ Some more trivia/information.

Chapter 3: ouroboros

Chapter Notes

Yay Mydei is here!! I went into a fugue state and wrote 14k words in a week. I really love this fic. Enjoy! :^) I think I'll take a little break after this lol

IMPORTANT!!!

Mydei's POV is just a general TW for child abuse and domestic violence/domestic abuse. There are some gore-y/disturbing descriptions of Gorgo's dead body, but it's a little surreal as well.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hyacine has been in this room for the past four consecutive hours and at this point it's getting a little hard to think.

This room being the HR office of FLAMECHASE, and by *four consecutive hours* she means, you know, doing her job.

Her job –Human Resource Specialist– is usually easy. It's the sort of job you clock into and kinda dick around all day most of the time, because once you get past the hurdle of boring paperwork, it's smooth sailing. And she can't *really* complain, because she started as a customer support analyst, AKA one of those people getting yelled at for eight hours a day. She trained under Anaxagoras (put a pin in that, we're going to come back to Anaxagoras) and then swiftly transferred to the HR department as soon as possible (having a bachelor's degree in Psychology helped, thankfully), because holy *fuck* that was truly unbearable.

So, objectively speaking, HR is easier than on-call customer support. You just protect the interest of the company (while saying you're actually *for the employees* but that's bullshit and Hyacine knows that's bullshit) and yeah, you're an active cog in the capitalist machine moreso than other employees and most days you end up wasting the time of people in need for a job; but she has to eat and the call center was making her suicidal.

Hyacine thinks of the HR lady wojack Phainon showed her and yup, that's pretty much her. At least she fought for thirty minute lunch breaks and actually won them from higher management, with the support of Anaxa (this isn't it, keep the pin there) and Aglaea. So she can at least rest a bit easier at night.

There is a time in the year, however, where the job goes from boring and bearable to downright hellish. And that time period is the summer, when they do *recruitments* .

Together with the rest of the *HRlings* they sift through job applications and recruitment sites, they pick the most decent-looking candidates, and then Anaxa handles the actual interviews,

because they're the head of the HR department.

That's kind of where the issue arises. Anaxagoras.

So, and this is well-known in the company, the head of HR (that being Anaxagoras) and the head of Customer Support (that being Aglaea) are locked in a six-year-old dick measuring contest that started when they were both bottom-of-the-rung call center operators.

There are two steps candidates have to go through before they can be hired: the interview with Anaxa and, if they pass that and Anaxa considers them good enough, the final interview with Aglaea.

You see, the thing is, there is nothing those two love doing more than pissing each other off– and this has only worsened now that they both have actual positions of power in the company.

Anaxa will pass forward under-qualified candidates or people that are outrightly bad in the interview so they can become Aglaea's responsibility. In turn, Aglaea, the hiring and department manager, will hire them so that they circle back to being Anaxa's responsibility. Anaxa baits her, Aglaea bites back, and the company gets burned.

It's a vicious cycle. It's snake eats tail. It's Ouroboros.

Now, this is a fast-moving industry anyways, and it's kind of cannibalistic. They are on a constant rotation of people quitting and new people joining, and the standard for quality isn't sky high. They're not exactly looking for the Albert Einstein of customer service, and most people that are bad at their job end up quitting after a few months anyways– so while Anaxa and Aglaea's petty back and forth doesn't actually affect the company *that* much, it affects Hyacine. *Why* , you might ask? Well, you see–

Lately there's been a push from senior management, the people that are above Aglaea and Anaxa but below the board of directors, to expand their customer support analyst team and get more people on-call. HR's workload during recruitment season was heavy anyways, and now it's doubled -or even tripled- in size with the recent expansion. Besides the recruitment itself and the interviewing, they're also tasked with doing quality assessment for their employees and the new trainees alike. This means listening to recordings of their calls.

Training in FLAMECHASE lasts two weeks (way too little), and then the new kids are put in this Customer Support Limbo for another two weeks where they're still technically in training but they're also very much taking real calls, though for fewer hours a day and less pay. This is less of a test run and more of an acclimation period, like putting a frog in water and slowly turning up the heat. Technically speaking, based on this two week period, the heads of HR and Customer Support are supposed to work together and choose who gets hired for realsies and who gets axed.

Alright, that's great. Refer to fig. A, labeled "Anaxa and Aglaea's school playground fight".

This means a lot of people that are utter dogshit and have no interpersonal skills are being hired.

Now, *how* does this affect Hyacine?

Because now she has to spend eight hours every day contemplating the inherent goodness of human nature as she listens to the newly hired trainees' calls, and wow. *Wow* . It was bad before, but now? She's genuinely questioning her life choices. It's painful, it's downright painful, and Hyacine spent her early twenties volunteering in psychiatric hospitals and doing counseling for kids with cancer– *this* is the most emotionally affected she's been by a job. The second hand embarrassment is so bad she has to close her eyes and rock back and forth, like actually *self-soothe* , to get through a call. It's a young boy, nineteen years old, who ended up yelling at an elderly customer because she was too confused and too slow to speak.

Her break is coming up, so she takes off her headphones and turns her head up towards the ceiling, her eyes still closed. She hopes that the sky will come crashing down on her right now. She prays to whatever God will listen for this misery to end. Jesus Christ, she needs a cigarette and she needs Little Ica.

After a bit, she comes back to herself, stretches her arms, and looks at Anaxa who is seated across from her. They're looking worse for wear. Actions, meet consequences. Their head hangs low, hands all running through their green hair, pulling and tugging. The capitalist fuckmachine has thoroughly broken them. She's witnessing a thirty-seven year old gown-ass adult having a nervous breakdown because a nineteen year old kid that *they* pushed through is bad at his job.

"You know, Anaxagoras–" Hyacine starts, "I remember this kid from recruitment, and he was always fucking awful. You don't need to keep doing this, oh my God, just give in and do your job properly!"

Anaxa is silent for a minute and then, slowly, they lift their head to look at her.

"I hope I get glaucoma in my other eye and I hope it kills me."

"...Okay, well, first of all– glaucoma is not fatal. Second of all, like, answer me?"

They sigh and lean back in their chair, arms crossing at their chest. "No."

"What do you mean, *no* ?"

"I won't let her win."

"Win– This isn't a competition, Anaxagoras."

"It *is* now, and I won't let her win it. I'm committing to my stance."

Hyacine frowns and wow, *wow* , she really wants to kill them right now. There's a pen next to her, and if she's fast enough–

"You're being ridiculous. We're supposed to be professionals."

Anaxa simply huffs and turns their head away defiantly. "Hmph."

Hmph?! What the fuck kind of answer is that? Is this real? Is her life real? Is this a dream? Perhaps she died and this is her own personal hell.

A beat of silence passes.

"...There is that one guy that's pretty good, though," she says, perhaps trying to find some light in this eternal damp darkness she's caught in.

"Which one? The Kremnoan?"

"Yeah, the uhh–" she sifts through some papers, looking for the guy's CV. "Mydeimos, yeah."

She sees Anaxagoras contemplate for a moment, moving their head from side to side as if weighing the pros and cons. "Yes, he's serviceable. Kind of a natural at it."

"Yeah," Hyacine agrees.

"Mhm. Yes." Anaxagoras agrees, as well, because for some reason they always have to have the last word. Hyacine looks at them. Anaxa looks back at her.

"...Good talk," she grabs her bag and her cigarettes, "Buckle in, teach, because we have four more hours of this bullshit left."

She pats them on the back on her way out and, as she hurries down the hallway, Hyacine can hear the sound of Anaxagoras' maniacal laughter resounding throughout the office– they have completely lost it.

Deserved, if she's being honest.

He is small, very small, two years old or perhaps two and a half. He is outside his house, on the little patio, and the grass is a little gross and a little yellow. But it's a nice summer afternoon and the world has taken on that sleepy, blue-ish haze before the sun sets. He is playing with his trains, making them crash into each other and making *boom* noises. He sees a small bug crawl on one of his trains and he squishes it with his thumb. He laughs, a little high-pitched and a little chubby cheeked. Mommy and Daddy are yelling inside the house, and he's not sure what it's about because he never really understands. He just knows they get very, very upset with each other and sometimes they break things.

Sometimes they would be eating dinner in peace, him with his nuggies and mashed potatoes, Mommy with her glass of wine– and all of a sudden, Daddy would slam the table with his fists hard enough to make the cutlery jump, and he would start screaming at Mommy about this or that. And then she would get mad too, and then she would also start screaming back. That's when he hits her, and then she hits Daddy back.

"...deimos..." his uncle calls from somewhere very, very far away. He gets up, wobbly because he's a *late bloomer* and he just learned how to walk. He goes a bit farther than his

father allows him to, usually. He stares down their driveway, looking for the source of the sound.

"Mydeimos…" a bit louder now, clearer. He would like to answer back, but the issue is he can't talk yet, and it's making Mommy very sad. The boy shrugs and figures it's nothing, so he goes tiptoeing back to his trains. Sits down heavily on his knees and reaches sideways for his favorite green train.

When he turns back and looks down at his toy railway, Mommy's cold face stares up at him, her eyes glazed over and milky-white. Her lips are blue-ish purple, frozen in a scowl, and she looks so so scared, kind of like the pictures the nice lady at the therapy center showed him. Dark red bruises extend on her pale throat, dragons grappling with each other, something far bigger and far more sinister than he can understand. Flies fall out of her gaped mouth and maggots suckle on her breasts, rotten black milk, spoiled, foul. Bile and insects and everything the Heavens have deemed unholy– swimming like koi fish in a pond. Her stomach is swollen, bloated like a sailor's corpse, and the world smells of pomegranates.

She is very blue all over. She looks very sad, a twin of the Virgin Mary icon Daddy makes him pray to every night. He does not notice how his hands, adult and streaked with red ink, are gripping her by the throat.

Mydei wakes up in a cold sweat.

It's a recurring dream, and he's had it since he was nine years old. It always plays the same. He's always playing with his favorite toy trains, and then Krateros calls him away, and then he turns back and he's killing his mother.

He groans and reaches over for his phone to check the time– 6 AM. He woke up one hour before his alarm, because fuck his life. It's his first day of work too, and he's made sure everything went right the day before. He ate well and went to sleep early and didn't even workout, just to make sure he gets a good night's sleep.

Unfortunately– The Horrors.

Mydeimos would like to linger on them and maybe it would do him some good to unpack literally any of that; however, if he does, he won't be able to function for the rest of the day.

So, deep breath. Lock them away tight. Take a second and compose yourself, Mydeimos, because you're supposed to be a functioning member of society. Sometimes your mother is murdered and you have to go to work.

Work. Yes. He pushes the covers away and weakly gets to his feet– he's a little unstable, like his body doesn't want to cooperate with his mind. What does his body know? It's always betrayed him in some way or another, always a little malformed and misaligned. Something like a half-assed abortion made by a lazy doctor.

Kitchen. Go make something to eat. Do *something* , don't think very hard.

Hephaestion is in the kitchen, scrolling idly on his phone. There's a half eaten sandwich in front of him. He raises his fox-like eyes at Mydei when he hears him approach, and smiles.

"Good mornin', Mydeimos~" he chirps, sing-song.

"Why are you up?"

Hephaestion stutters a bit and then laughs, taken aback. "What, are you a cop? Am I not allowed?"

"No? I'm just asking. It's early."

Mydei opens the fridge while Hephaestion answers him, "Couldn't sleep well. Was a bit anxious for you, little lion. New job, very exciting!" Mydei scoffs like that, a little amused, and fishes out the bacon and the eggs from the fridge.

"I don't believe you. Want something to eat?"

"Nah, I ate."

Hephaestion sounds like he expects something, but Mydei can't tell what it is so he doesn't say anything. Instead, he focuses on his eggs and bacon. "Is Ptolemy up?"

"You *know* he is. It's re-sit exam season, I don't think he slept. Leonnius and Perdikkas are at work, though. Peucesta's still asleep, because–"

"Peucesta doesn't have a real job, yes I know," Mydei finishes for him, smiling a little. "Ptolemy! Come! Food!"

Ptolemy looks like a zombie when he drags himself out of his room, doesn't even say *'hi'* or *'good morning'* . Simply sits at their long dining table, next to Hephaestion, and waits to be served. Mydei doesn't mind, because he likes serving them. He sets down a plate of bacon and eggs in front of Ptolemy, then goes to cook his own food.

"You call me to breakfast like I'm a dog…" Ptolemy grumbles through a mouthful of food. Hephaestion laughs at that and stretches his lithe arms. "That's 'cause you become a dog when exams roll around, my friend. You know pulling all-nighters won't actually help you study better, right?" He reaches over to boop Ptolemy's nose, which the other really doesn't appreciate. He pulls away with a scowl and slaps Hephaestion's hand away.

They get into a little catfight, like girl characters do in old cartoons, as Mydei sits down with his own plate.

The other two chat about something, and Mydei's not really paying attention because he's still a bit bristled from his dream.

("Mydeimos," his mother says as she reclines on the bed, back leaning against the headboard. She's nursing a black eye, holds a pack of ice against the bruise. She grabs his arm suddenly, roughly, and it hurts. "Don't get yourself involved with men, okay? You have to promise me."

“I’m not– I don’t…” he tries to say, a little startled, because he doesn’t even know he likes boys yet– how does she?

“Promise me, Mydei. You have to promise me.”

And she sounds… scared, and rushed, like she’s running out of time. Like her livelihood, her wellbeing, depends on this– on him.

“Okay. I promise,” he says then, not really knowing what he’s promising.

But it makes her smile; a soft, weak smile, tired. Pained. And then she pulls on his arm, gently, and he stumbles into bed with her. Naturally, almost by instinct, he goes to nuzzle into the crook of her neck where he can smell her strong, cloying perfume. She’s always smelled so good, kind of like gunpowder.)

“Hellooo??” Mydei is pulled back to reality from where he’d zoned out by a series of snaps and the feel of Hephaestion’s light hand on his shoulder. Mydei flinches away from it, but the other man remains unfazed. “I asked you something, Mydei~”

He blinks, dizzy and not quite himself, and tilts his head at Hephaestion.

“I asked if you’d bake me a cake today.”

Mydeimos frowns, stuffs his mouth with a forkful of bacon. “Sure, I will, but why?”

Hephaestion scoffs at him, and Ptolemy gives him a tart *’Dude.’*

“Uhh, like, check your phone? You can’t actually be serious.” Hephaestion sounds a little amused, and there’s no actual bite in his words, but Mydei is starting to get anxious. He could *swear* it was the 10th of August, not the 11th. Mydei reaches over for his phone, turns it on, and–

It *is* the 11th. That’s right– he remembers now. Miss Aglaea told him that he’ll start on *’the next Monday’* and he never cared to check for the specific date; and honestly, time has always been weird for him. Dates mingle and melt into each other in his head, hours pass in the span of minutes. Sometimes it’s 10 AM, and then he blinks, and suddenly it’s night and he’s in bed and twelve hours have passed by him without his knowledge. A life half-lived, glimpsed in brief moments of time. He tries to conjure up Gorgo’s face, find the similarities between his and hers, the arch of his nose or perhaps the curl of his eye– instead, he finds himself holding chalk dust, taste astringent, crushed to pieces by hands bigger than his, crueler than his.

Ah well, it’s been like this since he was a kid, so he doesn’t think about it too much.

It’s probably fine.

That being said, it’s the 11th of August. Mydei feels embarrassed and he has the decency to drop his fork and blush; hang his head in shame.

“You’re right,” he mumbles, “I’m sorry, Heph, I could swear it was the 10th. Happy anniversary.”

Hephaestion's hand squeezes his shoulder, and his voice gets very gentle. "It's okay, my friend, I'm not mad at you. I was just teasing, really!" He gives Mydei a little laugh, airy and a bit weak. "Stop pouting, it's a happy day," Hephaestion pokes his cheek, "One whole year cancer-free. Who would've thought I'd live to see the day?"

He lifts his face to Hephaestion's and– he is skinnier than when they first met, yet fuller than he was last year. Irreversibly changed, not necessarily for the worse but– different. A little more tired, a little older, his skin more pallid than it used to be. His hair is short now, and Mydei has always liked his long hair.

("You can't cry," he told him then, through his oxygen mask, "Please don't cry for me, Mydei. It's going to be okay," and then his hand, now small like a child's, came to hold his.

And it only made Mydei cry harder because his hands were so little now, he was so little now, like the shadow of the boy he met in college. Both teenagers and both stupid, taking photos of each other making out with ancient marble statues and getting chased away by the museum's security guard. Hanging out with their toes in the cold water of a lake. Watching Rupaul's Drag Race together and getting a bit too into the competition. Cooking all sorts of tasty meals for him. Kissing that one time when they were both very drunk and very lonely.

"It's not going to be okay. You might die."

"It's okay if I do.")

" *I* did," Mydei says, remaining steadfast. "I knew you could do it." Hephaestion's face softens, eyes crinkling at the edges and smile stretching like a wheat field; luminous, golden. "That's very sweet, Mydei, thank you. So… cake?"

"Yeah," Mydei beams, "Cake."

They return to their rooms after breakfast, because it's still early and there's nothing to do. Hephaestion and Mydei bully Ptolemy into *finally* going to sleep. Not long after, Leonnius and Perdikkas return from their work; Leonnius from his graveyard shift as a security guard, Perdikkas from his overnight shift at the hospital. He's already cooked breakfast for the two, and it's waiting in the kitchen looking all appetizing.

Mydei starts getting ready at 7 and by 7:30 he looks presentable– more than presentable, honestly, he looks *handsome* . Like he'll leave a good first impression on his coworkers, which he's not really interested in doing; he has all the friends he needs right here.

Mydei sits on the edge of his bed and reaches into his drawer for his pill organizer, pops open the tab labeled *'Monday'* . Paroxetine for his depression. Venlafaxine for his panic attacks and anxiety, because for some reason the Paroxetine doesn't quite cut it. Lithium, his mood stabilizer. Two of each, one of Lithium, a nice handful. Down they go– he doesn't take water with them. He likes how bitter they taste.

The perfect serotonin cocktail, specifically designed by the greatest mixologist of our times (his psychiatrist), to make sure he doesn't end up on the news or as a 'Kremnoan Young Adult Suicide Statistics' entry. Did you know it's the second-leading case of death among

Kremnoans aged 18-25? He's almost out of the danger zone, being 25 exactly, but– oh, dang it, it's also the second leading cause of death among Kremnoans aged 26-35.

Just for good measure, Mydei also takes a Vicodin (totally legally prescribed and medically necessary, thank you very much) for his back, because it's kind of bothering him and he doesn't want it to be a whole *thing* later.

Ah. He's perfectly souped up now, thinking at a molasses pace. Sedation. Quiet. Mydeimos breathes out, long and hard, laborious. His doctor said he's reaching his body's upper limit of lithium intake and that they should slowly ease him off of it. They're talking of less intense stabilizers. A mix of Quetiapine and Lamotrigine, fiddling with the dosage. It will make him tired and hungry and very, very quiet; more than he already is. Maybe it will quell some latent psychosis that wants to claw its way up his brainstem. They're waiting for it -the psychosis- like a sailor's wife waits for the clouds on the horizon; like he used to wait for the schoolbus every morning. The psychiatrist sat him down very gravely one day, a routine check-up, and had told him, succinctly and sternly, that *'he is two very bad days away from full-blown schizophrenia, and the Lithium isn't helping.'*

Mydei's been putting the weaning off, because if he doesn't take his Lithium, he'll start breaking shit in the house. But he waits for the psychosis to ruin his life, one box to tick on a very long list he has to fill out with his taxes; waits for it like a heated lover, legs spread, saying *'Yes, fuck me! Fuck me hard!'*

And, at the end of the day, why not? What difference would schizophrenia make? He's been half a person since he was nine, and only a quarter person since he was twenty-two.

His mouth feels like cotton.

Hephaestion knocks on his door frame and leans against it. Mydei blinks himself out of his haze. "Looking good. You nervous?"

"No, not really. The job's not difficult."

"Let me walk you to your car, I feel like stretching my legs a bit."

They are silent as they make their way to where Mydei parked his car, a block or two down because his usual parking spot was taken. *Asshole.* It's not official, but it was *his* . As he fiddles with the car keys, he hears Hephaestion sigh behind him. "I'm going back to work next week," he announces, out of nowhere.

Mydei stops in his tracks, and a familiar anxiety brews in his gut– he's not sure what that's about. He's afraid, but of what? "All out of sick days?"

"Unfortunately."

"Are you gonna be okay?"

"Dunno. I'm kinda nervous about rejoining polite society," Hephaestion tries to joke, but his voice falters. "But what can ya do? The work never ends. So much time has passed, I think I

even forgot how to do math."

Mydei doesn't know what to say. He stands there, a little still, hands steady on his keys, not moving to open the car door nor turning to look at Hephaestion. He's scared, yes, and maybe it *is* the change. Hephaestion is safe at home, lounging on the couch, close to his CPAP machine and the ontology ward. What if he gets sick away from home, at work? What if the cancer comes back? Mydei is not sure what cancer's got to do with a boring accounting job, but his body seems to think they're intrinsically linked.

To be fair, his body can't tell the difference between a minor disagreement between friends and being threatened with a gun.

He wants to swoop Hephaestion up and tuck him into his pocket, somewhere very far away from the rest of the world where nothing else can hurt him again. His hand is trembling on the key and he's gripping it with force, and he was really really small and weak and he couldn't have protected *her* even if he tried and he should have gotten help sooner and he shouldn't have ran away so far but he *didn't know any better* and he tried his best–

(A pool of blood soaks his bare feet, cruor stuck to her pretty golden locks, the ones he loved brushing and braiding so much. He looks next to the oven and finds a piece of her scalp there, hair still attached to it. He grabs it, brings it to his mouth to kiss, and stuffs it in his pocket.

Even while dead and pale and faceless, she is so beautiful.)

"You know, I never thought– ah, nevermind. You have to go to work."

"No," Mydei prompts him, "Go on. I have time."

"I really thought I was gonna die. I was *this* close, too. I never thought I'd get the chance to work again. Maybe I'm actually a little excited, now that I think about it. Life after cancer is kinda boring."

Mydei kind of feels like crying a bit, and he really doesn't like this. Somehow, it feels like Hephaestion is leaving him, even though he's worked that job since college. It's stupid. He feels like when he was a kid and his mother told him to stay very still and very silent in his room while she went to deal with his father.

Mydei chews on his bottom lip. "I'll make you that cake today," is all he says before he gets in his car and drives to work.

It's been about a week since his Professional Grade, Peer-Reviewed, SSS+ Mental Breakdown™.

Phainon had expected *something* to change but, ultimately, the only thing different is that now he's suicidal in a clean apartment– which, objectively, is an improvement. Unfortunately, it's not enough of an improvement. He haunts the halls of his home like a dilapidated ghost, and some nights he sleeps in Cyrene's room, surrounded by her clothes and

her smell and the small pieces of her flesh strewn about like bait for wolves. His reflection in the mirror is misshapen, as if distorted. He has grown dragonlike, terrible, frightening.

But– *but* ! If there's one thing Phainon is good at, it's lying; well, actually, it's more accurate to say *acting.* (what even is the difference?) Either way, he's *good* at acting, because Phainon is a blank slate that people can take turns pissing on and drawing the vague shape of a human. He has many roles in his repertoire, such as: The Good Friend, The Sexy Lover and, his favorite, The Perfect Employee.

Because, *yeah* , the work is shit and there's little to no chances of actually advancing in the company, so it's kind of a dead end job. It is, however, something that he can be *good* at. And he really, *really* needs to be good at something.

Phainon has been the most consistently well-performing employee since he was hired, and has won Overall Employee of the Month four times in a row!

Which means absolutely jackshit because the pay is still ass, and he's still up to his neck in debts, but hey– a man's gotta have his pride, and this at least makes him feel like he's *useful* . He's making the multi-million company even *more* millions. He's capitalism's most well-behaved dog, who's a good boy oh you are yes you are, now work for nine more hours like the obedient little puppy you are. He can practically feel Khaos Petridis scratch behind his ear and maybe feed him his cock for dinner. Or something like that.

There's a tale about a man punished for his transgressions against the Titans, forced to push a boulder up a mountain for all eternity, but Phainon doesn't think that's thematically relevant to his current situation.

It's an exciting day, however, because today they get a *new batch of employees* . It's thirty or so newbies, so it's about to get a little more crowded– not all thirty of them are gonna be working from the office, of course, since they fully have the option to work remotely if they so wish. Only severely mentally disturbed people, such as Phainon, Castorice, and Cipher, choose to spend nine hours of their day in this hellhole.

Still, it should be at least five or ten newbies puttering about.

Cipher is walking lightly on her desk treadmill, a leisurely pace, while Castorice is sitting on his desk. Phainon is leaning in his chair, trying to look all casual. The desk next to him, on his right, has been mostly vacant since Hyacine transferred to HR– not a day goes by where he doesn't deeply mourn the loss of his *very best number **two** love and peace desk neighbour work best friend* , mostly because in a sea of troubled individuals, she's actually pretty well-adjusted. People have taken over that spot every so often since she left, but none of them stuck around for long.

He's already starting to see some new faces and it's actually pretty thrilling, because positive social interaction gives him the best head high and makes him feel like he's worth something for once. Phainon loves performing, especially for new people, especially when the prize is a good first impression and a boosted ego. God knows he needs it.

“Ya think there’s gonna be any cute new girls, hmm~?” Cipher mewls, stretching a little and fiddling with the speed on her treadmill.

“Cipher!” Castorice says, utterly scandalized, “Workplace relationships are inappropriate!”

“Yeah, okay, Castorice,” Phainon chimes in, teasing, shifting so he can sit with his cheek in his hand, “I’ve read that Ratiorine office AU you wrote~”

Castorice gasps in horror and brings her hand to cover her mouth. “S-shut up!!” and she turns so so red, kind of like a tomato; cute Tomatorice.

“What the fuck is an *ay yew* ? Who’s Ratiorine…?” Cipher makes a face like she just spoiled rotten eggs.

“Oh~?” This is his favorite thing in the world; teasing Castorice, because she gets very flustered and very funny. “You don’t know~? Castorice writes these smutty, erotic little stories about the characters from a video– *hmph??* ”

Phainon’s efforts to embarrass Castorice are cut short by a soft, cold hand slapping against his mouth– the victim has jumped down from the desk and has fully put him in a headlock, surprisingly strong for her size, one arm around his neck and the other coming to cover his mouth and stop him from talking. She’s squeezing his throat. *Hard.*

What a way to go.

“Stop talking!! Oh my God!! What is wrong with you?!” she screeches, like actually screeches, and Phainon can’t stop laughing from under her vicious assault. “Cipher– *Cipher!!* You didn’t hear anything, okay??” Cipher is laughing too, doubling over, snorting all unladylike.

“I don’t know, Princess Homebody, I’m kind of interested now~” Cipher manages to say after she catches her breath a bit.

Phainon is actually getting a little lightheaded because *holy fuck* , Castorice is skinny and all, but she’s *powerful* . So he pulls the ultimate move, and this is a dirty trick he’s not proud of– but desperate times call for desperate measures.

Phainon lolls his tongue out and starts licking her palm.

Castorice is relentless though. His last line of defense crumbles like a child’s Jenga tower; instead of letting go and jumping up saying *“kyaa~~ yucky!!”* , she squeezes harder.

Well, he supposes this is it. It has been a life well-lived, full of ups and down, but mostly downs. If Phainon is to die because he reached his friend’s upper limit of playful teasing, then he shall shoulder his fate proudly and go out fearlessly. Cipher is taking pictures of his last moments.

“...Castorice?” a gentle, soft, accented voice breaks through the chaos. The light at the end of the tunnel– his salvation, a modern-day Jesus Christ of Nazareth.

Aglaea heactuallydoesn’tknowherlastname of FLAMECHASE INC.

She’s beautiful, heartrendingly so; so beautiful that she’s a bit hard to look at. An elegant browbone leading into the gentle slope of her nose, cloudy blue eyes, perfectly styled hair, golden manicured nails. She’s always dressed fashionably, all ruffled white shirts and expensive materials and gold accents; and smells *so* good too. Aglaea stands there, looking serene and untouchable, white cane in hand, eyes closed with a small smile.

“Why are you killing my Employee of the Month?”

“A-Aglaea!!” Castorice lets go of him all at once, and Phainon leans forward with the force of it, coughing and gasping. “I’m so sorry! This isn’t–”

“Please, just go to your desk, alright?” Aglaea tilts her head and paws at the desk behind Phainon’s. Castorice turns around all embarrassed, muttering a myriad of apologies (none of them are directed to Phainon), and sheepishly takes her place at her desk. She puts her headphones on and is almost immediately pulled into a call.

“Ooh, is Castorice in trouble? Agy, you should send her to HR~” Cipher mewls all mischievous, feigning innocence. Aglaea’s head twitches in the direction of her voice, but she doesn’t look at her. “Cifera, please clock in,” is all she says.

A warm, supple hand rests on Phainon’s shoulder and he’s *mostly* recovered by now. “Are you alright, Phainon?” He coughs once, twice, and raises his head to look at her–

There’s a man behind Aglaea, and he really didn’t expect that so he gets startled. “Oh, Jesu–” Phainon instinctively clutches his chest. “Um, hi?”

The man doesn’t really acknowledge him, and he honestly looks a little… Confused? There’s a weird furrow in his brow, something akin to disgust or uncomfortableness. He’s, well–

I mean, gorgeous? Really just. A beautiful man, wow, it’s kind of crazy. Phainon is totally staring; strawberry blonde fading into a bad red dyejob, eyes all golden and feline and pretty, bronze skin *tattooed* all over. Phainon really, really likes tattoos. He has a couple of his own, and this guy’s covered in these abstract red streaks; *wow* , that must’ve really hurt.

Okay, yeah, whatever, hot new guy. It’s fine. Phainon’s feeling a bit territorial, because this whole company is very *girl-heavy* (and whatever Anaxa is) and he’s one of the only guys– and by far the handsomest out of them. He holds the title of *FLAMCHASE INC. Pretty Boy* and he’s not really willing to give it up or share it.

The new guy kind of looks like a girl anyways, very bishounen, so it doesn’t really count either way. Phainon’s more of an *ikemen* , you know, so he still has this in the bag.

“Phainon,” Aglaea speaks again and *oh yeah* , he’s still there. He was a bit too busy being locked in a death stare with this other dude. “This is Mydeimos. He’s the newest addition to Tribios’ team, so please be nice to him and show him the ropes, okay?”

“Uh, yes ma’am, sure,” Phainon mumbles, not thoroughly convinced but eager to please.

“That’s a good boy,” and she actually *pets his fucking hair* , and Phainon flusters all over and turns pink and pretty because he really, really wants her validation all the time and now he’s getting it. Yay, yippe! “I’m gonna go now, I have to find Tribios. You boys play nice, alright?”

Gracefully, she steps away and leaves them alone, her pleated chiffon skirt swooshing after her. As she passes by Cipher’s desk, she playfully tugs on her little braid and makes her yelp.

Heels and cane clack in unison, the sound getting further and further away, until Aglaea’s figure disappears towards Tribios’ office.

“Hi, man, I’m Phainon,” he tries, a little unsure, and offers him his hand to shake. The other man just… looks at him.

And then he scoffs, puts on his headphones, mutters *’good boy, heh’* to himself, and immediately gets a call.

Okay, the guy’s a *jerk* – cool, that’s cool. Phainon is not mad about that, not at all, that means he still gets to be FLAMECHASE’s perfect golden boy, because he’s nice and kind and helpful; and this dude is like, none of those things.

Phainon pouts a bit, but he doesn’t turn his attention from Mydei, because he’s just gotten into his first call and, well, that’s always disastrous for newbies. Phainon really *has* to see this, needs to witness this self-assured asshole stumble and stutter over his words as a customer is yelling at him.

So, Phainon watches, arms crossed and feeling cocky.

Mydei’s whole demeanor changes the moment the line connects. His face brightens up, thick eyebrows shoot up as he smiles, *beams* , all bright and happy. “Hello?” he starts, and when an elderly man on the other voice answers, Mydei digs in with his opener: “Thank you for calling DolphinSamurai, my name is Mydeimos, how may I help you today?” and you can truly hear his smile, sunny, through his voice as he speaks.

He’s *good* , really good– he’s *different* . He sounds gentle, kind, patient; the customer is very old from what Phainon can hear through Mydei’s headphones, maybe seventy years old or even older. It seems like the customer found out that he can register his warranty and extend it for free, and he’s a little confused about the process; on top of all of that, he wants to also place a pretty big order of kitchen appliances.

Mydei leads him through it, typing as he speaks, asking for his account; when the customer says he doesn’t have one, Mydei promptly makes one for him. He writes the ticket while the old man goes on a tangent about something, does the warranty registration at the same time he’s checking the site for the products the customer wants to order, and places the order while laughing at some joke the customer made. He’s nimble, fast, and exudes confidence. He does not fumble, not even once, nor does he stutter or put the customer on hold. He doesn’t even ask the supervisor for *help* .

The customer has some more questions after everything is done, and Mydei is even-tempered and composed as he works through them. When he has to repeat himself or speak louder, he doesn't get frustrated or lose his temper. He says the same thing three times, and even spells it out at some point for the customer, who must be hard of hearing in some way.

He's really, really mellow, even looks like he's enjoying this, and it's making Phainon a little flustered. He has a nice deep voice, honey over steel, a little gruff– and he has a *little* bit of an accent, though Phainon can't quite place it.

"Thank you for choosing DolphinSamurai, have a great day!" Mydei ends, hangs up the call, and turns to Phainon with a shit-eating grin. He raises a perfectly arched eyebrow at him.

In the grand scheme of things, it wasn't a particularly *difficult* call, and the customer himself was well-behaved– Phainon can easily achieve everything Mydei has in that call, and in even less time. But it *was* a difficult call for beginners, who are unfamiliar with the procedures, the apps, and the products. Not to mention the *people skills* necessary for handling a really elderly customer.

Phainon's pouting big time now, and he wants to open his mouth and say something snarky, but then his line connects and he hears a customer on the other side.

They work like that for the next three hours, shoulder to shoulder, and at some point it becomes kind of a... Thing? A silent competition of sorts, one that they have both agreed to nonverbally through squinting eyes and raised eyebrows, trying to see who can get the most calls done in the least amount of time.

Phainon has quite literally never performed better, averaging eight minutes per call, and he's taken *twenty calls* in *three hours* . Some days -the slower ones- that's as many as he takes in one entire day– though, to be fair, today's been especially busy.

At some point, between calls, Phainon pulls down his headphones and taps Mydei. "You've worked in call centers before?"

Mydei stretches, extending his broad arms above his head and arching his back, kind of like a cat. He groans a bit when he does and his nose scrunches up all cute. "Nah," he says as he grabs his water bottle, "It's my first time."

Well, *fuck* .

Phainon grumbles at that. Mydei has this mean tsuntsun mouth on him, pretty pair of lips, and it makes Phainon want to pull on his pigtails. "You're pretty good for a *beginner* ," he says, enunciating the last word with a *pop* . He flashes his best innocent face, a pinch of puppy eyes here and a boyish smirk there, and it works its magic. Mydei searches his face for *something* while the words register in his head, and then he frowns and bristles all over. "What's *that* supposed to mea–" a familiar *beep* rings out from his headphone and he stutters, "H-hello? Thank you for calling DolphinSamurai, how may I help you today?"

Hah. Mission accomplished. Mydei gives him a mean side-eye, and then becomes immersed in his job.

Their lunch break comes around not long after that, and his matches up with Castorice's and Mydei's. He gets up from his seat and stretches his legs, massaging his thighs and rolling his wrists. This job is seriously *detrimental* to his bodily health. Mydei is finishing up his call, and Phainon takes this opportunity to bother him some more. "How many calls did you take?"

Mydei doesn't turn to look at him, busy with writing his ticket. "Twenty, average call time of eight minutes. You?"

Phainon clicks his tongue. "Tsk. The same." He'll have to work even *harder* after his lunch break to beat Mydei but, for now, at least he didn't *lose* . A perfect draw. He can work with that.

Just as Mydei submits his ticket and is about to set his system to "Lunch Break", his line rings and connects. He slowly turns to Phainon like something out of a horror movie, grin maniacal and lion eyes all narrow and full of mischief, and he mouths the words *'I win'* before going into his opener. "Hello? Thank you for contacting DolphinSamurai…"

Phainon stands there dumbstuck for a moment. This man would rather lose out on some of his lunch break than concede to being equal with Phainon. If it were him instead of Mydei and a call came just as he was about to go on break, he would've simply denied it. What impressive resolve. How *fierce*. This is a battle, and FLAMECHASE Inc. is their battlefield. Finally, a worthy opponent.

It's Phainon's turn to be on lunch duty and even if it wasn't, he would've still bought food for Castorice today– she's done so much for him the past week and this is the least he can do. Cipher's lunch break doesn't match up with their's, not today. Mydei's does, though, but he's still in his *winning call* .

He bought Castorice a King's Whiskey BBQ from Burger King, because she's a bit of a gross pig when it comes to her junk food and he *loves* that about her. He even bought her one of those little paper crowns. He hands her the food and casually puts the crown on her head, then demands she pose so he can take pictures of her like that; Queen Castorice of the Underworld, Our Lady Of Sorrows. She pulls a cute double peace sign and a big, big smile as he snaps photos.

Hyacine joins them too, but it's just one of her regular fifteen minute breaks. Since Hyacine moved to HR, their schedules and their breaks don't line up anymore, so they can't hang out as much; though they still chat daily in their groupchat, him, her, Cipher and Castorice, and they play League together all the time. She's a beast in League, mains Yasuo mid, and works off her nerves by calling people "braindead dogs" in /all chat. Naturally, Phainon mains Soraka support.

But physical meetups are hard because, when she's not the super best kirakira kawaii Humans Resource Specialist, she's a popular trans lolita fashion influencer with 100k followers on TikTok and that kinda takes up all of her free time. Even so, her online career

clearly does not translate to any kind of sustainable real-life revenue, considering she's still working like a mule for FLAMECHASE Inc.

Hyacine is holding a pink cigarette between her fingers and her nails are perfectly manicured, with all kinds of cute trinkets and stickers. Phainon knows she hates having to wear "civilian clothes", because not looking like a perfect porcelain doll makes her dysphoric.

"So, uhh, new guy in Tribios' team," she starts, taking a pull out of her cigarette and tucking a pink hair strand behind her ear, "What do we think?"

"Haven't gotten the chance to talk with him yet," Castorice says through a mouthful of burger. It's comically large, almost the size of her head.

Phainon is picking at his fries when he answers, "He's not from Okhema, is he? He kind of has an accent."

"Nah, he's not. He's from Castrum Kremnos," Hyacine answers, and of course she knows that– HR does thorough background checks.

Phainon's eyes get all big, because he's always been a little obsessed with ancient Kremnoan history and has always wanted to visit the city. "No way, really? Did you know that in ancient times, Kremnoans used to drink the blood of their slain foes?"

Castorice looks at him a little suspiciously, then shrugs. "I haven't heard that. I did hear their marriages used to be soul-binding ceremonies where a priest sacrificed a lamb, covered the newly-weds in its blood and then they would have weird, freaky sex in front of everyone."

"Of course *you'd* know that," Phainon says with a smirk and then ducks when she tries to hit him, "What do you think, Hyacine? Any spooky Kremnos stories?"

"I think," she says as she crushes her cigarette with her heel, "That you're being very xenophobic in front of your HR representative, and you're putting her in a big ethical dilemma."

That's her favorite line ever since she switched departments. He could ask her what shirt to wear and she'd answer *"You're putting your HR representative in a big ethical dilemma."* Man, he misses hanging out with Hyacine. He should bully her into getting drinks someday.

"Ah," she turns around, "Speak of the devil, here's your victim." Hyacine nods her head towards Mydeimos, who has just gotten out of his last call, fifteen minutes into his lunch break. Poor guy. Hyacine waves him over, "Mydeimos, come join us!"

Phainon expects him to just kind of sternly grunt, deny her offer silently and maybe punch a tree, but instead he *does* walk over to them. He's holding a stupid red lunchbox in his hands. "Hi," he greets, softly, simply. Phainon watches as Mydei cracks open the lid of his lunchbox and inside he's got a hearty serving of konoupidi kapama, fucking *braised cauliflower* .

"What are you, an old man? Who eats cauliflower?" Phainon snarks, leaning back to take a bite out of his caloric-bomb burger. Mydei frowns, eyebrows furrowing all cute. "It's *healthy*

," he bites back, "You're gonna die of heart attack by the time you're thirty if you keep eating like that."

'Yeah, whatever', he thinks as he stuffs his face, and he wants to tease Mydei some more but Castorice speaks up instead.

"Hello," she says, a little timid, "I'm Castorice, I don't think we met," she extends her hands and offers it to him.

And he actually *fucking* takes it shakes it, what the fuck, why didn't he shake *Phainon's* hand back then? "It's good to meet you, Castorice. I'm Mydeimos," and he *smiles* , what the fuck what the fuck, like an actual kind little smile and not the assholeish smirks he's been giving Phainon all day. Alright, if that's how he wants to play, then it's on. *He hates this guy.*

"Do you want to join our groupchat? We have a groupchat, all of us in Tribios' team." she asks, all kind, and Phainon's getting a little upset because *you're not supposed to just offer up The Groupchat, everybody else in The Groupchat has to agree to it.* Mydei tilts his head, his plastic fork forgotten in his cauliflower. "I am in the groupchat."

Castorice laughs a little and she wipes some sauce off her mouth with her hand. "Ah, no, it's not like… the work groupchat, it's like a friends groupchat. It's all of us in Tribios' team but without, you know, *the hags* . Hyacine's there too," she gestures towards Hyacine, and Hyacine gives a little wave.

Phainon huffs and leans back against the bench, arms crossed. Mydei's about to say no to Castorice and she's gonna feel like shit, which basically gives Phainon permission to beat his ass. "Oh," Mydei says and takes a bite out of a cauliflower. He hums a little, thinks, then *nods* . "Yeah, I'd like that."

Okay, whatever, cool. Mydei is in the fucking groupchat that *he* made all those months ago, almost a YEAR, and now he kinda regrets giving everyone admin permissions. Phainon's trust is broken. Utterly stomped on. And yeah, he's totally sulking right now, and it's very visible because Hyacine notices -she always fucking *notices*- and she giggles at him.

Hyacine leaves because her break is over and she's a bit late already, which leaves just the three of them eating in silence. As they finish up their food, something catches Mydei's eyes and they light up with mirth. "Is that–" he points to Castorice's bag, "Mejiro McQueen?"

What.

Castorice looks at him, perplexed, then moves her bag so he can see it better. On it, there's a pin of Mejiro McQueen from the fucking anime horse girl gacha game Castorice has been obsessed with; the same one that she managed to convince Phainon to play. Honestly, he didn't really get it at first (he's more of a *League of Legends* and *God of War* guy), but she insisted and even showed him the anime series, and now… *Well*...

Now he has a barnful of cute anime horse girls that depend on him for their wellbeing, and he's very, very fond of them; they're kind of like his weird misshapen daughters. Loveable ugly horse-girl homunculi, their existence an affront to God and their lives fundamentally

gnostic. So he can't really *judge* Mydeimos for being a grown man that's really into anime horse girls, considering he's *also* a grown man that's really into anime horse girls, but it's… surprising, to say the least. He didn't expect it. Somehow, it makes Phainon sulk more.

"Oh!" Castorice says, her neurons fully activating, working at full power, at the sound of her favorite Umamusume's name. "Yes, it is! Do you know Umamusume…?"

"Yes, I do," Mydei says, and he takes out his phone to show them his lockscreen– fucking *Rice Shower* . "I've been playing since day one, before the international release."

"Really?" and oh no, Castorice is getting really excited, she has that *look* in her eyes, that little glint, and she's rubbing her hands together. "Is Rice Shower your favorite?"

"Yes," he says, just as monotone as before, "I like her, she's cute and timid. I like characters like that."

"Woah, I love Rice Shower! I like Mejiro McQueen because, um, she's all elegant and poised," Castorice is actually *blushing* , oh my God she's *so* pumped. And then she looks at him, smile wide and eyes full of joy, and *oh no* –

"Phainon plays as well!"

Phainon groans, runs his hands down his face and feels like digging a hole into the earth and sticking his dumb head in it. This is so fucking mortifying. Mydei looks at him, shit-eating half-smile, and does a little *huh* . "Really?" he says, fully teasing, and steps a bit closer so that he's standing between Phainon's knees. "Who's *your* favorite Umamusume?"

"Mine is, well–" Phainon sighs, "It's a little basic, I guess, but I like Gold Ship. She's funny."

"Gold Ship is great! I love Gold Ship!!" Castorice squeals and really, she just loves all of the Umamusumes.

They chat about Umamusume together for the next few minutes until lunch break is over and it's– actually kind of nice. Mydeimos eases up, gets visibly more comfortable, and he's actually pretty enthusiastic about Umamusume. He has a lot in common with Phainon and Castorice and, okay, they have the makings of a friendship but…

Phainon is a little worried.

This guy's kind of great. He's almost as good as Phainon at his job, and Phainon's been working there for *eleven months* ; this is Mydei's *first day* , first ever *job* in customer support. He's handsome, beautiful even, and has this calm, stoic likeability to him. Castorice is utterly charmed, and Phainon's chest is burning, because he doesn't want Castorice to be better friends with Mydei than she is with him.

Which is, like, the story of his life. It's always been like this, ever since he was small. He holds onto people, holds onto them *hard* until he draws blood and they get all scared, and everybody he's ever loved has claw marks on them. It's been like that with Cyrene too, every

time she started dating a new girl or hung out with her friends without taking him along. Phainon would always blow up in her face, cause a scene, and then sulk in his bed for several days. Give her the silent treatment while she tried to pry him back to her; and if only he knew, *if only he knew* .

He is a tar pit. He's never been anything more than a tar pit. He pulls people into his gravitational field, forces them into submission, charms them with his smiles and his easy going personality, and then he burns too hot, too frigid, too much and too little. Phainon, sun-devourer. He consumes, cannibalistic in nature, craving hearts and the love inside them, insatiable, unsatisfiable. He haunts the corners of his loved one's rooms, like a feline predator at night stalking an unsuspecting prey, and he pounces on them when they least expect it; bitching and crying at 3 AM, unspooling sympathy and compassion from them as if it were the golden threads of the Three Fates, begging for help and denying kindness.

He bites the hand that loves him.

Which is why, if Castorice were to find a better friend, he would understand. He's not a very good friend to her. He sat on his ass while she slaved all day with a vacuum in hand, and now he's getting flustered and angry about that whole ordeal *again* . Phainon would understand, yes, but it would still *suck* . It would still hurt, and he doesn't want to hurt anymore and hurting is the only thing he's good at and he loves hurting and he deserves it too; the eternal paradox, hating pain, craving it as well, abusive lovers stumbling into bed in throes of passion and breaking each other's bones out of affection.

He recognizes this tremor in his hands now, ants crawling under his skin, the bodily feeling that signals *"kill yourself kill yourself kill yourself"* to his brain.

Mydei and Castorice are talking about fucking anime horse girls, and suddenly Phainon wants to show them what the inside of his skull looks like.

"Phainon," Castorice's voice cuts through his thoughts, and at some point she's gotten up and grabbed her bag. "Come on, break's over."

Right. Work.

Phainon can't really focus on the next six hours of work anymore due to the, you know, persistent suicidal buzzing in his ears *but* he does get through it successfully. He still spends his next two breaks with Castorice and Mydei, and Cipher joins them for the last one. Castorice and Mydei are still talking about Umamusume. Cipher tries to strike up a conversation with him, but he's not in the mood, so she backs off.

At the end of the work day, the score of the little competition he has with Mydei is forty-six calls for Phainon and forty for Mydei; the customer influx slowed down considerably in the second part of the day, thank *God* . He feels a little better having beat Mydei, but is it really any victory? He's a senior employee, and this is Mydei's first day, and it's not even that big of a difference.

Cipher has to make up for some missed hours so she sticks around at work some more. Castorice off-handedly complains about having to get an Uber now that her *'ride is*

compromised' , which prompts Mydei to offer both of them a ride home. Phainon is about to refuse, but Castorice is already getting into Mydei's car and he really doesn't want to leave those two alone.

Castorice takes the backseat, lounging on it and throwing her bag heavily next to her. Defeated, and a little flustered, Phainon takes the front seat next to Mydei.

The drive is mostly silent, except for the fact that Phainon is totally freaking out– he's only ever trusted Cipher to drive him around since the accident, so his palms are all sweaty and he's trying to steady his breathing because he doesn't want to hyperventilate in a stranger's car.

He's thinking of her in the passenger's seat, just like he's sitting now, and she's very drunk and very angry, and she's yelling at him, and he doesn't remember why, and then her eyes get all big and scared. He thinks of her teeth on the dashboard, white and perfect, her lightless gaze, all the blood. He thinks he sees his face instead.

His heart is beating but he's holding it in *he has to* , his knuckles are white where they're gripping his thighs and it hurts, and it will bruise, and it's okay and it's not okay, it will never be okay again, and he thinks he should grab the wheel and steer all three of them into the opposite lane and get this whole ordeal done with.

Mydei seems to notice he's freaking out, throws him a small side-glance, and Phainon must look really fucking pathetic right now, because he slows down his driving a bit. He sees Mydei fiddle with the aux cord and it seems like he's about to hand it over to him, he's *literally* extending it towards Phainon and Phainon's reaching for it– except, at the last moment, he takes a detour and points it backwards at Castorice. "Castorice," he says, calmly, "Play whatever music you like."

Oblivious, Castorice plugs her phone in, and Phainon is *stunned* . "What the fuck! You were *totally* gonna give it to *me!"* he accuses, pointing a finger at Mydei.

"What are you talking about?" Mydei says simply, but he's got that smart little *grin* on his face, and he throws Phainon that sideways *look* . What a brat.

"Don't act stupid!" Phainon presses on, "You were gonna hand it to me, you faked me out!"

He's poking his finger into Mydei's bicep now, not actually mad but more so *teased* , playfighting. *Playing along* . Mydei throws his head back, and laughs; a real laugh, a little awkward, but clear and loud, reverberating through the car. Phainon is looking at him, a tad starstruck. "I don't know what you're talking about," is all he says on the matter, and Phainon's poking him so hard it's going to bruise.

He spends the rest of the ride grumbling and bitching about that damn aux cord, but here's the catch: Phainon doesn't notice this, but he's not scared anymore. His palms aren't sweating anymore, and he's not thinking of cars swerving on black ice anymore. Instead, he's thinking of how mad he is and how he got faked out by the new guy at work at his big age. They drop Castorice off, because she's closer, and she promises Mydei she'll add him to the groupchat right away. They're alone for the rest of the ride.

Phainon's feeling awkward with the silence, so he speaks up.

"So, Hyacine told us you're from Castrum Kremnos."

"Hm?" Mydei sounds a little distracted, "Is she allowed to tell you that?"

"...Why wouldn't she be allowed?"

"Dunno," Mydei shrugs, "But yes, I am."

"That's cool. I was obsessed with Castrum Kremnos when I was young."

Mydei's eyebrow twitches inquisitively, but he keeps his eyes on the road. "Really? Why?"

"Mostly the history and the myths. I liked warrior cultures like that, I guess."

Mydei frowns and his mouth quivers in a scowl, not necessarily *unkind* but… maybe a little exhausted. "That's not all it is," he says curtly, blunt.

"No, no, I know!" Phainon doesn't *really* know, but he doesn't want to offend either, "I'm just saying, when I was a kid, I really liked that part. You know, like the story of the 300 Kremnoans? And that one myth of Kephale tricking Nikador to strike their shield with their own spear?"

Mydei's frown deepens somehow, and Phainon's afraid he'll wake up with wrinkles. "That one's ancient Okheman slander meant to humiliate Kremnoans. It's not part of *our* mythology."

"Ah…" Phainon is feeling very stupid, and he flushes all over. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean to offen–"

"But," Mydei continues, not allowing him to apologize properly, "The 300 Kremnoans are cool. *And* it's a true story."

"Oh, really? I call bullshit."

Mydeimos is so taken aback, so *offended* by Phainon's audacity that he nearly misses the car in front of them stopping at a red light. He almost read-ends it, and the tires screech infernally with the strength of the braking. "You–" and he's looking just a *bit* red, "You'd disagree with dozens of Kremnoans scholars? *Haikas* , it *is* a true story!"

"How can it be true? It's physically impossible! Three hundred Kremnoans against an entire *army* ? Mydeimos, come on."

"It *is* true! There have been multiple articles published on its validity, I *studied* them all in college! I wrote my thesis on the validity of Kremnoan myths, and this was one of them," Phainon's *delighted* to learn so many new things about Mydei, "One Kremnoan soldier was worth *ten* – no, *one hundred* Okheman soldiers."

"Alright, alright, I yield," Phainon raises his hands in defeat, "You win, Mydei."

Phainon wants to tease him more because, truth be told, he looks very pretty when he's all blushing and mad. Mydei huffs a little and wow, Phainon really worked him up, because he mutters something to himself in a language Phainon doesn't recognize.

After a short while, Phainon speaks up again, this time trying to be cordial. "Why'd you move to Okhema?"

"College," Mydei answers a little *too* quickly, and Phainon can tell that's not the entire truth. "Were you born here?"

"Nah," Phainon turns to look out the window at the people passing by, "I was born in Aedes Elysiae. It's a little village, it's actually quite rural. Very, you know, picturesque. I moved here with my sister when I was twenty."

"Ah. Okay." is all Mydei has to say.

What a great talker.

Good fortune made it so that they've just pulled in front of Phainon's apartment building. He turns to give Mydei a smile, a genuine one, and thank him for the ride. Mydei acknowledges him with a grunt and a nod, which Phainon supposes is better than nothing.

Later in the evening, Phainon makes his pathetic dinner and sits down with it in front of the TV, stretching lazily on his living room couch. He's fully ready to turn on *Love Island* and lose himself for a few hours when he notices some unread notifications from the groupchat.

It seems like Castorice has, indeed, added Mydei to it. He quickly adds Mydei's phone number to his contacts, and starts reading back on the messages he's missed.

Dummyrice 🔮💜 *has added* ***Mydei Work***

Dummyrice 🔮💜

hi guys

i've added mydei

*he's new so please be nice to him!! ^_^*

Cipher😺😺

hey dude

im cipher

do you have a hot older sister or smth? 😺

like a kremnoan shieldmaiden?

Cinny🍰🎀

Dude…

Not. appropriate.

Cipher🐱🐱

stfu hr demon

im not talking to u traitor

Mydei Work

Thanks for adding me.

No, I don't have a hot older sister. I'm an only kid.

Sorry.

👎

The thumbs down is pretty funny, Phainon will give him that. In this groupchat, they're in a habit of sending random pictures of their everyday life, so Phainon starts by sending a picture of him watching *Love Island* with his dinner, and then another one showing Bartholos napping on his lap. Castorice sends a selfie of her at her second job looking all bored, but says he should catch up with Polyxia one day on all the *Love Island* gossip. Cipher sends a picture of her cats fighting, and Hyacine sends a picture of Anaxa with their back to the camera, leaning on their cane as they move some papers around, because she's *still* at work.

Mydei is a little late, but he sends a picture of a bowl of chocolate cake batter and Phainon *groans out loud* , because of course this dude also *bakes* . Is he the perfect man, or what?

It's quiet after that and Phainon settles into a comfortable mindlessness, watching TV without thinking of anything at all; which is like, the best case scenario for him.

It's an everyday constant battle for Phainon to just feel *fine* , and *comfortableness* is a little bit out of his reach right now. So he'll have to take it.

As he's getting ready for bed, and it's nearly midnight, Cipher sends him a private message.

Cipher🐱🐱

guess what i did

Phainon

oh no

Cipher🐱🐱

so new guy

mydeimos yea?

i googled him

Phainon

cipher!!

you're a creep

Cipher😺😺

yea yea wtvr

stop typing stfu

found his insta

do you want it?

Phainon

weirdo…

that's stalking, dude

Cipher😺😺

lmfaoo stfu

do you want it or not

its public mind you

and it got recommended to me when i added his contact info

so like??

Phainon

why give it to ME?

Cipher😺😺

lowkey i think u wanna fuck him

Phainon

???

i met him today

where'd you even get that from, you haven't been hanging out with us at all

Cipher😾😾

cats intuition bro

do you want it or not

Phainon

.

yeah, i do

Cipher😾😾

mydeimos__p

now hop on league

hyacines coming too

Phainon

fuck no, i'm in bed

Cipher😾😾

boosted dog

🤡

Phainon hovers over the Instagram app, unconvinced of what he's about to do, and then says *fuck it* and types in his username. A profile pops up, and the profile picture is a low-angle selfie of him with his sunglasses on, his long hair in a bun, and the sun behind him.

'Mydeimos Polemos'

Weird last name, but okay. Phaion clicks on it, still a bit unsure, and is relieved to see that Cipher is following him, so she's not being *totally* stalkerish about it. He has a whooping 73 followers, nothing new posted on his story, and… he doesn't seem to be super active on social media. His last post is from three months ago.

It's a little strange, Phainon thinks as he scrolls through his profile– Mydei uses his account more like a digital photo album than social media. He doesn't really show off stuff or even

posts many pictures of himself alone. There's a few of him, pretty recent, at raves and concerts, looking devastatingly handsome. Most of the time, however, he posts big photo dumps that seem to have a common theme, and he doesn't even caption them. For example:

Phainon's attention is immediately piqued by a picture of two ferrets. One of them is a simple brown sable, the other one has this gorgeous white undercoat with light brown stripes; it kind of looks like it's made of caramel. The post itself is a photo dump with thirteen slides, and Phainon goes through all of them. Most photos are of the ferrets being silly or cute, playing with each other, but there's also one video. It's filmed from Mydei's point of view and the caramel ferret is skittering around at his feet. He picks it up onehanded, gets up from where he's sitting, and throws it into a box of packing peanuts. Then he goes back, at which point the ferret jumps from the box and comes to wiggle and squeak by his feet again. Mydei repeats the same action a few times, throwing the ferret into packing peanuts over and over, laughing lightly, until the video abruptly ends.

Another post is a slide with twenty-one photos, all of them being taken at a museum of sorts. There's pictures of Classic orange-red clay vases painted with black silhouettes, depicting various everyday labours, moments from legends, and religious rituals. One in particular catches Phainon's eye; Phagousa and their Maenads. The Titan is depicted as a great wave in the middle of the ocean, using their watery limbs to hold up their worshippers –a group of naked, mad women– as they dance and drink and copulate under the starry night sky. Most of the other photos are of bronze and marble statues depicting philosophers, warriors, and Titans. There is one that shows Nikador sitting at Thanatos' feet. Both Titans are sculpted as humans– Nikador in their battle armor, looking fierce in their crested helmet, staring down at their sword with determination. Above them, veiled in a shroud and with their face hidden, Thanatos is gently holding a flower.

There are also pictures of ancient swords, spears, engraved shields, and even an intact suit of Kremnoan armor.

Phainon likes this kind of stuff, though he's not very good at history. Math was always more his speed, but in a perfect world, he'd be rich enough to collect antiques.

Before he scrolls further down, he stops and thinks he should follow him because he's starting to feel a little *creepy* . He even goes to message Mydei about it privately.

Phainon

hey dude

cipher found your instagram and she shared it with me

is it cool if i follow?

Mydei Work

Okay.

👍

But I don't post much.

Well – now that he has permission, Phainon happily presses that follow button. A few minutes later, Mydei messages him back.

Mydei Work

neikos496?

Cringe.

👎

Phainon

listen.

i made it when i was young so i didn't care about it being cool

just used my last name

Mydei Work

You know you can change it, right?

Phainon

i got attached to it

Mydei Work

Why do you have so many followers?

Phainon

i'm simply HIM

Mydei Work

👎

Phainon gets a notification saying Mydei followed him back. Somehow, this feels like a victory, though Phainon doesn't know what he's competing for or even what he's competing *in* .

Phainon returns to instagram and clicks on the next post, which is from exactly a year ago. It's a simple, short video– a man who is not Mydei is in a hospital, and he's very happy. The

nurses are standing around him, cheering and whooping, and he's very, very frail– skinny like a twig, bordering on fatal, his olive skin pallid and washed out. His head is wrapped with a scarf and he's so weak that he needs a walker to get around. He rings a big bell on the wall, and that's when Phainon realizes that this is an ontology ward, and this is a video of Mydei's… friend slash brother slash boyfriend after finishing his cancer treatment, officially in remission. This is very intimate, and Phainon feels like he's not privy to this moment, like he's intruding on something very happy and not meant for him; still, he thinks it's cute that Mydei felt the need to post it on his personal instagram.

Further down his page, there's a photo dump of his tattoos– and now, *that* one's dangerous. Phainon knows he shouldn't click on it because the cover photo is of Mydei's broad back, and just *that* is making him a little hot under his collar. He is *just a man* though, and God has made them weak-willed and easily tempted. He's also a terminally bisexual man at that, which doesn't work in his favor; so he clicks on it and takes a good gander.

A tapestry of woven muscles unfurls before him, perfectly interlocking like they were hand-stitched by a legendary artist. Every dip and divot is accentuated by those red streaks, as if a bloodied and wanting mouth has traced the lines of his muscles, and they are so *striking* against Mydei's tan skin– sun-kissed, tawny and smooth like clay waiting to be kneaded. One of the streaks slips down from his powerful ribcage, a red ribbon coaxing the eye to his tapered waist, cooing *'Touch me, see how I bend and sway beneath your palms'* – Phainon considers it for a moment, palms itching to squeeze the two divots above his hips and see the way those muscles shift under his hand. See the way his back might arch, the way Mydei might sigh.

Alright.

Enough of that post.

Phainon's already in dangerous 'creep' territory because he's three years into Mydei's instagram posts. *'Just one more'* he tells himself, and then he scrolls all the way down until the very first post on Mydei's page. It's from five years ago, and the cover photo is him as a child. He can't help himself, curiosity gets the best of him.

First photo – Mydei, maybe eight years old, smiling big, looking weirdly plain without his tattoos. He's a bit toothless and very scrawny, smaller than an eight year old ought to be. He's holding up a comically small fish and, from the background, he seems to be at a lake. A man's big hand is on his shoulder, but the photo is cropped and Phainon cannot see his face.

Second photo – Mydei, three years old, sitting in a man's lap. He is looking off into the distance, fist in mouth. The man is leaning his chin on his head, but it's also cropped and Phainon can only see his thick black beard.

Third photo – Mydei, seven years old, on his first day of school, looking snazzy in his little suit and his big Lion King backpack.

Fourth photo – Mydei on his first birthday, wearing a birthday hat, cheek pressed against the most beautiful woman Phainon's ever seen. *'He looks just like her'* Phainon realizes. Her

eyes are big, green, crinkled from where she's smiling with a mouthful of pretty white teeth. Her skin is olive like his, her hair the same strawberry blonde. She looks happy.

Fifth photo – Mydei, fifteen years old, posing with a diploma– first place at the National History Olympiad. Very impressive!

Sixth photo – Mydei, eighteen years old, side-hugging an older man. The other man is rugged, handsome, going gray at the edges of his hair and beard. It seems like he's blind in one eye.

Seventh photo – Mydei, nine years old. The half-blind man is kneeling next to him, and they are on the porch of a house. The man is smiling, gripping little Mydei by the waist, and Mydei's whole demeanor is awkward, maybe a little frustrated even. He's looking into the camera, and he looks *very* sad.

And then…

Eighth photo – The same woman, much younger, just as beautiful, perhaps a teenager. She's posing with a younger boy at a beach and, from what Phainon can tell, it might be the same half-blind man from the other photo. He's a little pimply, a bit awkward, gangly; next to him, she's radiant, her hair cascading down her back in curls.

Ninth photo – The woman, a stunning bride in a white gown. She's glowing, the very picture of a new wife, and she's *perfect* . Her blonde hair is done up, tied in a high loose bun, and her makeup is subtle, enhancing her natural features rather than painting on new ones. She's looking into the camera, unsmiling but not unhappy– rather, she is dignified, graceful. Composed only to hide the excitement beaming from every inch of her posture. She's holding a big bouquet of lilies, and a big golden ring is on her finger.

Tenth photo – The woman in a hospital gown, exhausted, tired. She's laying down in the bed, holding a small bundle in her arms, smiling down at it warmly.

Eleventh photo – The woman laid in a big cozy bed, looking lovingly at a baby. Her hand is on his tummy and he's gripping one of her fingers, seemingly wanting to put it in his mouth. Her eyes are so tender, so full of affection, that it all seems so fragile, as if made of porcelain. As if it could all be broken very easily.

Twelfth photo – A little blonde girl, five years old, holding a squirming, crying baby in her arms. The photo is very old, black and white.

Thirteenth photo – The woman, now in her twenties, holding a beer in one hand. She's toned, *hot* , wearing a crop top. It looks like she's at a party and she's having a lot of fun. The camera captured her while dancing, hand raised above her head. She is slim but not without curves, wearing blue jeans that hug every divot of her body. Her stomach is flat, covered in a thin sheen of sweat, her face a little red with exertion.

Fourteenth photo – The woman, still in her twenties. It's a selfie and the angle is a little awkward, because it's taken with a handheld camera. She's making a silly face, sticking her tongue out, furrowing her brows and crossing her eyes. This one is the most obviously

cropped of them, because Phainon can catch another figure in the picture– half of a man's face, one golden eye, a big black beard.

Fifteenth photo, the last one – The woman, older now, in her late thirties. She's at a waterpark with Mydei. Mydei looks *miserable* , like he just cried, and he's pouting the way kids do. He's wearing Lion King swimming trunks and a yellow bucket hat with lion (or bear?) ears on it. The woman is standing behind him, kneeling down at his level, holding him by his waist. Her head is on his shoulder. She's wearing a matching bucket hat. The light in her eyes has dimmed, but still she smiles, as if in defiance of something– reckless, toothy, boyish, a smile untrained in photogenics, sincere as a sunburn. There's a big black bruise on her shoulder. She's tired.

Phainon clicks the button on the side of his phone and locks it. He rests one hand on his chest, where his heart is beating very fast. He's feeling very tender, as if somebody cracked him open and scooped up his heart, leaving only inflamed innards and infections. Rattled a bit, yes, and thinking of all the photos he has with Cyrene and his parents; trips to the beach, high-school graduations, Christmas parties with big presents and magic.

The entire span of a human's life in snapshots, laid before him, all of the most intimate and beautiful moments; there are very few pictures, he notices. Only fifteen, and the museum trip had twenty-one. His chest feels raw, wounded tight as a screw about to pop, and there's a familiar sting beneath his eyes where tears are fighting their way out. He could cry, something in him deeply touched, as though little Mydeimos with his toothless smile grabbed his hand and looked up at him, all innocent and naive.

There's something wrong with those photos, Phainon thinks, they have cast some sort of evil witchcraft on him, that green eyed woman a sorceress; because he feels very fond all of a sudden, as if he's known Mydei all his life, or possibly he knew him in another life. He wants to gather him in his arms, the big Mydei and the small one as well, and just hold them for a moment. Perhaps love *something* back into him, maybe something he's missing.

It's just– it's very sad and very small. It's very *sweet* , all the little moments of Mydei's life, the dark corners from where he's managed to dig up some happiness. He was a fat baby with rolls, and then a small child, and then a handsome young man. Mydei always looked a little distressed in all those photos, upset, something not quite *right* behind his eyes; fishlike, staring into nothing, smiling because he had to. There was a bruise on one of the photos, he doesn't know which, a small one on his wrist.

Phainon is not stupid. He knows a memorial post when he sees one, and that's exactly what that was. He's done the same with Cyrene, poured all of his love for strangers to see, displayed it on billboards and transmutated it into expensive funerals; hoping that through publicity, through the humiliation of grieving openly, absolution would follow soon after.

It never did; it never does.

That's not the way Mydei did it, however. It's not like how Phainon has flaunted the image of his dead sister. The way Mydei did it– it was more noble, more distinguished, like a wound scarred over a thousand times. It was respectful, loving, kind. Photos shared with his loved

ones and his friends, *her* loved one and his friends. A celebration of life, not a blasphemy of one.

The woman's face is burned in his mind, beautiful and sad like dead mothers tend to be, perfect because she is deceased. A ghost not of a person, but of an entire time; childhood, or an approximation of it. Something golden, delicate, yet fierce as a prowling lioness might be. Always so defiant. He wonders what her perfume smelled like.

(If he were to check, and he does not, the post only has one comment, from one man named Krateros. It reads: 'She was beautiful. The best big sister.')

Phainon opens his phone again, navigates directly to Mydei's DMs.

Phainon

are you asleep?

Mydei Work

We just met.

Take me out to dinner before you booty call me at midnight.

Phainon

lol

no, it's not like that

i was just thinking

you work out right?

do you wanna work out together sometimes?

or are you the type of guy that's married to his gym?

The typing bubble pops up and then disappears many times until Mydei messages him back. It takes him nearly a minute to reply:

Mydei Work

👍

Alright, that's good.

That's a start.

Chapter End Notes

- Tag update
- Trivia/fun facts

Chapter 4: intricate rituals

Chapter Notes

This is shorter than usual, I had more planned for this chapter but I felt like it had a lot going on already. Please enjoy! I love reading everybody's comments so please leave a comment if you have anything to tell me or ask me ^_^ Things are starting to pick up, it's getting a little erotic, so uh. Beware? Enjoy?

!IMPORTANT!

Alright, so-

First and foremost, I'm starting to introduce elements of **Mydei's sexual assault**, such as **his slight aversion to touch**. It's referenced throughout the first half of this, but he doesn't name why it happens. I've also briefly edited the previous chapter to reflect this, just a small line about him flinching. It's not a huge part of his trauma response, but it's there and I want people to be aware that it's happening.

There's also a scene of homophobia and child physical abuse. It starts with **"You're no damn sissy,"** and ends with **Whatever, it's probably fine.**

Phainon has a big mental breakdown in which he **EXPLICITLY SELF-HARMS** both physically AND emotionally(!!), starting with **Phainon reaches for his phone, clicks it open,** and ending with **Tomorrow is his day off. He spends it in a vicious cycle of drinking and [REDACTED, TW]**

The following scene is Cipher's reaction to the above mental breakdown. If you want to skip it, since it's a little heavy, it starts with **Cipher is in the middle of a call when she gets a notification from Phainon.** and ends with **She can't take much more of this.**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hanging out with Phainon is like hanging out with the Sun.

'He burns too hot' Mydei thinks, absentmindedly. Phainon, drenched in so much sweat that his shirt clings to him, has turned the speed on the gym's Stairmaster so high he's practically running up on it. They've been at it for fifty minutes, him on the Stairmaster, Mydei jogging on the treadmill neighboring Phainon. The sting of exhaustion has set in deep in his chest, aching deliciously, his throat dry and parched like a bird in the desert– yet, he does not drink, does not reach out for his bottle of water. His eyes are transfixed on Phainon, and he himself– bewitched. Mydei does not look ahead of him as he should, at the treadmill's console, because he is pulled in far too violently by Phainon's gravitational field.

Magnetic. Arresting. He cannot look away from the other man.

“ –and I told the customer, *’Sir, no, I cannot do that for you, it’s against company policy’* and then he– *”*

It is incredible how much Phainon can talk. He has been yapping, uninterrupted, since Mydei met him at the subway station. For Mydei, it’s one of those days where words feel like lead in his mouth, where his throat constricts around sounds and he feels like throwing them up in a sickbag. The lights in this gym are too bright, the buzzing of the cheap LEDs incessant and relentless where they flicker above his head. Harsh white light bathes them both in moonlight, making them glow resplendent and melancholy; it feels like a dream.

It all feels like a dream, like he’s seeing the world through the colorless shards of a dimmed kaleidoscope. In this alabaster castle in the sky, Phainon blazes like the sweltering metal beaten into shape by a blacksmith.

Mydei has not gotten a word in, has not even tried *(it’s one of those days)* , but Phainon has kept himself entertained, chatting with a vaguely Mydei-shaped brick wall and making a game out of guessing his silent answers.

“Not feeling up to talkin’ today, Mydei, hmm? That’s okay, Castorice gets like that too sometimes. It’s a little charming!” Phainon has told him when they met that day, tilting his head unsophisticated and offering him a toothy smile. He reached over then, slinging his strong arm around his neck and pulling Mydei closer; all friendly and affable, as if this was normal, as if Mydei wasn’t constructed from noxious clay. Good-natured even, giving where he was not supposed to give, feeding a ravenous beast. *’No, please,’* Mydei thought, too stunned and too tired to speak; almost afraid, almost desperate. *’I’ll get you dirty.’*

With it, Phainon stole the very breath away from Mydei.

He’s been left split in half by it, fractured like this father’s precious china after a day of drinking. A burst blister of a man, raw and tender and spoiled with pus– Mydei tries to grasp at his innards as they unspool from his belly, yet still he finds them twisted and knotted into a gory nest on the floor.

Mydeimos cannot be *normal* about people. He consumes that which he loves, rapacious and carnivorous; too much when it does not matter, too little when it does, equal parts aloof and clingy. Measuring his attachment style would drive a psychologist to suicide. He has been both the recipient of *’What are we?’* and the clingy asker, three weeks into a relationship and begging on the floor for all that which he is unworthy of.

Mydei has always been *weird* , he’s come to accept that. Eldricht and eerie like the weeping ghost of a woman haunting an old mansion. He has been the two year old unable to speak, stubborn as he is now with words, the nine year old growing askew and awry like a poisoned vine crawling up an impaling pike. Now, for the past three years, he has grown more twisted still, monstrous, unrecognizable in the mirror; the reflection of a dead fish, bleached and blurred by the strain. A stubborn wisdom tooth, roots contorted and wrenched, unwilling to be pulled out despite the ache.

(*”You’re no damn sissy,” Eurypon had told him when he had been a rawboned seven year old, pulling him by the ear all the way to the car, pushing him inside and slamming the door.*

He had caught him and his girl cousins playing in Auntie's nailpolish, painting each other's nails. His were purple and magenta. He spent the entire ride back home peeling the polish off.)

Whatever. It's probably fine.

"Mydei~" Phainon coos, his face dusted pink from his toils on the Stairmaster. "You're looking at me all weird, what's wrong?"

Mydei suddenly realizes that he's been leaning forward, as close to Phainon as their gym equipment would permit. He pulls back in a flash as if the closeness scorched him, the frog realizing he's boiling, and scowls at Phainon with a scoff; this only serves to make the other man laugh all airy and easy, showing off his cute dimples. Mydei wants to break his finger on his canines.

Slowly, throughout their workout, the words come back to him; non-verbality dissipates alongside with the floating feeling of non-existence, leaving him more grounded, more present. He blinks away the bleariness of disassociation when they're in the locker room, unwinding from the gym session. Mydei is patting the sweat from his neck away with his shirt when he hears Phainon gasp.

He turns to see Phainon a little doubled over, his loose gym shorts rolled up to the crease of his thighs; he is massaging them. Mydei's eyes cannot help but wander to them *(he is just a man)* . He finds a pair of milky white thighs, smooth and supple, peppered with soft white hairs. They ripple with strength with every press of Phainon's hands, flesh shifting and rolling like tidal waves. They suggest softness, plushness, yet hardness all the same; a concealed predator, enticing a drunk man with a drink and trapping him with the hangover. His mouth dries up, and he is parched, and the drive to surge forward and mark those thighs is overwhelming, pressing on the roof of his mouth. He wants to know how pliable they might be under his teeth, wants to rip the meat off of them.

Mydei pulls his gaze away, up towards the little shocked look on Phainon's face. *"Mydeimos!"* he exclaims, sounding utterly scandalized. Mydei can only tilt his head at this. "I didn't know your nipples were *pierced!* "

Suddenly, he feels very naked– which he *is* . An unfamiliar heat rises to the tips of his ears. "Idiot, of course you didn't. I didn't tell you," he manages to say with small difficulty, throat atrophied from disuse. He coughs to clear it.

And then Phainon gets that heinous little *look* on his face, utterly profane, that stupid mean smirk crinkling the corners of his eyes. "Mydei, that's *naughty!* What else is pierced?" his eyebrows wiggle, and Mydei misses the implication.

He opens his mouth and lets his tongue loll out, permitting Phainon to see the little ball pierced on it. "Mhh 'ongue." For whatever reason, Phainon's expression only gets more mirthful as if he were a starving man presented with a feast. "Can I touch it?"

Mydei sputters, taken aback, and pulls his tongue back inside his mouth. He thinks he must look a bit like a chameleon at this moment. He flushes properly now, face hot and peachy.

Perplexingly, he actually gives this some thought, entertaining this ridiculous demand. He mulls it over in his head, eyes darting around the empty locker room, and then landing back on Phainon's sweet, expectant face, his pouty lips. For a reason he cannot bear to admit, Mydei finds that he cannot deny Phainon this. His lips press into a tight line and then, as casually as he can manage, feigning nonchalance, Mydei simply answers, "Do whatever you want."

The giddiness is practically radiating off of Phainon as he crowds into Mydei's personal space, pushing him backwards; Mydei's back hits the wall. Horrified, he realizes that *he does not mind this* ; and even more terribly, he realizes he craves more as he steps closer to Phainon.

(Mydei is weird about physical contact, jumpy and flighty, hates when people sneak up on him or touch him– on bad days, not even Hephaestion or Ptolemy or the rest of his friends. This is probably fine. He does not think about it, cannot think about it. He does not think about why he doesn't hate it when Phainon touches him.)

Phainon's hand ghosts over his jawline as if testing Mydei's resolve– or rather, asking for his permission. Mydei does not give him the satisfaction of a nod, instead he challenges him to take what he wants; he grasps Phainon's forearm, neither pulling nor pushing, but applying pressure. Phainon looks bashful all of a sudden, flustered, but he takes the dare hook line and sinker. His previous determination falters for a moment, blue butterfly wings unfurling to reveal something far more vulnerable, far more hungry. Phainon schools his expression almost as soon as he feels it slip from him, filling back with wonted boldness. A small shy smile spreads on his face, deceiving in its tenderness– Mydei can feel its sharp edges stabbing at his back.

With a touch so delicate, so featherlight, that it makes Mydei want to scream at him, Phainon grips his jaw, thumb at his bottom lip. He keeps his mouth pressed close, stubborn to not go down easy– it makes Phainon click his tongue, a frustrated *'tsk'* . "Seriously, Mydei…" he says, playfulness dancing in his voice. He likes it when Phainon is playful. "You're always so difficult with me… It took us two weeks to schedule this little gym date because you're so dang *busy* all the time~"

Mydei furrows his brows and parts his mouth to remind Phainon that he was *equally* as difficult to schedule with. "You were als– hmphh–"

Quick as Nikador's lighting, Phainon seizes the opportunity to hook his thumb inside his mouth, running it along his molars. Mydei curses himself silently– he's fallen for it. "Gotcha~" Phainon coos, way too pleased with his schemes. Coward using underhanded tactics, a shame on Kremnos' legacy. "Mydeimos, your canines are so sharp, mmm…" he presses his curious finger against his fang as if testing its edge, dragging it back and forth and jamming it further on the pointy tip like he's looking to draw blood. "Woah, like a little kitty~" Phainon chuckles as he says it– he *likes* this.

Mydei can only be glad that this gym sucks and it's empty so early in the morning. His heart is thumping in his chest, going at a rabbit's pace, one part scared and two parts excited. His brain is telling him that this is inappropriate, in a public space no less, but his desire urges him to stay still and allow it. His eyes fall half-lidded, hazy, intoxicated by it all; Phainon's

touch, inquisitive yet still gentle, the heat of his body, the musk of sweat. Phainon crooks his neck to peer deeper into his mouth, eyes searching as though he might find Mnestia's golden apple or Phagousa's chalice inside.

Phainon makes a little *'ahh* ' sound as his eyes lock with whatever he was searching for– Mydei's small ball piercing, poking out proudly from his tongue. His other hand, which has been behaving well and standing still at Phainon's side until now, grabs the other side of Mydei's face and tilts it upwards to give Phainon a better view. He moves his digits from his canine to his tongue. He pinches it between two fingers, pulling it outwards until the cold air hits it. It twitches instinctively in Phainon's grasp, and the other man looks so happy because of it.

Phainon is painted all pink now, rosy all the way to the tips of his ears and crawling down his neck inside the collar of his shirt. His breathing has picked up, panting subtly as a dog. *God* – his hand is shaking where it's grabbing his tongue, that's how excited he is. Still, despite all the eagerness, Phainon keeps his touch tender and tame, considerate, even…

Pleasant.

Mydei is in no better shape, just as pink and even more exposed– he's holding onto his damp shirt like a lifeline, clenching it as if it might give him strength. Phainon runs the hand holding his jaw down the side of his neck, stroking the sensitive hairs at his nape, then lets it linger on Mydei's shoulder. With how concentrated Phainon is on his tongue, Mydei thinks this touch was completely subconscious, Phainon's body acting completely on his own– as if it were one of its basest needs, like water or food.

Mydei feels drool gathering at the corners of his mouth and catches it before it has the chance to fall, wiping it away with the back of his hand.

He's stroking his tongue, pointer and middle finger running along the length of it, pressing down. Mydei barely contains the need to lap at those fingers, close his mouth around them and suck. He wants to swirl his tongue between his fingers, at the thin skin connecting them, then lick all the underside all the way back up. He wants to grab Phainon by the hand and shove his fingers deeper into his mouth, past his uvula, and show him he doesn't have a gag reflex; he wants to bat his eyelashes all cute and say *'Aren't I such a good boy?'*

Instead, Mydei stays still as a statue and lets Phainon set the pace.

Seemingly satisfied after the thorough check-up on his tongue, Phainon's thumb moves to the piercing, and he doesn't hesitate– he starts to toy with it immediately, pushing it back and forth. Thankfully, it's long since been healed, or else this game would come with some very unwelcome consequences. He grabs the ball with two fingers, his hand crowding into Mydei's mouth, and bounces up and down, seemingly transfixed with the movement. They are impossibly close now, chest to chest– Mydei can feel every rise and fall of Phainon's ribcage, flush against his. He feels his warm breath, sweet-smelling, on his cheeks and on his lips.

Phainon's tongue is peeking out in concentration. Very cute– Mydei wants to be mean to him all of a sudden. Bully him a little. When Mydei decides Phainon's played for long enough, he

chomps down and bites his fingers. Hard.

Phainon yelps and pulls back, cradling his hand to his chest. He looks offended, kind of like a dog that was stung by a bee with his cheeks all puffy and his eyes wide with surprise; Mydei finds it all very charming. He starts laughing, and then Phainon joins in too.

“C’mon, let’s shower.” Phainon offers and does not give Mydei a chance to respond, instead pulling him along to the gym’s showers. He’s acting as if nothing weird happened, as if almost his entire fist wasn’t in his mouth just minutes ago, ginger touches setting his skin ablaze and leaving deep marks– ugly and simmering with pus. Mydei wants to lick all the places Phainon has touched just for the chance to get a taste of the other man’s sweat, which is a totally normal thing to think about the co-worker you’ve known for two weeks.

Phainon treats that whole incident with casualness, speaking to Mydei on the way to the showers as if nothing has happened between them. That puts Mydei’s mind at ease and he thinks that maybe this is okay, and this is just how Phainon is with his friends.

He’s watching the water dripping off his bangs onto the cold tile floor when Phainon’s voice sounds off from the shower next to him. Phainon has insisted they shower next to each other for some reason and Mydei hasn’t lingered on that request. At this point he’s just trying not to pass out, because he likes his showers scorching hot.

“Wanna get something to eat after this?” Phainon asks and Mydei can tell he’s moved closer to the wall separating them.

“Don’t talk to me while we’re showering.”

“Huh? Why not?” and Phainon’s got that *quality* to his voice, a certain whininess. Mydei can tell he’s pouting.

“It’s just weird.”

“Okay, then I’m weird. That makes you weird by association too.”

“That doesn’t even make any sense.” Mydei turns to glare at the wall between them, as if Phainon might feel his intimidating gaze. Clearly he doesn’t, as per the cement several inches thick dividing them.

“Yes it does, you just don’t get it, dum-dum. Anyways, answer me.”

Mydei bites the inside of his cheek, swishing his piercing around his teeth.

A sigh. He can never refuse Phainon.

“Yes, I’d like that.”

Phainon is knuckles deep in a burger. He’s brought them to this dingy steakhouse, *if you could call it that* , cheap and homely. It has all the coziness and the charm of a high school cafeteria– and with all the filth to match it.

“If we were girls,” Phainon starts, mouth full and spitting crumbs, and Mydei groans in advance; he already knows he’s about to hear something stupid. “Do you think our periods would sync?”

“If we were girls, my period would be better than yours.”

By the look on Phainon’s face, you’d think Mydei just called his mother a cock-loving slut. He is *genuinely* insulted. “Yeah?? Fucking *how* ?”

“It would be longer and also more abundant. Just more of it.”

“How the fuck is that better? You’d be more miserable when you get it.”

Mydei arches an eyebrow. “Pain builds character. That’s why you’re so fragile and sensitive.”

“Bullshit. I can lift more than you.”

“Nu-uh.” and Mydei drives his point further by stealing one of Phainon’s fries.

“ *Give that back.* ”

“Nuh. Uh.”

Phainon leaps across the table at him, and Mydei breaks into a fit of giggles.

When Phainon gets home that morning, aching sweetly with the consequences of a good workout, he decides that he will not think at all about everything that has transpired– which proves inefficient, because that’s all he can think about.

The wet heat of Mydei’s mouth, the way he stood there and took it so obediently like a *good boy* . Phainon’s well-past his teenage years so he’s definitely *not* gonna get hard at the thought of his new coworker letting him fuck his mouth with his fingers which is kinda what happened. But his dick makes a valiant effort, a small twitch, and he ignores it because this is insane, that was insane, why the fuck did he do that?

He thought it’d be like, funny. A funny haha moment. He’d ask if he could touch Mydei’s tongue piercing and then Mydei would get that adorable mean little look on his face, call him *’haikas’* and then *obviously* say no.

Mydei instead said yes, leaned back and allowed Phainon to manhandle him against a wall and it’s just– Phainon didn’t think that far, okay? He never thought the answer would be yes. And he’s not a pussy, so he couldn’t back down either.

So yeah, two weeks into knowing Mydei and he now knows how soft and pliant his tongue is, how pretty his molars are and how sharp his canines are. How they felt so good pressing into his thumb, sweet twinges of pain. His head is spinning with it, how Mydei permitted it all, how much he himself dared to take. What is wrong with him? What’s actually wrong with him? *Who does that?*

He tried to play it cool after, took Mydei to wash up and then to eat at his favorite diner, tried to pretend like he didn't lick those fingers clean and sucked them clean of Mydei's taste.

Yeah. Not his proudest moment. Objectively though, the hottest one of his life.

Phainon cannot think straight anymore, so drunk on Mydei that it's making him look stupid. He's accepted the fact that he's attracted to Mydei within like, three days of meeting him. He's *exactly* his type. He likes hot women with big tits and long legs, and he likes muscular men with pretty faces. Mydei kind of looks like if you took a girl's face and put it on an athlete's body. He's buff, but not *too* much, very similar to Phainon's own build, though there are differences. Phainon's legs and back are thicker, but Mydei got him beat in the arm and chest department.

Ah. The chest department. He won't get into the chest department, because if he starts thinking about Mydei's tits, plump and inviting, and those slutty little piercings, then it's going to become a whole Thing. And he really cannot afford a whole Thing right now.

I mean, Mydei probably doesn't even like men. Actually, does he? That whole thing was probably a joke to him– it was *dead serious* to Phainon though.

As with all romantic dilemmas he finds himself in, Phainon takes out his phone and DMs Castorice. He tells her everything that transpired.

Dummyrice 🔮💜

okay so

okay.

so. Okay.

so you're telling me that

you just 'finger fucked mydei's mouth in the lockeroom'

your words, not mine

so you did That

and he let you do That

and then like way before that, he joked that you were 'bootycalling him at midnight'

am i correct?

Phainon

correct

Dummyrice 🔮💜

okay.

right

so all of That happens

and now you're asking me if i think mydei likes men?

Phainon

yes

Dummyrice 🔮💜

okay.

and you genuinely think this is a question that needs to be asked?

the answer needs to be elucidated?

Phainon

?

yes, that's why i'm asking you

Dummyrice 🔮💜

and you think the 28 year old internet poisoned virgin has the answer?

Phainon

you know more about gay/bi men than i do

Dummyrice 🔮💜

well g-d, phainon

yeah. i do think he likes men

Phainon

how do you know?

like what's your reasoning?

Dummyrice 🔮💜

are you actually fucking with me rn dude, i can't tell

Phainon

no i'm dead serious

i think all of that was a joke to him

lol

Dummyrice 🔮💜

okay.

well.

here's my reasoning: he has nipple piercings

Phainon

HOW DO YOU KNOW THAT??

Dummyrice 🔮💜

? he wears very tight shirts and i looked

Phainon

i thought you were gay

Dummyrice 🔮💜

yeah. i am.

i'm a lesbian, phainon, not blind. boobs are boobs.

i'm a good jewish girl, g-d gave mydei a nice rack and i appreciated it

doing otherwise would be blasphemous of me.

can a fisherman not appreciate the green fields a shepherd wanders?

Phainon

are the fisherman and the shepherd dating lol

Dummyrice 🔮💜

yes

they have crazy pastoral yaoi

very aedes elysiae

i'm cooking up 100k words as we speak

they're frotting on the shore

also i got curren chan today

Phainon

i wish i had crazy yaoi with mydei

Dummyrice 🔮💜

i know, phainon

Phainon

i wish we were frotting on the shore

Dummyrice 🔮💜

i know, phainon.

Phainon locks his phone and puts it aside. Eh. Mydei probably doesn't like men.

He's laying comfortably on the couch, sore all over from all the physical effort he did today– it was more than he usually goes for, but he had a buff hottie to impress. His hand is rubbing his abs absent-mindedly, fingernails lightly scratching against his belly and– okay yeah, he's officially horny. It's Horny Time. And it's definitely, totally unrelated to whatever the fuck happened with Mydei, *that* has nothing to do with it.

The upside of living alone is that you can jerk off anywhere. The downside of living alone is that everything kind of swirls around him like a bad Van Gogh painting, and it's not like a drunk dizziness situation– the world just kinda *looks like that sometimes* now, which is probably fine and normal and not a reason to call a psychiatrist. Another con is, of course, Cyrene's ghost haunting every corner, toothless and pale, a vengeful yokai. The final con is definitely the blood on his hands, the one he can't get rid of no matter how much he scrubs.

But hey, jerking off anywhere is cool. Almost worth killing your sister over.

Gay porn. His favorite gay porn, because it's been a while since he rubbed one out and he has to break out the good stuff. Phainon reaches for his phone, clicks it open, and– his eyes snap to the date. His stomach turns upside down and he gags violently, stomach threatening to spill his insides– another lurch of his throat, a violent threshing, and Phainon has to swallow his vomit back down.

It's August 24th. How could he forget? How has he not been keeping track?

Tomorrow is the anniversary of Cyrene's death, the *official* eight month mark. Phainon marks this day in his calendar every month, but this time he forgot– he almost forgot about it entirely. And thinking about it, she hasn't been as present, neither in dreams nor in waking. Not in his thoughts. He has grown placid, pleased and comfortable like a cat lounging in the sun.

He *has* been feeling better. *He's not supposed to.*

Is he forgetting about her? *How could he?*

Phainon rises from where he's laying down, coming up to a sitting position, hands gripping at his hair and pulling, nearly ripping it out. He conjures the images of that night in his mind, the way her blue eyes, those sapphiric jewels, widened in fear. Her shrill voice screaming out his name, trying to but being cut off by the impact *(her last words to him, garbled and scared– "Phain-unnh").* He forces himself to think about the thrashing of the car as it rolled over three times before it landed in the grass. He thinks about the pain. He thinks about how much it hurt when his ribs snapped; how, at that moment, it felt like the sweetest thing, the most correct thing. He thinks about coming to consciousness with his nose pressed in his airbag and his first thought, as it has always been since he was little, was of Cyrene– he called out her name then, voice small and twenty years younger, a tiny *"Cyrene?"* When he didn't hear her answer, he craned his neck and found her face down on the dashboard; her airbag malfunctioned and it didn't go off, but it's fine. It's probably fine. He reached out a trembling arm, weakened and cut and bruised, and lifted her head up and he looked at her and–

Yeah, there it is. This is it. This is that good feeling, finally, the one he deserves, the one he's entitled to; his legacy, his inheritance, a blighted heirloom passed down cellularly. It hurts– it hurts so bad. It's so good, better than any orgasm he can fuck into his hand. His blood is pounding in his ears, wardrum heralding doom, heart thudding as if it's trying to pump life back into him. This is how it feels most delicious, when he's so afraid and petrified that the entire world warps into the palm of his hand, small enough to swallow, reduced to this one moment of panic. Nothing else exists, hic ist nihilum, the ending and the beginning.

Phainon lights up a cigarette just to put it out on his palm. He moans at the burn, watches the skin brown and blister through glassy-eyes.

He reaches for his phone, ever the coward, and texts Cipher. Phainon knows she's at work, and he shouldn't, and this is selfish and hypocritical; yearning for release, being scared of it too, begging someone else to pull you out. He can tell she's in a call because her answers are slow and sporadic and she apologizes *so much* as she talks him down from it.

Eventually, the feeling subsides. Post-breakdown calmness sets in. He apologizes to Cipher, but she doesn't respond right away– when she does, it's with one of her usual memes. The landscape around him slowly greys until it's tranquil– he falls into sedation, barely dragging himself to Cyrene's room. Collapses hard on her bed. A sweet voice calls from her closet, sheet-white face peeking through; the gorgeous canvas of her visage is smeared with red as if a child played on it.

"Nini~"

There she is. Phainon closes his eyes.

Tomorrow is his day off. He spends it in a vicious cycle of drinking and putting out cigarettes on his arm.

(Cipher is in the middle of a call when she gets a notification from Phainon. Her first instinct is to ignore him because hello, she's literally at work. But she has a bad feeling about this– one hand is typing the ticket while she's working the customer through a technical issue, the other opens up Phainon's text message.

Her stomach drops and the hairs on the back of her neck stand up– it's way too early for this. She checks the date. Fuck. She should've known, she should've prepared for this, should've switched some shifts around. She forgot, fucking useless idiot, and she can't make it tomorrow either because she used all of her sick days and she's a little late on rent anyways. She tries to juggle this. Phainon is incomprehensible ("i;mf just fucking cant take it any more if ucking hate myself i hate it here i wanna ufcking die"), the customer is getting impatient, and she can't type as fast with one hand; neither on the computer, nor on the phone. Her back feels like it's about to crack, and she doesn't know which priority is higher; her job, or Phainon.

She cannot hold them both. She has to drop one.

For the first time in over a year, Cifera disconnects the call– just, fucking hangs up in the middle of it. She pushes her headphones off of her head and sends a quick message in FLAMECHASE's Teams chat– "brb comf break 5 mins". She runs to the bathroom, as soon as her legs will take her, slams the door shut in one of the stalls. It smells like piss, acidic and sour, and it stings her nose, and she's so scared, and she's running out of things to tell him. She wants to leave and come to him, but she can't. She's used up all of her sick days and all of her paid days off, and she could just claim it's an emergency but then she'd have to make up for the lost hours and–

She can't. She just fucking can't. She can't do that.

Maybe it's selfish and maybe her personal comfort is less important than her best friend's literal life, but if she has to spend more time than necessary here, then it's gonna be her on the news instead of Phainon. She has five minutes to talk him out of suicide.

It's repetitive. Cipher is telling him the things that she knows will calm him down, kinda like giving a baby a tit to suck on to make them stop crying. At this point, she doesn't even know if she believes them anymore. It's awful, but part of her wants to give up. She can't do this anymore– she doesn't want to do this anymore. Cipher wakes up gasping at two in the morning and checks her phone to make sure Phainon isn't trying to kill himself. Every time he messages her, her blood pressure shoots up.

She cannot bear to look at her bathtub anymore, or any bathtub for that matter. Every time she does, all she can think of is red blood on white tile, smell sickly-sweet. Just the thought of it makes her heave. Five minutes. Five minutes on the clock, and then he promises her he'll go to sleep. She reminds him that they're going out to a picnic next week, and he says he's looking forward to it. That's something.

"Do you want me to come stay with you tomorrow?" she texts him, knowing that there's no company-approved way for her to be free tomorrow. Still, she'll make it happen somehow. She'd move mountains if Phainon needed her to, even if it meant she's left broken and splintered.

“No, that’s okay. I’ll be okay. Thank you.” he answers back, and that’s just simply gonna have to do.

Cipher locks her phone and spends five minutes throwing up nothing but water into the toilet. Then it’s back to work.

She can’t take much more of this.)

A nice afternoon on the cusp of autumn– their picnic date.

It’s one of those days that happen once in a generation, a total eclipse of the sun, planets aligning and forming a perfect circle, purple cicadas hatching out of iridescent cocoons, angels singing with winged trumpets, cats barking and dogs meowing.

Because today, for the first time in forever, all -*and she means ALL*- of their days off synced up. Hers, Castorice’s, Cipher’s, Phainon *and* Mydei’s. This doesn’t happen, and as Hyacine thinks back on the past year, this has *never* happened before. If they want to hang out, all of them together, then somebody usually has to take a paid day off or switch some shifts around with someone else.

But it happening *organically* , as predestined by the computer that generates their shifts every month? Never, literally never.

So, the original plan was to go to a bar, get some drinks, get a little tipsy and a little clumsy and have a bunch of unadulterated, harmless fun. Mydei would probably be designated driver, because he’s a newbie and this can be counted as a hazing ritual; taking care of his sloppy drunk coworkers.

But Polyxia hasn’t been doing that great lately, and Castorice doesn’t want to be drunk in case something happens. Therefore, they defaulted to plan B: a nice day in the park, a couple of cold beers, maybe a few snacks. Hyacine even brought along a picnic blanket with little unicorn patterns on it and a pitcher of ice-cold lemonade. They’ve found a nice, secluded grass area in the park, a meadow of sorts with large oak trees shielding them from the sun, and a cool breeze blowing every once in a while and rustling the leaves.

Hyacine is sitting pretty in her favorite summer lolita cord– airy cotton blouse, all short lace-lined sleeves, and thin linen bloomers under her pale blue skirt. The weather doesn’t permit all the petticoats she would’ve liked to wear, but the bloomers are puffy enough to give her skirt a pretty *oomph* . Her silk socks come up to her knees and not an inch further, and her shoes are her favorite cream Mary Jane platforms with bows and a cute red strawberry charm on each of them. Hyacine has taken extra time on her hair, putting it up in looped side braids, all pink and blue and sweet as icecream; very Dutch milkmaid, very Pippi Longstockings, and very very cute.

She feels good, looks good, looks and feels like *herself* . Hyacine hates working at FLAMECHASE Inc. because they don’t let her wear whatever the fuck she wants, despite being a grown ass woman. She has to wear awkward business casual, black slacks and white

button ups and minimal makeup. She doesn't like that– she likes looking like an explosion of cotton candy and toothache.

Cipher and Castorice are sitting next to her, and Hyacine loves their style as well. Castorice is a little modest but still very feminine, a bit timid yet stylish; just the way Castorice acts in her everyday life. She's wearing a flowy, long sundress with little purple flowers peppered all over it, thin straps and a flirty slit on the side. She's done her hair up in this half-up fishtail braid, the rest of her *very* long locks falling down her back and onto the ground like a lilac willow tree blanketing her from behind.

Cipher has always been more tomboyish– very tomboyish, actually. She's all black cargo with many big pockets, a bit *military* even, chains hanging from the belt loops. Her shirt is a teeny tiny white crop top, tight across her chest, and it's so small it might as well be a sports bra. She never wears bras anyways, because she's got these small perky boobs that are the envy of all. Her stomach is out, toned and flat, her abs all on display for everybody to gawk at. Her shoulders are strong, the muscles of her arms defined. Hyacine can tell something is up with Cipher, but something has been up with Cipher since they were in kindergarten.

All of this to say– *they* look good, presentable, very cute and pretty. Hyacine has made sure of all of this, not quite micromanaging but rather insisting that they all dress up to take pictures, because they only get to hang out so rarely. This is fine usually, and Phainon behaves and sits next to them and they talk for hours and he enjoys his time together with the Three Wise Lesbians. But, well…

It's been different since Mydei joined their group three weeks ago, and not different in a *bad* way, just different in a… strange way? Truly, it's as if she took her two big dogs to the park and let them loose.

Mydei brings out a side of Phainon that none of them has seen before; boyish, unrefined, a little vulgar. Impish and a touch *mean* . If Hyacine were to presume, she'd even say Phainon is being *flirtatious* ; the way he sometimes comes up behind Mydei during their breaks and pinches the sides of his waist, hard enough to make the other man yelp, the way he teases him and stands a bit too close to him, as if he cannot suffer to part. As if Phainon were a magnet and Mydei were iron, and their bodies had no choice but to stick to each other.

(*It's early morning on some random Thursday and Hyacine is heading towards the breakroom to make herself a coffee. As she approaches, heels click-clacking on the tile floor, she hears the distinct sound of skin slapping against skin. Hard. Violent. She hurries over and swings the door wide open, only to find a group of men huddled together, 'ooh'ing and 'aah'ing with every slap.*

In the center, sitting on two chairs and facing each other, Mydei and Phainon are hitting the everloving shit out of each other– and it's not in the joking, playful way, they're hitting with the intent to hurt.

But they're smiling ear to ear, utterly delighted in whatever the fuck they're doing. They're taking turns, Hyacine notices. Mydei slaps Phainon hard enough to make his head turn, the sound reverberating throughout the small room, like meat falling on a cold floor. And Phainon turns back to him, eyes a little crazed, grin big and maniacal, and–

“Phainon,” Hyacine says, hushed, stunned, “You’re bleeding.”

Mydei split his lip on impact and small rivulets of red are dripping down his chin. Phainon’s hand comes to wipe it, but Mydei is quicker to act. He swipes his thumb across his plush bottom lip, pressing on the wound and making Phainon hiss at the sting; it is on purpose, Hyacine notices, because his precision is deadly and venomous. Mydei moves slowly as if trying to entice as he brings his bloodied thumb to his lips. His tongue peaks out, wicked, unruly, and sweeps languidly at his finger– lapping up Phainon’s blood as if he were a man starved.

Phainon inches forward, almost imperceptible, as if to chase for more. His lips are parted, his blood smeared like messy lipstick, blue eyes glossed over and hazy with want. His hands twitch in his laps, fingers flexing.

Mydei smirks, mischief playing in the corners of his mouth where they tug upwards, and he looks at Hyacine. “I think I won, didn’t I, Hyacine?”

Both of their cheeks are swollen and bruised for the rest of the day.)

So, like, yeah. It’s been like that, and right now Hyacine is watching two grown men chase each other around in a meadow. They have been at it for one hour, as in sixty minutes *on the clock* . Sixty *consecutive* minutes, they have not stopped to catch their breath or to drink water. Mydei is running around a thick tree trunk after Phainon, trying to catch him but finding that he’s *just* out of reach. He extends his hand, flexing his fingers taut, and barely grabs Phainon by the edge of his collar. Mydei stops his momentum, pulls backwards, and Phainon collapses down– and takes the other down with him in a messy tangle of limps. They squirm on the soft grass in their embrace, each trying to gain the upper hand.

All three of them, Castorice, Cipher *and* Hyacine, are watching in stunned silence, unable to go on about their little picnic date.

“Is this, um…” Castorice tilts her head inquisitively, a little curious and a little uncertain. “Is this normal? For boys?”

“Huh,” Hyacine considers for a moment, crunching on a Taki. “I think so? I didn’t know Phainon was like… this.”

“To be fair, Hyacine,” Cipher says as she reaches for another mini-sandwich. She’s eaten half of the cute little sandwiches Mydei made and brought along, while the boys haven’t even had a sip of lemonade. “I think this is like, enrichment for him. He’s been hanging out with three girls for like, a year, and even before his only friend was Cyrene. He’s been very well-behaved, but I think he just has some energy to work off.”

The boys are laughing, but it really doesn’t *look* like a laughing matter, because now Mydei’s got Phainon pinned under him and he’s straddling Phainon’s pelvis. He’s trying to hit him with his palms and his fists, but Phainon is parrying all of his blows with his forearms.

“This looks– violent, are they *playing* ?” Castorice looks at Cipher and Hyacine as if they might have any answers.

“Well… If they were cats, I would say… yes? They’re laughing and their body language is relaxed. So like, if they were my cats, I wouldn’t be worried.” Cipher shrugs as she talks, downing another sandwich.

This isn’t exactly Hyacine’s definition of a *fun day out* , but she’s had the displeasure of being friends with teenage boys before she transitioned, and this is kind of how it went.

Except these aren’t *teenage boys* , they’re grown ass men with jobs and they pay taxes, and oh my God Mydei has Phainon in a headlock now and Phainon is turning purple. “Alright!” Hyacine yells out, grabbing the pitcher of lemonade. “That’s enough, boys, come on! Have something to drink, take a *break!* ” and then under her breath, *“Jesus Christ…”*

Hyacine is starting to sound like her sister-in-law when she’s wrangling her kids, except her kids are *three and five years old* .

They both drop it, almost in an instant, as if they needed a responsible adult to step in. Grown ass men, Hyacine can’t fucking believe this. They straighten themselves out and Phainon starts approaching the girls casually, his stride relaxed, as if he wasn’t about to meet Saint Ica at the Pearly Gates. They’re both flushed pink all the way down to their chests, breathing hard and gasping for air, and covered in so much sweat their shirts are damp.

With all the grace of a toddler, Phainon grabs the pitcher of lemonade from Hyacine and drinks directly out of it, bringing it to his mouth and holding it with both hands– and still, he manages to spill some on his shirt. He slurps as he drinks and catches an icecube in his mouth, crushing it between his teeth and chewing on it. Hyacine immediately thinks of her five year old little nephew, mysteriously sticky all over, his mouth all dirty with spaghetti sauce and his grubby, moist fingers covered in Cheeto dust reaching out for her. Phainon inelegantly passes the pitcher to Mydei, who’s just as badly behaved when he drinks.

Hyacine catches a strange glint in Phainon’s eye and she sees the way his lips curl upwards cruelly; falconlike, a hawk waiting high above the clouds to dip down with ferocity upon an unsuspecting pigeon. Predatory. Ill-intended. Her breath catches in her throat and she starts to get up, but it is as if she’s cursed to move in slow-motion. She barely makes it to her feet before it all unfolds in front of her, all too quickly for her to intervene.

In a fraction of a moment, the very *second* Mydei is done drinking, Phainon snatches the pitcher away from him and pours the remnants of lemonade on his head, slaps him over the face, and then takes off running. Mydei stands there puzzled for a second, unable to process what just happened, struck dumb. He’s looking at Hyacine all helpless, as if she might have the answer to what just happened. She just shrugs with a sigh and tries to reach and help him, but then–

The fire returns in his eyes, a dangerous determination. He frowns and scowls, his face twisted with demonic grit, and then he chases after Phainon with a growl.

’Back to square one.’ Hyacine thinks as she sighs and sits back down on the blanket. Mydei tackles Phainon to the ground, and they wrestle for dominance.

She hears Castorice gasp softly next to her. “Intricate rituals…” she says, almost reverent.

The boys fight for one more hour, at which point they're completely spent. They are both red in the face, satisfied with big stupid grins on. Phainon's shirt is a bit torn and hanging off his shoulder– Mydei must've ripped it at some point in their struggle.

Castorice and Cipher spend some time at the water fountain, washing the dried stickiness out of Mydei's hair while Hyacine chides Phainon, all in good humor. "No, Phainon! Bad, bad Phainon!"

Later in the evening, things calm down, and only because Mydei and Phainon are so tired they actually just go to sleep, all of their energy spent. They fight over who gets to lay their head in Cipher's lap, to which Cipher simply says that she has enough space on her thighs for both of them. They nap as she's playing with their hair, scratching their scalps.

Hyacine smiles at the sight. This was nice. Her phone jingles and lights up, so she goes to check the notification– it's from their work groupchat.

It's from Tribios.

Oh no.

Tribios

Hey, guys!

I have something exciting to share

Surprise! We're gonna be team building in nine days

I rented this nice table at this pub/bar thing

Good drinks, good food

So please make sure you attend! It's to improve social relations between us

And I've already booked the babysitter and cleared your schedules for that day, sooo

You don't have much of a choice

❤️

Agy is coming as well

I invited Naxy too, but…

You know how they are

Alright, toodles! ❤️

Chapter End Notes

i don't know how i feel about this chapter. it feels like the emotions are all over the place but, honestly, phainon's emotions are very volatile. he's fine one moment and then incredibly suicidal the next, and then 10 minutes later he's back to normal and ready to have a picnic date with his friends. i guess that's reflected in the fic? shrug

mostly this chapter was meant to set up mydei's and phainon's dynamic, but then uh phainon took over and derailed it. so i decided to break it down into more parts

shoutout to my beta reader/editor/bestie gael whos literally mydei in terms of mental illness. they called me, and i quote, " a gay mentat who wants to memorize a man's ball smell so bad you write 40 thousand words about how he wants to kill himself"

also, i fiddled with the timeline a bit-- as of the end of chapter 4, it's september 1st!

Chapter 5: spilling

Chapter Notes

This was supposed to be one entire chapter, however it was getting long (over 14k words) and it's. Heavy. This chapter and the next one are very heavy, this is the blister popping, and I felt like there needed to be a break between The Horrors 1 and The Horrors 2. It's going to slowly get better from here on out.

!IMPORTANT!

This chapter has a general big TW for **SELF HARM, SUICIDE, SEXUAL ASSAULT** Below are the specifics vv

▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For all of its faults, of which there are *many* , FLAMECHASE's break room is actually kind of nice. They just got a brand new kitchen set, new fridge, counters, sink, even a small oven; full renovation. Their coffee machine is old but trusty, the professional barista kind, and there's a smoothie maker as well. There are high-quality cherrywood coffee tables circled by soft beige armchairs, mustard-yellow barstools around the island, and they even have a vending machine with snacks and drinks.

It's all very… corporate millennial, chevron-patterned tile floors and huge stickers of "inspirational quotes" on the walls (Phainon's personal favorite is *"A dream doesn't become reality through magic; it takes sweat, determination and hard work"*. God. He should kill himself in front of the board of directors.) Cringiness aside, it's a cozy little place away from the hustle and bustle of the call floor.

Phainon inserts the coins into the vending machine and selects the number for *'Coca-Cola'* because he's genuinely addicted to it. Good yummy cola. Castorice is next to him, pouring the *fourth* sugar packet into her coffee– which, by the way, is 70% milk anyways. She's just drinking milk with sugar at this point and it just so happens to be vaguely coffee flavoured. Mydei is waiting for them in one of the armchairs, scrolling on his phone all stoic and mysterious. He's absent-mindedly chewing on his home-made lentil salad because he's like, a health freak and super strict about carb intake and good nutritional value and all that. One time, Phainon asked him how he got that body of his and Mydei answered by scoffing and saying *"It's 70% diet and 30% training."* – which is factually incorrect, because Phainon is built the same and he eats like a fussy toddler.

Cipher is not with them, though they did invite her to spend their lunch break together. She said she'd rather smoke five cigarettes and get some pastries from down the street, claiming that she's too lazy to walk back all the way to the break room just to hang out. *"What?"* she

said then, eyes a little mean, *"We hang out all the time anyways, do I have to spend every waking moment with you?"*

Cipher gets like that sometimes. She pulls away and stops answering her messages for days on end, makes excuses to not spend time with him or Castorice. If they ask her out for drinks, she claims that she has to take care of her cats. If they suggest going for a walk in the park, she says she has other plans with her *'other friends'* ; Phainon knows that's bullshit, because he knows she doesn't *have* other friends, not since her wife took the friend group in the divorce. Her only other friend is Hyacine, and Hyacine is too busy with her job and her TikTok account to chill with them.

Phainon reckons that the only reason she hasn't completely ghosted them yet is because she *has* to see them every day at work. Still, Cipher is funny and easy-going and is down with all of his bullshit ideas most of the time so he's just enjoying her presence, even though he knows it won't last forever.

He has a bad feeling about it this time, however. She usually sends him memes throughout the evening after they're off work, or pictures of her cats, or she just sends random messages in their groupchat. He even asked her to play League together and she blew him off, which *never happens* because Cipher loves nothing more than to carry with Rengar jungle or K'sante top. It's been dead silent since the last time they talked– which was when he had a suicidal breakdown, so… Phainon sighs at the thought of it. He kinda deserves it, or maybe she needs some space and time which is like, conceptually fine, but emotionally it's making him want to rip his hair out.

Phainon knows it's selfish to push her and intrude on her like this. He just hopes that if he waits long enough she'll come back.

Phainon sighs, long-suffering, and Castorice pats him on the arm. The vending machine has spit out his cola. He reaches for it and they join Mydei together, each sitting in an armchair.

"So," Phainon cracks open the bottle, letting the acid get out. "Tribbie's team building tomorrow. Excited?"

Mydei just lets out a non-committal grunt, but that's just how he communicates sometimes. Castorice shifts uncomfortably and brings the coffee cup to her lips. "I don't know if I can make it," she says, blowing on it to cool it down, "It's kinda late, and my sister's caretaker leaves at 8 PM. So. You know, I have to be with her."

Phainon hums into his coke, relishing in the refreshing acidic taste. After a big, big gulp, he shifts to lean his head on Castorice's shoulder. Just really gets into her personal space to bother her, because bothering the fuck out of Castorice is one of his basest needs; it's kind of like how, every time Bartholos yawns, he sticks his finger in his mouth. She sighs but permits it. "Why don't you bring her with you? I'm sure Tribios won't mind, and the table is big enough to accommodate one more person."

Castorice clicks her tongue. "Is the place, uh, accessible? Does it have a ramp? Elevator?"

Phainon bites the inside of his cheek– he has not considered that. Does Castorice consider that every time she goes out with Polyxia? Wow. He's a little embarrassed for not thinking about it. "I looked up the place online," he answers, "It's kind of a fancy pub-bar situation, not old money fancy but like… Millennial rich hipster fancy, I guess? It's in one of those old historic buildings, so I don't… know if it has a ramp. I haven't seen one, haven't looked for it."

"Then we can't make it." Castorice says, and she's all heated up and angry all of a sudden. She shrugs his head off her shoulder and Phainon backs off. She's pouting, and not in the cute Dummyrice way, she's *actually* upset, eyebrows furrowed, staring into her coffee as if it killed her family. "That's fucking bullshit. I can't go *anywhere* with her."

"That's… not her fault."

Castorice whips her head around so fast that her ponytail hits him square in the mouth. When he meets her gaze, the look in her eyes is fierce like he's never seen before. "Of course it's not her fucking fault, Phainon. I'm not mad at *her* , I'm mad at–" and she gestures broadly, at the world around them, *"Everything else."* She leans back with a sigh, takes a sip of her coffee. Phainon looks at Mydei for help, but Mydei just keeps scrolling on his phone.

Something something laying in the bed you made. Alright. Phainon retreats more into his seat, shrinking like a kicked puppy

"Castorice," Mydei speaks up all of a sudden, barely caring to lift his head from his cheek. He's still looking into his phone. "Don't be cross with him– he's just a little peeved that I'm stronger than him, and it's making him act stupid." Castorice cranes her neck to look at him, struck dead in her tracks. *Who the fuck says 'cross'?* Phainon is actually *so* stunned that he does an entire 180 and turns to face Mydei fully. He cannot believe his fucking ears.

"No, you're not." Phainon says simply, warning in his tone, signaling that there's no argument to be had here. He's not taking the bait.

"Yes, I am."

Phainon huffs, kind of like an old dog sighing as he's gearing down to sleep. This is incredulous. Preposterous! Utterly despicable! Phainon wants to grab him and push his head into his salad. "No. You're literally not. We've been to the gym together, we lift the same."

Instead of being a *man* and replying to him, Mydei's eyes flit to Castorice– *God* , she looks so miserable, eyes wet and tired, her mouth droopy. She looks like she hasn't been sleeping well. The corners of Mydei's mouth crinkle in a little smile, and he's all handsome dimples and beautiful arched nose. "Don't you agree, Castorice?" and he has a *lilt* to his tone, one that always indicates *play* . Easy-goingness, *"let's just have fun"* .

Castorice sniffles a bit, her eyes darting between the two men, and then she just kinda gives a half-hearted, weak chuckle. "..Yes, Mydei, I think I do."

Phainon inhales sharply and leans back into the armchair, hands gripping his knees. Alright, so this is how they're playing it. Wow. *Wow* . They're ganging up on him. This is betrayal.

Mydei stabbing him in the stomach and Castorice stabbing him in the back. That's fine. Years of League have taught Phainon how to 2v1. He shifts towards Castorice and grabs her hand. "Castorice," he starts, solemnly as an aging king, "We have been best friends for almost a year. We trained under Anaxagoras together. I was your *first friend* . There's no way you think he's stronger than me, didn't I carry that new couch you got? Up all those stairs?"

It's true. Castorice got a new couch some three months ago, and she was worried about getting it up the stairs when it arrived– to which Phainon, of course, offered to help her out. He *is* strong, stronger than the average man. That's him, Phainon Neikos, professional strongman, and pinnacle of health– if you don't account for the smoking habit, or the drinking habit, or the not-eating-or-sleeping habit, or *any* of his habits. Still, he managed to carry that couch up several flights of stairs and didn't even break a sweat.

Castorice laughs, wipes at her tears, and lifts her bare shoulders in a shrug. "I don't know, Phainon, I don't remember that… And Mydei's arms *are* larger."

Phainon drops the heartfelt act, pulling his hands away from hers and raising them up like an innocent man accused of murder. " *WOW, OKAY!* First of all, they're not *that* much bigger, second of all, like– that's not all it takes to be strong, you know? My back and thighs are bigger."

"That's because you're overcompensating, Phainon." Mydei leans in all predatory, like a lion waiting to strike. "Admit it. You can't lift a couch, I don't believe you."

"I– this is *bullshit* , I *literally* did it! Castorice!!" and he points a finger at Mydei, poking him right between his pecs. Castorice is laughing heartily now, amused and carefree. "I can lift a couch one handed. Matter of fact, I can lift *fourteen* couches in one hand *and* Bartholos in the other."

Mydei leans in closer, further into Phainon's personal space, and his face is *so close* – Phainon blushes a bit, all pink like a virginal princess. Then Mydei meanly laughs in his face, a loud singular *"HA!"* , before backing out. "I believe you about the fourteen couches, but I *don't* believe you about Bartholos."

Castorice snorts next to him. "Every time that cat jumps off the bed, it knocks the earth off its axis." she chimes in, giggling. Phainon likes it when she giggles, because she snorts like a little pig.

Phainon doesn't forget this whole *Bartholos* ordeal, though, because the second he steps into the apartment after his shift is done, he goes hunting for that damn cat. He finds him licking his paw in the hallway, completely unaware and just as fat as he last saw him nine hours ago; what was Cipher *feeding* this thing? Bartholos senses his presence and while he is usually the lovey-dovey type, all rubbing against his legs and purring and shit, today he knows he's in danger. Cat's intuition or whatever Cipher calls it. Bartholos slowly turns his stupid head up to look at Phainon, who's standing in the doorway like a serial killer from the bad slashers Hyacine likes. The cat's big dumb round eyes lock in with him, orange to blue, fire and water. His paw is still suspended in the air. His cute little pink tongue is sticking out just a bit. Blep. Phainon almost feels bad for what he's about to do to this poor innocent creature. *Almost* .

None dare make the first move.

A western whistle plays from somewhere in the distance. A tumbleweed rolls in front of them. Phainon's fingers twitch, and he brings his arms out slowly *slowly* …

It then happens all at once.

He leaps towards the cat at a moment's notice. Bartholos yowls, perhaps in fear or perhaps it is a warcry, and he bolts away. He skitters in place at first, his paw pads unable to find any purchase on the polished hardwood floor, but then his razor claws come out and those give him the *oomph* to propel his body weight; he leaves little scratch marks on the floor.

It's a legendary chase– except, no it's not, because Phainon is, you know, a human being and Bartholos is a cat. Phainon is bigger, stronger, heavier, faster, and has longer legs; Bartholos, on the other hand, has lost the genetic lottery on every front. Fat, ugly, misshapen with really short legs and a big belly so he just ends up looking like a rectangle on four sticks. Phainon grabs Bartholos by the sides and lifts him up into his arms. He's meowing and squirming and *very* unhappy.

Phainon has a point to prove though– and a plan to make it up to Bartholos later. Phainon holds the tomcat under his arm like a fucked up clutch as he sets up his phone's camera, leaning it against the kitchen counter, and sets up the timer. He manhandles Bartholos so that he's perched on his hand– just as the timer is about to run out, he lifts him up towards the heavens, and the camera snaps a series of pictures in quick succession. He sends one of them, the best one, to Mydei.

Phainon

[Attachment.jpg]

told you i can do it

Mydei starts typing almost immediately, as if he was expecting the message.

Mydei🦁

Photoshopped.

👎

"This fucking guy…" Phainon mutters under his breath, and at this point Bartholos is screaming and clawing at him. Too bad, fat guy, Phainon just clipped your claws the other day. You are helpless. From Bartholos' point of view, the gentle giant that feeds him is rattling him around for the purposes of impressing his weird crush situation. Horrifying. Phainon switches his phone to recording mode and pressed the red button.

"Okay," he says into the camera, "I'm gonna prove to you it's not photoshopped, dumbass."

He lifts Bartholos again, and Bartholos is looking really funny right now, holding onto Phainon's arm for dear life with his dull claws and looking around with his big eyes for help.

He keeps bouncing his arm up and down as if he were weightlifting. Once he feels his muscles getting sore, because yeah, he's strong but this is still ten kilograms of pure fat and muscle, he lets Bartholos down. The torment is over, little one. Daddy proved his point. The cat runs away and hides under the couch.

Phainon sends the video to Mydei, and Mydei, once again, responds right away. Phainon wonders if Mydei is sitting under his covers with his phone in hand, waiting for his messages like a worried war-wife, giggling all schoolgirl-ish when he gets a notif. Probably not, though.

Mydei🦁

Poor cat.

You're cruel, Phainon.

A small pause.

Mydei🦁

He reminds me of my ferrets a little.

Phainon

i saw them on your instagram

what are their names?

Mydei🦁

The sable one is Nikador, the light brown one is Kokopo III.

Phainon

the THIRD?

what happened to kokopo I and II

Mydei🦁

The War.

Phainon

???

Mydei then immediately sends him a picture of the cheesecake he's eating. What the hell, sure.

Mydei was not exactly laying under his blanket and giggling *"all schoolgirlish"* every time Phainon sent him a message. Instead, he was sitting leisurely at his dinner table, stuffing his face with cheesecake and huffing fondly every time Phainon sent him a message. He pushed his buttons further because he really likes how whiny Phainon gets when he's mad.

Now, a few hours later, he is huddled between Peucesta and Leonnius, shoulder to shoulder, presenting his case before the Council of Five Gay Men. Peucesta looks like he's about to murder him. Leonnius is squinting at Mydei's phone and zooming in on the photo Phainon just sent him, the one where he's holding Bartholos up.

"Phainon is just like that, Peucesta. The boyish, charming type."

"Bro, he finger-fucked your mouth– your words, not mine, and now he's sending you pictures and videos of him in a tight short-sleeve number where he's flexing his arms."

"That's all correct." Mydei answers.

"Right, and you're *still* asking us if we think he likes men?"

Mydei simply nods, shrugging a little. He has completely exasperated this man– Peucesta throws his hands up and leaves the room. Hephaestion, on the other hand, looks extremely entertained. He's sitting on the armchair next to them, legs folded under him. "Mydei~" he coos in that voice of his, "You're so sweet and innocent!"

Leonnius seems to have thoroughly investigated Phainon's photos, both the one with the cat and the gym selfie they took back then. He returns Mydei's phone to him and nods sagely. "He's a fruit." he announces like a judge giving out the verdict. Guilty of gay, and the sentence? Capital punishment. Mydei presses him on. "Why do you say that?"

"He's got a gay face. Anyways, what's for dinner?"

…Very enlightening.

"I'm making spanakopita."

Dinner rests heavy in his gut by the time he's all set in bed. He's full and content. The blue light of his phone illuminates his face in the darkness of his room, painting it pallid like moonlight– as with most nights, he's messaging Phainon.

Phainon likes sending voice messages and short videos because he's *'too lazy to type'*. Mydei looks forward to them, because Phainon is nice and funny and he's got this all encompassing quality to him; the world stops and revolves around him, everything reduced to the 0s and 1s that make up their messages. He captures every room he's in with his personality, so colossal, so bright. Mydei likes being around him because Mydei gets to be silly with him– he loves his friends, don't get him wrong. They understand him in a way Phainon never will, being Kremnoans, and it's not like he's not *himself* when he's with them, it's just…

He's a different Mydeimos. Still him, but just another side of him. Calmer, more stern. He has to be in order to put up with Peucesta and Hephaestion's bullshit, with Ptolemy's bad

moods, with Leonnius' flamboyance, with Perdikkas' pessimism; and he loves all of these things to death about them, all of their quirks and flaws and the little details that make them *them* . He wouldn't change them for the world. There is a space in his heart engraved with their names, and it will be forever there no matter what happens, what pulls them apart or brings them together.

But Phainon is different too, in a refreshing and exciting way. Newer. His endless facets fascinate him, an onion with infinite layers. He wants to know what he looks like bare and naked and full of filth, wants to know how he gets angry and upset, wants to know how pretty he is when he cries. Wants crawl into his ribcage and poke at his ruby red heart, too big for his own good. Break open his beautiful skull and see what nebulas pour out. He wants to dissect Phainon beautifully, and see all the parts that match up with his, all the ways in which they are alike– all the ways in which they are different, too.

He sighs wistfully into his pillow. He's had crushes before, most notably on Hephaestion when they were both dumb college kids, but this, too, is different– *he* is different. Older, meaner, a little more chipped in all the wrong places, growing uglier by the day, less of anything and more of nothing.

Mydei keeps replaying the most recent video Phainon sent him. It's shot from his point of view and it shows Bartholos happily gulping down one of those Churu purees. He's getting it all over his whiskers and his snout. When he's done, Phainon puts aside the tube and starts petting behind his ears, which makes Bartholos purr like crazy. *"See,"* Phainon texted him alongside the video, *"He's not mad at me at all."*

Mydei is fixated on the video, because Phainon's lovely slim fingers are in it. He's got beautiful hands, large but elegant, like a pianist. His nails are short, manicured, well taken care of. Phainon is very *tidy* in general, almost sterile in quality, like he takes very good care of himself but only because he wants to hide something. Mydei glimpses the ragged edge of a scar stitched closed, vertical, pale and raised against Phainon's smooth wrist. He hadn't noticed it before, hadn't thought to look for it either. He feels a strange kinship over it, the intimacy of the razor, the fascination with watching blood drip down in droplets; he knows it, bears the marks like Aquila bore the Sky, smaller and more subtle, horizontal *(all of that to say; less deadly)* . Mydei has noticed that Phainon sometimes has trouble flexing his thumb, and now that he thinks about it, his grasp on objects is unstable at best. Yes, he remembers now– Phainon sometimes randomly drops things, completely unprompted and for no apparent reason. He complains of pain in his wrist and his arm. Mydei hums. Distal median nerve injury, most likely. Common with this suicide method, but his isn't severe. It could be fixed with surgery.

His gaze fixes back on those fingers, supple and alluring. Mydei remembers them soft to touch, uncalloused (unlike his own), gentle. They felt good on his skin, on his arms and on his jaw. His caresses were inquisitive, looking to explore and not claim; barely-there grazes that were both stubborn and timid. He sighs into his pillow. It has been a long time since he's been touched lustfully by someone, three years to be exact, and even then, it was different from how Phainon did it.

Phainon asked.

Mydei's never really enjoyed sex, it was something he did but never really *understood* . To be fair, though, none of his past lovers were exactly good at it either. They were all hurried and kind of selfish, and Mydei felt like he was more so stuck in a whirlwind than sharing a moment of passion with someone.

But he liked the attention, at least. The way it could almost feel like love if he pretended very hard. He liked feeling useful, like he was good at something for once. It was a nice little lie.

And then, well…

Mydei suddenly thinks of the weight of Phainon's fingers in his mouth, how they pushed down his tongue and caressed his teeth. The heat of Phainon's chest against his, his beautiful flushed face filled with wonder, and everything was so mellow and so *meek* . The way he stroked his nape and lingered down to rest his hand on his shoulder, the way he was breathing so hot and sweet. He looked absolutely wrecked, the poor thing, as if sticking his fingers in Mydei's mouth and just petting his jaw was the best thing there ever was. Mydei loved it. It was more exhilarating than any blowjob he's ever gotten.

So why, now, is he feeling like throwing up?

The enormity of his desire disgusts him.

All of a sudden, he feels like he is too small for his skin, like it's ill-fitting. Like there are a million bugs skittering under it, an entire bevy of them, flesh-eating; he feels them from the crown of his head to the tips of his toes, skittering. The only remedy, he thinks, must be ripping his skin off. Letting squirming maggots eat it, and regrow a new epidermis. A clean one. Untouched. Unsoiled.

When his gut twists with nausea, it is in the shape of Adrianos.

"What a mark he's left on you! Woe is you, Mydeimos, that you must carry it around! Always with you. Never apart." The chorós sings, star-like, the cruel Fates unspooling the tragōidía of his life. *Oedipus Rex. Antigone. Philoctetes.* He unfolds as if by the pen of Sophocles. Uselessly stuck in this cycle, vicious Mobius strip, eternally looping back onto itself.

This is all it is. This is all it will ever be. This is all he has become.

Mydeimos slams open the door to the bathroom and falls to his knees in front of the toilet, as if he could vomit out all of the illness inside him. The labour comes up empty, and he ends up dry heaving with his head in the bowl. Peucesta must've heard him retching, because he peeks out of his room and comes to see.

"You good, Mydei?"

Mydei's hands are shaking where they are gripping the porcelain toilet, and he has become damp all over. His shirt clings to his body, wet on the chest and on the armpits as though he has just ran a marathon. His face has taken on the veil of pallor, growing white and hollow– carved from cheese, harsh and unpretty. He looks at his friend with tired eyes, molten gold dimmed into daffodil yellow. His lips are cracked. Peucesta regards him strangely, equal parts

worried and bored; he has this long black hair, bone-straight, a face marred by piercings, every inch of his body covered in tattoos. Thanatos themselves come to take him, Mydei reckons, yet he is not so lucky.

“Yeah,” he blubbers out, “I’m good, just… the pie. It didn’t do me good.”

“Ah…” Peucesta seems unconvinced, but unwilling to press further. Mydei does this sometimes– used to do this often. He thought he had moved past it, but clearly hasn’t. “Alright, man.”

The brief walk back to his room is wobbly, and then he collapses into bed like a corpse thrown into a pauper’s grave– heavy, as if his bones were weighted down with steel. He sinks into the mattress, but not as if it were a fluffy cloud– he sinks on it as if it were made of nails, impaling him in all the good pressure points to leave him unmoveable, paralyzed, and numb. If that were possible, he could grow roots here, become dressed in robes of moss. Flowers would grow out of his fingernails, white lilies– or perhaps something less innocent, deadly nightshade or oleander. He could sleep then, the King of The Woods, as Georios slept after the earth was formed.

He could sleep forever.

When Mydei reaches for the small razor in his nightstand’s drawer, he does not do it in a panic or a haze. He does not despair, he never has. He reaches for it calmly, as if it was just simply another one of his daily deeds, like buying groceries or washing the dishes. Something that simply has to be done. He pats around the drawer’s bottom for it, and when his fingers find its sharp edge, Mydei stops to consider it.

You see, he has this app on his phone that counts the days since he last self-harmed, and Mydei just broke one continuous month. And despite it all, despite the wall that stands between him and reality, he was proud of it. Happy, even. He likes seeing the number get bigger and bigger, strangely enough. Maybe it infected him with a bit of self-worth, who knows, but it’s enough to halt him.

Alright, no cutting. His therapist will be very proud. He resorts instead to biting his hangnails until they bleed, which is *not* cutting and it means he doesn’t have to reset the count.

And it still gets the job done, too.

The light bulb in his therapist’s office flickers above his head. Its light is yellow, sickly like jaundice, and it bathes the entire room in an eerie glow. Mydei is on the couch, clutching a throw pillow in his arms and idly playing with the tassels around its edge. In front of him sits his therapist, a stern-looking older woman, legs crossed. She’s holding a spiral-bound red notebook in her hands, and she has been holding it every session for the past five years. Sometimes, as he speaks, she will write down something in it.

Mydei is not speaking now, however, so she is not noting anything down– he is not speaking because he is transfixed by the light fixture. It’s one of those modern abstract lights– Mydei thinks that it looks like a legless jellyfish, or perhaps a frozen nebula exploding. The

lightbulb keeps flickering, and he can hear the electricity humming inside it. He blinks uselessly at it, mouth a little open.

Mrs. Sofia clears her throat, and he lazily drags his eyes to look at her. Her face is unreadable as it has always been. “Mydeimos?”

“...Yes?”

She sighs, though not out of frustration, and yeah– there she goes. Writing in her notebook. Her hand comes to push her glasses up, and then she’s back to boring into Mydei with her eyes– brown, warm, beautiful. “We have to get you off Lithium.” Mydei doesn’t say anything, but the question is clear on his face, found in the furrow of his brow. “You were talking and then spaced out for thirty seconds.”

Mydei makes a face, scrunches up his nose as if he smelled spoiled food. He does not want to get off Lithium, does not even want to think about it. To this, Mrs. Sofia also makes a face, though a subtler one; a curt ‘oh come *on* ’ look. She taps her pen against the notebook, and the sound of it makes Mydei want to tear it out of her hands and throw it out the window. Maybe take out the lightbulb while at it too. “Lithium toxicity is life-threatening. It can lead to seizures, and it’s been known to cause end-stage renal disease. Mydei, I promise you there’s better treatments for bipolar. It’s a short-term medication. It was prescribed to you as an *emergency* .”

Mydei pouts at that and crosses his arms over the pillow like a hug. He presses deeper into the couch, as though he might disappear inside it– as though this was a consequence he could run from. “I don’t want to talk about that right now. I have an appointment with my psychiatrist in a few weeks.”

Mrs. Sofia nods, slowly, and Mydei can tell she’s not fully convinced. She shifts her crossed legs around, now crossing right over left. “Before you spaced out, you were telling me about this man you met at work.”

“Oh. Yes, Phainon. So, uh, how do I say this… I’ve been meaning to tell you, but honestly I– forgot? But, um, we went to the gym together and he put his fingers in my mouth.”

Mrs. Sofia can’t even *pretend* to not be surprised, that’s how off-guard it takes her. Her eyebrows twitch upward, mouth falling open a little bit before she schools her expression back to the familiar sternness. She nods. “How did that happen? Please elaborate.”

Mydei takes a deep breath and averts his gaze, because this is all just really embarrassing. “So after we worked out, we were in the lockers and he noticed my tongue piercing. And then he asked if he could touch it, and I said yes, and so he did. By putting his fingers in my mouth and kind of um, touching around. And he held my jaw too. And it felt– it was, you know, it was…” Mydei wants to die. “You know.”

“Sexually charged? Intimate?”

He covers his face with his hands. This is not what they usually talk about. He’s been seeing her for the past five years, and at first it was to heal the dad-murdering-your-mom trauma, but

that kind of got put on hold for a while when Adrianos happened. So they've been going in circles about that particular thing for the past three years, and they've slowly started to go in circles about the mom thing too. They don't talk about his sex life because there is none. Mydei is completely and utterly desexed. He doesn't even masturbate– he gets the urge to, of course he does, but he doesn't do it. He doesn't, because it makes him feel guilty and dirty and he can't orgasm anyways because of his meds. Suffice to say Mydeimos has considered himself somebody that has fully moved on to a sex-free life which, apparently, is not true.

And that's bad, it's bad that it's not true. It's bad that the fires of his libido are being fanned, because his libido disgusts him. The very thought of it makes him want to hurl. He thinks of Phainon caressing up and down his arms and kissing him on the lips, chaste as a knight kissing his lady, and saying *"Mydeimos, you are so beautiful, you're perfect, I love you so much."* and he gets so squirmy and toasty and he wants to giggle into his pillow and kick his legs up. His fantasies rarely move past kissing and cuddling and tracing the sun tattoo on Phainon's neck. Sometimes, though, he imagines grabbing Phainon's hand by the wrist, running his thumb over the scar there, and leading him to shove his fingers down his throat as far as they'll go. Swallowing around him, eyes fluttering closed like butterfly wings. He does not have a gag reflex, and Phainon would gasp at that, and he'd go pink all over to the tips of his ears. He would moan and make sure Phainon feels every vibration, and then he'd look up at him with pretty golden eyes, all innocent and doe-like with their thick eyelashes, and he would have these alluring tears in his eyes to make him look all the more titillating. Mydei would lick Phainon's fingers, swirling his tongue around them and pressing his piercing deep on the underside of his fingertip. In this particular fantasy, they both cum untouched and then they get married, live happily ever after and never argue and neither one of them commits domestic homicide.

This, all of this, all of the soft feelings in his chest squeezing his heart, the way he imagines the smell of Phainon's musk, his lovely lips on his, fingers intertwined, makes him suicidal. It makes him have panic attacks that feel like his heart is going to stop. It makes him feel as if he's crawled ten miles through shit and mud and vomit, it sends him to the shower where he scrubs his body until it turns pink and inflamed.

"Mydei." his therapist brings his attention back to her, and he groans a bit– almost whines. He shifts on the couch uncomfortably. "Would you say that the interaction was sexually charged?"

"Uh… yeah, I guess. Something like that."

She writes down something quick. "Right. And how did that make you feel, in the moment?"

"I– uhm. Oh, I…" he laughs nervously and shifts even more, starts pulling on the pillow's tassels. "I don't know, I mean, you know…"

She just cocks an eyebrow. Cruel.

"In the moment, it felt… nice, I guess? I liked it, I think, it felt…" he gestures broadly with his hands, at nothing in particular.

"Were you aroused?"

Mydei chokes on his spit and sputters. “Y-yeah? I guess.”

Mrs. Sofia scribbles something in her notebook, and then she’s back to him. “And you allowed it to happen?”

“Hm?”

“You permitted it? Consented?”

Mydei grows very tense all of a sudden, and his fight or flight instinct kicks in. He wonders if he still has to pay if he runs out of his therapy session. “I said *’do whatever you want’* to be a dick, but I meant yes.”

“Alright,” she fixes her glasses, “And how did you feel afterwards?”

“I felt normal, and then at night when I was in bed, I suddenly started feeling all weird. Um. Dirty, I guess? Like I did something wrong, or… then I thought, yeah, I let him do it, but what if I didn’t?”

Mydei sees Mrs. Sofia emote for the *second* time in five years. A small look of surprise, and then it’s back to the poker face. “Pardon?”

“Like, I said yes, but what if I didn’t?”

“You verbally said *’yes’* –”

“I said *’do whatever you want’* .”

“Basically *’yes’* . Were you being coerced? Did you feel unsafe, as though something bad might happen if you turned him down?”

“No, I don’t think Phainon’s like that. If I said no, he’d just laugh it off and move on.”

“Right, so there was no pressuring involved?”

“No.”

“So then…?”

“It’s like… I wanted it, but what if I didn’t actually want it?”

“That’s impossible. You can’t want and not want something at the same time.”

“I– no, you don’t understand,” and now he’s getting agitated, and that feeling is creeping up the back of his head, and he kind of wants to cry. “What if I didn’t actually want it, but I still said yes, and then it still happened?”

“I suppose that would be sexual harrassment.”

“Yeah."

“But you *did* want it.”

“But what if–”

Mrs. Sofia puts down her pen, *loudly* . “Mydeimos, you are in control of your actions and of your thoughts. You are an adult and you are capable of consent. It’s yours to give. Even if it has been violated, or you’ve been pressured, you still own it. You cannot give it out by accident. You are allowed to *want* something.”

“...Okay.”

She clicks her tongue, tilts her head, and she’s got that look in her eyes that Mydei recognizes– the one that forewarns of something painful. “It’s easier for you to accept your consent being violated than it being respected. It’s more familiar. You are in uncharted waters. You feel it’s more natural for you to have something taken away by force than to give it out freely– and the fact that you have completely avoided any sort of sexual behaviour doesn’t help. You want it *–and Mydei cringes at that–* , so why don’t you let yourself want it?”

“I’m–” and his voice is very, very small. “I’m scared, I guess.”

“What are you scared of?”

“Of getting hurt again.”

“Are you going to live your entire life in this fear? Do you want to? Does it feel good? *Are you happy?* ”

Mydei sighs, shaky, long-suffering. “No. But I don’t know how to fix it.”

“You have to try. The issue is that you don’t *try* . To be completely honest, we’ve been doing this for a very, very long time, and I see very little progress–”

“I am better. I am doing better.”

“You are on *heavy medication* . The goal is to get you off of them. Would you still be doing better if you weren’t taking pills?”

Mydei looks at her, eyes wide and wet, mouth aghast. She’s never been like this before. *”Are you mad at me?”*

Mrs. Sofia takes off her glasses and puts them aside. She rubs the little indents they’ve left on her nose. “I am not mad, Mydeimos. I am concerned.” Her face turns softer, her voice gentler. “Mydei, I’m going to say something very upsetting. You can’t control it. No matter how much you try, you can’t control other people’s actions. There are nuns who live in complete seclusion among other women, and they still get assaulted. The responsibility of not being assaulted doesn’t fall on *you* .”

“Are you saying it will happen again?”

“No, I’m not saying that. I cannot see into the future. It might. It might also not. This is not a reason to stop living. You have to live with the uncertain–”

“You don’t get it.”

“For the sake of professional boundaries, you’ll have to trust me when I say *I do.* ”

Mydei is silent for a very long time. He looks at her. She looks at him. And then, he speaks again, hushed, whispered. *”I don’t know how to fix it.”*

“I’ll help you. You have to try.”

“I can’t exactly– just go and… fuck him, you know, we’re not there yet. I don’t know if he likes me like that.”

“That’s not what I’m telling you to try–”

“Do I just go and fuck a random person?”

“ *No*. Listen to me. It’s the *feelings* you have to try and live with. Those feelings of desire, lust, sexual attraction. Live with them. Sit with them. They’re normal, they’re not *dirty* . You’re not dirty for having those thoughts, Mydei. Do you understand me? You are not dirty. You are not a dirty person.”

That’s when Mydei breaks into tears, ugly and blubbering. Mydei learned how to cry very, very quietly when he was little, and he still does it nowadays. Small little sobs and clenched teeth and hot angry tears scorching down his face and leaving tracks. Not a sound made. “I’m just– I’m so– I’m so sad, and I’m so *mad* and–”

Mrs. Sofia hands him the box of tissues, and Mydei takes them. “I know. That’s okay. It’s okay that you feel like that. You didn’t deserve that, and it’s not your fault. You trusted him– *that’s okay*. You weren’t stupid for trusting him. You can trust people again.”

“I don’t know, like– if– if I do like, how do I even do it? Sex…”

Mrs. Sofia takes a deep breath and thinks very carefully. “You do it with a person you trust very much, that’s the hard part. You have to let yourself trust them. And then you take it very slowly. It doesn’t have to be all at once. You take it at your pace, little by little, as much as you’re comfortable with. You don’t have to go all the way in one sitting.”

“What if they don’t like that?”

“Then it’s not the right person.”

“Okay.” Mydei blows his nose. “Do I– I mean, like, masturbate?”

Mrs. Sofia hums, then nods. “That could be a good start. Doing it by yourself– it’s safe.”

“Yeah, okay. What do I do with Phainon?”

“Don’t do anything in particular– be yourself. Do whatever you want. Flirt if you want to, or ask him out on a date. Be his friend. Let it happen naturally. And don’t run away.”

“Oka–”

“And get off Lithium.”

“Okay.”

They spend the rest twenty minutes running in circles about the same subject they have for the past five years– the whole murdered mom thing. While Mrs. Sofia suggested they continued on the sexual assault topic, Mydei told her that he’s not comfortable talking about it anymore; that made her really proud, he could see it in her eyes. Setting boundaries or whatever.

It’s the same song and dance, and he’s getting tired of it, and he can tell she’s getting tired of it too. All options thoroughly and utterly exhausted. He refutes all of her claims, her techniques, her years of experience and her fucking PHD as well. He wants to get better, asks how, and the answer– *try.* Trust people more. Unlearn shame. Unlearn stubborn independence. Get out there. Love. Let loose. Relax. Sit with the uncertainty, get used to it, become immune to it. It might happen again. It might not. You might do it. Mydeimos you’re covered in blood, Mydeimos stop you’re hurting me, Mydeimos you’re fifteen years old and you are knee deep in a sea of blood and there are creatures in the water Mydeimos I am so afraid. Mydeimos why did you run Mydeimos why didn’t you run faster. Mydeimos it’s so cold here and I am so very alone. Mydeimos I miss you. Mydeimos I love you. Mydeimos I hate you YOU ARE HURTING ME. Why are you hurting me? Mydeimos I am so small and I just want to love you.

You are just like him.

“I feel like,” Mrs. Sofia cuts in. She has noticed the glaze in his eyes. “We should talk about the cat.”

“No.”

When the session is over, Mrs. Sofia speaks up again. His hand freezes on the doorknob. He does not turn around. “Trauma is a liar, Mydei,” she says, and he can hear the click of her heels as she moves around the room. “It’s a really good, beautiful liar. It will tell you that if you just do the right thing, if you protect yourself enough, if you learn your lesson and be more careful, then you will be safe. Secure. You won’t have to worry about it again, it won’t happen. That’s the lie, and here’s the kicker: the goalpost keeps moving. You’ll have a few good days and then you’ll wake up all sweaty and scared and think *I am not safe* . And then you will be even more careful, take even more precautions, isolate yourself more. No amount of preparation will be good enough, no amount of preparation will change what’s already happened. Next thing you know, you haven’t seen the sun in weeks. Don’t you want to see the Sun?”

Mydei mulls it over in his head, worrying at his bottom lip. ‘*The Sun…’*

Tribbie’s team building is in a few hours and he has to get ready, because–

He will see Phainon today. He really wants to see Phainon today.

Chapter End Notes

i am going to post chapter 6 as soon as possible... maybe by the end of this week? its like... 75% written, just felt like posting it as one big chapter would be both too long and too heavy

i wish i added cerydra and hysilens earlier in the fic, because hooooooough theyre peak esp cerydra. i dont think theyre gonna show up much though

i wanna try my hand at a canonverse post-irontomb phaidei fix-it fic after this mayhaps.... but also a canonverse mydei study from childhood to death..... :3c

Chapter 6: secrets

Chapter Notes

Told ya I'd get the second part out soon. This is long, sad, and full of yearning. Enjoy!

!IMPORTANT!

This chapter has a big trigger warning for **SEXUAL ASSAULT**. Specifics below vv

▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's 7 PM and Phainon is in front of his bathroom mirror, looking back at himself obsessively and trying his hardest to make himself into something resembling a human being.

It's been a little over a month since his very public mental breakdown and Cipher's emergency intervention. This is how things are going for him:

He keeps up with cleaning the apartment and the cockroach issue is all but eradicated. Taking care of Bartholos actually helps, and he's starting to wonder if this is a more *permanent* arrangement. Every time he seriously contemplates suicide (and we'll get there), he steps back and thinks of the cat– how he'd be lonely and confused and hungry and thirsty. The responsibility keeps him alive. He has a new crush, and things are going well. Castorice went deep-diving in Mydei's social media presence and found that one of his friends' boyfriend tagged him in a picture from Pride, so he definitely likes men. Mydei is patient and indulges in his bullshit, he fans the flames of his ego and his competitive side. He likes bullying Mydei, knows that Mydei can take it, and the guy throws it right back at him. It's perfect.

That's all nice and good, and by all means there is a significant improvement in his day-to-day life, so then why…

Why does he still want to kill himself so damn bad? Time bleeds down into a cursed chalice and mixes together into thick muck– he drinks it and wakes up to realize that it's midnight and he's spent the entire day trying to not commit suicide. He thinks of it often. Thinks of it most of the time. Mydeimos could be talking to him about ancient Kremnoan military strategies and Phainon would be staring at the sky, thinking about how nice it would be to deepthroat the barrel of a shotgun. He wakes up and makes his coffee and thinks about dumping the entire pot of boiling water on his head, hoping that the shock would make his brain seize and stop working. He looks up the success rate of drinking bleach, looks up the consequences of surviving a fall from the top of his building.

He's not planning, not really, not anymore and not like he did back then. He's not really planning on *doing* anything, because of Bartholos, but he is thinking about it. Kind of like a baby sucking his thumb, the thought of suicide is the only constant comfort in his life.

Cipher doesn't speak to him anymore. Doesn't speak to anyone, really, not even in their groupchat. When she comes to work, she is tired. Pale. Smaller, as if she's lost weight, as if the clothes are swallowing her up. She is twitchy and nervous and shaky all over, and when Phainon tries to strike up a conversation, she slips out like a weasel. He's picked up a very good thing and threw it against the wall. He wanted someone to keep him together and, in turn, he has shattered them.

Shattered. This is how he feels sometimes, like fine china knocked down by a mean child. Barely holding himself together with glue, crumbling like old wax. The hallucinations come and go. They have not gotten worse, but they have gotten clearer, more cruel, have taken a more terrible shape. He wakes up sweaty and cold and paralyzed, unable to move anything but his eyes, and there is Cyrene pressed up against his chest, looking at him with big frightened eyes. She is crying in those moments, sobbing tears that make her pretty face all splotchy, and she asks him over and over– *why* . And he doesn't know what to tell her, can't speak anyways, and he just wants to gather her in his arms and apologize.

There is too much grief in his body and he doesn't know where to put it. He cries often, most days, but it is not enough. It feels like every tear piles on and grows into an obelisk, and instead of his heart feeling sated, it feels heavier.

The shape of his suicide ideation has started to shift from setting himself on fire to praying he gets cancer and dies. Crossing the street without checking and hoping that a car comes and obliterates him. He wants the burden of death off his shoulders and onto someone else's, and he wants something big and public so that people would know to check on Bartholos.

There are good days, better days. There are also worse days. They hang in a fragile balance.

It is better. It also doesn't make a difference.

Phainon washes his face, hoping to reduce any redness and puffiness from his crying fit. Tribbie's little team building bullshit is in an hour and he has to catch the subway *because he will not fucking get in a car* , and it's just– he wants to sleep. If this was happening literally last month, Phainon would've excused himself and apologized profusely and say that *'something came up'* . But now, he's…

He's trying. He's trying really, really hard. He's trying because he doesn't want to embarrass himself anymore, and he doesn't want to let people down anymore, and he wants to be *good* . So, he tries and forces himself out of the house. Who knows, maybe something good will happen, like maybe Cipher will throw her hand over his shoulder and start with her banter, or maybe Mydei will push him against the wall and suck him off. Something like that.

Phainon runs his hand through his hair and fixes every little stray strand. He fixes his shirt and smoothes his jeans, and he looks– presentable, handsome, cute in his previously Cyrene Approved™ outfit. He looks like he can be *someone* . Enough of Phainon, he can be Phainooon~ Ahh, Phainon, you're so silly!! You're so funny and goofy, Phainonnn, oh you make me laugh so hard!!

So, despite it all, despite the burden, he opens the door and goes outside. Catches the bus and then the subway. The mere thought of getting behind a wheel sends him in such bouts of

panic that he's afraid his heart will give up– and nonetheless, his car is sitting wrecked and fractured in some junkyard. He does not have any money to repair it, and even if he did, he does not want to nurture his sister's grave.

His sister's grave. Phainon leans harder on the filthy subway pole. He should visit it sometimes, *anytime* . Probably should clean it up and bring some flowers, or just stand there and talk to her, or–

He's never visited it since burying her. Perhaps, he thinks, if he ignores the physical proof of her death, she would unrot and raise anew like Mnestia from the golden cocoon. Reborn, clean, radiant, alive again. His mouth goes dry– she, she's just bones now. At this point, almost nine months later, she is just bones. Her beautiful face, so kind, so lustrous– he hasn't, he's never thought about it like that before. The image of maggot eating her eyes, writhing in and out of her mouth, is striking. Bugs crawling over her body like soldiers laying waste to a city, eating from a feast not meant for them. His sister with her easy smile and her pretty voice. All the memories are being pulled out like golden thread from the middle of the earth; her hunched over the sink, bleaching her roots, her singing a song for her third grade talent show, her collecting each and every affordable piece of Miku merch.

Holy shit, he's gonna have a panic attack in the subway. There's a kid picking his nose next to him. He's going to have a mental breakdown in front of a snotty kid– that should be grounds for euthanasia.

Deep breaths, just like Cipher taught you, come on. Hard, long inhales and shaky exhales. Get it out. Get it *together* . Stop whinging. Phainon presses his palms to his eyes, hoping to stop the tears. It's too hot in here, too crowded, too many people pressed up against him. All of a sudden he feels like he is suffocating, like air is a luxury and he is a pauper. Look, here they come– the painful sobs ripped from his chest with a violence that is sure to shock the world. He tries to suppress them, and all that come out are these small, pitiful whines that leave his torso shaking. Oh my God, people are staring, people are staring because he's the guy whining and gasping on the subway. The car pulls into the station and comes to an abrupt stop, sending the entire train reeling. Somebody bumps into him and almost knocks him over, and Phainon truly, genuinely, wants to start biting people.

In a daze, he pushes his way past the sea of people, manhandling his way out of the car– he's pretty sure he knocks a lady's purse down, if her shouting is to be believed. He takes the stairs upwards two at a time, unthinking, and only begins to breathe when the cool September air hits him. Finally, some room. The people passing by him are looking, and he's really, *really* trying to keep it together.

It's just– does it hurt? Is she in pain? She's dead, so she's not much of… *anything* , but it must– it would hurt, if she was alive, and her flesh was stripped from her by bugs and worms and– he's going to throw up. All that she has ever been; bones.

A hand lands on his back, small and cold.

He clenches his fist in anticipation for a fight, because this *is* becoming a fight– until he hears a voice calling for him, sweet and familiar. "Phainon?"

Oh.

Hiii, Castorice~ Oh my God, Castorice, hello~~ Castorice, you look so pretty, haha! Castorice, do you want to hear a joke? Castorice, let's take a selfie!!

Yeah, like that. Be like that. Get it the fuck together. Phainon runs a shaky hand through his hair, and turns around to face her with his most dazzling smile.

"Casto– *Polyxia!!* " Phainon squeaks like a kid on Christmas, and he reaches down to grab Polyxia's hand. "Baby, how are you? I'm so glad you could make it!"

Polyxia weakly chuckles, her eyes flitting to the screen in front of her. *"Hi, Phainon~ I felt well enough and decided to tag along and bother Castorice."* The look in her eyes is a little mischievous, a little tired. She is paler than usual, big dark circles marring her pretty face, and she looks like she lost some weight in the past month. Still, she remains unbeaten. *"Are you okay? You look like shit, did you see a ghost or something? Haha. Castorice isn't that scary, is she?"*

"Polyxia… Come on…" Castorice flusters and blushes to the tips of her ears, and she does that thing she likes to do with her hands– rubbing them together, almost shyly.

"Don't bully poor Cas!" The smile is starting to hurt Phainon's face. He hopes it's convincing. "You girls walked all this way?"

"Yes. Fresh air is good for me, and God knows Castorice needs to exercise more." Polyxia blinks at her monitor some more, *"And I don't even wanna bother with public transport. Are you gonna accompany us the rest of the way like a gentleman or what?"*

Phainon laughs nervously, and tries to puff up his chest and peacock as much as possible. "Well, ladies– yes, *of course!* Your gallant knight has arrived~" and he finishes it with flair and a bow, extending his arm to show the way to Castorice and Polyxia. They seem pleased enough, convinced enough, and Phainon does not mention how Polyxia's facial muscles are less responsive, or how her breathing comes out in hard, rattled rasps. There's no need to think about anything now.

Bliss might be just at his fingertips.

He chats with the girls as they walk, pushing through the suicidal discomfort, trying to find *something* to cling on. Polyxia is recapping the latest *Love Island* drama, and he, well– he obliges, half-dazed and half-dead, reaching to kindle the fire of personhood from him.

Suicidality has stolen so much time from him, he's forgotten how to live.

They stop in front of the bar, and Phainon is relieved to see that there is, indeed, a ramp. They are the first to arrive, however, and everybody feels a bit awkward going in without Tribios– because they're just three people nearing their thirties, so of course they need their mommy to talk to the scawy waiters.

A car pulls up and everybody holds their breath, hoping that it's their saviour.

Mydei steps out instead, looking handsome in his combat boots and this little black tanktop that's juuuuust short enough for Phainon to see a little bit of his tummy; suddenly, he feels all warm like a Victorian man seeing an ankle for the first time. Never mind that he's put nearly his entire fist down his throat, they don't talk about that.

Alright, switching gears. Decreasing "killing yourself" priority, increasing "bothering the fuck out of Mydei" priority.

Mydei, ever polite, smiles and acknowledges the girls first. He greets Castorice and kisses her on both cheeks– back up, they still do that in Kremnos? He then turns to Polyxia and squeezes her hand. His smile is beautiful, easy. "Hi, nice to meet you– you must be Castorice's sister, right? I'm Mydeimos."

Polyxia flushes a little, barely there. *"Yes, hi, nice to meet you too. Mydei, huh? Castorice told me a looooot of things about you~"*

"All good, I hope?" and he gives Castorice a *look* , a playful warning. He kisses Polyxia's cheeks. Where the fuck is Phainon's kiss?

"I'd say they're good. You're not local, are you? Where are you from?"

"Castrum Kremnos."

"Ooo, interesting. Castorice and I moved around a bit as kids. Born in Styxia, raised in Aidonia."

Phainon swears he sees Mydei's eyes sparkle. "Chilly. I would love to visit Aidonia and see the monuments to Thanatos, and the Temple of the Maiden of War."

Polyxia huffs a bit. *"Really, they're not that impressive. Just a bunch of old rocks."*

"Still, the history is–"

Alright, that's enough. Mydei is– I mean, he looks cute, done up, a little punk rock-y and very pretty. He has his hair in a low bun and his stupid braid is swinging left and right. He's even wearing a pair of sunglasses on the top of his head. He looks good, but Phainon isn't gonna allow him to show off in front of the ladies like that.

Blond men are the enemy. He also has a thing for them, but that's besides the point. Phainon himself also *technically* counts as a blond –because he is *literally* a natural blond– but he bleaches and dyes his hair white, so that's also besides the point.

"Why are you wearing sunglasses at night like an asshole?"

Mydei's mood shifts immediately and he shoots Phainon with that frowny face of his. Jackpot. Mydei schools his expression right away, because he's very committed to being stoic. "It's part of my outfit."

"It makes you look like a bouncer."

“Are you saying that because I have more muscle mass than you? In that case, I agree.”

Alright, alright, nice shot– but Phainon has some aces up his sleeve, and those aces are called *‘innocent bystanders’.*

“Castorice, Polyxia!” he claps his hands and steps closer to Mydei, who already crossed his arms in anticipation. “I have a score to settle with our dear Kremnoan. Say, since you’re an *unbiased* party, could you tell me… Which one of us is taller?”

Mydei scoffs, and Castorice groans. “Not this again, Phainon!” she begs, but it is futile. “This is all we ever do on our breaks now. I’ve been keeping so many scores and breaking so many draws that I lost count…”

Castorice is out, but Polyxia is cut from a different cloth. Phainon cocks an eyebrow at her, and it’s worth a million words.

”Alright,” she says, *”I’ll do it.”*

Phainon moves to stand next to Mydei. Mydei’s bare shoulder presses against his as the man leans in closer too, and even their shoes are touching– sneakers to boots. Phainon finds that incredibly erotic, and he stops himself from shuddering. Mydei is so warm, like a furnace, and he can't help but steal a look at him– his eyes follow the curve of his arched nose as it dips into his cupid’s bow. He sighs without realizing, a bit too wistfully to be casual.

”Hmm…” Polyxia speaks up after a few beats, *”I would say you’re about the same height but… You might be a teeny bit taller, Phainon? Less than a centimeter.”*

“HA!” Phainon chortles and shoves Mydei, to which the other man just clicks his teeth and groans.

“That proves nothing. Polyxia, whose arms are bigger?” Mydei extends his arms and flexes. Alright, Phainon can play this game too. He mirrors the action.

”Mydei’s.”

“Alright, but whose back is bigger then?”

Another change of pose.

”I think yours, Phainon.”

“Polyxia, whose shoulders are broader?” comes Mydei’s challenge.

Another pose. They’re starting to look like Jojo characters.

”Still Phainon’s.”

Phainon gets a wicked, *wicked* idea. “Polyxia, Polyxia~” he calls out, all innocent. “Whose waist is smaller?”

Mydei cocks his head at that like a confused puppy. “Why would we even measure that?”

“Don’t be a party pooper, Mydei, come on!” Phainon presses on, and Mydei’s only reply is a *‘hmph’* . Wow, so stoic. He bunches his shirt at the back, and his competitor follows suit.

Castorice laughs at that, and Polyxia looks amused too. The cool autumn evening breeze blows gently amongst them, ruffling Phainon’s hair and the hems of Castorice’s skirt. She puts a hand on her sister’s shoulder, impossibly fond.

”I have to give this one to Mydei. Very tiny waist, all things considered.”

Mydei blushes at that, barely perceptible, his bronze skin coloring peachy– *mission accomplished* . He looks sunkissed, fatally pretty, and so utterly lovely that it hurts to look at him. A little timid, but more so stubborn. Phainon wants to see him even redder, pink to the tips of his ears. He sneaks behind him like a sly coyote, and his hands easily find purchase on his waist. It’s tapered like sin, hard and muscular under his palms, yet when he starts to knead it he finds the flesh soft and yielding willingly. The tips of his pinkies graze along the exposed part of his stomach, the ghost of a touch, and it is enough to make Phainon bite his thumbs. His thumbs don’t quite reach each other, but they’re not that far apart either. A nice, curvaceous slope– the ratio of his body is *insane* .

Mydei gasps and shoves him off, yet he does not look nearly as pissed off as he ought to. He looks more… flustered? Embarrassed, but in a cute way. He huffs and looks away all balky.

Castorice and Polyxia are quite surprised by the show.

”Are they always like this?”

“Pretty much.”

”Haha. Castorice. Oaf4Oaf.”

Reinvigorated with fresh ambition, Mydei turns to Polyxia. He seems determined like a lion about to strike. “What’s the score?”

”Three for Phainon, two for you.”

“Alright, let’s settle it then. Whoever wins this one wins everything. It’s worth seventy-nine points. Polyxia, whose chest is bigger?”

That’s a low blow. Phainon refuses to engage in unsportsmanlike conduct– and by the way, no, grabbing your enemy’s waist does not count as unsportsmanlike conduct, thank you very much.

“That’s not fair, Mydei, you *know* you’ll win that.”

“Oh? Are you afraid of losing?”

“That’s not it.”

“You are conceding defeat, then.”

”No.”

“Then by all means, Polyxia, plea–”

Two taloned hands grab both of their shoulders. It’s as if the air fills with electricity– Phainon can see Castorice and Polyxia visibly relax as they are saved from this endless hellish loop he’s roped them in. He fixes his gaze on the hand grasping him, and is relieved to see a perfect *red* manicure. Whew. If it was Aglaea instead, this would’ve been a lot scarier.

“Snowy, De, what are you boys doing? Oh, you’re so silly~”

Tribios pulls them close to her in a suffocating embrace.

She’s, well– she’s an adult with an actual job and a loving husband. Tribbie is the most senior employee of all of them, and she’s repeatedly been offered higher positions, such as Head of Customer Support and even higher-up management roles. She always turned them down, however, saying that she and her husband make enough money to live very comfortably, and she’d rather focus on her studies and her family and her side-gig than be stressed out because of work.

Her *side-gig* , of course, is tinkering and making things. She makes little automated toys for children and sells them on Etsy, and her biggest hobby is taking things apart and putting them back together. She’s currently studying Engineering at a prestigious college in Okhema, and somehow she still finds the time to work full-time and take care of her seven year old daughters– Trianne and Trinnon. Two sweet little angels, those twins; Trianne is cheeky and mischievous, Trinnon is timid and polite. It’s always a delight when she brings them to the office with her.

She pulls back and lets them go, before turning to greet the others. “Cassie, Pollie, look at you! I’m so glad you could make it!” She gives each of them a hug. Tribios really likes the color red, and you can tell; she has this beautiful natural ginger hair, almost fiery in hue, and she always accessories with red lipstick, red nails, red jewels. Even the rims of her glasses are red. She’s just– a very nice older woman, a grounding presence, with all the goodness and sweetness of a wine mom in her mid to late forties.

“Why are you kids sitting outside, hm?”

“Oh, well, we–” Castorice starts to explain, shifting her weight awkwardly. “We thought we should wait for you, so yeah– we were just hanging out.”

Tribios smiles, doting, and chuckles a little. She links her arms with Phainon’s and Mydei’s and starts to pull them inside the bar. “Well then, come on! It’s already 8 PM, we don’t wanna keep the establishment waiting~ I’m sure the others will arrive soon!”

And just like prophesied, the others do start to pour in soon after. First is Hysilens, distinctly *not* with Cerydra. When Tribbie asks her about it, she just gives a bullshit excuse– *”Cery is not feeling well.”* Phainon knows that it’s actually because those two are fighting *again.*

When Aglaea arrives not soon after, it is in a twirl of silk and gold. She's wearing these gorgeous earrings shaped to look like big ancient coins depicting the last Imperator of Okhema, and her heels (Louboutin red-bottoms, of course) are so high she towers over everyone in the bar. Aglaea commands every room she enters, and for a good reason– her presence is unmatched in elegance and sophistication. The old money kind, not the luxury that yells, but rather whispers. She's the oldest daughter of this old, famous fashion house, yet she works a mundane job because she wants to make her *own* wealth instead– which is like, typical out-of-touch rich people bullshit, but Aglaea pulls it off. She once told him, *"I want to make enough money to buy FLAMECHASE Inc."* and Phainon fully believes she's capable of it. Glued to her heel is a Labrador retriever, golden like everything else about Aglaea, named Garmentmaker– her seeing eye dog that she takes to crowded, or unfamiliar, places. She looks incredibly cute in her *'DO NOT PET, SERVICE DOG'* vest, and she lays down so politely with her head on Aglaea's feet when her owner sits down at the table.

Hyacine arrives about an hour later, but that's to be expected– she spends about three hours just getting ready, and her outfits all weigh over ten pounds. Tribbie exclaims happily when she makes it through the door, dressed in ribbons and ruffles and petticoats. "Cinny, you look like a little doll!" Tribios actually has to scoot over to make room for her and her skirts.

"Hyacinthia," Aglaea delicately brings her glass of red wine to her mouth. Phainon does not like her tone. "I thought you'd be coming with Anaxagoras."

"Aglaea," Hyacine says, good-natured, mimicking Aglaea's cadence. "Now why would you think that?"

"You two are nigh inseparable."

"We work shoulder to shoulder for nine hours a day." Hyacine shrugs and orders a pint of bitter pale ale. "I did ask them if they'd come, and they just said… What was it… Oh! They said," she clears her throat, and Phainon knows she's about to go into her pitch-perfect Anaxa impression. *"I would rather drink molten glass than spend time in the same room as that woman, unless it was professionally necessary, which this is NOT."*

"I think they mean you, Agy~"

When Aglaea sets down her glass, the rim is stained with her perfect nude lipstick. She scoffs and snickers. "Yes, that does sound like them."

Nobody else arrives so, you know, this is it, and this is *enough* . They all order their drinks, but Phainon makes a *good decision* today and doesn't get anything alcoholic; he really *is* trying to be better. What he orders instead is an obscene amount of cola, because Tribbie is footing the bill and nothing tastes better than free coke. Multiple conversations swirl around him, and Phainon is just happy to listen to them.

"How are the girls, Tribios?" Aglaea asks, turning to face her old trainer

"Oh, they're just going into second grade, so we're all very excited for that. Trianne is a little imp, and we're trying to get Trinnon to open up more, make more friends at school. We're planning a trip to Ladon for the holidays. How's your mother?"

“She’s getting up there in age. Oh– Hysilens, you have to try the cocktails at this place. They’re great, you’d love them.”

“Really? Recommend me something good, then.”

“So, Mydei,” Hyacine wipes her face after downing her pint, “You have five roommates? All guys?”

“That’s right.”

“Woah. Must be like a sausage party in there.”

“Mm… Less of a sausage party, more like… the werkroom of Rupaul’s Drag Race?” Hyacine and Castorice holler at that, and even Polyxia chortles. It gets a chuckle out of Phainon too.

Eventually, he finds himself in a conversation with Polyxia and Castorice. Polyxia is telling him about her art, and Castorice is shuffling through pictures of both traditional and digital paintings on her phone. They’re beautiful, some depicting scenes from her favorite TV shows or Castorice’s fanfics, but most drawings are of landscapes, still life, and portraits. They’re all very faithful to life, colorful and vibrant. *”Yeah, so, there’s this technology that tracks your eyes and you can draw digitally like that.”* Castorice shows him a portrait of herself holding a bouquet of Antila flowers, smiling demurely with her hair covered by a purple tichel, patterned with butterflies. *”That one won first place at a competition for artists with disabilities.”*

It’s a beautiful digital painting, capturing Castorice’s delicate features perfectly, her quiet and comfortable beauty. It’s drawn with so much *love* that Phainon can physically see it in each brushstroke. Castorice hands him her phone so he can have a better look and he zooms into her eyes. “Hey, Polyxia, can I buy this one off of you? I wanna print it and laminate it and frame it. Gonna put it on my bathroom door so Drawingrice can watch me poop.”

Castorice shoves him playfully, and the corners of Polyxia’s face twitch upward. *”You know what, for that reason? I’ll give it to you for free. Though if you want to commission me to draw you and Mydei making out, I’m down.”*

Phainon looks over both of his shoulders in mock suspicion, as if making sure Mydei isn’t listening; he’s not, he’s busy talking with Tribios and Hysilens. He leans in close to Polyxia and whispers conspiratorially, “Gee, can you? I’ll give you half my salary and a pack of cigarettes for it.”

”Deal.”

About two hours later, the bar’s front door opens with a loud bang, and Phainon is the only one startled enough to check. He turns around towards the commotion and his heart immediately falls out of his ass. Standing there, seemingly arguing with a waiter and a little wobbly on her feet– Cifera.

And she looks like shit, even worse than lately. Is she drunk?

“Um…” he turns back towards Tribios and tries to get her attention by tapping her hand. She looks at him, he gestures at Cipher, and her eyes *light up* . “Agy, Ciphy is here! Cifera, over here!” She gets up and waves her hand. Tribbie has always been a bit… oblivious. The waiter seems to understand that *she's with the group* , and half-heartedly starts to lead her over to their table. She sits next to Hyacine, towards the end of the table.

The mood shifts. Phainon thought she walked a little weird, unsteady, but now that she's closer he can tell– Cipher is not drunk, *she's high*. And not on weed either, but on some serious shit; she keeps grinding her jaw, and her pupils are so blown out her irises look like little blue-green rings around a black void.

The conversations immediately die down, and Phainon can hear Aglaea sigh under her breath. Cipher looks between them, between all of them, her face twisted in manic cheer. Smiling big, all teeth showing, the muscles of her face pulled taut. “Whaaaat's uuuuup? What's going on~” Her voice is raspy, each lilt uncontrollable. Suddenly, she stops in her tracks, as if seeing them for the first time. “Why's everyone so *down* all of a sudden?” She smiles and laughs and hiccups, throws an arm around Hyacine.

“Um, Cipher…” Hyacine tries to squirm out of her hold. “Aww, come on, Cinny, what's with that face? What's with everyone's faces? Did I… get it wrong?” and she's starting to put on her *act* . “Was I not invited, Tribbie?”

Tribbie laughs awkwardly. “No, Ciphy, of course you were, it's just– are you feeling okay?”

“Oh, Tribbie, I am *on top of the world.* Never been fuckin' better.” She gestures over a waiter and orders a vodka cranberry. “C'mon, why the long faces? I'm here, let's partaaaaay!! Cassie, you look so pretty~”

To say it's awkward would be an understanding– it's downright *unbearable* . He feels like he's choking, and he can't stop looking at her and she very pointedly *does not look back* . When the waiter comes with her drink, she downs it before he can leave and then immediately orders another. He's so, so embarrassed right now; they've hardly exchanged any words since his last episode and she's been dodging him as if he were a bullet, and now this…

Cipher is self-destructive, he knows that, but Cipher is also *proud* . She would never expose herself like this in public, not in front of everyone else, not in front of *Aglaea* . Her misery is a lot more well-hidden than his, so well-hidden that Phainon *himself* doesn't know what this is all about. Something is very, very wrong with her. Her hands shake uncontrollably, and she can't stand still. She keeps picking at the same scab on her hand.

Phainon is stuck between his shame and his concern, and he doesn't know which one to act on first. One side wants to apologize, the other wants to ask her if she's okay. Selfish and selfless– selfish usually wins.

“So like, what's up?” she claps her hands, “What are we talking about? Families and kids and relationships and all that bullshit?”

Hyacine's voice is very small and very concerned when she speaks. “Cifera, I don't think–”

“What? What’s wrong, Hyacine? Did I do something wrong? *Does my presence offend you?* ”

“Cipher, *no*, of course not!” Castorice sounds almost *outraged* at the accusation, but Phainon knows that’s not true. That’s unlike Castorice. He knows her well enough to know that she’s very, very upset right now.

“Oh–” Cipher breaks into laughter, then mocks Castorice’s tone and voice ruthlessly, making her sound high-pitched and nasally and annoying. *”Of course not! We’re just so worried, blehhh.”* and then more laughter and more giggles, as if this is the funniest thing she’s ever heard. Castorice is *wrecked* at this, she’s self-conscious like that. There are tears in the corners of her eyes already. “God forbid Cipher comes in all happy, right? You’d rather have some boring work party and talk about stocks or some bullshit? Look at you, you’re not even– you’re not even drinking real alcohol. Don’t you wanna *get it started* ?”

Something darkens in Tribios’ gaze. “That’s not appropriate for a work event, Cifera. You can’t speak to Castorice like that. Apologize to her.” At that, Cipher’s face turns childlike and innocent, another act of hers. “M-mommy…? Are you my mother, Tribios?” and in a moment, it twists back to the amused cruelty, all ravenous glee.

Looking at her, Phainon can’t help but think of those theater masks, one laughing and one crying. Her facial expressions are uninhibited, erratic, now wrathful now cheerful. Her fingers are twitching on her new glass of vodka cranberry, as if she has no control over them. Cipher looks between them with a panther’s predatory eye, and then her gaze stops to fix on Mydei.

“Oh… *Ohhhhh* .” she gasps as if she made some great discovery, “That’s it. That’s *why* . You don’t want to be embarrassed in front of the new guy.” She fully turns around and leans on her elbows, getting closer to Mydei. Mydei, on the other hand, looks neutral and unperturbed.

“That’s your shiny new toy, isn’t it? I’ve heard how you talk about him in meetings and fuckin’ work huddles– *’Ohh, De, you’re so good, you’re already one of our top employees!’* ” she says, mocking Tribbie.

”Mydeimos, you are a great addition to our team.” mocking Aglaea.

”M-M-Mydei, can I show you my favorite horse girl?” mocking Castorice, striking deep.

”Mydei, Mydei~ Come, let’s see who’s faster~” when it’s his turn to be mocked, Phainon feels oddly… betrayed, like he would’ve never expected this from her. Something about her body language when she imitates him, the tone of her voice, hits him right in the center of his heart. Phainon is not so much sad as he is angry, and growing angrier still by the minute.

“You all are trying to *replace* me. You think I can’t fucking tell? Isn’t he just so damn polite and suuuuch a gentleman and he’s so emotionally well-adjusted, not like Cipher the fucking *mess* .” Her grin turns sharp, hateful. “Well, here’s the thing, for everyone here–” she downs her drink, “I googled you, little lion, yeah, I did, when you started working here. There’s not a lot of *Mydeimoses* in Okhema.”

Phainon feels Mydei tense next to him. The whole table is so deathly quiet that Phainon could hear his breath hitch. Cipher rubs her eyes and smudges her mascara. “Did you guys know…” and she– she just keeps looking at him, and there’s something *incredibly* unkind in her eyes, more so than when she usually teases. Something like venom. Mydei starts to bounce his leg.

“Little Mydeimos Polemos here– nice one, by the way, it rhymes, props to your mom. Oh, yeah! Talking about your mom, so I googled you and found this old news article! Did you guys know that in *2009*– ”

Aglaea’s hand comes down on the table so fiercely that every glass shakes. He has never, *ever* , seen her look so– upset? Disappointed? Concerned? Fury is written all over her beautiful face, in the furrow of her brow and the scowl of her mouth. She is red to the tip of her ears, though if it is out of embarrassment or rage, Phainon cannot tell. *”No.”* is all she says. Her voice is so commanding, so absolutely imposing, that Cipher finally, *finally* closes her mouth. She looks like a kid caught with her fingers in the pie, eyes wide like plates and mouth agape– a telltale sign of *’oh shit’* .

“I have indulged this for far too long. You don’t get to talk like that about us, you don’t get to say *that* about him.” A finger points all accusatory at Cipher; for the first time ever, Phainon notices that her and Aglaea do their nails the same way. Sharp and golden. “That’s not for you to say. You don’t get to drag everyone else down because you’re upset.”

Cipher’s look of surprise slowly transforms into a… Sad, melancholy sort of triumph– as if she’s just gotten exactly what she was looking for. “I knew it, I knew you–”

”I’m taking you home.” Hyacine stands up and knocks down a glass of soda. “Please, Cipher, just– let me drive you home.”

There’s some more talking going on, but Phainon’s tuned it out. He is focused solely on Mydei, who’s looking down at his feet and clenching his fists. Unclenching them. His mouth is agape. *”I’m leaving.”* is all he says, inaudible over the heated conversation, before he gets up and walks out the door.

Castorice is already gathering her and Polyxia’s things, stuffing them haphazardly in her Kuromi bag and blinking back tears. *”Cas…”* Polyxia says, and Phainon notices her hand twitching ever so slightly in her lap, an almost instinctual drive to comfort her sister. It's a gesture so small, so delicate, that Phainon thinks he imagined it. Hyacine and Aglaea are trying to get Cipher to agree with being taken home– Aglaea has even gotten up and walked around the table, her hand on Cipher’s shoulder. The grip she has on Garmentmaker’s handle is unforgiving. Cipher is arguing back with the both of them fiercely, and the waiters must have taken notice because a security guard is walking over. Hysilens is on the phone with Cerydra, asking her to drive over and pick her up. Tribios has gone to the bar to pay the bill, and–

With one glorious swing, Cipher has shattered it all, this nice little fun moment. Phainon can’t even find it in himself to really blame her. Ruining things is his specialty.

The security guard seems to be diffusing the situation, with Cipher finally conceding to going home. As Hyacine links her arm with hers and starts leading her outside through the back door, security guard in tow, Aglaea addresses him without looking at him. “Go check on Mydei.”

It all happened so fast that it left Phainon in a daze. He cannot even bear to look at Cipher as he moves past her, yet he catches the sound of her hushed, crazed apologies whispered like a prayer to Hyacine.

He finds Mydei outside, angrily tapping on his phone. He stands a little too close to the street for Phainon’s liking, and every time a car rushes by it sends his bangs flying in every direction. There is a slight shake to his hands, as if there is something uncontainable waiting to jump out of him. Phainon strides over carefully, silently as if he might spook him away, and puts his hand on his shoulder. “He–”

Before he can get the word out, Mydei startles and grabs his wrist with such force that it unstabilizes Phainon, doubling him over. Mydei is grasping him hard and twisting. “Mydei– aghh, fuck, *let go!”*

There is a brief moment, shorter than a breath, where their gazes meet, and the look in Mydei’s eyes is fierce, stormy and dark, almost crazed; Phainon cannot help but think it is also desperately lovely. Terrible like a triumphant king. Majestic even, awe-inspiring as only an executioner can be. A lion clutching an oryx between his jaw, and Phainon only wants to lean in and offer his jugular for the taking. His eyes search for *something* on Phainon’s face and *when he finds it* – Phainon watches with rapt attention as, little by little, every muscle in Mydei’s face relaxes, softens, brightens up in recognition and then reddens in shame. He lets go of his wrist as if he just realized he was holding a red-hot iron, and steps back. “Phainon.” he says, sounding a bit breathless, “I’m sorry. You startled me.”

“Jesus, Mydei!” Phainon shakes his wrist and rubs it. To ascertain the damage– yes, it is going to bruise, and Phainon can’t wait. How splendid it is going to be, he thinks, to wear the evidence of Mydei’s touch like a bracelet. Phainon tries to make himself seem very upset when he speaks now, because if he speaks as his heart dictates, he is going to sound so love-drunk it would even disgust the old poets. “Ouch, man, like what the fuck?”

”Sorry.” He sounds genuinely remorseful, and he cannot quite look at Phainon. Without saying anything else, he turns back to his phone. Phainon feels a bit bad for playing it up, but still shuffles over to stand next to him. Mydei allows it, at least for now, and Phainon’s a bit of a jerk so he can’t help but snoop on him; he cranes his neck a bit to see what he’s doing on his phone.

He’s ordering an Uber.

“Didn't you drive here?”

“Hmph. I did, but I had too much to drink. I’m not good to drive.”

That’s probably the responsible thing to do. Mydei *did* have quite a few beers, not enough to be drunk but certainly enough to be a little tipsy.

Phainon breathes in to talk again, but Mydei snaps around like a hurricane. “What do you want?”

He gapes a little, opening and closing his mouth, looking for words that won’t come. Then, finally, “I just wanted to make sure you’re good.”

“I’m good.”

“Are you… sure?”

Mydei’s frown only deepens. “I am not a child, I can self-regulate.”

“I just– look, I’m sorry about Cipher, I don’t know what came ov–”

“I am not interested in having this conversation.”

Alright. Be like that, then.

Mydei turns back to his phone, and huffs angrily. He shakes it a bit as if that’s gonna fix whatever’s wrong with it. Phainon, foolish as always, tries again. “What’s wron–”

“It says there’s no drivers nearby.” his voice is even when he says it, yet Phainon can hear him mutter under his breath, *”Fuck, I want to go home.”*

“Are you, um–” Phainon sighs, takes a deep breath, “Look, I’m not sure what she was talking about and you don’t have to tell me, that’s fine, but you seem a little out of it. What about your roommates, can they come pick you up?”

Mydei doesn’t grace him with a glance. “No, they’re not at home.”

“...None of them? Not even one of five?”

“No, Phainon. Hephaestion and Leonnius are visiting their parents in Kremnos. Peucesta is at his boyfriend’s house and Perdikkas is caught in an overnight shift at the hospital. Ptolemy… I’m not sure where he went, but he’s not home. Is that sufficient information for you?”

“Mydei, I’m not trying to be a dick. I’m just concerned.”

Mydei is gripping his phone so hard Phainon thinks he’s going to break it, and he wants nothing more than to reach over and smooth his hand over his. His palms are itching at the very thought, so he shoves them in his pockets. “There’s no need to be concerned for me.”

Phainon is feeling very desperate all of a sudden. Desperate to keep him close, desperate to open him up and probe him. *’I can mend your hurt,’* he thinks, hopelessly fond, *’Let me, just let me.’*

“I’ll drive you home.”

It comes out of him suddenly, violently almost, like an animal bursting out of its cage. He catches himself off guard, the usual liar finding himself incurable with sincerity. His heart

nearly jumps out of his chest, and he goes to clutch at it instinctively, smoothing his hand over the core of his sternum. Caressing between his breasts as if that might help calm the nerves. He swallows thickly.

He did not mean to say it, yet he meant it earnestly nonetheless.

Mydei studies him for a while, his predacious eyes lingering over his face, over the nervous tint in his shaky breath. He is scared, he is– he hasn't, not since, Cyrene– she… Her teeth–

"Okay." Mydei finally says.

Phainon releases a breath he didn't know he was holding. He feels as though he were a criminal exonerated just before the blade kissed his neck. Mydei fishes in his pocket for his keys, then hands them to him.

Phainon just… looks at him, incredulous. It's as if he's forgotten how to act or think. Mydei cocks an eyebrow and jingles his keys. Phainon stares still, unmoving.

A notification pops up on Mydei's phone. "Oh," he says, "Nevermind, they found me a car–"

Phainon snaps out of it with a gasp that startles Mydei. He reaches over and snatches the keys out of his care. "I'll do it," he declares *boldly,* more to convince himself than anything else. "C'mon, cancel the ride. I'll do it."

Mydei does not look convinced, not at all. Phainon is already starting to walk past him. "Look, man, it's a free ride. Are you taking it or not?"

To that, all Mydei says is, "You're going the wrong way," and he gestures with his head in the direction where his car is parked.

They walk side by side in silence, though it is not a long walk– Mydei got super lucky with the parking spot. Phainon would be jealous if he was still driving a car. Instead, he is so scared he considers throwing up and running away. Every step he takes feels torturous, as if he were walking barefoot on hot coals; the soles of his feet singed off and cooked to a crisp, rendered useless by the anguish.

Next thing he knows, he's in the driving seat gripping the wheel like he's trying to asphyxiate it. He does not remember when he got into the car, but he feels Mydei's warmth next to him, feels him fiddle with the seatbelt.

It was Christmas, and it was snowing, and the news never warned of black ice on the roads. That night was not much different than this one, and he was yet again the sober driver to a drunk passanger– though Mydei is not nearly as gone as Cyrene was. He hears the seatbelt click into place.

Phainon's fingers flex and unflex on the steering wheel as if testing its stability.

"What's wrong?" Mydei's voice cuts through the stale air of the car so violently that it makes Phainon physically cringe. What *isn't* wrong would be the better question. He thinks of how to best answer it, and then decides to show his ass and be honest.

“I got in a car crash almost a year ago.”

Mydei is quiet for a moment, two seconds too long, enough time to make Phainon’s heartbeats pick up speed. He screws his eyes shut, equal parts embarrassed and scared, and then–

A warm hand on his arm, gripping just above his wrist. Gentle this time, entirely way too delicate. Mydei’s thumb rubs in small circles, too close to the old scar. He cannot bear to look at him, not now, he does not want to see pity reflected in his eyes; not from him as well.

“You’re all talk for being such a scaredy-cat.”

“What?”

Phainon swings around to look at him, and he is surprised by the distinct *lack* of pity in his eyes. He is grinning, a sort of cocky half-smirk, and he looks– a little amused, a little satisfied, yet kind still. Something soft, tender, like he’s trying to not spill the yolk out of a cracked egg. Mydei approaches the matter with an odd sort of casualty, like car crashes are just part of everyday life. Like Phainon’s life hasn’t been wrapped around it like a centipede curling on itself.

This new approach hits him like a bucket of cold ice, and Phainon cannot be anything but revenant. His eyes are practically sparkling. He’s being treated with care, yet not as if he could break. He’s being treated like…

A normal human being, perhaps?

“No, no, I’m just saying. I didn’t expect Phainon of Aedes Elysiae to be so scared of a fifteen minute drive.”

Phainon’s mouth falls open, and the grin on Mydei’s face only deepens at that. His eyes are crinkling, his dimples looking positively kissable. The passing cars and the streetlamps make an odd light show of his features, shadows waltzing across his face, ever-moving. It all feels a bit surreal, the tight air, the hand that has not stopped caressing his arm. His hands are so calloused, worked to the bone, yet precise and gingerly still. Beautiful white teeth, sharp canines, made for biting and tearing flesh. All of a sudden, Phainon can only think of smooching him.

“If you can get me home in ten, I’ll give you one of my fancy craft beers.”

“Fucking *deal* .”

He gets Mydei home in nine, because he catches all the green lights.

His place is a house, like an actual house, which makes sense because there’s six grown motherfuckers living there. It’s… surprisingly tidy inside. Like weirdly tidy, almost sterile, everything in its place, every stylistic choice deliberate. It’s spacious, and Mydei left some windows open to air out the house; it’s cool inside, but not uncomfortably so. He’s told to

make himself at home in the living room, and so Phainon picks one of the armchairs and perches on it. The buzzing in the back of his head has gotten quieter, yet it still persists.

He hears Mydei opening the fridge in the kitchen, and then he comes back with four fancy beer bottles; they seem to be like, plastic or some shit. He throws one at Phainon and Phainon catches it. Cracks it open without checking the label and takes a big sip.

Holy shit.

He swallows because he has no other choice, but it's not a pleasant ordeal.

"Why the fuck is it spicy?"

"It's made with hot chili."

"Man, what the hell?"

"What? You don't like it?" Mydei cocks his head, sounding genuinely surprised that Phainon doesn't like fiery devil's diarrhea tasting beer.

"No, I don't."

Mydei rolls his eyes and looks over the labels of the other bottles. "This one is blueberry with chocolatey undertones."

"Yeah, that sounds good."

This time, Mydei chucks the bottle at him, aiming for his head. Too bad, dipshit, Phainon was the top basketball player on his middle-school team. He's still got it, because he catches it midair right when it's about to hit him. He tastes it, now a little more careful, and– yeah, that's blueberry with chocolatey undertones. It's sweet, like actual juice.

"You have the palate of a toddler."

"Sorry, not all of us are Kremnoans used to drinking boiling blood."

"That's not true, that's–"

"Ancient anti-Kremnoan propaganda, I know. What about the Blade of Fury, is that also propaganda?" God, Phainon loves pulling at his pigtails. Mydei scoffs.

"How could it be propaganda? There's pictures of it. You know, you can see it from anywhere in Kremnos, no matter where you are. That's how grand it is. Big, huge marble statue. It's beautiful."

Phainon can't even argue with that– it *is* beautiful. One of the last remaining ancient wonders of the world.

They drink the beers together. And then Mydei goes and gets some more from his fridge, and they drink those too. Before he knows it, Phainon's vision is a little blurry, and Mydei is

swaying while sitting. Yeah, he's not driving back home.

"Let's play a game." Mydei says out of nowhere, slurring his speech a little.

"Alright, what game?"

"I tell you– hrmph, I tell you a secret, and then you tell me a secret, and then so on."

Phainon hums a little, thoughtful. "Alright. How do we decide a winner?"

"No, there's no winner."

Weird, coming from Mydei. Phainon shrugs. "Sounds goo–"

"I'll start." Mydei shifts on the couch, getting more comfortable and sitting with one leg bent under him. "In 2009, my dad tried to kill me and then successfully killed my mom. It was all over the news and I was under anonymity because I was a minor, but it was a very public case and some junky magazine released my full name and my likeness. It's forever on the internet now. *That's* what Cipher found, and what everybody that googles me finds."

Okay.

Phainon takes in a deep, shaky breath. Where does he even start? He instantly, like *instantly* , sobers up, all the haze of the alcohol gone with the snap of a finger. He can only look at Mydei, and what stares back at him is– bitterly sad. His jaw clenching and unclenching, his eyes exhausted. It is a melancholy gaze, the one that Mydei casts upon him, somber even– yet, what Phainon finds most breathtaking is the simmering fury beneath it, the odd sort of pride. An unyielding, devastating determination. *'God,'* he thinks then, and the small corner lamp gives Mydeimos a golden halo, *'He is so beautiful. He is so woeful.'*

"I'm sorry that happened, Myd–"

"Your turn."

Phainon winces at that, and the command makes him shudder. He'd do anything Mydei told him. He doesn't feel like following up *'my mother was murdered'* with *'that's funny, I also murdered someone'* is appropriate. So, instead–

"I tried to kill myself like, five months ago? Five and a half, maybe, I don't remember. I got very close, too. Had to get stitches, then I was on suicide watch for a few days."

Mydei doesn't seem to react to that, just reaches for another beer. His voice is casual and even when he speaks. "Yeah, I noticed the scar."

"Got matching ones." Phainon stretches out his hands and brings his wrists together, showing off the thick white scars there, jagged like the teeth of a saw. Mydei cranes his neck to look.

"You missed, didn't you? Got some nerve damage along the way?"

Phainon laughs nervously, but weirdly enough it is– it's not shame that drives his nerves, not the ugly kind that he bathes in. It is the same puerile nervousness that he feels when he makes a small *oopsie*. Something about all of this feels incredibly normal, kind of like… Mydei gets it, and understands it, and he's not making a whole *thing* out of it. "Yeah, something like that."

He watches as Mydei drinks an entire bottle of beer, crushes it in his hand, and throws it away. "My turn. When I was twenty-two, I was raped by my boyfriend."

Okay.

Phainon's heart sinks to the bottom of his stomach, and a cold chill overtakes him. There it is– here comes the *bad bad no good at all shame* . He feels like killing himself out of nowhere.

Mydei looks worse for wear. He physically recoils when he says that, his hand coming to slap over his mouth. His eyes shoot wide open, terrified. He's looking at Phainon, and he's *horrified* . Helpless. "I never told anyone that. Just my therapist."

"Mydei, I–"

"I'm gonna throw up."

And with that he bolts. Runs to what Phainon assumes is the bathroom. A door is opened and the sound of Mydei's knees hitting the tile floor is *sickening* . He retches, all liquid, for a long while. Phainon can only sit and sink into a strange feeling of despair. He rubs over his heart as though that may calm him, and only one thought mars his mind–

What have I done to him?

When Mydei returns, he can barely hold himself up. He's practically dragging his feet behind him, and he sits down on the couch heavily with a *thump*. He does not look at Phainon, yet Phainon looks at him nonetheless. He's grown pallid, sweat-slicked. His hands are shaking.

None speak. Phainon breaks the silence.

"Mydei, look, I just want to say I– I'm sorry, for… I didn't know, you know, so– I apologize. For that day in the gym, for always kind of grabbing at you–"

"Stop it."

That simmering fury, it's boiling over. He is mad, really mad. The whiteness of terror has given way to the redness of anger. "This is why– This is why I don't tell people this. They start treating me differently."

"*No*, Mydei, I'm not treating you differently, and I'm not gonna, it's just–" Phainon gestures wildly with his hands, desperate to get his point across. "If I ever made you uncomfortable–"

"Shut up, *stop*. I'm–" he looks like he's about to cry, "I'm an adult, I'm *capable* of consent. I'm not–"

“No, I know, it’s just–”

”I’m not helpless!”

Mydei yells, and he grabs an empty bottle and chucks it at the wall. Knocks down a picture hanging on it and it shatters on the wooden floor. His voice is more booming than Phainon expected. Whatever argument he had dies down with it. Phainon just runs his hand over his eyes, pinching the bridge of his nose. He feels like he’s gonna throw up, too.

“It’s not a big deal,” Mydei continues, “Stop making it a big deal.”

“I’m not–”

“We were having sex and he tried to choke me and I freaked out, I told him to stop and he didn’t. That’s it. *It’s not a big deal.”*

“Okay,” Phainon says, trying to placate him, to diffuse the situation. “It’s not a big deal.”

“Right.”

The silence is stifling, oppressive. It’s constricting all around him, cutting off his airflow. He can’t stop thinking about it, about the *what ifs* .

“Mydei.”

“Hm?”

“For my sake, please, because I *will* drive myself crazy…” Phainon can’t finish it. The sigh that breaks out of him is painful, shaky, and it comes out as more of a sob.

Mydei shifts on the couch. “Look at me,” he demands, and Phainon follows like an obedient dog.

He looks– he’s so *kind*. Incredibly upset, ravaged by grief, yet so mellow. So approachable. Phainon wants to beg for an embrace.

“I’m sorry for yelling at you. I freaked out,” when Phainon opens his mouth to speak, Mydei just raises his hand to silence him. “Let me finish, please.” He takes a very deep breath. “You haven’t done anything to make me uncomfortable. I have enjoyed all of your touches a lot, even when you’re playful and you grab me. I mean, I do the same to you, don’t I?”

“Yeah, but… Y’know, it’s… different, I guess.”

“Phainon, I really don’t want it to be, okay? I have a lot of shit going on. I don’t want to be treated like a delicate flower by you.”

Phainon wants to cry. He really wants to cry. He’s going to cry. “Okay, yeah. I get that.”

“We can just pretend this never happened.”

“No, I don’t…” Phainon gets up from the armchair, and walks over to the couch where Mydei is. His gaze follows him as he moves, and when Phainon just lingers in front of him, Mydei scoffs and moves aside to make room for him. He sits down next to him. “I don’t want to pretend like this never happened. I think, maybe, it’s good that you told me. Um. Brings us closer together or something.”

Mydei’s chuckle is self-deprecating, but it lingers into a handsome smile. “Yeah, maybe.” and then a moment later– “You look like shit.”

“Look, man, it’s a *lot*, okay?”

“Oh, it’s a lot for *you?* My bad, chief.” He raises his arms in mock surrender, and then laughs so sincerely that it makes Phainon’s heart ache. Despite that, however, he can’t help but laugh a little too.

In a bout of what is perhaps *pure madness* , Phainon brings his palm forward, raises it up– and presses it against one of Mydei’s. Mydei startles at first, unsure of its meaning, and then he relaxes, slowly. He allows it. Phainon intertwines their fingers, and brings their joined hand to his lap.

They just look at each other for a while.

“You’re hiding something from me, aren’t you?” Mydei says, though it is not an accusation.

“Yeah, I am.”

“Are you going to tell me?”

“One day.”

“That’s cruel, Phainon. I’m all naked in front of you.”

“God, I wish you were, though.” Phainon laughs, and Mydei laughs too.

It’s so easy to hold his gaze. Twin pools of molten gold, his pretty lashes wet with tears. Phainon is a weak man. His free hand comes to Mydei’s face, cups his sharp cheekbones, and with his thumb he wipes some of the unshed tears there. Mydei simply nuzzles into his palm, pressing closer, and sighs deeply.

“It’s left me a walking corpse,” he whispers, as if he were praying, “The rape.”

“No,” and Phainon prays back, “I don’t think it has.”

Mydei sneers at that, and all the softness leaves him. He moves out of Phainon’s hold, putting space between them. “It can’t be loved out of me.”

“I know.” *But I can help.*

Mydei gets up and goes to clean up the broken glass and the beer bottle. “You can stay the night, if you want to. Take Leonnius’ room or something. I’m– tired. I’m going to bed.”

It ends like that. Mydei cleans up for a little bit, and then shows Phainon to Leonnius' room. He gives him some pajamas, and then retreats into his bedroom.

Phainon lays still in this strange bed for a long time, unable to sleep, wishing he were in Mydei's instead. He rolls over to his side and catches sight of the bruise on his wrist, from when Mydei grabbed him. It has started to redden, looking almost furious. When he probes it with his finger, he finds it tender to the touch. Phainon's heart quickens at the prospect of it turning purple-blue, then yellow-green, and then eventually fading back into his flesh. Carrying around Mydei's mark, if only for a week, such physical evidence of his existence, so shockingly real.

It is no wonder, then, that Phainon's overtaken by a need to claim back.

He brings his wrist to his mouth and kisses it as if it were a lover– as if it were Mydei. He runs his lips over it, upwards and downwards, and he swears he can taste jasmine tea and pomegranate and expensive craft beer. His tongue lolls out to lick at it, to suck, to savour the salty flesh there. He imagines it is Mydei instead, his beautiful lips, his bosom, the hard, flat planes of his stomach and then lower still. He is sighing into it, gasping quietly, whispering things he'd rather not repeat.

Phainon orgasms untouched.

When he sleeps, it is with a clearer head than ever in the last nine months.

Mydei has a nightmare.

He is ten years old and he is killing a cat. The rest ought to remain unspoken– the cat wears his face, and then his mother's, then his uncle's. When the cat puts on his father's face, that is when it transforms into a great red lion, and its strength overwhelms him. It pins him to the ground and dives into his soft belly, tearing his flesh, pulling out his innards.

It hurts, but only because he deserves it.

The first time Mydei looked for comfort after a nightmare, he was three years old and gripping his Simba plushie. The last time Mydei looked for comfort after a nightmare is now, twenty-five years old and still gripping his Simba plushie.

The door to Leonnius' room creaks when it opens, and he lingers in the doorway. Phainon awakes with a small startle. He is half-asleep, face swollen and marred by lines left by the bedsheets. His eyes are bleary, unseeing. Mydei's silhouette is blackened by the darkness, illuminated at the edges by the moonlight.

Phainon groans, shifts a little. "Cyrene?"

Perhaps that is all Mydei needed. He returns to his room, stepping softly, and goes back to bed.

He leaves the both of them to their nightmares.

When they wake up the next morning, properly wake up that is, Mydei will cook Phainon a small healthy breakfast. Phainon will undoubtedly say something stupid, and the both of them will laugh over it. Then he will drive Phainon back home, before returning to his own abode.

He will go to Leonnius' room to make sure everything is in place, because Leonnius is a bit of a clean freak, and that is when he will see it– a small strand of hair, shining like silver amongst the pillows. He will pick it up carefully, with such reverence one might think he is handling the Shroud of Turin. He will hold it up in the sunlight, see how it glimmers pale and pearly like the mane of an unicorn.

And he will bring it to his lips, and kiss it.

Chapter End Notes

i was very nervous about this chapter because i was unsure of how explicit i should be about mydei's trauma. i decided, though, that it's better to be sincere and frank with it. call it what it is and show how it most commonly looks like. i even got emotional writing this one at some point lol

Chapter 7: shotgun

Chapter Notes

Hi, I'm back with almost 14k words. Had to take a break from this fic cause it burned me out but wahoo here we are. I love this fic so much.

!IMPORTANT!

This is a Mydei-centric chapter and that always comes with a general **SA and CHILD & DOMESTIC ABUSE** TW. There are two explicit scenes TW'd below, but generally, Mydei is dealing with the emotional and psychological consequences of his abuses all throughout the fic.

▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There are little pockets of time Mydei seems to return to.

Take, for example, this—

He is nine years old and very skinny. He's very scared and very upset and he tries his best to be silent—he can't sleep because he's frightened, and he's frightened because his dad came home drunk and angry again, and he got into an ugly fight with Mom.

Eurypon is pacing just outside his door, and he's muttering something Mydei can't quite make out; still, Mydei can tell he is disturbed, troubled, not quite himself. He's hiding under his blanket and keeping very very still, as if his father were a prowling lion and he a newborn gazelle—as if even the slightest movement, nevermind the separation of the wooden door, could snap Eurypon's cold gaze onto him.

It happens exactly as he feared—Eurypon swings the door open like a man crazed, a movement so sudden and unexpected and *loud* that it startles Mydei out of his cover, and he just… stands there for a moment. Slick with sweat, breathing hard. Brutally handsome, like the teeth of a chainsaw. He's looking at Mydeimos, amber to amber, two scorpions encased in time. There was a time, many years ago, when Eurypon would hoist him up on his lap and scratch his smooth cheeks with his beard, making him laugh. He looked deep into the boy's eyes then, intense, and said that they're so so alike with both of their golden hues, that it's very rare and it means God loves them so much more. Said that it's special.

Eurypon's eyes aren't really amber or golden right now. They're black like the pit of a well. Black like the abyss. Black like a bruise.

And Mydei is scared, he's proper scared now, and his heart is running so fast it starts to skip beats.

It's like looking into a shark's eyes. Beady and shiny like polished stone, and cold too. There's nothing reflected in them.

Empty.

"Mydeimos," his father speaks, and the voice isn't his. It sounds different, distant, nearly inhuman. As if someone took his skin and was wearing it around like a trophy. "Put on your shoes. We're going for a drive."

"But it's late," Mydei says before he can catch himself.

He knows he's said the wrong thing, because Eurypon clenches and unclenches his fist. His anger seethes like boiling blood just beneath his skin, and his jaw is set in so much tension Mydei is afraid he's going to shatter all of his teeth. His dad is trying so hard to be good, but Mydei can tell he wants to snap at him. Lounge at him. Eurypon takes in a deep breath, shaky, and he can see his entire chest quiver with it, as if inhalation has become impossible for him. The mere act of containing himself was physically difficult for Eurypon.

The distance between them, between the bed and the door, becomes suffocating. Endlessly stretching yet desperately close. Eurypon is both an ocean away, and yet so close that Mydei can see every eukaryotic cell in his body. The nucleus and the mitochondria. He thinks theirs must be identical, like their eyes—something fundamentally twinsome, a two-headed calf. Mydei thinks, when he's sure God can't hear him, that he and his father must be the same person but at different times. That Eurypon is the adult Mydeimos coming back from the future to torment him for a mistake he's made.

When he's sure God (that being, Eurypon) can't see him, Mydei likes to buy a carton of eggs with his allowance. He brings them to school in his backpack (it has lion ears on it) and runs his fingers over them while the teacher is talking about the Battle of Ludon. He thinks about the baby inside of it (he doesn't know that the eggs you eat aren't fertilized, he's just nine years old) and if its momma was sad when the farmer took her babies away. He wonders if his mom would be sad if the farmer took him away from her, but he overheard her on the phone once with her brother saying, *"I can't leave, 'cause of Mydei"* so of course, the logical conclusion is that she would be quite happy. Means that she could leave. He wonders what the farmer would do with him. After school, he finds a nice little park with a swing, and he sits on it while he throws the eggs on the hard pavement. He grows increasingly disappointed when he sees that each of them are white and yellow and there's no baby. But he persists. And every month he buys a new carton of eggs and cracks them open in the park. Sometimes he watches as little birds come to eat from the yolk. One time, however, after many tries, he cracks one egg and sees that it's different. It's hot orange and shot with little red veins that pulse uselessly, and there's this pink little thing inside with a big black dot in the middle of it. *That's the baby*, he thinks. He scoops it up and it's… not really a chick, though Mydei *knows* it's supposed to be one. It's just something that could possibly be a chick, just like how Mydei is something that could possibly be a person. He puts the embryo in his pocket and carries it home.

He's not sure why he's thinking about it now, but he gasps when he hears Eurypon's old dress shoes squeak as he steps closer to him. He flinches away by instinct, and puts his arm up to

guard himself. His dad scoffs at that, and simply pulls his blanket off of him. “I know it’s late, just come on. Stop talking back to me.”

“Okay,” Mydei squeaks, small, “I’ll let Mom know.”

That really was the wrong thing to say, because his dad groans and runs his hands over his face. He grabs onto his beard and pulls, the way he always does when he’s stressed out. “Why does your *fucking mom* need to know about *everything* that goes on in this *fucking house?”* He’s not quite yelling, but he’s not talking sweet either. He has an edge in his voice, simmering with rage, and it’s enough to scare Mydei into paleness. He’s learned from a very young age that when there’s an angry man in the house, everybody has to work together and try *really hard* to keep him calm and happy. So that’s what Mydei does right now.

“...Sorry. I won’t tell her.”

“Go put on your shoes. And get your jacket, it’s cold outside.”

“Yes, sir.”

And Mydei does as told, because his obedience keeps Eurypon at bay. He treats this whole ordeal like he’s stuck in a cage with a wild tiger—and essentially, that is exactly what’s happening. He leaves his bed slowly and realizes, with horror, that Eurypon is standing in front of the door. That means he has to go past him if he wants to leave. Mydei is too nervous to approach, scared that Eurypon might snap and grab him. He looks up at him, pleading, ashamed of it.

“Jesus, kid,” Eurypon laughs, because there’s something about this that he finds funny, “I’m not gonna do anything to you.”

Hard to believe. If Eurypon’s not doing something to Gorgo, then he’s doing something to Mydei. *Something* is always happening in this house. Still, Eurypon moves aside. Gives Mydei a clear exit.

Mydei thinks, well, even if he’s grabbed, that’s not as bad as what Mom usually gets. And maybe his dad is being genuine. He decides to be a very brave little boy, and he steps past Eurypon. The smell of alcohol and tobacco clinging to him hits him like spoiled curdled milk. He makes a sour face, and Eurypon laughs harder at that. “Your dad smells bad, huh?” and he checks to smell his breath, “Sorry, kid. Come on.”

Eurypon grabs his shoulder and the gesture isn’t violent in and of itself, but Mydei has come to expect it so he startles nonetheless. He lets himself be led downstairs to the closet, and Eurypon keeps watch over him as he fishes out his sneakers and his jacket.

He’s fiddling with his zipper and can’t quite get it in, because his hands are trembling. He’s very nervous, because his dad wants to drive drunk in the middle of the night and Mydei just learned in school that you’re not supposed to do that. The insertion pin keeps slipping away from him. Eurypon sighs, and it *is* affectionate—it must be, because he gets down on his knees and helps Mydei zip it up. Then he pats the jacket down and fixes it around his shoulders; it’s a little big. Mom sized up so he could *‘grow into it’*.

“There you go.”

“Thanks, Dad.”

They walk to the car, hand in hand. Two unloveable things. The air outside is so cold, and he can’t breathe. He goes to sit in the back, but Eurypon asks him to take the front seat instead. He even helps Mydei with the belt.

It smells so bad. He smells so bad. The car is dripping oil from somewhere, if the stench is anything to go by, even though Eurypon made a whole *scene* out of saying he *got the fucking thing fixed* when Mom asked him about it.

They drive in silence at first. It’s just them on the road, and Eurypon isn’t speeding up or acting crazy, so Mydei thinks they probably won’t both die in a fiery car explosion.

“Are you hungry? Let’s stop at McDonald’s.”

Mydei looks up to him, and is met with Eurypon’s expectant gaze.

“No, not really.”

That was also the wrong thing to say, because he starts to grip the steering wheel so hard that he might break it clean off. He grits his teeth. “Stupid me for trying to do something nice for you for once. Fucking—”

Everybody has to work very hard to keep the angry man in the house happy.

“Actually, um, I am a bit hungry. Yeah. We could stop at McDonald’s.”

That seems to do it. Mydei isn’t sure what to order when they get there, because he’s worried that if he orders too much, it’s going to make Eurypon mad. So he settles for a McChicken and a small portion of fries. Eurypon tells the lady at the counter to throw in a big chocolate milkshake too, even though the weather’s freezing cold. He doesn’t get anything for himself, and instead settles to watch Mydei eat outside.

He’s watching him closely and it’s kind of unnerving. Mydei tries to focus on his food, but every once in a while he will flit his eyes up towards his dad and find him staring back with a severe gaze. Though he does not seem to be staring at *him*, not really, but more so *through* him. His eyes are a little glassy, a little glazed over, and his brows furrow and unfurrow. His hands are linked together in front of his mouth like some villain from the animes Mydei likes to watch, and he can tell that his mouth is twitching over unsaid words.

It’s as if he’s arguing with someone in his head. Perhaps he’s arguing with himself. Or with the memory of his father. Mydei finds it creepy and struggles to finish his food and his milkshake, because he’s worried that if he *doesn’t*, Eurypon is going to be mad.

“All done,” he says, pushing his tray forward, and he’s so full it’s uncomfortable. He feels like throwing up.

That's when Eurypon's glare sharpens—he was somewhere far away seemingly, and only now came back. He looks at Mydei for a second, and then chuckles. "I just realized you're wearing your pajamas."

Mydei looks down at his jammies—they're orange with Simba heads on them. "What's wrong with my pajamas?"

"Nothing, just–" Eurypon chuckles again, and it makes Mydei smile a little too, "Nothing. Let's go."

Mydei figured out, about ten minutes into their drive, that they're essentially driving in circles. And Eurypon is growing restless. He's arguing with invisible enemies again, his whole face twitching in anger and dropping in sorrow. It must be a hell of a fight. Mydei tries to look away, look out the window, but feels himself mesmerized by it. By him.

"Your mother wasn't always like that," Eurypon says all of a sudden, "She used to be nice. Then you came along."

"Ah."

"Now all she does is provoke me."

"Oh."

"And I can't help myself when she's like *that."*

"Mmm."

"And you love pissing me off too. I swear, sometimes it's like you two gang up on me."

"Ah… I'm sorry, Dad. I don't mean to."

"Yeah…" Eurypon says, more to himself than anyone else, and his eyes are dazed, "I know you don't."

More silence passes. Mydei starts to count the times they've passed by the McDonald's. Is he stalling…?

"Mydeimos…" Eurypon whispers at one point, and his voice is full of longing. Mydei looks up at him and finds his face full of strange affection. "You look just like her sometimes."

That must be a bad thing. Dad doesn't like Mom very much anymore.

"Oh. I'm sorry."

When they get home, nearly half an hour later, Mydeimos is so carsick he thinks he's going to vomit all the McDonald's he ate. He quickly slips out of his shoes and his jacket and arranges them neatly in their rightful place, and really he's just happy that he survived the car ride. He goes to cross the hallway, but he feels Eurypon's burning gaze at his back. It's enough to make him stop and look back.

“Dad…?”

He stares into the maw of a wolf. His eyes are polished stones again. He is clenching his fists, uncleaching them, flexing his fingers. Shifting his weight from one leg to the other. He’s pale like the bark of a birch tree. Everything about him is dull. Lusterless. There’s fear in those beady little eyes, almost childlike, and Mydei wonders if Eurypon is back in his childhood home, thirty years ago, standing over his mother while his dad is beating the living hell out of both of them. Eurypon has told Mydei one or two things about his grandfather. How he was a hardworking salt-of-the-earth man that also had a very peculiar hobby called ‘belting your child so hard he passes out’. *“You must think I’m so awful,”* he said once, drunk like a dog, *“But I’m not. I’m not like him. And you should be grateful.”*

All of the cells in Mydei’s body are screaming *danger* and telling him to *fucking go.* He wants to run, but if he does, then Eurypon is going to chase after him. And he’s going to catch him, because he’s older and stronger and bigger than Mydei, and he’s going to make him regret ever trying to run away.

They look at each other for a while, then Eurypon wipes his hand of sweat on his olive green jacket. “Mydei,” he says, beckoning him closer with it, “C’mere, kid.”

Mydei does, because the consequences of disobeying are worse than whatever Eurypon’s got planned for him. Mom is sleeping upstairs. He doesn’t want to wake her.

So he comes, though his legs want to betray him and book it. He walks on shaky stumps, and stops right in front of his dad.

Eurypon crouches down again, just like he did when he helped him with his jacket. He gets very close to Mydei. His face is red and blotchy, especially the tip of his nose. The stink of alcohol makes him want to retch. His golden eyes are soft and kind and a little wet. Bloodshot. He looks like he’s about to cry.

He grabs Mydei by the elbows first, gently, rubs his arms up to his shoulders. He squeezes them, manly and stoic, then moves to cup his face in both hands and caress his cheeks with his thumbs. Mydei is wildly uncomfortable, because Eurypon has never done this before. He can’t even attempt to understand what this is supposed to mean, or if it’s supposed to feel nice.

He smiles all yellow-toothed and he can barely hold his tears back. A small sob. The sight of his father crying is so novel and embarrassing that Mydei feels like crawling out of his skin and hiding away.

“Mydeimos…” Eurypon says, and he’s petting Mydei’s hair and rubbing under his eyes. “I love you very much, do you know that? Daddy loves you *so much.”*

Daddy…? Mydei cringes, but he tries to school his expression. He knows this is a nice thing that nice dads tell their nice sons. He’s never heard it from him before, though.

“Oh, uhm…” he shifts a little, uncomfortable, “...Thanks, Dad. Um. I love you too.”

Eurypon smiles harder at that and makes a sound stuck between a sob and a laugh.

And then his hands wrap around Mydei's throat.

He sees his psychiatrist the next day and gets off lithium. The taste of his new medicine is as bitter as his father's callouses.

The silver strand of hair rests in his wallet like a precious keepsake.

Phainon checks his phone when he gets home after whatever the fuck all of *that* was. Cipher's drug-induced tomfoolery and uh, his sleepover with Mydei, if it can be called that.

There are a *lot* of messages he's missed.

First, in his group work chat.

Tribbie💌🫧 *has removed* ***Cipher***😾😾

Tribbie💌🫧

I'm really sorry about yesterday.

That was not appropriate for a work event at all.

Dummyrice🔮💜

why was cipher removed??

Aglaea⚜️🪞

We won't be continuing our collaboration with her as an employee.

Don't worry. I'm taking care of it.

Then, in their friend group chat.

Cipher😾😾 *has left.*

Dummyrice🔮💜

??? i'm really confused

Polyester🦋🪻

Well that was certainly something. That must've been one hell of a first impression, right Mydei? Lol.

Dummyrice🔮💜

hyacine do you know what this is about

i'm really worried about her

Cinny🍰🎀

Don't be worried Cas. She's okay.

Aglaea and I are taking care of it!! 🌈

Phainon

did she get fired?

Cinny🍰🎀

Yeahhh? Kind of.

Anaxa is gonna take care of the paperwork today.

But yeah, she's not going to be working here anymore.

Polyester🦋🪻

Oop.

Dummyrice🔮💜

that's fucking ridiculous

what do you mean she KIND OF got fired??

did she or did she not get fired

where is she going to work???

Cinny🍰🎀

Look, I don't know if it's my place to tell.

But she'll be okay. Aglaea's gonna take care of her.

That reminds me, I have a cat that I have to rehome for a bit.

Dummyrice🔮💜

WHY ARE YOU REHOMING HER CATS??

Cinny🍰🎀

Ugh, Cas.

She has a phone, you know?

Just ask her about it.

I don't want to be the one to air out her dirty business.

Do you want a cat? Aglaea, Anaxa, Tribios and I took the others. Phainon has Bartholos.

That leaves me with Embezzlement.

So… any takers?

Bartholos is already too much responsibility for him to handle. Another cat would drive Phainon up the walls.

Mydei🦁

I don't like cats.

Polyester🦋

Ooo Cas can we? Please?

Dummyrice🔮💜

fine

we'll take embezzlement

Cinny🍰🎀

Awesome!!

Dummyrice🔮💜

is it for like. forever?

Cinny🍰🎀

It's just for a month or so, dw.

I'll stop by today to drop him off!

And his litterbox and stuff.

And then the conservation just… dies.

Life tries to tug forward into normalcy. Like he's supposed to, what, take a shower and go about his day? Make himself a cup of coffee and maybe go for a jog? He's supposed to pretend like Cipher didn't drop out of his life all of a sudden?

For all he knows, she could be dead—I mean, he *knows* she's alive, Hyacine literally said she's okay, but she's not here. She's gone. She might as well be dead. Disappeared.

If she were here, Cyrene would tell him something wise. Maybe flick his forehead like she used to and tell him he's being a very silly boy and this isn't all that important.

Still, Phainon feels short of breath. His heart is so tight in his chest it feels like it belongs to a mouse, or something else small and scared because like what do you *mean* Cipher left this isn't supposed to happen because like, it's Cipher, and Cipher is always here and you know what, matter of fact, fuck her and her stupid fucking cats too. It's his fault. She got fed up with him and had a public breakdown because she's an useless junkie and yeah, you know what, *fuck her*, fuck Hyacine too, and while we're here, fuck Mydei as well—cause like, what the fuck was all of that last night? *Ooh look at me I'm Mydeimos, I've been through so much, my dad killed my mom and I got ran over by seventeen buses and also I got a traumatic brain injury or something like that and my friend had super extra special deadly fucking cancer but like, hey, I'm taking it soooo well and sooo nobly and I have my life sooo together not like you, Phainon, piece of garbage shit fuck garbage shit. Idiot.*

There are moments in time where Phainon is under so much duress that he fully and wholly understands why some people kill out of anger. This is one of them. His vision becomes blurry with it, and he knows he's crying but he can't feel his tears, and it's just—come on, man, you're twenty-seven.

You're a twenty-seven year old single idiot dry-heaving like a horny dog in his living room, and you got nothing going on for you. Dead end job and up to your neck in debts. Your friends tolerate you at best, and your *best friend* just up and fucked off. You continuously swing the baseball bat of your temperament at everything that is good and precious in your life. You've crowded Mydei in his personal space and made him uncomfortable and *yeah,* he said he liked it, but like… Why would he, when it's *you* doing it? You're barely holding it in together, and for what? You wanted to be something once. You wanted to be a fairytale hero when you were a little boy, the protector of Aedes Elysiae, and then you were like, well what's the closest thing to that—obviously a commercial pilot. You spend most of your time fucking off in a flying machine of doom and you're in charge of the lives of hundreds. It sounds *perfect* for you. So you put yourself through pilot school and you're great, you're *really good,* it's all you expected and more. You take big loans to pay it off and you work really hard and you graduate *cumma sum laude* as the top of your class and then it's time to apply for a pilot license! This is where it gets really funny—*you fail the psychological assessment.* And you keep failing it. And failing it. Every. Fucking. Year.

So you give up, and now you've got all of these debts, but it's fine, because at least you're *together.* Together with Cyrene. And she pets your hair and kisses your brow when you cry and says, *"I'm sure you'll get it one day, Phainon. Let's just go to a doctor!"* But you're too stubborn and too embarrassed to see a doctor about it, so instead you find a piece of shit job and you let it whittle away at you until you're like, nothing like yourself. Speaking of yourself, who are you? *What* are you? What do you want?

(*"What do you want to be when you grow up?"*

Cyrene had ice cream all over her mouth, pink and strawberry-flavoured; she had always been a messy eater, a little too eager to dive into sweetness.

"I don't know," he answered then, as honestly as he could, "What do you want me to be?"

She laughed, airy, easy, throwing her head back. Her blonde hair was coiffed into a choppy bob, Mom's doing. Their mother was at work alongside their father, which meant that she was in charge of the cooking and the cleaning—though she never seemed to mind. She was happy to provide, and it seemed like she always had some allowance to spare for ice cream and chips.

She was sitting on the little swing their father had installed for them, and he was at the table, licking his ice cream happily—vanilla flavoured. "What kind of answer is that?" she chuckled, "I meant, what do you want for yourself?"

"I dunno," he answered, ever-oblivious. He did not have much on his mind those days, just all the love for his sister and his parents, and all the hatred for his schoolwork. "I guess I'll just do whatever you do, so we can be together."

She laughed again, and he didn't notice this but– it was sadder, somber even, like the edges of it have been frayed by an open flame. Always older than her age, parentified, the eldest daughter. Love poured out of her like out of an open artery; fear did, too. She had been fearful, restless, desperate for purchase. If he had known, he would have reached over and kissed her cheek—as fate had it, however, he was only ten years old and none the wiser.

Still, despite it, she laughed.

"That's funny, Phainon," Cyrene said, licking her thumb and reaching over to wipe some ice cream from his face. Ignoring her own filth. "Cause I was gonna say the same thing."

He did not say anything at that, though now he wishes he did. Just took a big bite out of his icecream. If he listened closely, which he did not, he would have heard Cyrene whisper under her breath; 'Together…')

Phainon is just about to think about how he's, you know, a sororicide on the loose (really just the cherry on top of his favorite *'self-pity'* flavoured cake), when his phone dings. A text message. He's pacing around the room while *actively* going crazy, but the chime is enough to snap him out of it. He grabs his phone as if it wronged him, presses the button to turn it on—

Cipher 😾😾 *is typing…*

And she's *been* typing. She's already sent him a couple text messages. Phainon doesn't read them—he sees red.

"You're a no good piece of shit junkie trashy bitch and I hope you fucking—" he mouths off as he types. He goes on for a while. Writes a whole paragraph in that same vein. Phainon's about to press send when he feels something soft and fat vibrate against his leg, and when he looks down—Bartholos. Still ugly as sin. Licking the hem of his jeans and making biscuits on his slippers. The cat looks up at him with big orange eyes, pleading, and oh, right. He

hasn't fed him today, and he has to feed him because Bartholos is helpless and small and depends on him for his survival. Phainon drops his phone and fishes out a nice can of wet cat food (gourmet cat food, mind you, only the best for Barty) from his cupboard; are you supposed to keep these in a cupboard? Nevermind, Bartholos loves it nonetheless and he practically jumps on it, chewing happily and getting his whiskers all moist and dirty. Phainon crouches next to him and strokes his fluffy grey fur. He watches, enraptured, as the fur slips between his fingers like silk; it's so dense and well taken care of. Bartholos is on the older side, but he's just so—Cipher must love him very much. When she dropped him off she practically gave Phainon an entire list of how to take care of him, how often to brush his fur, what food he likes. She even said she'll help out with money for him if he's ever too short on it.

Bartholos turns to look at him again as soon as he's petted, abandoning the food in favour of bumping his big head against Phainon's hand. He licks his fingers and gets them all dirty with cat food slop, but it makes him laugh. He scoops the cat into his arms and buries his nose in his chest. Inhales deeply. He smells so good. *He smells just like Cipher.* A little rough and dusty, but pleasant, like old parchment.

"It was my ex-wife's idea to get him," Cifera told him this story a million times, *"And when we divorced, yeah, I kept him. Got a bunch of other cats too. Love him to bits, the ugly motherfucker. He's my baby."*

Her baby, and she gave him to Phainon for, just… Nothing. His well-being. *Companionship.* She smiled all toothy and said *'I think you need a friend around the house'* or something like that. Little Bartholos who's all lazy and sweet and purrs like a car engine. He's getting his fur all wet with his tears, but Bartholos doesn't seem to mind; instead he tries to bury his head in the crook of Phainon's neck, and he starts licking and eating at the small hairs there.

He misses Cipher like a broken leg. Misses her like he misses the bottom of a Black Jack bottle, well-loved. It feels like something very precious is being taken from him, like it's forcibly being ripped from his chest and stomped on. He doesn't want to let go. He doesn't know how to let go, God, he's never let go of anything ever, and they keep piling up in this mountain on his shoulders and he can't—he can't carry it. He's unable to. He's not good enough. He wants to put it down. Let him put it down. Allow him to put it down. Anybody, anything–

Another chime from his phone.

Phainon has calmed down. The storm tempered, but now his head is pounding because he worked himself up like an idiot. He doesn't even know why he's mad at Cipher. She's messaging him so, like, she can't be that mad. And yeah, he thinks Cipher is the type to ghost and never come back but—she wouldn't do that to *him*, right? She would have all the reasons to, for all the shit he put her through, but she just. Wouldn't. Right?

He lets the cat eat in peace and takes his phone in hand once more. Wipes his tears and decides to be a brave young man for once.

Cipher🐱🐱

i hate to be doing this over text honestly

cuz im not that much of an avoidant asshole

but i dont have time to meet up

we have to stop being friends

for now

What.

Phainon

what?

are you gonna stop being friends with the others too?

Cipher🐱🐱

no

look

i just need a break

its not forever

Phainon

wait, why just me??

Cipher🐱🐱

look.

im. going inpatient at this rehab center

and honestly i dont like really ~WANT~ to get better but i HAVE to get better

cuz i know that like. what i want (mmm yummy drugs) and what i need (Not That) are 2 different things

so im gonna go get better

but you also have to get better before we can be friends again

i Do want to be friends again. sometime

Phainon

like in a long time?

Cipher😾😾

i dunno

that depends

on you and . on me

Phainon

i don't understand

why just me?

Cipher😾😾

youre. not well phainon

and im not well either n like

tbh i feel like i take care of your mental health more than i do mine

i wake up with panic attacks thinking that you killed yourself while i was asleep

and then i relapsed. not that i was sober in the first place but i relapsed hard like. i dunno. about the time we stopped talking and just.

im going to rehab and i have a new job lined up. and i have to stop being friends with you for a while

Phainon

i. didnt know you had drug issues

Cipher😾😾

phainon i would blow like 25% of my paycheck on drugs when we went out

i was literally born addicted to meth. pretty much grew up in a meth lab

you couldnt have possibly known and i dont blame you

but we have to take a break until were both better

Phainon

this is so out of nowhere

Cipher😾😾

its not really

ive been thinking about it for a while

been talking to hyacine about it

she said that it was unhealthy and it wasnt good for either of us

Well, that's great. Hyacine knows all his shit now. *What does she mean unhealthy?* It can't be unhealthy. Phainon doesn't want it to be unhealthy. It makes him happy. It's a good thing in his life, she's—*she's a good thing in his life.* It couldn't have been unhealthy, because he loves her. He adores her. Nobody—nobody gets him like Cipher does. Nobody makes him laugh like she does. He doesn't want to let it go; he *can't.*

Cipher😾😾

dont worry

i didnt tell her about the suicide thing

Phainon

oh

why didnt you tell me?

that it was making you uncomfortable or

sad or stressed out

i wouldve stopped

Cipher😾😾

i dont know

i felt like you needed me. needed my support like that

round the clock

and i just. yeah

i felt like. you know how people who hang themselves stand on stools

i felt like i was that stool under you

like if i stopped youd just be hanging

so we have to stop being friends for now

and you have to try to get better okay?

i dont like that this is happening either

youre not the bad guy here. its my fault too. i havent always been the best friend to you

ive been mean sometimes and. that thing yesterday. im sorry

Phainon is staring at his phone, incredulous. This can't possibly be happening, this can't—

Phainon

what if you forget about me?

Cipher😼😼

dont be stupid lol

cmon pretty boy how could i possibly forget about you

youre still my best friend

and i dont blame you

and im not mad at you either

i want to take a break so we can be better friends to each other okay?

i wont forget about you

Phainon

okay

Cipher😼😼

im gonna block you now okay?

cya

And then that's it. Gone like dust.

Go on with the rest of your day now. Act normal. Your sister is dead and you need to wipe the windows. Your friend is gone and your piping needs fixing. Mental note: call your landlord. Other mental note: if you kill yourself, Bartholos is going to starve, because he's too nice to eat you.

It's just—it's… Let's just sleep. He just woke up, but yes, let's go back to sleep. Let's crawl back to Cyrene's room and slither into her bed, among her pretty pink sheets, and sleep. It all smells like her. It's all so beautiful. Someone sings sweetly. The wound of Cipher pulses in Phainon like a dying heart. New and raw and tender.

Let's just sleep, yeah. Let's sleep for the next fourteen hours.

His new meds (lamotrigine and quetiapine) are making him sleepy, hungry and irritable. The lowered dose of lithium is making him feel like there's ants crawling under skin. His mouth has been bone dry for the past three days and at this point he's just pissing water with how much he's drunk.

It's just the perfect cocktail to send Mydei into a fuck-ass spiral and all he wants to do is lay down and sleep and then like, never wake up. But his roommates keep him on his toes. Phainon hasn't been feeling the gym lately, so Leonnius picked it up again for his sake. He has to work twice as hard now to stay the weight off. Hephaestion pulls him out of his naps whenever he feels like Mydei's slept too much and he takes him on these long winding walks. Says he needs the clean air for his lungs and that he'd rather go through chemo again than hang out with the others. Ptolemy tries to keep him awake by goading him into info-dumping about early Kremnoan military tactics. Peucesta drags him along to his drag shows and it's like, fiiiineee? He mostly ends up disassociating while his friend is doing splits to *365* by Charli XCX. Which is an awful time to disassociate, because that sounds like a lot of fun. Perdikkas tells him all of these vitamins and supplements he should add to his diet and it's like, thanks Perdikkas, can you also prescribe me for an euthanasia?

"Um… no?"

"Ah. I didn't realize I said that outloud."

There are things that piss him off now that didn't piss him off before. Like the sound of Hephaestion's CPAP machine whirring at night, or the way his keys jingle in his pocket. Mydei suddenly hates the way Castorice hums after a good bite of food or the way Phainon slurps his coffee. He ends up working overtime at the *'Don't Scream and Break Things'* Factory just to make sure he acts *normal* and doesn't snap at all of his friends. Be normal. *Why can't you be normal?*

All in all, it's not as bad as he thought it would be? He fully expected a *huuuge* manic episode, like that one that got him institutionalized for the first time; it was a few years back, when he had this delusion that he was the undying prince of Castrum Kremnos sent to slay Nikador. Not his best moment, but somehow better than the time when he convinced himself he was the one that actually killed his mother.

So, he keeps it together. Barely, but he's been *barely keeping it together* for the past sixteen years of his life.

Talking about the past sixteen years of his life—Krateros messages him one day.

Krateros

Mydei

Look what I got

[image.jpg]

🤖

Got it for 800 Balance Coins

It's a picture of… well—Mydei *knows,* intellectually, that it's a Gundam. His uncle loves collecting them and Mydei *really doesn't get it.* They all kind of look the same to him. This one's *really* ugly, spectacularly so. A big golden robot with wings on its back and on its face and then just some blue bullshit all over. It's, yeah. It's certainly a Gundam. Krateros loves 'em. Always did. He has a room in his house reserved only for them. This is who Mydei got his autism from—guess it skipped Gorgo.

Mydei

Is this what you spend your big boy money on?

Krateros

Well yeah

Don't gotta spend it on you anymore XD

Don't you recognize it?

The Gundam

It's the PG Unicorn 03 Phenex

Narrativ ver

Mydei

That means nothing to me.

Should I recognize it?

Krateros

It's the one you broke when you were little

Oh. That's—that's right. When Krateros first got custody of him, he was… Well, he was a thirty-three year old autistic IT tech guy nerd who was really into collecting Gundams; he's still all of those things, just sixteen years older.

Krateros was wholly unprepared for a child, especially considering that that child was *Mydeimos.* All Mydei can say about him is that he *tried his best.* There was really no other choice. They tried placing him with his estranged grandparents first, Eurypon's mother and father, but they were deemed unfit to care for a child. Old, sick, disabled, on pension, barely getting by. So Krateros it was, and at one point during his first month there, he gave him his entire Gundam collection. Thinking about it now, it must've been worth thousands. Maybe tens of thousands. Krateros was especially attached to this ugly golden thing, and it was *huge.*

Almost came up to Mydei's bellybutton. He wasn't the type to play with toys anyways, but he gave it a shot. Tried to make up little stories about them, because he knows that's what kids are supposed to do. The therapist lady always said he had *deficits in pretend play*, but if only she could see him now—those Gundams were killing each other in such unique ways.

Oddly unique. Oddly precise. Not in a kid's cartoon violence way, but more in the way of someone, who might or might not be around nine years old, that liked spending a good amount of their time glued to their uncle's computer screen while he was at the office, browsing through LiveLeak or gore.com or r/WatchPeopleDie for several hours a day, and watching enraptured with big golden eyes how people twitch with aftershocks.

That's probably not relevant at all, but the point is that Mydei got angry and frustrated all of the sudden and broke the big ugly golden robot. Fucked it up until it was unfixable, then apologized sheepishly when Krateros came home to the murder scene. All he said then was, *"Oh buddy, that's fine, it was just a toy,"* but it *wasn't* just a toy. Krateros must've been heartbroken.

Mydei

That's right.

I remember now.

I felt awful for that. I'm sorry.

You must've been heartbroken.

Krateros

No, not really

I mean I was, but not because you broke it

More so because you were going through a hard time

I really didn't give a fuck about you breaking the Gundam that much tbh

I just felt like I was failing you somehow

Krateros did fail him, but so did every adult in his life—and really, he doesn't blame Krateros. *He tried his best.* Mydei was a shy, timid boy, and then became an oppositional "problem child" overnight. He even got expelled at fifteen for breaking another boy's nose.

("Why don't you just fucking work WITH me instead of AGAINST me?" Krateros had told him then, exasperated, hitting the wheel of his car in the same way Eurypon used to. "I never asked for this. I never fucking wanted kids."

All Mydei heard was: I never wanted you.)

Mydei wants to comfort him, say that Krateros didn't fail him, but that would be a lie—and Mydei doesn't like lying.

Mydei

It's a nice robot.

It's a rare night where his and his roommates' schedules kind of match up and they all happen to be free together at home, even if it's for a few short hours.

Naturally, they're all bullying Mydei for his taste in men. Well, it's mostly just Peucesta. He's currently battling Ana L'secs—his drag persona. He's got this little Morticia number on, if Morticia was a 1930s rich, husband-killing, black widow-murderess. A mix between Anjelica Huston in *Addams Family Values*, Catherine Zeta-Jones in *Chicago,* and Isabella Rossellini in *Death Becomes Her.* There are levels of *bob* to Ana L'secs that were, quite frankly, previously thought unreachable by mortal men.

Peucesta looks stupid without his wig on, just a bunch of tape around his head, and these ridiculous drawn-on black eyebrows perpetually stuck in a cunty frown. He looks *so upset*, and it's making everyone giggle.

"I just don't get what's so special about Gayface!" he says, throwing away the tenth makeup wipe of the night.

"What do you mean? Gayface seems nice and sweet. He doesn't need to be special," Leonnius argues back, digging into his special Leonnius Stew, handcrafted by Mydei of course; the best comfort food.

"He's like one of those, what do the kids call it, golden retriever boys. They're very popular nowadays!" Hephaestion chimes in, acting as if he's some sixty year old grandma.

"He's not a *golden retriever boy,*" Peucesta is genuinely getting worked up, and it probably has less to do with Phainon and more to do with the fact that he glued his eyebrows down with Elmer's Glue, "He's a grown ass man with coarse hair on his balls."

That gets a laugh out of everyone *(except for Mydei)*, but Ptolemy scrunches his face up in disgust. "That's a little explicit—"

"I don't give a fuck if it's explicit, dude, it's true. I don't like Gayface."

"I really don't understand why you hate Gayface so m—"

"His name isn't Gayface. Why do we keep calling him Gayface?" Mydei speaks up for the first time tonight. This is all becoming a bit too overstimulating.

"Well," Peucesta turns to face him, heels stomping on their living room's beautiful hardwood flowers, "He's got a gay fucking face."

"He's not even gay."

“Mydei, c’mon, I thought we already established he liked men,” Hephaestion reaches over to pinch him.

“No, I mean—he likes men, but he’s not gay. He’s bisexual.”

The whole room erupts in a big *oooh* that can probably be heard all the way to Castrum Kremnos. Peucesta, however, doesn’t look amused. “Having a gay face has nothing to do with your actual sexuality. There are straight men with a gay face.”

“There are straight women with gay face!” Perdikkas adds intelligently.

“Right! And he’s got a fagcent to boot. It’s worse than Hephaestion’s~” Leonnius points to the culprit with a shake of his head, and it makes Hephaestion rise his hands as if he was caught stealing.

“Hey now, what does my fagcent have to do with Gayface?”

“Can we please just stay on topic,” Mydei pleads, and he’s genuinely getting a little tired of this, “We were talking about Gayfa–Phainon.”

“Look,” Peucesta starts to rip off his false eyelashes, “You historically have bad taste in men. All of your ex-boyfriends… Hephaestion—”

“OKAY, PEUCESTA.”

Peucesta disregards Hephaestion’s mock offense, and instead comes over to sit on the arm of the couch, next to Mydei. He does his drag queen shtick, all sultry and sexy and dangerous, and rests a graceful, clawed hand on Mydei’s shoulder. “I just want the best for my little Dei,” he’s giving him the whole Ana L’secs experience, his voice pitched up, womanly, and dripping in honey, “It’s not your fault that you only date performative faux-feminist artsy guys or musclehead gymbros who turn out to be alt-right fags.”

“That was one time…” Mydei grumbles under his breath, and Peucesta swipes his bangs out of his face. He leans in and kisses his temple, wet and hot, leaving a red lipstick stain behind.

“Here’s what we’re going to do, dear~ How about you invite Gayface to Perdikkas’ birthday party next week, hmm? You can even invite the rest of your little work friends.”

That’s… actually a really good idea. Mydei is surprised; Peucesta isn’t the *‘good ideas’* guy. That’s his job!

“Yeah…” he says, contemplating, and then, “Yeah. Yes, I could do that. You guys could meet him and actually give an informed opinion for once.”

“Well then, it’s settled~” Peucesta slithers into his personal space again to ruffle his hair and squeeze his face. “Ughhh, Mydei, you’re so precious, I could just eat you up!”

And then he’s gone in a whirlwind of sequined black artificial silk, disappearing into his room—probably to try and peel himself out of his corset.

Perdikkas removes his glasses and lifts his gaze from his phone. Rubs between his eyes and sighs deeply, long-suffering. “Why is Peucesta inviting strangers to my birthday party?”

“So,” Ptolemy says, putting away the nail clipper he’d been fiddling with. “Which was Adrianos?”

Mydei’s stomach twists and he instantly feels bile in his throat. *“What?”*

“Faux-feminist, or the alt-right guy?”

The room spins like a lonely tumbleweed; his brain fogs up so quickly he nearly forgets his own damn name. “Oh…” Mydei mutters, trying to form words, trying to seem unaffected. “Uh, faux-feminist.”

“Ah,” Ptolemy nods sagely, unaware, “Yeah. Always hated that guy. You were too good for him.”

Mydei pardons himself, and goes to the bathroom.

One of those pesky stomachaches. He must’ve eaten something bad again.

Do you know the moment when you invite your friend group out and everybody politely declines?

Yeah.

Castorice is eating this disgusting quatrillion double smack-ass processed cheddar cheese super-size XX(...)XXL Burger King Whopper and getting it all over her face. A pink tongue flicks out every now and then to lick off the sauce on her mouth, and the motion reminds Mydei of a chameleon hunting or a frog cleaning its eyes. “Oh, um, thanks for inviting me, but…” she trails off for a bit as she starts looking for a napkin, which is sorely needed at this moment. “I have to start getting ready for Rosh Hashanah. It’s next week and, um, honestly it’s a lot. I don’t think I have the energy for a party. Sorry.”

“I see. I didn’t know you were Jewish.”

“Yeah, I am,” she adds, a bit absent-mindedly, muffled by her napkin, “It’s just a really exhausting week.”

“I get that, it’s no problem. Hyacine?”

Hyacine smiles sheepishly and fishes for her phone. She has this huge, impractical decoden phone case with one million keychains all swinging and jingling about. “You said Saturday, the 20th?”

“Mmhm.”

“Ah, I can’t either. I’m taking Anaxa to their first endocrinologist appointment. They wanna start estrogen.”

“...The entire day?”

“Well,” her big acrylics full of charms clack against her phone screen as she types, “The appointment is at 2 PM, and then we’re going shopping for clothes with Aglaea~! And I think I just wanna spend that day supporting them.”

That’s really sweet. Mydei just nods and hums in approval.

And then all that’s left is–

Mydei turns to look at Phainon, and is met with a view that steals away his breath.

The setting sun behind him, casting him in hues of red and orange, his white hair so vibrantly colored it looks as if dipped in blood. The sun tattoo on his neck, faded and old and ugly, seems to glow with strange new life, with power. Mydei can feel his cheeks getting hot, hooked on the flex and bob of his Adam’s apple as Phainon inhales from the cigarette. The glint in his eyes is golden where it catches the light—his roots are growing in, too. Blond and pale like a newborn chick, like fields of gentle wheat. He is so far away now, entirely somewhere else. His gaze is distant, unseeing, cold almost—cruel in a way. He looks as though he were a Messiah brought to life from marble. Tortured and lovely and ravishing. His gorgeous Galatea.

There’s something mean in the furrow of his brow, something violent that makes Mydei want to open up his ribcage and show him all the filthy parts of himself, say *“Look, see, I am ugly and violent too”*. The circles under his eyes are deep and dark and purple, his lips are pale and cracked. He has never looked worse—he has never looked more beautiful. What Saint does one pray to, when faced with such loveliness? Who is there to thank?

Mydei wants to lick and bite him all over. He wants to know what his blood tastes, nevermind that he’s tased it already, he craves it. Mydei wants—

He punches Phainon’s shoulder, playfully.

“Haikas, are you not paying attention?”

“Hm?” and Phainon doesn’t startle at it, but he does look as if he were just woken up from a dream. He lazily drags his gaze to look at Mydei. “Sorry, no, I wasn’t. Did you ask me something?”

He blinks so slowly, as if the world has slowed down for him, as if movements were a burden. Mydei understands—he loves that he understands, that Phainon understands too. His eyelashes are full and dark, and the curve of his mouth is dangerous, and there’s just—He’s so—

There are no words to describe it.

“Do you want to come to my friend’s birthday party on the 20th?”

Phainon cocks his head, a little taken aback, and Mydei can tell that he’s not feeling the idea. He tries not to be hopeful.

“Oh. I can’t really afford a gift right now.”

“No need to bring a gift.”

Phainon laughs a little, boyish and handsome, circling the left side of his mouth upward into a smirk. “Sure. I’ll be there.”

“Great,” Mydei says, and his heart betrays him with its rabbit pace beating, “I’ll pick you up.”

Perdikkas is turning thirty years old, so it’s a very special occasion—it also means he’s officially been studying to be a doctor for ten entire years, which is really just very funny. That’s besides the point, though—special occasions require special celebrations. As their *communal* birthday gift, aside from all of the other gifts he’ll be getting, his roommates chimed in to rent this nice place for a day and a night. They also took care of everything, from the cake to the food to the music and down to the decorations. And yes, the incredible amounts of booze, too.

The place is a spacious two story house, a place uniquely marketed *for college parties,* with a pool, a gorgeous backyard and a big airy living room perfect for turning into a dance floor. This is not exactly a *college* party but hey, they’re kind of within the age range.

Mydei isn’t the party type, quite the opposite actually. He doesn’t like packed spaces and he doesn’t like loud music, he enjoys being drunk but he dislikes being shoulder to shoulder with other drunk people like he’s in a can of sardines. He doesn’t like dancing, but he does like watching other people dance. Socializing is fine, but it’s difficult and more importantly, it’s exhausting—it drains him like nothing else.

This whole ordeal is, overall, just an entire nightmare for him, but he’s willing to shoulder it for Perdikkas’ sake. Poor guy hasn’t been to a proper party in forever, and he used to be quite the party guy in college if Leonnius is to be believed.

Phainon is idle in the passenger’s seat, which isn’t normal for him. It’s kind of like having a yappy dog who all of a sudden gets *real silent*—it’s uncanny.

“You don’t have to do this,” Mydei says all of a sudden, finally taking his keys out of the ignition—they have been looking for a parking spot for the past ten minutes. “I can drive you back home.”

Phainon turns to him like a typhoon; he’s wearing this beautiful white silk shirt, billowy almost at the sleeves, and a black choker, also silk, to match. He looks fierce now, spiteful. “Is the great Mydeimos concerned about me?”

By the tone of his voice, Mydei knows that it’s supposed to be a tease, that Phainon is intending to be *mean.* But he can’t tell which part of that is supposed to be hurtful. Mydei just blinks at him and cocks his head as if Phainon were the stupid one here.

He is concerned, of course. Phainon's been unlike himself lately with all of this Cipher business going on. He hardly texts anymore, and he's distracted at work. He ponders his answer while Phainon studies his face, his eyes moving wildly up and down; Gayface doesn't respond well to pity, Mydei has come to know that.

He's searching for *something* in Mydei's visage; perhaps for his stubborn honesty, or for something to bite down on.

"Well… concerned? I simply don't want you to be a sourpuss at my friend's birthday."

That seems to have been the correct answer, because Phainon throws his head back and barks a laugh. "First of all, *sourpuss?* How old are you?" and that gets a chuckle out of Mydei, "Second of all, I am the life of every party I go to."

"Oh? Is every party you go to in hospice wards?"

Phainon gasps with mock offense, bringing his hand to his chest and Mydei, well—you see, he's left some buttons open. So it's just cleavage on full display, and he's just now realized this, so he's trying very hard not to stare.

"*Mydeimos*, that's offensive!"

"Offensive? *You* always make fun of the way I talk."

"You talk like an old woman!"

Mydei scoffs, deciding to not entertain this further. His hand is on the door handle when he feels Phainon shift and squirm like a newborn kitten next to him. It's kind of pissing him off, because he's already dancing on the edge of overstimulation. He turns to tell Phainon to *quit it,* and it's at that exact moment that Gayface chooses to twist his elbow and just—feed it to Mydei, like hey here's my hard-ass elbow straight to your teeth, bon appetit! He reels back and covers his mouth and it *actually* genuinely hurts, sharp fucking elbows, and somehow Phainon has the nerve to go *owchie;* grown ass man saying *owchie,* honest to God, outloud.

"Phainon, what the fuck are you–"

It has become a common occurrence, it seems, for Mydei to look upon Phainon and be struck dumb with admiration. The man is now undulating like the waves of a tempestuous sea, arching his back prettily and jutting out his ass; all Mydei can do is stare, cheeks hot and flushed, and wonder if he's doing it on purpose. Phainon twists as though he were a white snake writhing in the grass, seductive and inviting. His loose chemise airs out at the neckline, plunging as it already was, and sags down to reveal a pale breast and a pink nipple—then lower still, down to his navel. Mydei's mouth falls agape, mesmerized, entranced as if he were enchanted by a spell.

There is something to be said about the eroticism of contrasting notions, and Mydei is experiencing just that; the dainty faux-silk shirt, effete in nature like a sickly 19th century poet, slipping down to reveal the strong musculature of Phainon's body. He has seen Phainon *basically* naked before, prancing around with a towel wrapped around his waist after taking a

shower at the gym, but there is… *Something* about this, about the coy reveal of skin, that makes it hard for Mydei to breathe. Something so intensely salacious that Mydei can't help but yield to it, defenseless like a newborn cub. Perhaps, he tries to rationalize, it is the naive unawareness of his own beauty that titillates Mydei—or perhaps it is the way that the silk caresses Phainon's body like a wanton lover, touching every spot Mydei wishes he could with wanting and tender hands. It makes him so deliriously jealous that he feels like ripping it off of him and burning that cheap thing. *"I want to be your shirt,*" Mydei thinks, afflicted with a sickness, *"I want to be your shoes. I want to be the coat you wear. I want to be the hair on your head. I want to be your skin."*

And then, quick like a flash of lightning, it's over; Phainon slithers back in his seat, holding a gift bag in his lap, looking proud of himself and happy. Mydie has very little time to school his expression and make himself seem unaffected—he hopes it works.

"What's that?" he says, nonchalantly, nodding at the bag.

"A gift for your friend? You know, for his birthday party?"

"Ah. You shouldn't have. You said you couldn't afford it."

"Well, yeah, but, you know," Phainon reaches into the bag and pulls out a gorgeous ceramic bowl painted white and blue, woven with floral patterns. "It's a traditional Amphorean ceramic. They had this antique fair close to my place and I spotted it. It was cheap and I bartered for it, practically got it for free. Thought your friend might like it."

It *is* beautiful, and thoughtful too.

"It's a nice present. A lot more impressive than the earbuds I got him."

That makes Phainon laugh. His face scrunches up all cutely—Mydei likes that a lot about him.

It's about a ten minute walk to the house, because parking in Okhema fucking *sucks*. Just before going in, Phainon gets that curious, mischievous glint in his eyes. He reaches over and tugs on Mydei's headphones, which have been sitting around his neck.

"What are these for?" he grins, "Are you the type of jerk to bring your own music to a party?"

Mydei tilts his head. "No…? They're noise-cancelling headphones."

It only seems to amuse Phainon more. "Why do you need noise-cancelling headphones at a *party?"*

Mydei crosses his arms at his chest. "Because I am autistic and loud music overstimulates me."

It's so fucking delicious seeing Phainon's cocky expression drop, and now he's dragging his feet and acting all embarrassed. "Ah. Sorry, I didn't know."

A *"hmph"* is all the answer he gets before Mydei passes by him and drags him inside.

It's certainly a party, and if Mydei was into parties, he'd be having a blast right now. Alas, this is kind of his own personal hell, lots of people packed close together and blaring music. They got one of those rave lasers for light shows so it's just *so much*—but he's here for his friend's birthday, so he'll endure for a bit.

The music isn't bothering him *too* much right now, so he grabs Phainon by the arm and takes him to meet his roommates. They find Perdikkas and the others, wish him a happy birthday and give him their gifts. They are all, naturally, charmed by Gayface—even Peucesta, who's committed to being a contrarian. There's just something naturally likeable about Phainon; the way he smiles and laughs, the way he is so touchy with everyone. He's a natural at this, at *people*, and Mydei is a little starstruck. He's got all five of his roommates wrapped around his finger in twenty minutes and even moreso, he's buddying up to complete *strangers.* Acting like he's known them for a lifetime.

"He's so easy to love," Mydei thinks, *"There is not one part of him that is unloveable."*

There comes a moment when a bunch of people are huddled around Phainon, listening intently as he tells a story, and breaking into laughter when he gets to the punchline. This is all getting a bit too much for Mydei, so he slinks away carefully when he thinks everyone's too distracted to notice, and he finds a couch in a quieter corner where he can destress.

Mydei doesn't even get to put on his headphones before Phainon appears beside him, looking lost as a puppy. His face would make you believe that he just got kicked out in the cold rain and abandoned, and if he had ears, Mydei is convinced they would be droopy.

"Mydeeeeeei…" he whines, sitting next to him and resting his chin on Mydei's bare shoulder. He can only hope he does not feel how hot his skin burns, and he prays that the party is dim enough to cover his flush.

"What."

"Why'd you leave meeee…" and he's still whining, and Mydei wants to put him in a headlock and squeeze him 'till his eyes pop out. Ugh. Cute.

"It got a bit too much for me. I needed a break."

Phainon perks up immediately at that, lifting his head from his shoulder—Mydei misses the lack of contact deeply, as if he took his entire limb with him.

"Let's take a break together, then~" and then he pulls a—

No way.

"Where'd you get *that* from?"

And Phainon answers with that heartrendering grin of his, all boyish and crooked teeth, a snaggletooth that Mydei wants to lick and suck. "Some guy just like, gave me a joint. Think it's laced?"

Mydei considers it. “No, I don’t think so. Perdikkas’ friends aren’t like that.”

Phainon seems unconvinced for a moment, then shrugs nonchalantly and lights it up. He drags from it greedily, inhales deeply, and waits a few seconds before exhaling. For some reason, this all goes to Mydei’s cock which, what the hell, might as well happen.

“Are you not gonna share?” he asks, trying to sound indignant, and Phainon only tilts his head in response.

“I thought you didn’t smoke?”

“I don’t smoke *cigarettes*.”

He laughs a little, but does pass Mydei the blunt, and Mydei—well, maybe it’s the new meds making him act unwise, or maybe it’s the overstimulation. He feels frustrated, like he’s holding something in that is trying to claw its way out. His skin is bound with electricity. He wants to *show Phainon* something that would leave him as speechless as he’s been leaving Mydei.

He does grab the blunt, but instead of dragging from it—

He grabs Phainon’s jawline and forcefully pulls him forward, making him stumble and crash into him. Mydei is crazed on the proximity, and he feels Phainon’s silk-clad chest rise and fall quickly as it is pressed flush to his own. The look on his face is enticing, surprised but lustful still, and Phainon is *so reactive* because he’s already flushed and his eyes are already glazed over; he’s so sweet under his ministrations, and there are few things sweeter than the little gasp-whimper sound he made when Mydei grabbed him.

Little shit. Mydei wants to get him a taste of his own medicine, revenge for finger-fucking his mouth and always grabbing. He has no idea, the poor thing, what he’s doing to Mydei; what he’s stirring inside him. Phainon is all on him now, and he’s staring at him with eyes full of obedience and longing, and it just makes Mydei want to bully him a little. So, still holding him, he pushes Phainon backwards until he’s pressing into the back of the couch, and he half straddles him; plants a knee between his thighs and *accidentally* presses where he is hottest. It just makes him suck in his breath and squirm more. Perhaps it is cruel, but God, Phainon already looks drunk on it, looks up at him as if Mydei hung the moon in the sky just for him.

Perhaps he did. Perhaps that can be true right now, in this very moment.

When Mydei hooks his thumb between his lips, his nails grazing against his pretty teeth, the question of permission comes only in the form of a cocked eyebrow and a tilted head. Phainon blinks slowly, full of reverence, and nods. It is a perverse inversion of their tryst at the gym, when Phainon handled him so gently; Mydei can’t be gentle, and everything he does is perverse.

Phainon’s permission is sweet like sugar, and when Mydei goes to pry his mouth open, he finds it going slack, willing and wanting. He has such lovely teeth, such a cute tongue, and he’s breathing so hard now; he feels his hands ghosting over his waist, shaking, not sure if he

should touch or not. Mydei wants, and it disgusts him. “Go on,” he says, silently, and he hopes that Phainon understands.

He *does* understand, because he feels a strong pair of hands at his midriff, kneading absentmindedly. The contact hits him like a freight train, and there is a moment where Mydei is stuck between leaning into the touch and breaking Phainon’s arms. It is over clothes, though that hardly makes it any easier, any less threatening. *“It’s Phainon,”* he tells himself, *“It’s just Phainon.”*

Mydei decides to push through it, through the discomfort, through the initial fear. He has to be brave because he wants to tease Phainon, and that’s higher on his personal Maslow’s hierarchy of needs.

Underneath him, he’s pliant and needy, and his eyes are filled with such wonder—such curiosity too. He can’t help but notice Phainon’s growing bulge against his knee, and maybe Mydei himself is in no better state. How exhilarating. He’s light-headed with it, as he leans down to hover over Phainon like a bird of prey; and Phainon could not possibly be happier with this, with being handled roughly, and his captivating tongue kitten-licks at his thumb. He’s twitching with impatience, hands caressing down to Mydei’s hips, his mouth chasing upwards after him, begging for a kiss.

Mydei does not allow him such indulgence. Instead, he tuts at him and makes him settle back; scratches his scalp and calls him a *good boy* when he obeys.

And Phainon *moans* at that, loud and sweet, and he tries so hard to be good and not buck up against his leg. He fails though, just a little, as he can’t help grinding up, a movement that would be almost imperceptible were Mydei not completely and utterly obsessed with him, focused on him like a prowling lioness.

He smells so good, Mydei can now tell with how close they are. Phainon’s wearing cologne, or perhaps perfume, and it smells… Fresh and watery, like vegetables and bulrush, a bit acidic with a tinge of grapefruit, and sweet like mango. It’s more addicting than any drug.

The blunt in his hand is fighting to stay lit; so then, Mydei takes it between his lips and drags deeply from it, yet does not inhale. Instead, he angles his head *just so* and Phainon, the darling boy, knows exactly what’s coming, so he settles himself and opens up wider. He’s so good for him. Mydei cradles his strong jawline with one hand and places the other on his neck, that pale, elegant column, just over his pulse point—he finds it racing at an alarming speed, yet Phainon is so languidly lascivious beneath him.

The smoke is gray and silky when Mydei blows it into his mouth, thick like molasses and slow-moving too, as if it had nothing better to do than caress the back of Phainon’s throat. He takes it all so well too, grabs harder onto Mydei’s hips to ground himself.

He pulls back to admire his work, and finds Phainon ruined; panting with his pretty mouth agape, forehead slick with sweat, his hair sticking to it like tendrils. It’s too dark here to see, but Mydei imagines he’s flushed red and beautiful. He looks fucked-out.

Shame on Mydei for letting his guard down; Phainon takes advantage of this opportunity to hook his arms around his waist and pull him fully in his lap. That gets Mydei's heart pumping, even faster than it already was, and not in a good way—the surprise of it ruins the fragile balance of his nervous system. He frightens, tenses up, and grits his teeth; every fiber of his being is yelling *danger.*

Phainon notices gently pushes him off his lap before Mydei can pick whether to run away or punch all of his teeth out. "Sorry," he says, sheepish, barely audible over the music.

And then it all hits him at once, the shame of it all, the loudness of *everything,* and then all Mydei can do is shut down a little. Disconnect just a tad, just enough to put some distance between himself and the world. "I want to go home," he tells Phainon.

"Oh, sure. Let's go."

"No, you can stay if you want to."

Phainon actually *pouts* at that, grown ass man, juts out his bottom lip all cutely and *hmphs.* "I don't wanna stay without you…"

Mydei would find it very endearing if he wasn't actively fighting against breaking every window in the house. He takes a deep breath, trying to still himself, and gets up. "Alright, let's go." He puts on his headphones and it all gets very quiet. It's better, but not good, and he barely perceives Phainon holding onto him as he makes his way through the sea of people.

He doesn't have the patience to search for Perdikkas and let him know they're leaving, but he does find Ptolemy instead. He tells him that he's just *done*, and Ptolemy nods and says *something* back but Mydei can't quite hear him. He knows, however, that he gets it—that they all get it. He's been here for *four whole hours*, and it's well past 1 AM. He's already pushed himself to his very limit. Ptolemy pats him on the shoulder as he, presumably, says goodbye and Mydei feels like gnawing his fingers off.

Mydei is so drained and so tired, but the cool night air helps a little; he feels poked and prodded and burned all over, flayed at the extremities, and he takes a moment to just breathe. *This sucks,* but he wouldn't call it a mistake—Perdikkas seemed very happy that he came. With the music now no longer a problem, he can start trying to be normal. He's half-here anyways, that light-headed buzz of dissociation settling like a heavy blanket over him, crushing him and—

Very silently, he can hear the annoying whining of Phainon's voice. He's talking to him and waving his hands. Mydei takes off his headphones.

"What are you saying?"

"I was asking if you're good to drive."

Mydei thinks about it. It's not the first time he drives while disassociated, and he's always careful about it. He *could* drive, but he doesn't really *want* to.

“I mean, are *you* good to drive?”

Phainon hums. “I’m not high, if that’s what you’re asking.”

“I’m asking because of the car crash.”

That seems to stun him a little bit. Mydei gets a bit of a sick satisfaction out of seeing him squirm. “Ah, well…”

Phainon shifts his weight from one leg to the other as he considers it; he’s glowing beautifully in the moonlight, ethereal.

“Yeah, I think so. If we take it slow. Um. I’d do it for you.”

“For me, huh…” Mydei thinks bitterly. He doesn’t enjoy being taken care of, but if he’s to drive that means he has to keep his headphones off—and he’s not in the mood for loud noises anymore.

“Alright,” Mydei says, “Sure.”

He tosses Phainon the keys and he catches them midair. Opens his car door as if he owns it and gets comfortable in the driver’s seat; Mydei follows, settling next to him, slipping his headphones on.

“Wait,” Mydei says all of a sudden, “How are *you* going to get home?”

He cannot even hear himself ask it, but Phainon mouths *‘Uber’* at him. Sure, if that’s what he wants.

Phainon gets him home quickly. The streets are quiet and tranquil, and the swaying of the car almost lulls Mydei to sleep. He thinks he does doze off for a bit, because he feels Phainon shaking him. His mouth is moving for the letters of his name, M-Y-D-E-I, and Mydei thinks there are few sights more worth looking at than this one. His limbs are heavy.

He remembers his therapist telling him to be brave. To not run away. He takes off his headphones.

“Thanks,” he tells Phainon, and before Phainon can answer, he continues, “We should talk.”

“Oh? About what?”

“About…” and Mydei gestures vaguely between them, “This. Us. Phainon, look, I–”

Phainon puts a hand up. Tenses tight like a drawn bowstring. He smiles and chuckles, but it’s a sad thing; his demeanor changes, becomes distant, aloof. Cold like the ice that burns you. “I can’t. Not now. Please. I know. Another time.”

Ah. Mydei supposes that’s alright—with the Cipher thing going on, Phainon must be all over the place. He gets it, he really does. Can’t even say it bothers him at all, because it doesn’t. He’s willing to wait. To the heat death of the universe, if he has to.

“That’s fine.”

“I’m sorry, Mydei, I don’t want to—”

And Mydei gives him a little smile, genuine, because he knows that’s what Phainon needs.

“I’m not mad at you. Really.”

Phainon doesn’t seem convinced. “...Yeah?”

“Yeah,” he repeats, soft, “Why would I lie? I’m not.”

“You could lie to not make me feel bad.”

“I don’t really care about not making you feel bad. I care about telling the truth. I’m not mad.”

Mydei shrugs, and he continues, “And even if I were mad, I would get over it eventually.”

That seems to do it for Phainon, and he relaxes a bit. “Okay.”

He doesn’t feel like leaving the car yet, instead he looks out the window; gazes longingly at the dark night sky. He wishes Okhema were less polluted, so he could see the stars. He remembers a similar night, when he was being driven around by another man, some sixteen years ago. “Before my father killed my mother, he took me on a drive like this,” he says all of a sudden.

“I’m sorry.”

“I don’t like being the passenger either, just like you don’t,” he continues, and dares himself to meet Phainon’s gaze, “Though I find that I don’t mind if it’s you.”

“Yeah,” Phainon croaks out, throat sore and stiff, “I don’t mind if it’s you either.”

Mydei squeezes his shoulder, lingering on it just a bit too much to have it be just friendly. He takes the car keys out of the ignition himself. Exits the car and holds the door open for Phainon to leave, too.

He waits around with him as Phainon smokes a cigarette and orders his Uber. When his driver arrives, Phainon waves a bit awkwardly and disappears into the stranger’s car. Mydei wonders if he’s scared right now, but dispels the thought. He believes in Phainon—believes that he can be very brave.

As he makes himself comfortable in his own bed, Mydei finds that he is still pent up and frustrated and horny from their ministrations, which is unlike him, and it embarrasses him. He remembers, once again, his therapist telling him to be brave. That they are normal feelings. To experiment with masturbation.

This might as well happen, and why ever not? He’s a young man in the prime of his age, strong and virile, and perhaps it’s a waste of a perfectly nice cock. He hasn’t done this in

years, at least three, but maybe before that too. He can't remember the last time he touched himself.

Mydei sees little reason to do it. He figures he can't cum because of his meds, common side-effect and all, and he hardly feels it anyways. He slips his hand beneath his waistband and takes himself in hand; he finds the sensation dulled. Something is *there*, but it's numb. He clicks his tongue. He can't say he's surprised, but he is a bit disappointed. What was he expecting, really? This body is simply the miserable sack of meat he carries around, and he's not even in it half the time. Three-quarters of the time, actually, to be accurate. He's not quite half-hard but he's not soft either, like a swan's last dying song.

He pushes through it, even as his heart picks up the pace, not in arousal but in fear. Mydei's brain can hardly tell who's touching him, can't tell it is himself, and his nervous system is so fucked up that even furniture accidentally brushing against his crotch sends him into a panic. But he has to be brave. His therapist told him to experiment, and maybe she didn't mean like *this*, didn't mean *now,* not when he's drowning in shame and barely heaving off the overstimulation. To be fair, she definitely didn't mean it like this. But fuck it, he finishes the things he starts, and so Mydei starts stroking.

It's nothing, really. He barely registers the touch burning him where he is most sensitive. It's unpleasant at best and unbearable at worst. It only sinks him deeper into disassociation, an uncomfortable disconnect, and the last remnants of his consciousness that cling to the body tell him to just think of something sexy and hot and kind.

So, he thinks of Phainon. He's not sure how sexual fantasies are supposed to work, but in this one, they're kissing on Mydei's bed and Phainon is all over him. He kisses his jawline and his neck and his collarbone and Mydei knows, intellectually, that it's supposed to feel good; instead it only scares him more, so he jumps ahead in the Sexy Fantasy timeline and suddenly, Phainon's fucking him hard.

Fantasy Mydei enjoys it because this is a fantasy and he has to enjoy it, and he's moaning but the voice isn't quite his. He's not sure whose it is, but nonetheless it makes Mydei want to cry. Fantasy Phainon is lovely and generous with his kisses, and as he thrusts upward into Fantasy Mydei, he grabs something off of the nightstand. Mydei doesn't think about what it is, doesn't conjure up an image, but it's something heavy and blunt.

Fantasy Phainon kisses him sweetly and starts to pummel Fantasy Mydei over the head with the object, splitting his head open, spilling out his brains. He murders him beautifully, and he's not Phainon anymore; he's faceless, rather, a figure that is both his father and his rapist. That's a little funny, his brain can't even conceive the idea of Phainon hurting him. Through the violence and the gore, Fantasy Mydei screams *'NO, PLEASE, STOP'.* He doesn't know why he doesn't fight back. He's fully capable of doing so, with all the gym and the boxing lessons, but then again, the real Mydei was also capable of doing so.

Maybe Fantasy Mydei is just as scared as the real Mydei was.

This is kind of useless. Mydei comes back from his fantasy and finds that he's grown soft in his hand. Yeah, he expected as much. What a spectacular failure. What was he even thinking?

He just managed to upset and trigger himself, and now he's sitting crossarmed like a an idiot and staring up at the ceiling. Yeah, this might as well happen.

There's something intrinsically broken about Mydei. A few months ago, he would just let it be. Accept himself as a desexed person. Now, though, he wants to fix it. He's not sure how. But he wants to do it. For himself. Maybe a bit for Phainon, too.

His PTSD, just like his panic attacks, robes itself in the cold and heavy press of derealization. Nothing really feels real anymore, but at least he's not exactly *feeling* anything. Emotionally. Physically. His poor brain, overworked to its last leg, gives him the escape of numbness, and Mydei is going to take it. It's better than anything else it's tried in the past.

The next morning, he still feels like he's half asleep and dreaming. All of his roommates are snoring and sleeping like logs after a night of partying. He makes himself a lazy breakfast—his limbs feel as though bound in iron, and he's so sluggish that he bumps into the furniture on his way to the dining table. His phone chimes—a text message.

Mydei takes an embarrassingly long time to guess his password, but he gets it eventually; it's his mother's birth year.

Phainon

i got a cold from your friends stupid party

"Hah," is all Mydei can manage. The tail end of a laugh.

Mydei

👎

Phainon

what do you mean "👎"

come deal with it

Mydei

What, so I can get sick as well?

Phainon

yes

we're in this together

That does get a proper chuckle out of Mydei.

Mydei

He could do that. For Phainon. Yes.

Mydei can’t help but wonder why he doesn’t mind when Phainon touches him. He knows the answer, of course, in the back of his head, but it’s a little too disgusting to think about.

No matter. Instead of thinking about it, Mydei looks up recipes for nice, warm soups that help with a cold.

Chapter End Notes

long time no see :) if you enjoyed leave a comment !! ^_^

▶ fic updates

Chapter 8: philia

Chapter Notes

> This is a 17k word monster, and it could've been longer but I stopped myself. The concept is as such: scenes of love between the characters that I really wanted to show but had no better place to put, so I compiled them all into a chapter. The scenes themselves are non-linear and jump in time, but in the drop down below I've compiled a timeline of when each scene happens, alongside the usual trigger warnings.
>
> This is probably my favourite chapter that I've ever written.
>
> ▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Vignettes of love—

Phainon has not been sick in six fucking years. *Colds* are what kids get. There *should* be no such thing as a grown adult with a *fever.*

And yet, here we are. Twenty-seven years old and sick as a dog with the flu. The flu. At his grown age. Phainon is more embarrassed than anything, really, and he's already used his paid sick days so it's just like—okay, sick *and* broke *and* raw-dogging psychosis. He takes a very miserable bus trip to his doctor and gets a medical note that says yeah, he's fucked. He snaps a picture of it and sends it directly to Hyacine through DMs, because he's in no mood to email HR and potentially have Anaxa see—*that* would truly be mortifying. Phainon can practically already hear them; *"The flu? At your age? Hah."* At least Hyacine would be more empathetic to his plight.

Cinny🍰🎀

The flu?

At your age?

LMAO

Phainon

hyacinthia

don't.

Cinny🍰🎀

Grown-ass man with the flu 🥺

Phainon

??

Cinny🍰🎀

It's kind of cute it's like

Aww you're sick

Sick baby

UwU

Phainon

i think i'm in hell

Cinny🍰🎀

These aren't gonna be paid btw

Phainon

yeah hyacine i know

Cinny🍰🎀

And you have to bring the paper to me in person eventually

But I'm gonna forward the photo to Anaxa and they're gonna take care of it

I'm not at work today

Well, isn't that just great.

Cinny🍰🎀

League? 🥺🥺

Let's duoq

Let me carry you to master princess

Phainon

girl NO

Cinny🍰🎀

Killing you with my mind

Killing you with my mind

Killing you with my mind

Phainon just sends a gif of a bored and unimpressed monkey. Yeah, that'll show her.

Mydei dials his building's interphone a few hours later and at that point it's just… Phainon's immune system has lost this fight. He's waving the white flag. It's crazy how fast it hit him. He woke up with a sniffly nose and a sore throat, but now he's fighting a 39°C fever and coughing up so much mucus that it's becoming concerning.

Phainon has quite literally never been this sick before in his life. Still, he crawls out of bed and makes his way past the rug of discarded used tissues. He waits until Mydei is at the door before unlocking it and swinging it wide open, in a very *"Well, here we are!"* gesture.

He would find the surprised look on Mydei's face priceless if he wasn't so under the weather. His amber eyes widening a little, eyebrows shooting up, very cute.

"You look like shit."

"Yeah," Phainon croaks in response, and his sinuses are so stuffed up he sounds unrecognizable. He sounds like he's on the verge of tears *and* like a snotty teenager at the same time.

"You really are sick."

"What, you thought I was lying?"

"No," Mydei says as he pushes past him, "I thought you were being dramatic."

Bartholos waddles from the living room to say *'hi'*; he's such a friendly young man, so proper and polite, truly like no cat Phainon has ever met. What kind of cat is *friendly* and *likes* strangers? Bartholos short little legs are trying very hard to make it to Mydei, and Mydei—

He gasps and nearly drops the grocery bags he's holding. Throws himself backwards and away from Bartholos, back hitting the little drawer he keeps in the hallway, with such force that Phainon *hears* his back cracking.

"No cats," Mydei says, breathless, "Absolutely not."

It is the most emotionally affected he's seen him since they met. Truly scared, and of Bartholos at that. Phainon can't help but be a little intrigued—but not enough to be cruel,

never that. “Sorry,” he says, truly apologetic, “I should’ve put him away. Are you scared of cats?”

“Not scared, just… I don’t like them.”

The reaction is a little much for just *not liking* cats, but Phainon’s a bit too feverish right now to be a little shit. He picks up Bartholos, a herculean task in and of itself, and takes him to Cyrene’s room. He brings his essentials as well, water, **FOOD,** litter box, and when the cat is nice and settled in, Phainon leaves and closes the door behind. Bartholos quite likes it in Cyrene’s room, so he’s not worried about pissing the kitty off. He finds Mydei in the same position he left him, clutching the white plastic bags like his life depends on it.

“What are those for?” he says, nodding at the groceries.

“You sound like a squeaky toy,” comes Mydei’s intelligent answer.

“Okay. Not what I asked.”

Mydei cocks his pretty head a bit—he does that a lot, and Phainon loves it. Does the question make more sense at 45**°,** bud? Then, he does something that Phainon finds enrapturing; he turns to look down at the bags. A simple motion, yet he finds it entirely way too lovely nonetheless—his head twisting downwards, swaying with it the long locks of her, red as if dipped in blood. They caress the side of his neck, that elegant column, and Phainon is *just* feverish enough to feel jealousy over it. He could reach out, simply, and touch it for himself, feel Mydei's pulse point beating faster and faster. Would he blush prettily all down to his chest, just like he did that day in the gym? Just *entertaining* that thought feels too lewd. Heat is rising to Phainon's cheeks—he chalks it up to the fever.

A beautiful view is granted to him, one that he loves most dearly; Mydei's profile, regal and noble like an olden prince, his nose curving down as if yearning to reach his lips. Strong, handsome, manly. There's something erotic about its aquilinness, Phainon thinks, about his august brow, high and proud, curving into his nose like a wanton lover. He has a small bump there, on the highest peak of his bridge, and Phainon's been wanting to trace it with his tongue since the first day. This truly is the best view of Mydei, from the side, and he often finds himself stealing looks at work like a shy schoolgirl.

"These," Mydei's voice rings out through whatever fever-induced nasal fantasy Phainon is having, "Are for the soup."

"The soup?"

"The soup I'm gonna make you."

Mydei making him soup… Phainon really should get sick more often.

"Woah, you're making me soup… I should get sick more often."

Mydei is already moving past him and into the kitchen, yet still Phainon hears his scoff. "Idiot, why would you want to get sick more often? It's bad for your health."

Phainon peaks his head into the kitchen, watches as Mydei starts to unpack the groceries. Chicken, lemon, rice, eggs… Certainly not a soup that Phainon's ever had before.

"Well, if I get sick more often, you'd come over and make me soup."

"If you just want me to make you soup," Mydei points a threatening spatula at him, "You can just ask me. No need to get sick."

"That's very romantic of you, Mydei…"

"Go lay down in bed," Mydei commands, his brow furrowing, "And stop bothering me."

Yessir.

Back in bed he goes, feeling just more feverish that before—though when he goes to check his temperature, he finds it unmoved from the previous 39°C. Every sinus in his body is stuffed to the brim, face flushed hot as the fever ravages him, throat sore like nails on a chalkboard. Everything is too hot, too suffocating, and there's little to no relief when he peels his sweat-stained shirt off. Everything is a little wiggly, Phainon notices, but everything is *always* little wiggly. Sometimes it looks as if the floorboards are breathing underneath his feet like a great beast, Georios who gave their body to create the earth. Sometimes his wardrobe undulates as if stuck in perpetual chorea. The hallucinations seem to worsen as his body temperature rises. This is probably fine.

Phainon doesn't realize he dozes off until he's woken up by Mydei shaking him. Somehow he feels even worse, as if a great big weight is pressing down on his chest. His *eyes* hurt. He's tearing up, not crying yet still leaking tears. His nose… Yeah, it's fucked. It's mouthbreathing time. Mydei looks downright concerned.

"Have you… taken anything for this?"

"Yeah…" he mumbles, and weakly points at a small pile of meds on his nightstand, "Got some bullshit from the doctor."

There's softness in Mydei's eyes, a parental sort of worry, and Phainon would find that very cute if his brain wasn't cooking in his skull right now.

"Hold on… Hold this," is all Mydei says before he thrusts a bowl of soup into his hands. Phainon watches as he, quite rudely, starts ransacking through his drawers. Before he can ask *what the fuck he's doing*, Mydei triumphantly pulls out a pair of socks and—oh. Oh no.

"I'm not doing vinegar socks."

"You are doing vinegar socks."

"No."

"You are, quite frankly, powerless against vinegar socks. Vinegar socks are happening."

Grown-ass man with vinegar-soaked socks on. Okay. This must be a humiliation ritual at this point. Last time he got vinegar sock'd, he was eleven years old and running a fever high enough to kill a small goat.

He wishes he could fight back against this fate. Alas, with his limbs heavy as iron and a bowl of hot soup in his hands, Phainon is useless. A mere victim of destiny. He can only watch in horror as Mydei departs from the room, and returns with—yeah. Socks. Soaked in vinegar. And a wet towel.

He sits on the edge of the bed next to him, Phainon sitting up hunched and a little broken. "You can either put these socks on nicely," Mydei says, his voice measured, "Or we can do it the hard way."

Phainon can only offer up his feet in defeat. He winces as the damp, soggy socks are put on, and wriggles uncomfortably. This is hell, this is literally hell. Mydei presses the cold compress to his head.

"There. That will bring the fever down."

"I don't feel comfortable."

"That's too bad."

Phainon looks at the soup miserably. It's… a little creamy, and it smells good, and it looks nice and warm. It's better than the socks, that's for sure. "Is this supposed to help?"

"Yeah," he says, "Can you eat on your own?"

"Y…" and then Phainon considers his answer *really hard,* "No."

Mydei looks at him for a second, studying his face. He seems unconvinced. Here's a fun fact about him that Phainon likes very much; Mydei is the stoic, silent type. His preferred answers come in the form of "hmph" and "oh". His face hardly moves with emotion as he speaks. But, *but*—he has these nice thick eyebrows, several shades darker than his hair, nearly brown. And, at times, they carry the weight of Mydei's expressiveness in them. This is one such moment; his eyebrows twitch upward and then furrow a bit, creating wrinkles in-between that call for Phainon to smooth over with his thumb. He can practically see the gears turning in Mydei's head. Then, his face relaxes, eyes roll, and he sighs.

"Liar. But fine."

Success! Phainon leans back like a child emperor and opens his mouth. Gives him a big *'aaaah'* just to be extra annoying. There is something akin to affection dancing in Mydei's features, something fond as he grabs the bowl and the spoon. He scoops up a good nice bite, lots of chicken and lots of rice.

"Hold on, wait, can you do like, *'here comes the airplane'*?"

Mydei blanks at him. Blinks once.

"No, I can't do that."

"Please? *Pleaseee!*"

Mydei's mouth twists a little. His cheeks flush with dusting of pink.

"Here… comes the airplane…"

Phainon's life can be *so good* sometimes. The soup is like creamy, lemony broth straight to his tummy. A pleasant blend of tastes, neither too overwhelming, and it's nice and hearty. His *do* sinuses clear up a bit.

It goes on like that for a while. Silently, Phainon sinking more and more into the mattress, full of soup and content. Mydei watches him closely as he feeds him—he has this habit of just *staring* at people, his gaze intense and profound, and Phainon finds that he crumbles easily under it. It cracks open a strange sort of vulnerability in him, as though Mydei can see right through him and straight into his black little heart. Phainon's movements become slow and he's lulled half to sleep from it. It's a tender thing to do, feeding someone like this. One spoonful at a time, waiting patiently for the other to chew and swallow. Phainon's mouth goes slack after every bite, falling open obediently, waiting for more. Mydei is gentle with it. Mydei is always gentle. He has these beautiful hands; Phainon knows them to be soft to the touch. At one point, he grabs Mydei's wrist—not hard, not for any particular reason, but just for the sake of it. Maybe to anchor himself a little bit.

This is nice. It feels good. An odd sort of sleepy fuzz. Mydei tells him the soup is all done and Phainon just hums. Moves his hand to grab onto his thumb. His face and chin is wiped with a towel, and suddenly he finds his eyelids very heavy.

"Mydei…" he grumbles, "Are you going to stay?"

"Hmm… Yes, I think so."

"I'm really tired."

"Let me change your socks and you can nap."

Phainon's already asleep by the time his socks get changed, snoring blissfully and breathing through his mouth. He doesn't feel the way Mydei rubs his thumb, lovingly, over his ankle.

He wakes up two, maybe three hours later, and he's *burning up.* The first thing he does is go into a coughing fit that makes his entire sternum ache and pulse. He spits out a phlegm into one of his bedside napkins. The second thing he does is call for Mydei, because *he's not here*. With his voice raspy and weak, he can barely hear it over the sound of the ringing in his ears.

Mydei comes. He always comes when he is called. He peeks his pretty head into the door, cocking it a bit. "You're awake?"

"What were you doing…"

The thought of Mydei having free reign over his home, his personal belongings, ought to make Phainon anxious. It doesn't, though.

"I was letting the cat out. I felt bad for the little guy, locked up in a room all day."

"Ah… I'm not… I don't feel well… I'm hot all over…" is all Phainon can manage, collapsing back into the sheets, face buried in the pillows.

"Poor thing…" he hears Mydei coo, and such words would *ravage* him if the fever wasn't doing so all ready. He hears —*feels*— Mydei come up next to his bed. "Tch. You've soaked the bedsheets."

"Huh…?"

"You sweat buckets while sleeping," Mydei clarifies and, yes, now that Phainon's thinking about it, his whole bed is damp and wet like a swamp. It's uncomfortable all of a sudden. He rolls over on his back, trying to find a dry spot on the bed. His eyes immediately search for Mydei, finding comfort when they of his frame; wide, broad, strong, beautiful still. It's becoming a bad habit, Phainon thinks as his brain is getting cooked inside his skull, to drink from a sweet well that does not belong to you. He could cry at the sight of him. It's all a bit too intense for knowing the guy for less than two months, but Phainon is nothing but intense. Without his consent, one of his arms stretches forward, reaches towards Mydei as if he could catch him in the palm of his hand and keep him in his pocket. Inexplicably, bafflingly, Mydei reaches back for him. Holds his hand for a moment. "Jesus, Phainon," he says, "You're burning up. You should take a shower."

Phainon laughs, weakly. His hair is wet and stuck on his forehead—Mydei brushes it aside. "Your fever's gotten worse."

"I *feel* worse."

"A lukewarm shower will help lower your temperature."

"Don't wanna…"

"You have to."

"Mmnooo…"

Mydei huffs like an exasperated mother. Puts his hands on his hips. "Come on, Phainon. Shower."

"I'll take a shower if you wash me."

Mydei tenses up. *Rips* his hand back, away from Phainon. He takes one, two, three steps back. *"Why."*

It's not a question—it sounds more like an accusation. Phainon doesn't understand.

"I… sorry? I thought it would be… Fun, or something. And I'm feeling pretty, uh, weak, I guess? Like actually."

Mydei crosses his arms. There's something sharp, dangerous in his eyes; it's beautiful. Phainon wants to cut himself on it.

"Are you going to do something *weird?"*

"Weird…? I don't understand. Like what?"

Phainon's feverish mind is trying to conjure up what *'weird'* things he might to do Mydei in the bath. Maybe splash him…? Or… He could suddenly get nauseous and puke?

"Something weird."

"I don't—"

"To me."

He opens his mouth to respond, but the flu takes this moment to grip him tight and make him cough. It scratches up his throat and leaves him dry-heaving for a second. When he turns back at Mydei, his face has softened. But just a little bit.

"I really don't understand, Mydei. Can you be a bit clearer?"

"If I get in with you, are you going to…" Mydei measures his words. Seems to look for the right ones. "Touch me?"

"I mean," he answers after he blows his nose, "I totally planned on splashing you."

Mydei grows restless with his answers. Phainon can tell that he still hasn't answered the question, but truly, *he's doing his best.* This is all he can manage through the fever.

"I'm worried you're asking me to go to into the bath together so you can take advantage of me. Sexually."

Oh. Phainon doesn't even know what to say to him. That hasn't even crossed his mind. There's something tight coiling in his chest. Something sad. Something that makes him want to sob—he doesn't even know what to call it.

"Why… why would I do that?"

"Because you know I would let you."

"I… don't know that, actually, and I don't want to—I would never—*I'm not that kind of person."*

"I know."

"I've never done that to you before, I mean, I don't think—Oh God, have I?"

"No."

"Then what's this, all of a sudden?" Phainon sits up from the bed. His whole chest hurts. Mydei shifts his weight from one foot to the other.

"I don't know," he says, "I haven't been feeling well. I'm concerned, I guess."

"I've asked. In the gym. You said *'do whatever you want'*. Why did you say it like that?"

Mydei hums thoughtfully. "Well, I said it like that to be a dick, but I *did* mean *yes*."

"Can you please just say *yes* or *no* from now on?"

"…Yeah. Okay. I will."

And then that's that. The conversation dies and silence falls over them, yet Phainon feels himself burn hotter still. Burn with shame, burn with anxiety. He can't bear it. He puts his face in his palms, hands gripping at his hair.

"I'm not—I don't—I don't want to do *weird things* to you, Mydei. The thought doesn't make me… *happy*. It's only fun if you're also into it. Like yesterday, it was—it was a lot of fun. I had a lot of fun. Was it fun for you?"

Mydei laughs a little, a bit forced, a bit embarrassed. The blush on his cheeks is gorgeous. "Yeah, I—yeah, it was fun."

Phainon both itches to reach out for him and aches to step away. Like a cornered animal, he's not sure what to do. He's not sure what Mydei wants him to do.

"I'm not going to like… force you or…" *The Word* is stuck in Phainon's throat. Impossibly heavy, though he's never had issue with it before. He can feel it fight its way out of his clenched teeth. "I'm not going to *rape* you."

Mydei inhales sharply as that, as if it physically hurts. As if the word is a brand he has to wear, aching incessantly, rotting. The sound of it is pain. Phainon wants to throw up—he can *see* Mydei's eyes glaze over. He makes a little *'oh'* sound as he bumps into the wall; Mydei's been backing up, he's just realized.

Horrifyingly, Phainon realizes that he can't stop talking. "I don't want to hurt you. I don't want to hurt anyone. I want to be *good.* I keep hurting people but not—not like that. I'm not—perfect, fuck, I'm far from it, but I would never—I've never—*I don't want to do that.*"

Even more horrifyingly, Phainon realizes that *he's not above begging.* "Please believe me."

Mydei's trying to hide how heavily he's breathing, but Phainon can tell by the quick rise and fall of his chest. He's grinding his teeth, too. Hard.

"But what if you did? What would happen then?" is all he asks.

"If I did?"

"Maybe on… accident. What if you started to, say, do something I don't like?"

"I'd stop."

"…Okay."

"But you'd—you'd also have to tell me to stop, right? Because if you say, like, *'do whatever you want'* but what *I* want isn't what *you* want, and you don't tell me stop either, it's like… Not fair. To either one of us."

"…Right. Cause you can't read my mind."

"Yeah," Phainon says, feeling impossibly exhausted.

A beat of silence.

"And if you get mad?" comes another one of Mydei's questions.

"…Why would I get mad?"

"Let's say we're having sex," he says, articulating with his hands, "And I tell you to *stop*. Wouldn't you get mad?"

Phainon is speechless. "N…no? I don't understand what's there to be mad about."

Mydei is equally speechless. "So we're having sex—"

"No, I got that part."

"And I say, oh I don't want to do this anymore. All of a sudden."

"Right."

Mydei only prompts him to answer with a gesture of his hands. As if he's just asked a very hard question.

"I'd just be like *'okay'* and then stop."

Phainon can practically *see* the question marks popping up in Mydei's head. "You wouldn't get mad?"

"No, because like, that's a stupid thing to get mad about."

"A stupid thing to get mad about…" he echoes, thoughtfully, as if Phainon just told him the answer to *'what's the meaning of life?'*

"I'd be like, worried. And I'd ask, oh, what didn't you like? Or ask if something is wrong."

"Right…"

"But like… I'm gonna be honest… Getting my dick wet isn't really that big of a deal? Like it's meant to be, you know, fun. Both of us. Having fun. Together."

"At the same time."

"Yeah," Phainon affirms, "At the same time."

Mydei… couldn't look more miserable if he tried. He *is* trying to hide it, but he can't hide the worried frown in his brows. Always those pesky eyebrows, being fatally honest, giving Phainon a hook to hang onto. He watches his fingers as they flex and clench onto the meat of his bicep where his arms are crossed. He's worried—you can't prove a negative. Phainon feels both drunk on the sickness and painfully sober on the reality of what they're talking about.

"I, uh, like years ago, right? I was having sex with this guy, and he straight up looked back at me in the middle of it and said *'you're fucking terrible at this, I want to stop'*. So, uh, yeah. Not my first rodeo."

A cute attempt at breaking the tension. He hopes it lands. *It has to land.*

It's mesmerizing —downright intoxicating— to watch Mydei shift moods. Poor guy's been gripping himself so hard he's left red prints all over, so when he finally *lets go* of his biceps, it's Phainon that feels relief. His eyebrows twitch upward, first in surprise and then in amusement. His upper lip curls first when he smiles, showing a bit of teeth, letting Phainon gaze upon his sharp snaggletooth. His golden eyes crinkle, molten gold flowing into cute crow's feet and then, finally as if breaking through bondage, as if *allowing himself this*— Mydei laughs.

He's dignified even when he laughs. It's a deep, syrupy sound, and it reverberates inside Phainon's ribcage like the echo of his own voice. It's a beautiful tone, noble even, and it takes some weight off of his shoulders—weight that he didn't realize he was carrying. Phainon, then, allows himself to laugh as well. He could cry.

"Alright," Mydei says, "In that case, I'll wash you. Only if you put swimming trunks on."

That stops Phainon dead in his tracks.

"Huh?"

"I'll wash you," he repeats himself, "If you put swimming trunks on. And get me a pair too, I guess."

"I… are you sure?"

Mydei doesn't think about it. "Yeah," he says, and then clearer, "Yes."

"I… don't know if I have two pairs of swimming trunks, but I'll look?"

He does, indeed, have two pair of swimming trunks. Though one of them is older, from when he was a bit skinnier—naturally, that's the one he gives Mydei.

They take turns changing. He goes first while Mydei sets up the bath. What an upstanding guy, this Mydeimos, he's even brought Phainon a *stool* to sit on. And he's sitting so, so pretty on the stool in the bathtub, such a good boy, and his head is pounding so fucking hard it might explode.

Mydei opens the door to the bathroom and it's like, fine, he's not going to comment on the guy's body because he's just a guy and it's *just* a body. It's nothing special. I mean, it's quite literally cut from marble, every muscle fitting against each other like Mnestia-woven puzzle pieces, *every* muscle flexing with *every* move. His obliques are *insane.* Deep grooves on his ribcage, expanding ever-so-slightly with every breath, inviting Phainon to trace them with his tongue.

They've gone to the gym together quite a few times now—Phainon still gawks at Mydei's physique, which is *fine.* Mydei is leaner than Phainon is, his muscles more defined—Phainon, well, he's gained some weight lately. By all means, however, he's still a certified grade A hunk, both bigger and stronger than most men, there's just… Some fluff as well. Mostly on his stomach, and he thinks it looks quite charming so he doesn't want to work it off. Mydei, on the other hand—the split image of Nikador.

Phainon's legs are still bigger though so hah, take that!

Mydei gets into the bathtub with him, one leg after the other, and he stands looming above Phainon with his arms crossed. Phainon has, quite literally, never been this giddy before in his life.

"Two things," Mydei says, voice leaving nothing to be question. Authoritative.

"Mhmm?"

"One," and he raises a finger, "Water's gonna be lukewarm. A little cold."

"Mhmmmm."

"Two," and he raises a second finger, "You'll be good and you'll behave. No splashing."

"Yessir!"

Phainon can be good. Phainon will be *so good.*

Mydei turns on the water and checks the temperature. He keeps turning the *'cold'* knob around until he seems satisfied.

It's nice, being washed like this, and it works to bring his temperature down too. Mydei sprays him with water, lets it run down his face and back in rivulets. The water is a bit *too* cold for Phainon's liking—he prefers boiling hot showers. Still, though, it's comforting. He feels downright *pampered*, like a spoiled baby or one of those vegetables at the store getting misted. Ah… Cabbagenon. Celerynon, perhaps.

When Mydei crouches down to wash his legs, Phainon smiles. Laughs.

"What?"

"Nothing," he says, fond, "I just remembered, wasn't there a part of the Bible where Jesus washes the disciple's feet?"

Mydei scoffs, proud as he always is. He grabs his ankle. *"Those who have had a bath need only to wash their feet; their whole body is clean. And you are clean, though not every one of you."*

Phainon's heartbeats pick up at that; oddly enough, he starts feeling overwhelmingly guilty. "Why did he say that?" he asks, as though Jesus' words were directed at *him.* "Why'd he say it like that?"

Mydei's eyebrow cocks, but he does not look up to meet his gaze. "He knew one of them was going to betray him."

"Ah… I didn't know you were religious like that."

"I'm not," he says with a small laugh, "But my father made me read the Bible every day, so some verses stuck with me. This one stuck with me because, uhh, it made me realize I like men."

He can't help himself—Phainon bursts out laughing. Hard. It takes him by surprise because fuck, that's really funny but also Mydei is being *so* earnest right now. He covers his mouth and tries to stifle his laughter. "Sorry, no—I don't mean to laugh, it's just—That's unique."

"Yeah, I mean, I was pretty sheltered," Mydei doesn't seem phased, "My first crush was on this painting of Archangel Michael."

"Archangel Michael…?"

"He was beautiful," Mydei hums, "And dangerous. I liked that. I was maybe eight?"

A beat of silence. Heavy.

"Ah…" Phainon, all of a sudden very shy, speaks up. "I was wondering… If I were Judas and you were Jesus, would you forgive me?"

That's when Mydei looks up at him. A little surprised, yet still half-lidded; still lovely. He seems to actually considers it for a moment, and Phainon's mentally ill enough to go into a small, split-second spiral over his answer. Would Mydei forgive him if he betrayed him? What if he says no? By all means, he'd be *correct* to not forgive him—yet, Phainon finds that he would still want to be forgiven. Forgiveness. Anything. His palms itch. Why is he having a mini-panic attack over this? He feels awful. *He feels guilty.* What if he betrayed Mydei and got him killed? He would never do that, but what if he did?

Ah.

He has done that. To someone else. Someone dearer. Months ago. Almost a year. *Almost a year.* Dreadful anniversary. Mice and rats, an entire parade of them. Singing. Trombones—he

never knew her favorite song, so he just asked the band to play the regular funeral march. But she wouldn't have liked that. *She wouldn't have liked it.*

It's ringing in his ears now, real, and he wonders when all of this will stop. The dreams. The hallucinations. This searing pain. His chest burns, both with the flu and with the weight of his sins. His fingernails dig into his palms, and he's trying to keep his breathing very steady, and —

"Yeah," Mydei says, and a second might have passed, or an eternity, "Sure, I would."

"Why?" and he says it too curtly, too quickly, because Mydei's expression wanes. Just for a moment.

"Why not?"

"Well, if I'm Judas and you're Jesus, and I betray you, then that means I kill you."

"Right, but if I'm Jesus, that means I'm meant to die," he's very casual with it, too, "And with my death I bring salvation."

He wants to say something else, but Mydei hums instead, a bit sing-song—

He leans in and places a soft, delicate kiss on his knee. Tucks a strand of hair that got wet behind his ear as he does so. Beautiful thick eyelashes brushing against his cheek, fluttering close like butterfly wings.

Phainon could really cry. Awe-struck, scraped raw inside, he thanks Gods he does not know the name of for his failed suicide attempt. Blessed with things he does not deserve, beautiful and tender things, things that Mydei keeps putting in his arms—things that he cannot hold.

It quiets, a bit. The beating of his heart, and the trombones too. He reaches out with both hands, headed for Mydei's broad shoulders, and stops just short of touching them; Mydei sucks in a little sharp breath. Flinches.

"Sorry," Phainon whispers, aching to touch, "Can I?"

Mydei chews on his bottom lip. "…No," he says quietly, as if the word can shatter whatever there is between them, "Not right now."

"Okay, that's fine."

His hands come back to rest on his thighs, well-behaved, yet Mydei's lips linger on his kneecap still; a second too long, long enough to hurt. He's too sensitive to the touch, skin too frail and now tender too, from the wash. He feels the kiss like knives; delicious and delirious, he wants more, he wants everything, he wants nothing else. He wants to touch the crown of Mydei's head.

He does not.

Instead, he tries very hard not to whimper Mydei trails his kiss down, just two centimeters, and turns his pretty head to rub his cheek there. Just for a moment, like a spoiled kitten.

"Bath's all done," he says, slowly, "You can get out if you want to."

"I don't want to," Phainon gasps out, quickly, "I want to take a bath. An actual bath."

Mydei doesn't look at him, but his eyebrows quirk up. "Alright, sure. Let me take the stool back and I can run you a bath."

"I want you to take it with me."

That seems to faze Mydei, and he turns to him with this cute surprised expression. "You don't have to if you don't want to."

"Hmph. Why wouldn't I want to?"

"What?"

"Think I can't take a bath with you, asshole? I'm much better at taking a bath than you are."

Phainon scoffs, incredulous. "Bullshit. You're powerscaling bathing?"

At that, Mydei grits his teeth. Clenches his jaw. "It's not *powerscaling* because there's no competition."

"There's no—There's no competition?! We can fucking *make* it a competition. A staring competition!"

Staring competition. That's very intelligent of Phainon, and even more intelligent of Mydei when he actually *agrees* to it.

Mydei takes back the stool to the kitchen, commanding him to *stay still* and *prepare the damned* bath. When a beautiful man tells him to do something, well, Phainon obeys.

They don't set any *rules* for their competition, so Phainon and Mydei just… end up staring at each other in silence for ten or so minutes. Both of them very much blinking, which does go against the typical rules for a staring contest. It's not about the competition, though, is the thing. Phainon just wants to *look* at him. His knees are pulled up to his chest, while Mydei is sitting spread open in front of him; Phainon couldn't possibly be more unhappy that they're wearing swimming trunks.

Mydei's gaze is always an intense one, bold and fierce, yet now it is softer—a bit tired maybe. He hasn't been sleeping well, Phainon notices, if the bags under his eyes are anything to go by.

"Phainon," he breaks the silence, "What would you do if… If a huge meteor was headed straight to Earth?"

Phainon blinks, then hums wisely. "I would…" he trails off, "I would…"

"Yes?"

"Well, of course, in such a time of strife, I would uplift queer voices."

Mydei frowns first, brows tight, mouth agape. His eyeballs flit all over his face as he processes whatever the fuck that answer was, and then—release, muscles unknitting, a deep-chest laugh. He snorts with it, and he goes to slap Phainon's head; ever the ninja, however, Phainon catches his hand mid-air. They struggle like that for a bit, laughing, splashing water everywhere on the tile floor below. Mydei's teeth are beautiful when he bares them, sharp, wild.

"You're an idiot," he tells him when he subsides, leaning back to his place and stopping his attempted battery on Phainon.

"Yes, but I'm *your* idiot, no?"

Mydei raises an eyebrow, cocky, condescending. "*Are* you mine?"

It takes Phainon's breath away, and he flushes all over, from the tips of his ears to his cheeks. "W-well…" he stammers.

Mydei grabs his hand then, sweetly, shyly almost. A little uncertain, perhaps over the control of his own strength as he tries *very* hard to be gentle. Like a feral dog being given a chicken egg to safeguard in it's maw, so too does Mydei treat his hand with overwhelming carefulness. With his thumb pressed against the ball of his fist *(he couldn't even tell he was clenching it so hard)*, he commands it to open and Phainon—Phainon can only obey, opening it up for him. Mydei turns it palm-up to look at it, baring the old scar, the most shameful of his endeavors. He can hardly look at this sight, Mydei with his eyes transfixed on the physical proof of his weakness, yet he finds that he can't tear his eyes away at the same time.

Mydei must have sensed *something* was wrong, because he brings up his forearm. Commands Phainon to *look*, and when he does—a myriad of scars, horizontal, thin like worms under his skin. Some are bigger, some smaller, some have healed better than others. Pale, terrible things. He looks, spellbound, drooling almost from where he's left his mouth open. "You don't have to be ashamed," Mydei tells him, his accent delicious, "We're the same. You're better than to be ashamed of your past."

Mydei takes Phainon's hand and brings it to his hot cheek, searing and burning up like the fever in Phainon's body. He lays on his palm, keeping it flush against his skin, and nuzzles into it. Closes his eyes a bit as his bangs fall all over his face. "Can I…?" Phainon asks and, breathless, Mydei replies, *"Yes."*

He runs his hands through his hair and slicks his bangs up with some water. He holds his hands there for a moment, feeling Mydei's scalp under his fingertips. Phainon dares not do more than this; this is blasphemous already, as if he's making a very beautiful thing dirty. He bares Mydei's face, luminous and naked without hair all over it, and he finds him grinning weakly back. The diamond on his cheek is gorgeous, red eyeliner tattooed on the underside of his eye permanently. The red streaks across his body, his arms and his back and his chest, seem to shift now like strands of red paint in water. Yellow sickly light comes like a halo

from above them both, a salvation, and with Mydei's olive skin tone, it casts him in shades of green.

This is all he can do. His hand brushes against Mydei's forehead as he lets his bangs fall down again. It is enough—any more would be greedy.

"Phainon," he whispers low, "If you tell me a secret, I'll tell you one too."

"A secret…?"

"Tell me about your sister."

His chest seizes. *"I can't."*

"Alright," Mydei places a small kiss on his palm, "Then tell me something else."

"I…" he trails off, wracking his brain, "For the past two months or so, I've been hallucinating. I think I'm in psychosis."

Mydei hums. Gives his hand another kiss, then opens his eyes to bore into him. "That makes sense. You should see a doctor about that."

"It's… It's your turn, Mydei. A secret."

He shifts back. Takes his cheek away from his palm, yet does not let go of his grip of it. Phainon feels the parting like a wound to the chest. Mydei looks bashful for a second, peachy pink, uncertainty in his golden eyes. He looks away, scared. Looks back, brave.

"Phainon, I like you a lot. I have a big crush on you."

"That's—" Phainon chokes on something, or maybe it is the sickness, because he starts coughing violently, taking his breath away. He keels over, wheezing almost to the point of puking. Mydei pats his back through it.

That's…? What is he meant to tell him? There's a million things to reply with, and Mydei is sweet as he waits for an answer. Too good. *That's not right? That's not true? That's bad? That's bad because I am not good, because I'm awful, because I take and I don't give back?* That's bad, because I kill. Because I have killed. I will kill you. I might kill you.

The kind thing here is to lie, tell him he appreciates the feelings but does not return them. Let Mydei down gently as one might be let down into a grave. Let him bury his feelings with gravel, and forget, and move on.

Phainon can't quite catch himself soon enough.

"*I like you too,"* he says back, and the look on Mydei's face—shame, then relief. A small smile, not cocky and proud like his usually are, but rather shy and cute like a schoolgirl's. He looks happy, but not too happy, as if he has to indulge in his joy only in very small doses. Perhaps he's afraid of it being taken away from him, as he ought to be—Phainon is a taker. *Greedy*.

"I know," Mydei says, and then Phainon's hand is brought to his face again. He makes his thumb swipe across his bottom lip, feeling his fingerprints, every groove and callous.

"I'm not a person," Phainon chokes out, "You have to understand that I'm not a person."

Mydei scoffs.

"That's funny," he says, soft like a bed of lilies, "Because I'm not a person either. What joy, that we have found each other. A pair of non-people."

They are born a day and two years apart.

This, naturally, means that Cyrene and Phainon always, always, celebrate their birthdays together.

It's no big celebration, just the two of them. It has always been just the two of them since they left Aedes Elysiae, though Phainon thinks this must be a little unusual. They're both *extremely* popular, Cyrene more so than he is, but still. Thousands of followers—ten thousand in Cyrene's case, hell, she's practically a small beauty influencer on the side. It's not exactly *'quit your job'* money, but it helps keep them afloat, even lets them get something nice a few times a month.

Still, point is: they know a lot of people, yet always end up celebrating their birthdays alone. Phainon doesn't mind and Cyrene doesn't seem to mind either. He can't think of any person he'd like to actually *invite* to his birthday. Well, there *are* some— he just started this new job last month and there's some girls he gets along with. Castorice is the shy and kind type, a proper good girl, which Phainon likes that a lot in a friend. There's Hyacine too, who's funny and a little kooky. Cipher is special, because Cipher is mean and Cipher *bites*. He also like that a lot in a friend. They're a nice little friend group, spending most of their breaks together, laughing, playing video games on their time off. He would've liked to invite them, but it feels a bit too soon. They're still not quite at the *'hang out IRL outside of work hours'* level. Maybe next year, if they're still friends.

Cyrene, on the other hand, is an even weirder case. Between her modeling auditions and her boring office job (Junior Financial Consultant, thank you very much), Cyrene is hardly ever home. She's always out with people, and started hanging out with this girl almost five months ago. They're friends, he thinks, or maybe they're dating? He should really ask sometimes. Thing is, Cyrene is practically attached to the hip with this girl and her friend group. So it's *weird* that she's still alone with her loser bother. Maybe it's like a pity case for her, hanging out with Phainon so that he's not left to his own devices on his birthday. Nothing good ever comes out of his solitude.

They're drinking this sickeningly sweet liqueur that Cyrene *loves,* Sheridan's Coffee Layered Liqueur. It tastes like candy, and Phainon prefers bitter alcohols more—but it's whatever, because it's technically *Cyrene's* birthday today, which means they do whatever *she* wants. That translates to drinking while perched on the couch and watching a moving.

The movie (that she picked) just ended and now it's time for presents. The sun has started to set. It's dusky outside. The late autumn air is crisp and it's a bit chilly inside the house. Still, Cyrene wears her pajama shorts, and Phainon notices a small yellow-purple bruise on her ankle.

"Cyrene?"

She seems distant, looking off to nowhere in particular, lost in thought. He pulls her out of it. Cyrene blinks a few times with a small *'oh?'* and it's a moment before she looks at him. She's swaying a bit—she must be getting drunk. It's her fifth glass of this shit, after all.

"What happened here?" he asks, tapping the bruise with his finger.

Slowly, dazed, she follows the movement downward with her eyes. It takes her a moment until she realizes he's speaking about the bruise. "Hmm? Oh, the bruise?" she hums, and runs her thumb over it. Lovingly, almost. "HA! I took a tumble down the stairs a few days ago. Reney's so clumsy!" She gives a laugh, airy, sweet. It makes him smile too, though he's never known her to be *clumsy* before.

"Oh. Well, you should be more careful."

Her long pink hair falls down heir shoulders like a rosy waterfall. Phainon loves her hair so much, because no matter how much she dyes it, it's still *so* silky. She even convinced him to die his own hair too, white, so that they can be *ice cream-colored*—it probably helps that they're both *super blonde* naturally. Cyrene tucks a strand of hair behind her ear. "I promise I'll be, okay? No need to worry~"

Phainon couldn't possibly ever worry about Cyrene, that's how much he believes in her. She's strong, beautiful, and kind. Nothing could ever possibly stop her.

"Why didn't you, uh, go out with that girl. Maria or… Evangelia?"

Cyrene laughs again, softer this time. "Her name is *Anna*, I told you a million times! You're so silly~" she scoots a little closer to him, puts down her glass, and takes his face in her hands. He notices, now, that her nails aren't done. Cyrene always loves getting her nails done. "I just wanted it to be the two of us today, okay? Just wanna spend some time with my cute little brother!"

She pulls him closer and gives him a small kiss on his forehead. "What about Georgia, hmm? Why didn't you invite her over?"

"Oh, um…" Phainon shies away a bit, "I told you I broke up with her like… two months ago."

"Ah, yes… That's right, I remember now!" Cyrene giggles.

"So is Anna like… *your* girlfriend?"

Phainon is a little embarrassed to ask Cyrene about her personal life this, but he's *really* fucking curious. She cocks her head, her smile all glassy and perfect. "Nini… It's not nice to

ask a girl such personal questions~"

She lets him go and downs her glass. Puts it aside on the table and leaves no more room for further love life-related questions. "Okay! Time for presents, now!" she chirps, clapping her hands together, then reaches under the table and pulls out a white paper bag. It's pretty big, and heavy too when she hands it to Phainon.

Cyrene got him new shoes. They're men's dress shoes, black, simple, yet very elegant; not the shiny kind of dress shoes, rather possessing dullness to them that invites an air of dignity. They are wholly unlike Phainon, yet he likes them nonetheless.

"I was thinking it's about time you get a proper pair of big boy shoes," she says, "Do you like them?"

He does.

"I love them," he tells her, "They're beautiful, but I don't know where I'd wear them…"

"Eh, maybe you'll go to a fancy party one day. Or on your wedding day or something."

Phainon scoffs at that. He can't imagine himself a married man.

He gives her his gift, a small jewelry box. Cyrene makes an excited *"oooh~"* sound when she grabs it. He watches with rapt attention as she flicks open the lid.

It's a simple gift. A silver bracelet with three charms; a quill, an open book, and the little Mem fairy-puppy thing from the cartoon they both loved as kids. Cyrene's reaction is… subtle, maybe? Her mouth falls open a bit, lips parting, and she runs her fingers over the bracelet. Reverent.

"This… Phainon, it's expensive."

"It wasn't *that* expensive… I just saved up a bit from my last job."

She smiles, toothy, and takes it out of its box. Lays it in the palm of her hand for a bit as she admires it—then, gently, she brings it to her lips and kisses it. "Thank you, Phainon…" she whispers, low as a prayer, "I love it so much."

"I, um, picked the charms myself. Thought you'd like them. The Mem one was like, a limited edition collab thing."

Cyrene does not look at him, instead she seems enraptured by the bracelet. "I love it," she repeats, "I love it so much."

She slips it onto her thin wrist, keeps watch over it as the charm bobble and clink with every move. She seems as though a phantom; pale and distant, wrapped in a shroud. Despondent. Her gaze writes of sorrow; of woe.

A small tear, crystalline, lands on one of the charms; then another, and another once more. Phainon thinks her a beautiful crier, and when her hazy blue eyes meet his, they are both

smiling and crying. It's as if she cannot choose, stuck in-between and crushed tight. Ribcage fractured. Teeth on the dashboard. Neck bent. Limp.

"Your sister is such a fuck-up," she sigh with a small smile; a small sob, too. Rocking side to side only a little. She tucks her hair behind her ears again. "Isn't she?"

In a fury of pink, before he can answer and say *"No, of course not, you can't be a fuck-up because you're my big sister"*, she leaves. Goes to her room and locks the door. Refuses to come out for the rest of the day.

Phainon never asks what she's sad about. He never asks about Anna again, either.

Hanging out with Anaxa is fun because Anaxa is fucking *hilarious.* They don't seem to know it, though, which honestly makes them every *more* funny.

Today, however, nothing's funny. They've thrown up twice since Hyacine came to pick them up, and they keep claiming it's because *'they ate something wrong'*—which is certified bullshit, because she knows Anaxa barely eats in the first place and when they *do,* they're very strict about their diet. As per their own claims, they're very sickly and they *have* to eat right.

So, yeah. Bullshit.

It's because they're nervous and she can tell. She can tell because *she knows.* She gets it, really, and of *course* she does—she was so nervous the night before her first endocrinologist that she didn't sleep at all. Just walked into the doctor's office like a half-living zombie.

Now, she's rubbing Anaxa's back and holding their hair while they vomit. When they're done, and my God it's a while before they're done, she helps them up and hands them their crutch. Today is a *crutch day*, which means shit's really fucked. Poor Anaxa.

"Anaxa," she starts, gentle, "There's nothing to be nervous about—"

"I'm not nervous."

Right. Of course, stupid Hyacine forgot that she's talking to *Anaxagoras Skemma* and not someone *honest,* like Castorice or Mydei, or Pha—nah, not Phainon. Cipher? She's honest sometimes, when she wants to be. Mental note: call Cipher later to see how rehab is going.

"No, yeah, for sure. But if you *were* nervous—"

"Hypothetically."

"Right. Hypothetically, just purely hypothetically, if you were nervous —hypothetically, of course— I'd like you to know that there's nothing to be nervous about. This doctor is *really* good, and he's suuuper trans-friendly! He helped me every step of the way of my medical transition. So, again hypothetically, there would be nothing to be worry about."

They don't seem convinced. Anaxa is just like that sometimes, and it's endearing when it's not self-sabotaging. Getting them to *this* point has been hard enough. It's been a several months-long endeavor, because they would say shit like *"Being on estrogen seems beneficial"* and when Hyacine would mention how that's like, totally in the realm of possibility, they'd just say *"Hah. As if."*

But hey, she's nothing if not a fucking *winner.* And she won this battle, goddamn it, and she's going to get Anaxa yummy girl hormones if it *kills* her. And it might, *genuinely*, kill her with how bull-headed they are sometimes.

They walk out of the bathroom and into the clinic's waiting lobby. "You know," she tells them as they both sit down, "I even got my FFS here. Did a pretty good job, no?" and she strikes a little pose, hand on her cheek, small wink. Anaxa scoffs, yet smiles.

"You were beautiful before, too. The change is subtle."

"Yeah, that's what I asked for! Just a little nip and tuck here and there."

They hum, low, and lean more into their seat. "Interesting. So it doesn't have to be a drastic change."

"No, not at all. You don't even *have* to get it. It's up to you."

They just nod absentmindedly. God, this is going to be a long road. Hyacine can't *wait* to walk it with them.

After a few moments, she hears them laugh to themselves. "What?" she elbows them, "Whatcha laughing about?"

"I'm just thinking about the shopping we're going to do," they say, grinning, "And how stupid I'll look."

"Stupid…?" Hyacine is stumped. She blinks uselessly at them. "What do you mean, *stupid*?"

Another bout of giggles. "I mean, *ridiculous*. Like an ugly woman."

Ah, this. She knows this well, too. Hyacine's gentle hand comes to grab their wrist, almost imperceptible as if to not spook them. Anaxa's not great with physical contact because they get overstimulated easily. Today, though, they seem to accept it. "I think you're a very beautiful woman—or a beautiful… thing?" This gets a laugh out of them, "And anyways, you don't have to *buy* anything, if you're not comfortable. We can just look."

"How'd you do it, hm?" they say, "You have a pretty unique style."

"Oh, I was terrified at first. First dress I bought was this ugly sequined thing and putting it on made me feel like a *freak.* Honestly, I just brute-forced my way through it. You just need to find your personal style. I always liked super frilly girly stuff, so once I found out about lolita, it was over. You know, I get pretty dysphoric at work, 'cuz I can't dress like a porcelain doll…" she trails off with a laugh, "You don't need to dress like a…" she tries to find the right

words, "Like someone from the magazines. You can be creative with it or like, androgynous, y'know? You don't have to be a pageant queen."

Anaxa is *extremely* stylish, in a dark academia snobby classics professor way. They like tweed and cashmere and they earn enough for the finest things. They like jewelry a lot, too, all gold and rubies. They're already there, it's just a matter of getting over the damn hurdle.

They just blink and nod at her words, and at least seem like they internalized *some* of it. They take their wrist out of her hand, but there's no insult there. She smiles at them, and though they are not looking at her, she knows they can feel it.

Anaxa wants to be alone for their appointment, so when they're called into the doctor's office, they tell Hyacine to *wait outside.* She does, of course, though she would very much like to be in there with them. For them. As they disappear behind the door, Hyacine is getting pretty nervous, because they were *so* brave for taking this step and, honestly, she's worried that something might happen to send them running backwards.

It's not even half an hour before they're out of the office. Their face betrays nothing; Anaxa has always been hard to read, but at this point Hyacine's hands are *sweating.*

"Well?" she jumps up, "What? *How was it?"*

"Oh," Anaxa says, and hands her the prescription, "I got this gel."

She reads it over, trying very hard to contain her giddiness.

"Hey!" her eyes sparkle, "That's the same thing I'm using!"

"Ah," Anaxa smiles, "So it certainly works, then."

They wait for Aglaea's chauffeur to pick them up outside, because Anaxa said, quote, *"I'm about to have a mental breakdown if I have to spend one more minute inside that hospital."* Totally fair. They *do* seem like they're in a better mood already, and Hyacine suspects they might even be a little *excited* about this new development. Their death grip on their crutch has subsided to something a lot more normal. *Victory!* Hyacine mentally fist bumps herself.

Anaxa clears their throat, "You said you felt like a *freak* when you put on your first dress. Why?"

Hyacine hums as she thinks. That's a hard question. She exhales some of her smoke, pointedly *away* from them. "Geez, that's loaded. Hmm… I just felt like a man in a dress."

Anaxa inhales sharply at that. Hit a nerve, for sure. A deep-rooted insecurity they also probably have, spoken of plainly and loudly and *casually.* She was, maybe, a bit too frank with it, but it's true nonetheless. "Elaborate?"

"Ehh, internalized transphobia," she waves her hand non-nonchalantly, "Big one to unlearn. It was weird. I felt gross, but I was also very happy. I video called one of my trans friends about it, almost in tears, and the first thing she said when she picked up was *'Oh my god, Cinny, you look sooo pretty!!'*" she laughs a bit, "Then she told me to stop being silly. Trying on your

first dress isn't different from trying on your first hat or a new haircut or… You get what I mean. New things are scary for everyone. It's gonna take time, but it goes away eventually, and honestly—fuck, Anaxa, the euphoria you get out of it is addicting. The more I wore that dress, the happier I was. And when I started experimenting with makeup? Yeah, that hit the sweetspot."

"Worth it…" they mumble noncommittally.

"Yeah! The temporary discomfort you get is worth it. Nice things you want to do are *worth it*," she taps them on the shoulder to get their attention, "One of my friends once said: do it scared, but do it anyways."

"How long is it going to take?"

Hyacine smiles, endeared, fond, "I don't know. It's different for anyone. Can take a day, can take years. You just have to keep trying until you get it right. And after that, it's… really, it's the best thing ever. I've *never* been happier."

"Seems like a headache…"

She shrugs, "*Life's* a headache, isn't it? We're all just trying to make it better," she turns to them, solemn, serious, "This *is* going to make your headache better."

A sleek black car pulls up. The signature golden-plated license plate, spelling GLDWVR, gives away its owner. Hyacine runs up to greet her as the blacked out window rolls down. "Agy! Heeey~"

Aglaea's beautiful hair turns to her, though her eyes don't seem to find her. Garmentmaker is sitting pretty by her feet, very obedient. "Hyacinthia. Hello. How was it?"

"I'll let Anaxa tell it. Naxy, our ride's here~"

Anaxa lets out a scoff and a small groan, entirely way too overdramatic. They're committed to the tsundere bit—Hyacine can only respect it. And despite seemingly being bothered by Aglaea's presence, they still tell her about their appointment today; though, they try their best to sound as unexcited and casual about it as possible.

She takes them to this fancy boutique, claims it has *"some of the finest clothes in Okhema"* and if *Miss Aglaea* is saying it, then it's probably true. It's a respectable establishment, though obviously the clothes aren't to Hyacine's liking—by all means, however, they are *exactly* Anaxa's style. Neutrals and greens, with a focus on good tailoring. Wool is abundant, so is high-quality cotton. There are some silk and velvet pieces, too.

Such a velvet piece is one that Anaxa is so *painfully* obviously attracted to. A long forest green skirt, floor length, with ruffles. They keep looking at it, going to feel the material, then shaking their head and looking at some brown blazers. Then, like clockwork, a few minutes later, they return to the skirt. Touch it again. Then leave.

By the third time they circle back to the damn thing, Hyacine steps in. "Anaxa, found something you like?"

"No, not really."

"What about this skirt?" she gestures at it, "You've been looking at it for a while."

"I just think the material is beautiful, that's all."

"If you want to buy it, Aglaea said she'll handle the payment."

Anaxa scoffs at that, "Get it? No."

"Are you sure? You seem to really like it, Anaxa…"

Their fingers run over the fabric, almost lovingly, and then move down to feel the ruffles. They want to buy this skirt *so much*, but Hyacine also doesn't want to *push them.* "My sister had a skirt like this, once. When she was younger."

"Oh! She must've been really stylish!"

The sound of Aglaea's white cane approaching and Garmentmaker's panting perks both of them up; the two turn to see her standing behind them, radiant, smiling. Seems like she's done chatting with the boutique's owner. "What are you two talking about?"

"Ah, we were just talking about this skirt! Check it out?"

Aglaea hums and stretches out a perfect hand to touch the item. She feels the fabric thoroughly, first the velvet and then the seams. Lastly, the ruffles. "It's well-made, and…" she leans in very, very close, "The color is beautiful. Yes. It would bring out your eyes."

She takes it off the display and swings it over Anaxa's arm, unprompted. "Try it out. Let's see if it fits."

When Anaxa returns from the changing room, they are dressed in their regular clothes and slightly flushed. They simply announce that *"it fits"*.

"You'll get it, then?" Aglaea says, a playful lilt on her tongue. She raises an eyebrow.

"I suppose, if you are paying, then why not? It is unlike me to waste your *generosity.*"

She laughs at that, airy, light, and grabs the skirt from Anaxa's hand. As she goes to pay for it, Hyacine and Anaxa hang back, looking at her. "I wish I looked like her," they mumble to themselves, and Hyacine's *so sure* she wasn't meant to hear that.

"Yeah, geez. Who wouldn't?" she answers instead of shutting up.

Hyacine would've liked to look more, but she can tell Anaxa's getting overwhelmed and that they need to get out *immediately.* They mention in passing that their leg is *bothering them*, which is Anaxagorese for *"I am in indescribable amounts of pain"*.

She stops at the pet shop to get more pigeon feed for Little Ica while Aglaea and Anaxa get into the car. On her way back, she overhears a bit of their conversation—

"I do worry, sometimes," Aglaea says with a sigh, "What if the glaucoma advances even further? It has been stagnant for some five years, but the risk is still there…"

Anaxa scoffs in their characteristic way, proud yet not unkind. "Are you looking for pity, Aglaea? You won't find it with me, if that's the case. I simply believe that you'll be able to do it, no matter what. Having such thoughts is ridiculous, coming from Miss Goldweaver no less…"

She throws her head back and laughs. "You always know what to say, Anaxagoras. Thank you."

Aglaea graciously drops both of them off to Hyacine's place before driving off into the sunset, very cool and romantic, yes. The first thing she does when she gets home is let Ica out of his huge crate. He immediately flies up and perches on Anaxa's shoulder, pecking at their earring. They're scratching under his chin with a finger when Hyacine brings them two cups of coffee, one for each.

They mellow down together for a while, with Anaxa massaging their leg at the joint of their knee. None speak, until one does.

"I feel like this thing keeps failing me," Anaxa says through gritted teeth, "Everything hurts. Everything is *wrong*."

"Hmm?" Hyacine hums as she takes a sip of the coffee, "What do you mean? What thing?"

"My body. It's sickly and frail. Bore me with a bad leg and gave me glaucoma to boot. And to top it all off, the damn thing's trans too. It can't do *anything* right."

The tone of their voice indicates something akin to a joke, but Hyacine doesn't think it's very funny—or very sincerely *just a joke* at that. They seem nervous, or perhaps agitated, if the tremor in their hands is anything to go by. She sets down her mug and puts a hand on their forearm.

Anaxa's experience with their own body is vastly different from hers. She's not disabled. She hasn't even had a big health scare, like, ever. But she *is* trans and she *does* get it. The frustration. The upset. The fact that she has to go through hoops for things other girls are granted at birth. Looking in the mirror, even now, at her naked reflection and picking apart every feature that she believes make her *not a woman.* It feels like a losing battle sometimes, but especially where Anaxa is right now, at the beginning. Sometimes it feels like it's a battle *all the time.*

And yet, still, it leaves her overbrimming with joy, and if she had a thousand options to choose from, she would always choose *this one*. *This* body. She did not know how sweet happiness —life— could taste like until the first time a cashier called her *'ma'am'* while she had no make-up on. Or when customers over the phone would leave reviews for *'that nice girl'*. She puts on three layers of petticoats to go out for groceries and when people stare, she

simply tells herself that they stare for the right reasons; and she doesn't really care anymore, really. Doubt washes over her in waves, incorporeal, gone the next moment. She's safe in this body that was given to her—and she loves it too, even when it's hard.

Hyacine feels as though high on it, high on womanhood; and even when she *does* stares at her naked reflection in the mirror, she finds that she's *satisfied* more often than not.

She gives their forearm a squeeze. "Your body is doing a lot for you. I think it's okay if it needs a little help sometimes."

"Yes." Anaxa says, cocking their head, "Maybe."

They wear that skirt to work every day of next week, and Hyacine recognizes the familiar glint in their eye.

Hyacine has lost count of how many times she's had to do this with Cipher, and every time it happens is just as heartbreaking as the *first* time it happened. Sixteen years old and anxious, rushing to the girls' bathroom at school to find Cipher twitching on the floor, overdosing and losing consciousness.

She's not overdosing *this time*, thank God, and she's clear-headed enough to beg her to not bring her to a hospital. Hyacine is mad because *Cipher is right,* she's already gotten arrested once before for using, many years ago, and she doesn't need to be criminalized *again.* Not to mention all the trouble that Aglaea had to go through to scrub her record clean, all the strings she must've pulled.

The first thing Hyacine does, once she arrives at Cipher's place, is get through the sea of cats. The second thing she does is drag Cipher to the bathroom and splash her with cold water.

Cipher's mumbling apologies through it, clinging to her side, pliable and easy. She's still going at it when Hyacine lays her in bed.

"Come to bed with me," Cipher groans, "Please, don't leave, I don't feel well."

"I'm not leaving, Ciphy," Hyacine whispers to her, rubbing her shoulder, "I'm just getting you some water. And you'll drink it, okay?"

"…Okay."

Hyacine watches over Cipher as she drinks a big glass of water, slowly as to not choke. She finishes and asks for more. Poor thing, her mouth must be so dry. Her movements are sluggish, her tongue heavy in her mouth. When she returns with a new glass of water, Cipher is shivering with chills and sweating buckets, curled around herself in a fetal position. Groaning in pain.

"What hurts?"

"Everything."

"I… don't really want to give you anything for the pain, to be honest."

"I know, I don't want to take anything, I just… Ughhhn…"

"Here," Hyacine coos, trying to be soothing, "More water."

Cipher's room is a tapestry of all that she loves. One of LeBron James' signed jerseys is hung on the wall and her windowsill is covered with geodes and crystals. Posters of superhero movies, and an entire bookshelf full of all her favorite Marvel and DC comics. There are at least twenty photo frames littered around the room. Some of them are of her cats. One of them is her, twelve years old and skinny, with her elderly grandma. One of them is of her, her elderly grandma, *and* Aglaea, back when she worked at Cipher's grandma's tailor shop. She looks to be around her early twenties in that photo, before she lost her sight. She's crouching down next to small Cipher, arm around her shoulder, while Cipher is throwing up peace signs. Her grandma's liver spotted hands are gripping their shoulders.

There's some landscape and wildlife photos too, because Cipher's really into photography and *really* good at it. Exotic tropical islands with strange, colorful birds perched on fruit trees, stunning pastures and mountains littered with grazing bovines, moody gothic cities that seemed as though ripped from an Edgar Allen Poe book; all immortalized by Cipher in snapshots. All of them trips that Aglaea took her on—showing that little girl born addicted to meth all that is beautiful in the world.

Aglaea… She must be so upset right now. Not at Cipher, never at Cipher, but just at the situation. She's basically been the only constant in Cipher's life, besides Hyacine, and when her grandma died, Cipher crashed *hard;* drugs, alcohol, parties, unsafe sexual encounters, abusive relationships. Still, through it all, for almost twenty years of her life—Aglaea was always there to catch her every time she hit rock bottom. *Always*. Paid in full for all the times she was in rehab. Bought her this apartment and paid the utilities until Cipher got on her feet. She didn't let her go homeless or hungry, not even for the sake of *"teaching her a lesson"*. Got her this job, nepo baby style. She never got mad at her when Cipher relapsed, simply held her through it and cradled her head. Took her to the best therapists that Okhema has to offer. And even when Cipher lashed out at her, stole from her, tried to break their bond, Aglaea proved that it was made of indestructible thread, strong like spider silk; and she always reached out first, never too proud, and never demanded an apology. Though she always got one, anyways.

Cipher always gets better and then she gets worse, then she gets better again. Every step of the way, Aglaea is by her side.

There must be no other person in this world that loves Cipher more than Aglaea.

Hyacine will have to call her in the morning, figure out what to do about this. Rehab is a given, and doubtless Aglaea already has a place lined up for Cipher. Somewhere peaceful and calm and beautiful, maybe a place that does animal therapy.

As though psychic, her phone lights up with a notification.

Aglaea

Talked to someone.

I have a place for Cifera.

Don't worry, it's nice. She'll like it.

Will pick her up tomorrow.

While Cipher is writhing next to her in the bed, Hyacine finds the time to send a quick message back.

Hyacine

Think she'll agree?

Aglaea

Yes.

She wants to get better more than anyone else.

She's just having a hard time is all.

That's a relief. Aglaea is amazing. Cipher nuzzles closer to her side.

"Hyacine, I'm sorry…"

"I know. It's okay."

"It's—It's not okay. I've said some awful stuff. Poor Cassie, I must've… I must've made her feel so bad… You know how she is…"

Hyacine knows. Castorice's self-esteem must be kept in a very, very delicate balance. Anything that perturbs it, destroys it completely. She'll have to talk with her about it sometimes, but right now… Hyacine brushes some hair away from Cipher's face. She's pale all over, colorless, her lips dry and cracked. Covered all over in a sheen of sweat and soiling the bedsheets under her. Trembling like a leaf in the wind, like a scared child, like a little girl. Hyacine wants to wrap her in a blanket and keep her safe from the rest of the world. Keep her safe from herself.

It could be nice, just the two of them, maybe with Aglaea too. On a cabin far away in the mountains, isolated from everything else.

But it… it wouldn't help. It would only ignore the issue, not address it. She places a soft kiss on Cipher's forehead.

"I'm sure they'll understand. You have to talk to them tomorrow, okay? Explain to them. And don't be ashamed. It's okay."

"The poor boy… the Kremnoan… Fuck, what was I thinking? I was going to—gosh, it's so fucked up, Hyacine, I'm so *sorry—"*

"Shh," Hyacine coos, rubbing her back. She shifts them around so Cipher is laying her head on her lap. Her trembling has gone down, but she knows it's only a matter of time before things get worse again. "Mydei's a good guy. He'll understand if you tell him. He's not the type to hold a grudge."

She whines. Small and broken. "Phainon…"

"What of him?"

"I'm… I'm worried about him."

"You're always worried about him."

"He's not—" she's starting to tear up, "He's not doing well, Hyacine, and I don't know how to help him, and I want to help him because helping him makes me feel like I'm *worth* something."

Hyacine shushes her again. Wipes her unshed tears, looking fondly into her beautiful blue-green eyes. Cipher is too gorgeous for her own good. Her heavy eyelids that make her look perpetually bored or perpetually smug, her perfect cupid bow arching downwards and then curving up. Her chubby cheeks, her baby face. Her warm hands and the mole on her breast. Pretty, pretty like a doll, but with an edge too, something that Hyacine can bite down on.

Hyacine couldn't possibly love her more if she tried.

"Cipher, he'll be okay, he'll—"

"Who's going to take care of him? Huh? Who's gonna take care of Phainon if I'm gone?"

Hyacine takes in a deep breath, and *thinks.* "Mydei will."

"And who's going to take care of Mydei?"

"Castorice will."

"And of Castorice?"

"Her sister. Phainon too, maybe."

Her eyes get all big, innocent like a child's. She chews on her bottom lip anxiously—it's trembling. Her hand grabs Hyacine's. Intertwines their fingers.

"Who's going to take care of me?"

Her voice is so small, so quiet, so sincere. Hyacine laughs a bit, impossibly fond, and can't help but squeeze her cheek. "Me, silly. And Aglaea."

"And you? Who's going to take care of you?"

Hyacine's chest aches. *"You,"* she wants to say, *"Only you."*

"Pfft. Anaxa, of course," she says instead.

"And of Anaxa…?"

"Well," Hyacine scoffs, "Anaxa doesn't need to be taken care of. I think they'd kill you if you implied that."

It makes Cipher laugh, weakly. She shifts to press closer to Hyacine's lap. For now, she's seemed to calm down; still, again, it is only momentary. Hyacine has to be prepared for the worst. Cipher sighs deeply against her.

"It's my ex-wife," she starts, sounding a twinge embarrassed, "I was already doing fuckin' awful, but then I see that she got married and… I don't know. I don't know why it broke me. I'm the one that fucked up anyways. I always fuck up, I always—"

Hyacine stops her there. "Stop thinking. I don't care if you always fuck up. You're my friend and I love you too much to give a shit. You're trying to be better. That's all that matters."

Cipher and her ex-wife must be one of the most spectacularly bad love stories of all time. Met at a party and got engaged a few months later. They tried to make that poor excuse of a *marriage* work for about… Three or so years, maybe more, maybe less, Hyacine honestly doesn't know because she'd rather forget about that entire stretch of time. Her wife was a functional alcoholic prone to outbursts, and Cipher was a functional heroin user also prone to outbursts. They crashed and burned often, but then her ex-wife got sober and started asking the same of Cipher. Started asking for kids, too.

Naturally, Cipher was left with no choice but to cheat on her with *several* women, and then keep lying to her face.

The divorce was really nasty. More so emotionally than in any other aspect, because it's not like Cipher had anything *material* to lose, but still.

She got to keep the cat, though.

Hyacine doesn't really get why her ex-wife getting married again would send Cipher spiraling, but it's also not *for her* to get. And she can empathize nonetheless.

Hyacine starts to cradle her hands through Cipher's hair. Now, her breathing has evened out—steadier, calmer.

"Hyacine," Cipher whispers from below, "You know I'm in love with you, right?"

She laughs at that, wild.

"Of course I do. You've told me that several times over the years. I think you know something about me too~"

Cipher scoffs. Rises up to meet her eyes. "Why *did* we never date?"

"You've never been *well.* I want you to be well before I date you."

"So…"

"If you get well this time—truly well, I mean. We can… try."

"And if it doesn't work out?"

"We'll just keep being friends."

Cipher smiles up at her, big and toothy and boyishly charming. She brings her hand to her mouth and gives it a tiny kiss.

At one point, Cipher dozes off and falls asleep—Hyacine cannot afford the same luxury. She has to keep an eye on her for now.

She looks back at the photographs in her room. Some of her cats, yes, some of her grandma. Some of Aglaea. Most of them, however, almost all of them—of Hyacine.

A photo of them as children, eight years old, playing in the park with small toy animals. Their smiles are toothless. This is a few years before her parents got arrested and she got placed with her grandma.

A photo of them, ten years old, hugging each other in the hallway of their school. Hyacine is looking at the camera, looking very elegant in her boys' uniform, and Cipher is looking at her. Cipher used to hate the skirt they made her wear at school, and Hyacine never wanted anything more than to *wear* that skirt.

Them as tweens in their cringy emo phase, posing like edgelords, all smudged eyeliner and skinny jeans and angst. Them at fourteen, Cipher dyeing a strand of Hyacine's hair dark purple. Them at Hyacine's humble sweet sixteen, the only person invited to the party, clapping as Hyacine blows out the candles on her birthday cake.

Them at their high-school graduation, throwing up their caps in the air, looking forward to a kinder, gentler future. Them, a bit older, pulling ugly faces at the camera. Them at one of Hyacine's college parties. Them on a random Saturday, playing on Cipher's PlayStation. Them at Halloween, dressed as Kuromi and My Melody; you can guess who was who. Them posing with Hyacine's psychology degree. Them at Cipher's wedding; Hyacine still remembers how heartbroken she was that day. Them with Aglaea at Cipher's birthday. Them bothering Anaxa at work. Them fishing. Them at cafes and movie theaters. Them at basketball games. Them on holidays, celebrating together with Aglaea. Them laughing. Them bumping noses. Them holding hands. Them holding *each other.*

Them, them, them.

She is drowning in *them.* She drowns beautifully too, loves every second of it.

On her desk, she sees a new photo, and takes it to inspect it. It's a polaroid. Her and Phainon at what seems to be the smoking area of a nightclub, faces twisted in nasty snarls, throwing up the *'rock on'* sign. They're trying very hard —and failing— to look fierce in that photo. It's cute, it's a really good photo. Hyacine likes it a lot.

Cipher is snoring against her, peaceful for once. Hyacine scratches her scalp, caresses the side of her face, pets her back. Finally, she takes her hand in hers. Plays with each finger. Feels every knuckle.

She will believe in Cipher, even when Cipher won't believe in herself.

When Cipher wakes up several hours later, groaning and shivering and throwing up, wrecked both by panic and shame, Hyacine is wide awake and ready to hold her. To wash her. To feed her.

To love her, in all the ways Cipher might need.

Mydei likes his hair long, and he's quite stubborn about it too.

Part of that is because it genuinely looks good on him. The other part, like most things in his life, is because of his father.

His mother's reaction to his father, rather, in this instance—

"I just can't stand it," she slurred, a little tipsy on red wine, "I can't stand it when he grabs you by the hair."

Gorgo bought a cheap hair clipper earlier that day. It was a loud and ugly thing, and Mydei was only seven years old, and to him the contraption looked as though designed to torture him; as though it were an evil monster from the fairytales. He had beautiful hair, then, shoulder-length and strawberry blonde, curling a bit at the tips and framing his face. *'My beautiful boy,'* his mom would tell him while she pet his hair, *'You're so beautiful…'*

She shaved it all off that day, and it hurt—emotionally, yes, but physically too. Gorgo held him down while he screamed and thrashed and cried. Gave him something sweet to pacify him after. The buzzing of the clipper shot through his nervous system like slippery eels, setting it on fire, leaving him wound tight as a bow with pain. She kept it short, not clipped yet still ungrabbable, since.

Mydei grew his hair out after she died. Haircuts became more manageable, but never clippers.

He's standing in a small, crowded bathroom with five other men. His friends.

Hephaestion just started chemotherapy, and now they're all shaving their hair to support him. This decision was made without Mydei's knowledge, or consent—he was simply *told* it was so.

Leonnius runs a head through his newly —nearly— bald head. He looks handsome like this, close-cropped. They all look handsome—Hephaestion just looks small. They're looking at him now, expectantly, and Mydei sits cross-armed in the door frame. Anxious and unsure, his heartbeat picking up with all the tell-tale signs of an incoming panic attack.

Hephaestion isn't looking at him. He's looking ahead in the mirror, a bit empty-eyed, a bit melancholy. Ptolemy turns on the clippers; the sound of their whirring makes Mydei's teeth rattle and hurt. He cringes away from it.

"Come on, man," he tells him, "Your turn."

"I, uh…" Mydei tries. It's getting hard to speak. "I don't—"

'I don't' what? *I don't want to support my friend through chemotherapy? I think my hair is more important than his cancer?*

He should do it. He has to do it. For Hephaestion, for—*he's dying.* He *could* die. He's losing weight already. He could endure it, for Hephaestion, and then cry about it later.

Mydei hears Hephaestion chuckle, weakly, and he pushes himself off his chair. Slinks through the sea of bodies to reach him. His eyes are sunken, tired. His hair, before it was shaved, has lost all its luster. He brings his hands to Mydei's face. Touches his cheek. "It's okay, you don't have to if you don't want to."

He cringes away at that, embarrassed, because the *stage 1 lung cancer patient* is comforting him for some reason. "I don't want you to think I don't support you, or—"

"That's stupid," Hephaestion laughs, "This is all a bit stupid. Now we're all bald, and I still have cancer."

"I'm sorry."

He laughs again, open-mouthed and loud, and settles into a smile. Hephaestion's smiles are plenty and abundant, though they rarely reach his eyes; for Mydei, though, they are always real. He reaches up and gives him a small kiss on the tip of his nose. "Nonsense," he says, running his fingers through Mydei's hair, "Your hair is so beautiful. It would be a shame. What would a lion be without his mane?"

Mydei flushes at that, half from shame and half from the compliment. He doesn't know what to say. Isn't sure if he wants to keep speaking today at all.

"Though," Hephaestion leans in to whisper, all conspiratorial, "To make up for it, you'll have to bake me a cake on my cancer-free anniversaries. Er, assuming there *are* any. Deal?"

'There will be many anniversaries,' Mydei thinks as he pulls him into a hug. Tight. Doesn't ever want to let him go, as if he could protect him from all the bad cells in his body. He sighs against the crown of his hair. "Yeah," he murmurs, "Deal."

When she wakes on the first day of Rosh Hashanah, Polyxia thinks *'This is about as good a time to die as any'.*

It is an *auspicious* time to die, or so did her mother tell her when Grandpa died on Rosh Hashanah many, many years ago, when she was very little and incredibly upset. Hashem calls to Him all those that He needs most by His side, something of that nature, though Polyxia doesn't *consider* herself particularly righteous.

It seems like Castorice hasn't woken up yet, because the first thing she does every morning is check on her. This mean, of course, that she has time to ponder this.

On one hand, it means God loves her very much if He were to take her now. On the other hand, it would be a logistical nightmare for Castorice. She would have to finish celebrating Rosh Hashanah before burying Polyxia, and really, it's not much of a jolly Jewish New Year celebration when your sister is super dead. Another issue is that right after Rosh Hashanah ends, Shabbat starts, and then Castorice would have to wait *that* out as well. So, by Polyxia's very astute calculations, it would have to be around a week or so before she can be put to rest in the ground; and really, the more she thinks of it, the less she likes the thought of her corpse being kept in a cold freezer for over five days.

So, okay, maybe not *this* Rosh Hashanah—but perhaps the next one? When *is* the next one? She ought to check and see.

Polyxia rises heavily, sleepy and groggy, to sit up in bed. She stretches her stiff arm, arches her back until it pops satisfyingly, and reaches for her phone to google "Rosh Hashanah 2026".

—Except, she doesn't do any of that. She can't. Which really fucking *sucks* right now because first of all, her arm is itching something fierce, and second of all, she's *really really* curious to see when Rosh Hashanah is next year.

Well. All she can do is wait for Castorice to wake up and bless her with a semblance of independence.

This, really, is what sucks the most about ALS, according to Polyxia. The loss of independence. The anger was the first hurdle to get over; the inherent, profound unfairness of the diagnoses. It doesn't even *run* in her family, not that she's aware of. She wasn't prone to stress. Her environment was just *fine,* nice and clean and healthy. It's just—one day she was walking, and the next she started stumbling.

The second hurdle was shame. She was so embarrassed all the time, being an adult woman and having to be taken care of. Polyxia felt like a *child,* and voiced such a thought to her therapist—the man only blinked and said, very casually, *'You are not a child. You're an adult disabled woman, and being taken care of as such. There is dignity in it.'* Castorice's persistent love and her caretaker's commitment to treating her —speaking to her— like an adult were the only things that healed this wound. Her —Castorice's, really— friends also helped; they never treated her differently, no matter how much she degenerated. They still act the same way around her as they did back when she could walk and talk , which is nice. There is a

component to this, spoken by that same therapist, that goes like this: *'You're going to die anyways, who has time for shame?'*

The third hurdle was the fear of death. That one was the easiest. The doctor laid it all out for her when she got a diagnosis, and she spent around a week scream crying into her pillow before, one day, she just accepted it. It is what it is—and isn't that very Jewish of her?

The fourth hurdle is the frustration and, yeah, she's not getting over this one. Frustration over her loss of independence. It's not shame, nor is it fear, nor is it anger—she just wants to *do* shit, whenever she feels like it. Take now for example. She really needs to go to the fucking bathroom, but she *can't*—I mean, she very much *can,* but that would just make her damp and uncomfortable. And, furthermore, she still has complete and utter control over her bladder—and if God has bestowed such a gift upon her, who is Polyxia to not take advantage of it?

All she can do is lay there and wait for Castorice. She can't even tell what time it is except that it's morning and they're supposed to go to the synagogue today. Their new cat —well, Cipher's cat that they're fostering— walks into her room and jumps into bed. His name is *Embezzlement,* which is a really fucking funny name to give a cat. He walks over to her, steps on her chest, and just loafs there. Well that's just great. Now she's being crushed to death by an obese tuxedo cat.

A creak from the other room. The sound of groaning and moaning—yes, the zombie has risen! *"Polyxia?"* Castorice calls out, as if she could answer back. Well, she kind of can? Polyxia gives her best *"Mmmph"* back.

The sounds of bare feet on wooden floors, approaching fast, and then—here comes the sun, peeking into her room.

Castorice's tired face, streaked with sleep lines, her messy hair in a tight braid; there's flyaways everywhere. Polyxia loves everything about her. She's so beautiful, her perfect mirror image, her shadow—is that conceited? Maybe. Polyxia knows she's hot. She's rubbing her eyes, and when she opens them—

"EMBEZZLEMENT, NO!"

She gasps and runs over to pick the cat up from Polyxia's chest. She sighs in relief when the weight is lifted from her—it wasn't that bad, really, but it was uncomfortable and Polyxia's respiratory system is like, already failing.

Castorice grabs her from under the armpits and pulls her in a sitting position—and it is only now that she realizes how much shes *aching*. Holy shit, everything hurts, but especially her back and her joints. The muscles in her arms are just kind of spasming. She groans and screws her eyes shut. Grits her teeth. Castorice knows this, so she reaches for her painkillers immediately. Crushes them up and serves them to her in a spoon with a little water on it.

The taste is atrocious, but it gets the job done—relief comes almost immediately. What really sucks about ALS (other than, you know, *everything else*) is how you're not spared the pain. Sure, she can't move her legs or her wrists, but by god do they ache. The atrophy is bad too. She looks *so* skinny now.

"Do you need to go to the bathroom?" Cas asks, and Polyxia thinks *'God yeah fuck I sure do!'*

She groans instead and blinks once; her signal for *yes.*

Little known fact about Castorice—she's lanky and thin, but she's *strong.* Strong enough to carry around a grown adult woman, albeit a very very light one.

Today is packed with activities, and Polyxia's already tired just from thinking about it. The synagogue service in the morning, then Tashlich in the afternoon, and then dinner at home and it's just—she just wants to sleep. She's been wanting to sleep more and more lately, and she knows why—she's gonna die. Very soon, most likely.

It's fine. She's been gearing up for this for the past year but she really, really hoped she could hit the two year minimum life expectancy; she's hovering at about a year and a half? Something like that. Too soon. She wants more time with Castorice.

Castorice struggles at the morning service, because she *has* to hear the shofar blow but it's also very loud and it bothers her. Every time the sound rings out, though Polyxia finds it beautiful and mighty, Cas shivers next to her and goes to try and cover her ears; though she always stops just short of it, as though unsure whether she should do it or not. Polyxia wants to tell her, *'Oh my God, Castorice, just get earplugs!'* but she can't regulate her monitor's volume, so she'd just be blasting it out in the middle of prayers for one of their holiest holidays. So she just watches Castorice struggle, and she thinks it's really righteous of her sister that she pushes through the discomfort nonetheless.

It last four hours, and it's—well, it *is* beautiful. She likes having a community, and everyone at their shul knows her anyways so they come and chat her up; having a disability like Polyxia's is both very boring and very lonely, so she appreciates any and all conversation. Most people are nice. They ask her about her day and she doesn't really want to tell them that every day is mostly the same, so she instead she just says that "whatever she's up to is not appropriate for Rosh Hashanah"—she just means the latest Love Island drama. Castorice shows them all the new things she's been drawing; a flock of butterflies, a dragon with petals for wings, their foster cat. She does *not* show them her latest masterpiece, entitled "Mydei And Phainon Making Out Sloppy Style" (y'know, like the meme). She's going to give it to Phainon as a birthday present this year.

There's a new family —or at least, Polyxia thinks they're new— that joined their synagogue. A woman and her husband with two very bored looking kids. Kids are kind of her biggest enemy, because—

"Mommy, what's wrong with that girl?"

Yeah, because of that.

"Poor girl, I think she's sick. Chas v'cholile!"

Alright, damn, she's not really *'Chas v'cholile'* worthy. Polyxia, it's not okay to run people over with your wheelchair during Rosh Hashanah. It's not okay to run people over with your wheelchair during Rosh Hashanah. It's not okay to—

Yeah, okay, cool, they're approaching, and Castorice is talking to a very nice young woman so it's not like they can just *bolt* either. She knows what follows next—she's about to be used as empathy training for some snotty-nosed kids.

Polyxia closes her eyes and prays for strength to endure this. As always, they talk to *Castorice* first.

"I'm sorry," the woman says, and she's trying to sound nice, "My boy has some questions about your… sister?"

Castorice blinks at them. "My sister is not a curiosity," she tells them, stern, frowning. "And if you have any questions, you can ask *her.* She can *think* and *hear* just fine. But I hardly think this is the time and place—"

"Why are you like this?" one of the kids turns around and asks her.

'Because I was a bad kid that asked strangers stupid questions and a God cursed me to be like this' is her first instinct, but that's an incredibly ableist thing to say and it creates a negative link between disability and *badness* for the kid—makes them think it's a punishment, which it's *not.* She has to be nice with him, because his overall opinion on *all* disabled people hinges on *this* moment. So, you know, no pressure.

Polyxia turns to her monitor. Blinks at it.

"I have a condition called amyotrophic lateral sclerosis. It means my muscles stop working." It's a gross oversimplification, but the kid's like *eight* and probably doesn't know what a *neuron* is. *"Do you know Stephen Hawking? The smart man that talks about space on TV?"*

God bless Stephen Hawking for giving her a more famous reference point. Who the fuck even *is* Lou Gehrig?

"Oh," the kid's face lights up in recognition, "I do!"

"It's just like him. It means I can't move, but I can think just fine."

"Where is the voice coming from?"

"It's coming from this monitor. I recorded my voice and I blink at the screen to make sentences."

"Cool."

"Yeah, cool."

"Does it hurt?"

"Yes."

"Are you sad?"

"Sometimes."

"Were you born like this?"

"No, one day I just started walking funny and it kept getting worse."

The kid shuffles around on his feet while holding his mom's hand. "Can you still play video games?"

"I wasn't really playing them before anyways."

"What do you do all day?"

"Same things you do, but I just need some extra help. Sometimes I draw."

"How do you draw?"

"With my eyes."

"Cool."

And that's kind of it? The kid finds something else more interesting and pulls his mom away.

The questions never really stop and neither do the stares. Most strangers talk to her —if they do at all— as if she were a child who can't understand complex sentences; they crouch down to be at eye-level and talk veryyyy slooowwwlyyyy while using simple words. Some people —grown adults— look at her like her very existence is a stain on their every day life. Like she's *offensive* to the eye. There's something intelligent to be said about the politics of *beauty* and *ugliness* and about who gets to exist with *dignity* in public; after all, some hundred years ago, being *ugly* was reason enough to bar disabled and poor people from being out and about. She wrote her dissertation on this back when she got her master's degree in Disability Studies, Rights and Inclusion, an entire lifetime ago, years before she even got diagnosed— she never thought the subject would ever be relevant to *her*.

Really, Polyxia wishes she could bark at people—thankfully, she has Castorice for that. Who sometimes quite literally *barks*.

It's around 2PM when they leave the synagogue, which is prime Tashlich time. There is a park next to their apartment building, something beautiful and wild, and in that park there is a lake—a small lake, nothing imposing, yet special nonetheless, hidden in a clearing and guarded by trees. Castorice buys a loaf of fresh, warm bread on their way there.

They're supposed to break pieces of the bread and throw them out into the lake—with the pieces of bread, their sins go as well. Polyxia doesn't think she has *any* sins, and Castorice certainly doesn't have any, but it's a nice tradition that they like to observe. Mostly because Polyxia just really likes the lake. Today, there is a family of ducks there. A mama and some six ducklings, paddling about on the water. They don't even know they're about to get a feast.

They stop just on the edge of the lake, where the water meets the muddy grass—this is gonna be *terrible* for her wheels. Castorice taps her on the shoulder to get her attention and when

Polyxia looks at her, she quickly breaks a piece of bread and stuffs it in her mouth, then acts like she's just done something *very* naughty and mischievous. It makes Polyxia laugh.

She breaks another piece and throws it as far as she can into the water. The mama duck rushes towards it. She gives a piece to Polyxia, puts it between her fingers, then throws another one.

This is the first time that Polyxia is unable to throw bread on Rosh Hashanah. It's a very weird feeling, when you will your body to do something and it simply won't listen. She tries very hard, as if it were possible, and the sardonic bitch in her wonders what this means for her *sins*. She scoffs. Her fingers twitch weakly around the soft warm bread.

"Castorice," she says, *"You know, I can't throw it."*

"Oh fuck, yeah," Castorice gasps, "Sorry, I didn't realize—oh, I'm an idiot, aren't I?"

"Nonsense."

Castorice grabs her hand and unclenches her fingers. The piece of bread plops weakly into the water. Polyxia watches it sink. *"I think that's enough,"* she says, *"I think I only have one sin, after all."*

"What's the sin?"

"Pulling your pigtails all the time."

Castorice laughs, says she doesn't mind the teasing. She keeps throwing bread into the water until it is halfway gone.

Polyxia just looks at her. Pretty as she is. Her best friend—for a long time, her only friend. All her other friends left after she got diagnosed. Her ex-boyfriend, too; she wanted to marry that man. Hah. Good riddance!

The sunlight filters through the trees. It casts Castorice in ripples and spots, as if she were half made of flesh and half made of Heaven. Her big brown eyes shine golden where they reflect the light. Her roots are growing in, chestnut bleeding into lilac. Polyxia thinks hers must be grown in too, then. Castorice is too kind for this world—who is going to take care of her, when she is gone?

She wants to cry. She tries her best not to cry, because if she starts crying then so will Castorice. The tears in her eyes are not for her own sake, though, let it be known that Polyxia does not pity herself *anymore*. She feels like crying for *Castorice's* sake. For her inevitable loneliness. They are twins. She is half her soul, and Polyxia can't even —doesn't even want to — imagine the pain.

"Five months," Polyxia thinks to herself, truly praying for the first time today, *"Just give me five more months."*

Chapter End Notes

if you enjoyed it, leave a comment!! ♡

full disclosure, my original plan for this chapter was for polyxia to die on rosh hashanah. the scene between her and castorice was going to be different too, from castorice's pov, but i decided that polyxia deserves a POV as well.

however, the more i actually wrote this fic and especially the more i read people's reaction to it, i realized that that would be entirely way too upsetting--especially for me and also for the readers. and it just doesnt feel right anymore. i didn't expect this fic to have such a big emotional impact on people (really, i didnt expect it to get read by anybody in the first place anyways). her funeral was one of the FIRST scenes i came up with and actually a lot of the fic revolves around her funeral and the fallout of it. polyxia is going to die, eventually, thats just the nature of ALS, but not during this fic, although i am toying with the idea of having an epilogue --or an entirely different work, a one shot, tied to this one-- where she dies and her funeral.

were kind of entering the homestretch for this fic. i'd say we have about 3 chapters left. maybe 2? depends. a lot of things are gonna be changed now that polyxia's funeral is out of the picture.

Chapter 9: relief

Chapter Notes

This one is almost 18k! Wow! These keep getting longer, my bad! I've put all of my homosexual yearning into this, and I hope you enjoy it. Also, nsfw. Phainon jerks off in the bath. Hey, we're puting the 'Eventual Smut' tag to good use, slowly but surely!

!IMPORTANT!

This chapter comes with a big **SUICIDE TW** and also an **SA TW** . Specifics are below vv

▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They fall into an odd sort of dance, something broken and off-rhythm. Phainon and Mydei are not dating. They are not quite just friends either.

Phainon ponders one morning, as Mydei makes him sunny side up eggs, that they might be somewhere sideways of friendship. Something softer perhaps, yet not soft enough, and still the confession hangs between them like the Sword of Damocles—held in this allegory by one of Mnestia's golden threads. They like each other. Neither makes a move.

He knows why *he* doesn't make a move, seeing as Phainon is unlucky enough to be privy to his own thoughts. He does not make a move because he is scared, because he keeps waiting for that aforementioned sword to drop and take his head with it. Leave him something bloody and writhing on the floor, something more lovable, something more darling.

Mydei keeps coming over to his place. After that day in the bathtub, fated as it were, Mydei slept over. It got late when Phainon's sinuses cleared up and he felt well enough to be on his own, though he would lie if he said he didn't feel amiss about letting Mydei go; thus, deviously, he concocted a plan.

"It's late," Phainon said then, stretching like a cat, "Why don't you sleep over?"

Mydei hummed as he worried over the pile of dirty dishes leftover from their dinner. His back was to him, nude, rippling with every movement of his arm. Shoulders tensing, stretching, untensing. The strong muscle connecting neck to shoulder swaying every time he turned to look and put a dish away. His tattoos danced on their canvas like women, bare, suffocating. Phainon felt very much like a kitten being dangled a thread of yarn in front of his face. "I have to go to work tomorrow," Mydei mused, half-mouthed, "Though I suppose, you *are* closer to the office… Hmm… Alright, sure. I'll sleep over."

Phainon tried not to sound too happy when he spoke up again, "That's great. You can take my room, I'll take Cyrene's?"

"I'm not letting you sleep in your dead sister's room. That's unhealthy."

"Yeesh, that's direct. Okay, then *you* take Cyrene's room."

"I'm not sleeping in your dead sister's room."

Phainon clicked his tongue, "Fine, be like that. Couch?"

"Mmm… no."

"Okay, man, then what? Do you want to sleep in my bed with me?"

Mydei turned to him like a crack of lightning, mouth stretched into a grin, flashing teeth like a lion might. Handsome and devastating. "Yes, I would like that."

Son of a bitch, Phainon thought as his knees went a bit weak, wobbly, and he was never more thankful that he was sitting.

It was a sight to behold—Mydeimos in his bed, on his side and facing him, chest naked, covers pulled only halfway, just to his hips. With his eyes, Phainon traced the curve of his waist, from the jut where it met his hip, down to the curve where it dipped and arched, and then up to the line of his ribcage. He made no point to hide his wandering eyes, hungry and blasphemous; he was tired. It had been a long day, it had been a long *life.* The concept of subterfuge and falsehoods exhausted him—and for what? It had all been laid down between them, naked and horrible and tender to the touch like a wound. Something that, doubtlessly, weeps and bleeds and thrashes. He blinked slowly. Mydei was too far away, and he was too beautiful that night. Vulnerable in a way, very much so, and Phainon molded him in his mind into the shape of a panting hare; he himself, the wolf. It would be redundant to say that Phainon felt *ashamed*, and yes, it was that kind of shame. His fingers itched with the pulses of suicide. A hole to crawl into and never come out of. An endless sleep. To drift down the river like Ophelia. His jaw ached with how much he'd been grinding it, as if he was trying to turn his teeth to dust. It was too much at once for one such as Phainon—he wanted to run. Still, he found himself tethered.

The moonlight pouring into the windows crowned Mydeimos in prismatic lights, glittering pearlescent like an angel's halo; and Phainon saw it, he really saw it, and maybe it was the psychosis, or maybe it was the hand of God Himself petting Mydei's head. He looked at Phainon, golden-eyed, cracked open and scraped raw. He had been very brave. His shoulders raised and fell with every breath, lips parted just so, and then he did something that took Phainon's breath away; he blinked. Slow and beautiful like the arid summer days in Aedes Elysiae. His hair was much like the golden wheat fields in his little village, stretching as far as the eye can see, and where the blonde bleeds into red, Phainon saw the sunsets he used to watch with Cyrene. Eyelash met cheek, and he found himself fisting the sheets, clenching his jaw tighter. A gentle movement, like everything Mydei did; the first snowflake of winter, landing like a lovely thought on the petals of a flower. Phainon was seized with such burning longing then, as though his whole chest might burst into flames, and such jealousy too, that it

was an eyelash that touched Mydei's cheek and not his own lips. Phainon could hardly stand it. Yearning gripped him like a chain collar grips a bad dog, and his knuckles went white from bunching into fists. He wanted to scream. It should've been him. He wanted it to be him. Why couldn't it be him?

The desire —the *need*— to lean in and close whatever space was between them, mouth to unloveable mouth, was a mountain-dweller of mythos among mortal men; his shame was stronger still, and so he stayed put.

Mydei took an icepick to the silence. "Are you feeling okay?"

"Yeah, it's just—Yeah, I'm good."

He was not good. He wanted to stuff himself inside Mydei's ribcage and lick his bones clean. He wanted to know what color his blood is. He wanted to know if, when Mydei cut himself, it was the same shade as that drunken, half-formed night in the bathtub. He wanted to know what his heart looked like, wanted to measure it in his hands, see how vibrant and fat it is next to Phainon's shriveled little thing that was still beating just for the sake of beating. He wanted to compare the connective tissues of their eyeballs. He wanted to be so close to him that they were no longer just Mydei and Phainon, but something else entirely, something new, something perhaps a little crooked, but beautiful and radiant nonetheless; something melted together and sculpted into a creature that might have been the both of them, once.

It was suffocating. Delirium-inducing. Phainon has not had a sip of alcohol yet felt drunk enough to keel over and crack his head open on the floor. His mouth was dry and his tongue was heavy and there was only one thing, *one thing,* that could parch him.

"Mydei," his voice was far away, and yet reverberated in his chest. It was everywhere around them and nowhere at all. "Can you come a little closer?"

Mydei's eyebrow quirked up, and not on purpose either; a knee-jerk reaction, maybe, and one that Phainon found lovely. "Do you want me to?" came his answer, and Phainon has never wanted something more in his entire life.

"Yeah, i-if you want to, I mean—yeah, I would— I would like that. Would you like that?"

Mydei shifted a bit, burying his handsome face into the pillow, gazing away at it—then, he looked back at Phainon, granting him only the sight of his eyes. And so, he looked at him for a moment, golden-eyed, coy and prideful. In the dark, he could not see Mydei blush, colored in shades of blue and specks of moonlight as he was. The moment passed like a held breath and, wordlessly, he scooted closer to him—even so, still too far away from Phainon, who wanted to reach over and count his red blood cells.

Phainon has always measured himself to be a hungry man, ever-hungry for the love and appreciation for others, longing for a scratch between his ears and a *'good boy'*. That night, he indulged in some of his most debased needs. *"Can you come closer?"*

Mydei made a surprised little face, eyes shooting big like plates, and softened after into something warm and amused. "Do you want me in your arms?" he asked, honeyed, teasing,

and Phainon flustered like a newly wed bride.

He stammered and laughed nervously, "No—Well, yes—I mean, just closer, only if you want to, I mean." Mydei hummed in response, a bit sing song, and rose up to properly close whatever space was left between them. He settled back down with his head on Phainon's bicep, his soft hairs tickling his elbow, and a small smile pulling at his lips. They stood like that for a beat. Mydei, content as a kitten, and Phainon, horrified to the point of nausea.

He had, admittedly, not thought Mydei would ever agree to this, yet Mydei *did* nonetheless—and Phainon felt his heart beating in his throat, scared that he might throw it up. Mydei, on the other hand, just looked at him. A bit expectant. His shoulders a little tense. Unsure, yet willing to try. Willing to give Phainon —give *himself*— this. He was looking at him with so much nervous trust, and Phainon did not know how to handle it; did not know how to not shatter it. One of his hand moved, hovering above Mydei's jawline. A question hung between them, unspoken—*Can I?*

He watched as Mydei bristled, as his mouth twisted from a gentle smile to a grimace. He eyes darted around the room. "What are you going to do?"

"I just—" Phainon whispered, "I wanted to bring you closer. That's all."

Mydei jerked at that, a small spasm, as if he was fighting the urge to pull back. His lips pressed into a thin line. "I don't want to kiss."

Phainon blinked, a bit stunned, and then blushed deep. "I'm not going to kiss you, I promise, just want you a bit closer… No kissing."

Mydei still looked like an animal ready to flee, muscles locked tight. The hold he had on Phainon's shirt was fierce enough to tear the fabric if he were to pull it. "You don't have to if you don't want to," he prompted, "It's okay."

"Is it?" he retorted, with just a small amount of bite, "If I say no?"

"Yeah," Phainon took back his hand, put it obediently at his side, "Of course."

He had to be the brave one then, just for a bit, just for a moment. Steady and unshakeable. He very badly wanted Mydei to say *'yes'*—more importantly, however, he wanted Mydei to be happy. Safe. He wasn't looking at Phainon anymore, eyes all over the walls as though they might hold unspeakable secrets. Chewing on his bottom lip like a nervous child, eyebrows furrowed; something tender inside Phainon's ribcage snapped, and he sighed, wistfully. *'Just a boy,'* he thought, *'Grown tall.'* He held this image for as long as he was allowed, unable —*unwilling*— too look away. He thought of this moment as painted in hues of pink, a soft underbelly, all that delicate trust; Phainon held a gutting knife, and asked Mydei to believe it would not be wielded at him.

It was beautiful, really. Romantic in a way, the art of sharing all the little trauma-taught flinches. His eyes did not break contact, yet the tension in Mydei's shoulders was unbearable for him to witness. The stiffness in his collarbone. Phainon decided that he must think of a way to ease it.

"I was thinking about bumping noses and all, you know, like—chu~~ you know?"

Only then did Mydei turn his golden gaze back to him; he was frowned, confused like a fish out of water. His frown only deepened when he met Phainon's eyes, who was wiggling his eyebrows and putting on his goofiest smile. Mydei's jaw clenched. "What the fuck does that even mean?"

"Dunno. Not sure, really." Mydei relaxed all at once at that, rolling his eyes, scoffing and huffing like an old dog.

"Why do I even entertain you?" he said, running his hand down his face, and Phainon could only flash the finest of shit-eating grins. He sunk deeper into the mattress. "Alright, fine, sure. As long as you promise—no kissing."

"No kissing," Phainon echoed, and then his hand moved from his side to rest on Mydei's jawline. The movement was clumsy; they both twitched at the contact. Mydei with anxiety, Phainon with need. His grip shifted, fingers brushing alongside his strong cheekbones, and next, a wandering thumb found Mydei's ear, his pliable earlobe. He pinched it so, between thumb and index, and felt the skin bend to him, obedient—when he started rubbing around it, feeling the place where his ear is pierced, he saw Mydei sigh and press down deeper into his pillows. Eyes fluttering closed, then opening again to show a lax sort of glaze, blurring the gold, and if Mydei could've purred—he would've. Mydei's lips twitched around a small smile and it emboldened Phainon more, who allowed that same treacherous thumb to trace up the shell of his ear, smooth-skinned, feeling every little strand of peach fuzz inscribe itself into his fingerprint. He scratched his helix, gently with his fingernail, and Mydei's lips parted around a soft and needy sound.

He watched as Mydei grew shy, averted his pretty gaze into the nothingness of the room, though not in an unkindly manner; Phainon imagined him giddy and fluttery in his stomach. He laid with his arms bunched tightly to his chest, bent like a dinosaur's claws, and his blush crawled lower, flushing his collarbone golden-peach; he felt, then, warmth under his fingers as Mydei's ears heated up and they, too, reddened.

"No kissing…" Phainon repeated, in the throes of madness, and removed his hand—to Mydeimos' great dismay as he let out a low, displeased grunt, decorated with a furrow of his eyebrows, and leaned forward to chase his touch. Phainon brought his thumb to his own lips, gave it a chaste and sweet kiss, and reached over to stamp it to Mydei's lobe, right where his earring would be. The gesture surprised Mydei as he sputtered for words, taken aback, and then he broke into a cute, ungainly laugh, snorts and all.

"That's silly," he said, kind, mushy, "You're silly."

Phainon *was* silly, so silly he was feeling downright clownish, crushed under the weight of Mydei's giggling. All of a sudden—heat in Phainon's chest, warmth the likes of which could not be put in words. It took hold of him, an immeasurable fondness, affection like the tectonic plates shifting beneath them. He sucked in a painful breath, and slid his hand around Mydei's back, between his strong shoulder blades. Mydei, in turn, pressed ever-closer to him, unclenching his fists and grabbing Phainon's bicep, hard enough to leave bruises—Phainon would wear them, dutifully, like badges of honor. His muscles rippled like waves under his

smooth skin, under Phainon's hot hand, and in this twisted embrace, Phainon rubbed upwards and upwards again until he found purchase on the back of Mydei's head—and there, he stilled, feeling his nape, carding his fingers through the soft, fine hairs. "Is this okay?" he spoke, voice raw, infinitely affected, his lips nearly touching Mydei's forehead. "Is this nice?"

Mydei looked up at him, pupils blown so wide like a black hole swallowing the sun, jaw slack, and he nodded, "Yeah, it's okay. It's nice."

Phainon's first instinct was to *grab*, to pull him to his chest and kiss him until the both of them forgot their names. Instead, he massaged him there, watched as he melted more and more into the bed, floppy like a cat who found the perfect spot in the sun. "I'm gonna pull you closer now, yeah?" he whispered, and Mydei whispered back a coy, *"Yes."*

And so, Phainon pulled, closer and closer, and Mydei came, willing. They met when their noses touched, tip to tip, then pushed nearer still, bodies sliding against each other—and, in the end, both were satisfied with the distance only when their eyelashes were touching, intertwining like fingers. Then—stillness. Their lips were only an accident away, a whisper away, from touching, and Phainon could feel Mydei's hot breath on his mouth. His naked chest pressed flush to Phainon's clothed one, breathing in tandem, and Phainon could swear he could *feel* Mydei's heart beating in his own chest.

All he could see were his eyes, a vast expanse of amber, so close he could spot the small involuntary movements of his eyeballs, those little twitches.

"Is this close enough?" Mydei asked, moving his head a bit so his nose rubbed against his.

And Phainon's answer came—*"No."*

So, yes, all of that happened and, while Phainon and Mydei are categorically *not* dating, Mydei has gotten into the habit of spending at least four out of seven days sleeping over at Phainon's apartment—*in Phainon's bed.* There is a space now for Mydei in Phainon's bedroom, in his bathroom, in his *house.* Mydei always sleeps on the left side, in the open area of the bed, thus caging Phainon between him and the wall. He sleeps shirtless and just wearing his boxers (black with Guy Fieri-like flames on them). He tosses and turns, and Phainon often wakes up shoved into a corned, bullied nearly into the wall, *freezing* because Mydei has hogged the blanket and somehow got himself tangled in it.

He has nightmares, almost every night. Phainon observes him once, during an afternoon nap, just really *looks* at him—one would not be able to tell Mydei was having a nightmare at first, because he does not scream or yell or grunt. His expression, however, is far from peaceful—his twitching eyebrows, his twisting mouth, the thin layer of sweat on his forehead. In his sleep, he mumbles *'no'* over and over again; sometimes he says *'stop'*, too. Something tender wilts in his chest. He sighs, and reaches over Mydei to the nightstand by the bed.

Phainon has learned, from the first week Mydei spent over, to keep a small towel close at hand for moments like these. It's—well, he's a bit ashamed to say, but he's bought it specifically for Mydei. It's one of those fancy microfiber cloth towels, a bit on the pricier side, but it's supposed to soak up liquid very well and it *is* very soft. It's also, very

importantly, red with a small golden trim, and he just, you know, thought Mydei might like it. So, he grabs it and starts to pat the sweat away from Mydei's skin, his forehead and then his cheeks, lower down to his neck and his chest. He tries to be very gentle, because the first time this happened, he googled "*should u wake up a person having a nightmare'* and Google told him *no*, so… Google's probably right.

He very badly wants to kiss the furrow in Mydei's brow and smooth it over with his mouth. He wants to hold him and smother whatever it is that's bothering him to death. He wants to—he wants many things. He's always wanting, and always too scared to ask. Phainon, instead, takes this small gesture and makes a ritual out of it, anything to sate the longing in his heart. Just looking at Mydei is plenty glorious; to ask to care for him, that would be like a rich man asking for a pauper's shoes. Mydei probably wouldn't allow it anyways, Phainon assumes. Speaking of Mydei—

He wakes with a gasp and a fury. Grabs Phainon by the wrist and twists; Phainon, in turn, winces and cries out, dropping the towel and scrunching his face.

"What are you doing." Mydei demands through gritted teeth, still half-asleep, still half-dreaming. Phainon doesn't *want* to hurt the guy, so he tries to appeal to his goodwill; as calmly as possible with all the pressure being put on his bones, he pleads, "Mydei, please let go. You're *hurting* me."

All at once, then, the haze in Mydei's eyes clear; they open up from their fierce glare, soften, and Phainon can *see* how guilt sets into them."Oh, I—" and he sets Phainon free, "I'm… really sorry, I didn't mean to—"

"It's fine," Phainon says, and he wants to add, *you could crack my head and I wouldn't care,* but he does not. Mydei looks all the more like a scared child who just knocked down a vase. Worry, Phainon has learned over his time by Mydei's side, sets itself heavy in those expressive brows; they tip upwards and come closer together, making him look downright miserable. "It's fine, I'm not mad at you," Phainon repeats, and Mydei's entire demeanor changes suddenly; he accepts his answer, and relaxes.

"What *were* you doing?" he asks as he lays back down in the bed.

Phainon flushes, "Well, you know, I—you were having a nightmare, so I was, uh…" he picks up the towel from where he'd dropped it. "You were sweating, so I was cleaning you up…?"

He braces for Mydei's disapproval—he gets his tenderness instead. "Tch. That's really kind…" he mutters, "Thank you."

Mydei grabs his phone and starts scrolling, back turned to Phainon.

Phainon, well, he's feeling a bit clingy right now, so he settles close to Mydei and lays his head on the crook of his neck. "What were you dreaming about?" he asks, just for the sake of asking.

Mydei hums as he opens Instagram. "I don't remember the specifics, but I was being raped," he says, casually.

(It is a lie by omission—Mydei does not tie the knot on the dream retelling. The 'by you' remains unsaid. Phainon does not need to know. His warmth against his back is comforting.)

"Oh…" Phainon feels like an idiot. He should have known. He unpeels himself from Mydei's back—Mydei's eyes follow him. "That's—I'm sorry, that's really upsetting."

"It's okay, it happens a lot. It's either that or my dad."

Phainon thinks of his own dreams. He suddenly becomes aware of a ringing in his ears. "Does it happen… often?"

"Yeah," Mydei answers, "Like almost every night. It sucks but, eh, what can you do? It's a symptom of PTSD."

"Yeah?"

"Mhm. It's gotten better I guess, but my new meds are making me super sleepy, so… you know."

"Right," Phainon does not know, "So, do you dream of what happened to you? Sorry, maybe I shouldn't ask, but—"

Mydei locks his phone and twists around to face him. "I don't mind answering. My dreams aren't the exact memories of what happened, but it's like… the same theme, I guess? Or action? Sometimes I dream that my dad is murdering me or my mom, and I've been having this reocurring dream since I was nine where *I* kill my mom. Most of the times, though, I'm getting assaulted in some way or another."

"That sounds… really stressful," is all Phainon can muster. Mydei is gracious enough to chuckle.

"Well, yes," he says, "It's post-traumatic *stress* syndrome. Do *you* have bad dreams?"

Phainon freezes. Chews on his lip. "Yeah, sometimes," *all the time.*

"What do you dream of?"

"My sister," a pause, "Dead."

"Ah," and Mydei turns back around, "Can you leave for a moment? I want to be alone."

Phainon leaves.

Phainon goes to Cyrene's room.

He's learning a lot of things about Mydei.

For one, he is *very* quiet. Mydei is not much of a talker in general, but it's become clear now how much he's actually *trying* when he's out and about. There are days where Mydei doesn't

utter more than a simple *'yes'* or *'no';* he's sluggish those days, Phainon notices, yet still prickly like a hedgehog. Anxious and lost deep in thought, a sailor at sea. Fidgety. Frustration sets deep in his bones, beyond belief, and he can physically *see* how much Mydei has restrain himself everyday. How his first instinct when dropping something —*and he drops things often*— might be to pick it up and throw it at the nearest wall. There's an anger simmering in him, and holding himself back takes takes effort equal to moving mountains. Mydei bends down to pick up the fallen loaf of bread and his hands are shaking with the force of his fury. His jaw is clenched tight, screwed shut, teeth grinding against each other. He grabs the bread like it owes him money, fingers digging into it, and Phainon can just *tell* he wants to obliterate it. Mydei closes his eyes, counts for a beat, exhales, and goes back to unpacking the groceries. "Okay…" he mumbles to himself, *"Okay."*

"Are you good, man?" Phainon asks, feeling awkward just watching him.

"Yes."

"Oh, um. Do you want help with the groceries?"

"No."

"Are you su—"

He slams his hands down on the countertop, his head dipping down low and sticking his shoulder blades out. Phainon, in turn, bristles and sours.

"Alright, Mydei. Chill the fuck out."

Mydei breathes heavy for a few seconds. His eyes are closed. Then, he straightens and faces Phainon. "I shouldn't have done that. I'm sorry."

"Okay," Phainon isn't pacified at all. He hasn't done *anything* wrong. "Why are you mad at *me?*"

"I'm not mad at you, I'm just—" Mydei sighs and gestures vaguely, "It's one of those days."

"What days?"

Mydei leans against the countertop. His shirt rides up a bit. "It's just—everything and everyone is a lot right now and I can't think clearly. My brain's all fogged up."

Phainon's first instinct is to twist the knife a little bit, because he's got that mean streak in him and he feels, quite frankly, a bit rejected. And embarrassed—that's the really big trigger. He's itching for an argument real bad, and maybe he wants to give Mydei a damn good reason to fuck off and run away and never come back. It really is on the tip of his tongue, but Mydei sincerely looks like he regrets it, and really, it's not that big of a deal; they're both grown men. They're gonna get into fights. Like two male hamsters in the same cage or something. Phainon's mouth twists with something cruel, and yet he can't help but look away from Mydei's face; he searches for something to bite down on, something to give him a good reason to be awful to him.

He finds none. Phainon sighs, runs a hand down his face, and does his best to be *good.*

"I don't really get it, but I kind of understand, I think," he starts, trying to be kind, "But… if you don't feel well, why did you come over?"

Mydei blinks and cocks his head. "I like being here," he says, as if it was *obvious* and Phainon's the idiot for not getting it, "I like being around you."

Oh.

"Oh."

This strikes a chord in Phainon, something harp-like and beautiful. The storm dies—how could he ever be mean to Mydei? Mydei is sincere, earnest, and he tries so hard, harder than Phainon has ever had. He's always admired his gentleness, his easy kindness, the way he handles the world and its people like they are made of glass; Phainon understands now that, perhaps, that is not an innate quality of Mydei's, but a choice that he keeps making over and over again. He wakes up and chooses to be gentle. Phainon would very much like to do that, too. He looks down at his own hands—finds them shaking just a bit.

"I want to hang out, I just can't talk. We can just… hang out in the same room and do our own thing, without talking, you know?"

Phainon does not know, because he's a chronic yapper—he loves to talk, loves it when people start conversations with him or message him first. He could talk the entire day, twenty-four uninterrupted hours, about *everything.* "Yeah, for sure!" he says instead, because Phainon would withstand *flaying* if it meant hanging out with Mydei.

Hanging out in the same room without talking. Mydei calls it *'parallel play',* and they end up doing it a lot. Phainon could be coming home from work dog-tired and find hot dinner on the table and Mydei laid like a cat on the couch, playing on his Switch. In this case, Phainon would pick up his plate and eat it next to him while watching TV (on a very low volume, because when Mydei feels quiet, everything else has to be quiet as well).

It's nice. It's nice to *be* with someone without the pressure of performing well. To just exist, together, in the same small space. In some aspects, Mydei is much like a cat. Not chatty at all and uninterested at a first glance, yet he follows Phainon to whatever room he's in. If Phainon gets up to go to his bedroom, Mydei appears a few minutes later, acting nonchalant and casual as he plops himself down in bed.

When they play like this, Phainon likes to steal shy glances at him; perhaps just to confirm that he's still there. That he's real. He likes to see Mydei's face, his handsome features, illuminated by the cold light of the TV while he chews on a pen; you see, Mydei has a bit of an oral fixation, which Phainon finds endlessly delighting and endearing. He has chewed through everything there is to chew on in this apartment, short of Phainon's fingers—he thinks about offering them, but decides against it.

This time, Mydei catches one of those sneaky glances Phainon indulges in, and he returns it in earnest. Holds his gaze and smiles like all sharp and wolfish. Phainon tentatively reaches his hand out for him—watches in awe as Mydei reaches back and takes it. They look at each other for a moment, Phainon feeling utterly deprived of breath; Mydei is the first one to break eye contact, slowly turning back to the TV, yet still not letting go of his hand. Phainon, on the other hand, fixates on the point of contact.

Mydei's hands are calloused and strong, yet there is a gentle softness to them. His grip is not tight, but not lax either. It is just right. Everything about this moment is just right. It's so—it's perfect. Mydei is so perfect. He's so beautiful right now. Everything is so beautiful and the heat is rising all throughout his body, licking greedily at his innards, coiling tight in his stomach. He can't stand it—this is not something that can be withstood by mortal man. Mydei's warm hand in his, his heavy presence next to him, and it is only now that Phainon realizes that their thighs are touching. They're sitting so close, nearly shoulder to shoulder, and he can feel every small movement Mydei makes. He can feel the very texture of his hand, can retrace all the lines on his palm from memory.

Phainon starts to sweat, wet around his neck, and he has to bite down on his tongue to stifle a needy sound. He tests the waters, mad as he is, and nudges his thigh just a centimeter closer to Mydei's. On the other side of the world, Mydei huffs a small laugh and pushes back. His grip on Phainon's hand tightens, perhaps as a warning.

He is small and pathetic and so, so easy, and Mydei smells so good, smells of his pomegranate bodywash and lingering perfume. Phainon wants to lean over and lap at his neck, flat-tongued and hot, only to see if he has a chance of tasting the pomegranate on him. Make him squirm and sigh. He wants to bury his head in the crook of his neck and inhale heavily, drawing everything that is Mydei into him.

To his great horror, Phainon feels his cock twitching with interest.

Mydei thumb shifts as it starts to move against Phainon's. It finds the base of his digit, just over the second knuckle where it meets the hand, and strokes there in small up-down motions, repetitive. Phainon feels his nerves fraying one by one, burning away, and there is a half-aborted buck of his hips that he tries to stifle, a valiant effort of his body to achieve some friction. He has not looked at anything but their beautifully joined hands this entire time, and yet Mydei seems to be none the wiser of the effect this is having on him; which is probably for the better, because Phainon has to grit his teeth to stop himself from moaning. His thumb moves, up and up, until it finds his fingernail. Rubs circles into the tip, then moves to press their pads together.

Through the fervor of his thoughts, Phainon thinks, *Mydei deserves to be kissed senseless.* Mydei deserves to be pinned down to this couch and smooched until he's all dumb and pliant and they're *both* out of breath. He deserve to laugh and giggle through it, to complain that Phainon is tickling him when he runs his hands up his sides. He deserves to unravel in pleasure and in joy, to melt into the sheets and ask for *more, more, more.*

Phainon untangles their hands and pulls back. Mydei turns to look at him with a disgruntled little sound. "I think I'm gonna take a shower," Phainon says, "I feel icky."

Mydei just answers with a wise hum. Studies Phainon's face for a moment and then turns back to the TV.

The cool air of the bathroom is a relief when it hits Phainon's heated skin. He splashes cold water on his face and when he looks up at his reflection in the mirror, he finds himself blushed pink all over, down to his chest. His breaths come in short, desperate bursts. There is a tightness in his pants. This literally can't be happening.

You know, Phainon used to be quite the lady/gentlemankiller in high school and pilot school and that one failed college run. He used to fuck like, a lot. Kinky sex too, like leashes and handcuffs and other shit. He doesn't mean to brag, of course, but the point is: he got fully erect from having his thumb stroked, what the fuck, that's weird, that's really, really weird.

He's so hard it *hurts*, and he's reduced to palming himself through his pants to get some sort of release; he spends a good three minutes trying to will his dick into limpness before he admits defeat. This is not a fight he can win.

So, he turns on the shower. Ice cold. Sits under it for a moment. Looks down at himself; flushed and weeping and hard against his belly. Twitching to chase the sensation of water droplets and begging for attention. Phainon wants to resist it; he cannot. So, he grabs his cock at the base, squeezes lightly, and just *that* little touch is enough to make him feel like he's been punched in the gut. It wrings out a small grunt from him. *It's been so long*. It's been so long, and he's so desperate and heavy in his hand, and he *wants* so badly. He wants Mydei happily pressed against him, sighing against his neck as he takes the both of them in his hand, or maybe—maybe he wants Mydei with his legs spread on the bed, flushed and radiant as he fucks up into Phainon's mouth, or he wants him riding him with strong trembling thighs, pulling Phainon's head back by his hair and spitting into his open mouth, or—

He wants a lot. Phainon thumbs back his cockskin and finds his head leaking precum; he would be embarrassed if he was not deliriously aroused. When he starts to stroke, it is with a tight and fast grip, as if punishing himself for having such feelings. He wants to get rid of this issue quickly, pleasure be damned; still, there are starbursts behind his eyes, and his knees are jelly. It's good. It's really good. It's filthy and disgusting and pathetic but so is he and it's *good.* He purposefully doesn't think of anything. Jerks off to the image of a black screen. He does not want Mydei to be subjected to his perversity—but if he were to subject him to his perversity, this is how it would go:

Vanilla and missionary. They would hug a lot and hold hands and look into each other's eyes. They would kiss until they're both drooling and a little drunk on it. Phainon would crack stupid jokes to make him laugh and ease him into it. He would like to have Mydei pliable and relaxed like a lazy cat, so he would pleasure him with everything he has—his fingers, his mouth, his tongue. Phainon would make him come once just from prelude. In the end, Mydei would gasp beautifully when he enters him, would wrap his strong arms around his neck and pull him closer and whisper in his ear. He would say, *"Phainon, you are so beautiful and perfect and I will never be mad at you. Let's get married."*

A moan turns into a sob and pleasure mixes with the painful aching in his chest. Through tears, of which there are *many,* his hand does not relent, up and down his shaft, thumb finding the sensitive underside of his cock to rub circles there. It makes his knees buck and his hips

thurst up, fucking into his fist like some sort of dog in rut, filling nothing in particular yet determined to mate. He runs his other hand down his throat and to his chest, pinches a perky pink nipple, then lower down to his abdomen—it stops on his ballsack, running a gentle finger over the tender seam of his balls and *fuck*, he's so sensitive there, that always does it for him, and it's not gonna be long now, it's—

Phainon cums so hard his vision goes black for a moment. He has to bite down his fist to stifle his moan. His balls draw up tight and his abdomen tenses up, and somehow he can feel his orgasm in his *throat.* Phainon has to hang onto the shower curtain to keep himself from falling over and smashing his head open on the bathtub floor.

After the deed, he watches his semen wash away down the drain and his brain, insidiously, conjures up a question for him to ponder:

Did Cipher also watch your blood go down the drain, just like this?

It gets to the point where whatever it is they are is becoming… noticeable. Which is bad, because this means his friends get to tease him about it.

Today is Mydei's off day, which means the girls (Hyacine and Castorice, his everlasting headaches) don't *have* to hold back on Phainon anymore. First of all, they made him buy lunch despite the fact that it was *Cas'* turn today. Second of all, they cornered him during lunch break, when he is most vulnerable—cigarette in one hand and gyros in the other.

"So," Hyacine starts, and the glint in her eye is evil, "You've got some explainin' to do."

"I… do?"

"Yes, you do," Castorice continues. Did they rehearse this? "Lately, every time we ask you *what's up*, you say, *oh nothing much, Mydei's over at my place.*"

Phainon thinks back and recalls for a moment. Then he nods with a mouthful of food. "Yeah, sounds about right."

Hyacine takes out her phone. It's clad in this gigantic My Melody sillicone phone case and it must weight enough that it could kill a man if used correctly. She pulls up her notes app and shows it to Phainon. "I've kept track, you know. An average of 4.3 days out of seven each week were spent with Mydei sleeping over at your place."

That doesn't seem right; the math, that is. "How did you get the .3?"

"Don't ask stupid questions, Phainon! What's going on between you and Mydei?" Castorice says, her voice authorative, and are they… like… roleplaying? Are they playing bad cop and worse cop? Castorice crosses her arms as she waits for an answer, trying to look very intimidating in her white beret and frilly skirt.

He shrugs. "Nothing's going on."

"Bullshit," Hyacine stomps her foot, "That's horseshit. Dogshit."

"…Goatshit, birdshit, are we just enumerating types of animal shit, Hyacine?" Phainon laughs as he wipes his mouth with a napkin, "But no, really, nothing's going on."

Castorice blinks at him, then her and Hyacine look at each other, blink some more, then it's back to Phainon. "There's no way we were wrong…" she mumbles, thoughtful.

"We're not wrong!" Hyacine insists, "Phainon, look me in the eyes."

Phainon looks her in the eyes and gives her his best trademark Neikos Puppydog Eyes. It's usually an irresistible move, but Hyacine's super gay, so she's immune. She scoffs. "You're telling me that you *don't* have a crush on Mydei?"

He laughs. "I didn't say *that.* I said there's nothing going on between us."

Hyacine frowns, then realization hits her like a truck, she pulls back and gasps. "So it's true! You *do* have a crush on him!"

"Yeah, that's basically what I said. If you were curious, Cinny, you could've just asked the normal way…"

"Well, then, I guess that's it, huh…" Hyacine slumps down next to him.

"Hyacine!" Castorice snaps her fingers in front of her face, "Don't give up so easily! It's not over yet. Right, Phainon," and she turns to him with an accusatory finger pointed at him, "You like him. Does he like you?"

"Yep."

That seems to stump Castorice. She gaps at him like a silly fish. "…Wait, really?"

Why is that so surprising?! "What do you mean, *really,"* Phainon mocks offense, "What, is it so unbelievable that someone would be *into* me?"

Castorice changes her whole demeanor. "No, no! I didn't mean it that way! It's just—How do you *know?"*

Phainon takes his sweet time answering this, just really lets them simmer with anticipation. He takes a big bite of his gyros. Chews more than is necessary. Swallows.

"He told me."

Castorice gasps. Hyacine stiffens next to him. This is so serious for them for some reason. "What do you mean, he told you?" Hyacine asks.

"He confessed and then I also confessed," Phainon shrugs.

"How? *When?!"* Castorice asks, hands on hips.

"Couple of weeks ago, we went out to the park. We found a beautiful cherry blossom tree there and the sun was setting, and all of a sudden Mos-chan got all shy and blushy and said…

He said… Senpai, I really, *really* like you~!!"

If the deadly silence that sets between the three of them is anything to go by, the joke didn't land. It crashed and burned, actually.

Hyacine groans next to him. She sneers and grimaces like that was physically painful for her. "That was so fucking cringe," she says, and Castorice just looks… confused? Wheels are turning in her head.

"Who is Mos-chan?" the first of Castorice's questions, "Is it Mydei?" the second, "Why did you call him that?" the third, "Why did he call you Senpai?" the fourth, and then the grand finale: "Are there even cherry blossom trees in Okhema…? I had no idea… That's pretty romantic, Phainon, hmm…"

"Castorice!!" Hyacine yells with all of the strictness of a military drill instructor, "Girl, he's fucking with us! He's *lying!"*

The light of realization bathes Castorice's face as her eyes widen. She slaps a hand over her face. *"Ohhhh!!* Phainon, I totally believed you…"

"Sorry, sorry~" He does feel a little bad, but not *that* bad. This is all pretty funny to him.

Hyacine pulls out her pink cigarette pack. Digs one out and lights it, takes a big drag, and exhales the smoke in Phainon's face, just to be a dick. It smells like cherries—Phainon steels himself and stifles his coughs, because he doesn't want to give Hyacine this win. She points it at him in accusation. "You. Tell us what happened. Seriously now."

"Why is it such a big deal? Why are you all up in my business?"

"We're your friends, Phainon," Castorice adds, sounding oddly kind, "And were gossipmongers to boot. We're just curious is all," she sits next to him and nudges him with her elbow. "Nothing particularly exciting is happening in *our* lives, so…"

"Speak for yourself, Castorice, my life is *plenty* exciting," Hyacine leans back with her cigarette, eyes trained on Phainon and he, well…

Well, now he's feeling pretty shy. He wiggles a bit like an overexcited worm and clasps his hands together. "Uh, well…"

The girls lean in closer. Sharks.

"Um, remember when I called out sick? I asked Mydei to come over to my place that day just to be like, fun and flirty 'cuz you know, we went to his friend's birthday party and—well, that's besides the point, but I caught the flu from there and *y'know*. Anyways, so I called him and he *actually* came over and he made me soup? And like, fed it to me? And then he was like, *oh you need to take a shower* and I was like, you know, to be fun and flirty, I was like *ooo wash me!* But then *he actually did it* and anyways, one thing led to another and anyways, yeah, like we confessed. In the bathtub."

This is mortifying. Phainon buries his face in his hands and *feels* how hot his cheeks are. Hyacine and Castorice are silent, and then—a cold hand on his shoulder.

"Phainon, that's awesome!" Castorice says, softly, "That's really cute."

"Yeah," Hyacine concedes, "That's pretty damn cute. Cipher owes me 20 Balance Coins."

Phainon peeks at her through her hands. "You had a bet going?"

"Yup. I bet that you two were gonna get together within six months. She bet that it's gonna take at least two years because, and I quote, *he's got that self-deprecating stick up his ass."*

"You haven't won yet," Phainon points our, "We aren't together."

Hyacine blinks at him, "Right, okay, so—back to my original point. You confessed and he spends most of his days over there and you… aren't… together?"

"No, uh, we—we haven't talked about it and we don't do… couple things."

"Why haven't you?" Castorice pipes up, "Just ask him."

A familiar anxious feeling tightens in Phainon's chest. "No no, no way, I don't want to—hurry him or something, and I don't feel like, um… I guess I'm worried he'll be weirded out if I ask him or that he's gonna like… change his mind."

"What if he's waiting for *you* to ask him, though? Maybe he feels the same way… It wouldn't hurt to make the first step, would it?"

"It would hurt, actually," Phainon says, and then adds, "I really don't want to talk about this anymore, okay?"

It ends there.

It ends there until he gets home later that day, of course. Phainon finds Mydei lounging on his belly with his nose buried in his Switch. He knows this is *Animal Crossing time* and nothing is allowed to interrupt it. There's warm dinner in the kitchen, which he eats gladly, and then he immediately hops on League because he promised Hyacine a few matches.

A few matches turn into a five hour affair. His back hurts from bending over at his computer desk. His fingers are numb and he is one more bad match away from throwing his monitor out of the window. Hyacine keeps teasing him about Mydei and worst of all, she's really funny with it too, so Phainon is defenseless. His ears are sweating from being contained within his headphones. Every once in a while he hears Mydei hum and click his tongue behind him.

He's supporting Hyacine through a pentakill and with her yelling over comms, he doesn't notice that Mydei has gotten up and approached him—when he touches Phainon's shoulder to get his attention, he nearly jumps out of his skin. "Jesus—Mydei, sorry, what is it?"

"Come. I want to show you something."

"Uhh," Phainon looks at the screen. They're collapsing the enemy's base, so this is probably fine, "Yeah, okay—Hyacine, I have to go, you got this, right? Mydei wants to show me something."

He hears Hyacine snicker. *"The old ball and chain, huh? Yeah, sure, go. We're ending anyways."*

"That's really misogynistic, Hyacine, don't call Mydei that!" is the last thing he says before putting his headphones down. He turns to Mydei, who's looking at him rather confused.

"What could Hyacine have possibly said that was misogynistic towards *me?"*

"Don't worry about it, Mydei. What do you want to show me?"

Mydei holds up his Switch. "My Animal Crossing island. I just finished reorganizing it."

"Awesome," Phainon says, head over heels, and Mydei leads him by the hand to the bed. Settles himself and Phainon down, and sits so close that the red tips of his hair are tickling Phainon's throat.

"It is based on the structure of ancient Castrum Kremnos," he starts, "*This* is the grand arena where my villagers will battle to the death in the olden tradition of the Kremnos Festival. They will fight for glory and honor and the victor will have a chance to challenge the very King of Castrum Kremnos for the crown. *This* is the dungeon where the vilest of criminals are kept. These ones over *here* are the worst of the worst, cowards who fled the battlefield in their comrades' time of need. They will be beheaded come noon, to feed Nikador's thirst for blood, and—"

"Sorry, let me interrupt you. How do you choose which villager goes to the dungeon?"

Mydei blinks at him. "They are criminals."

Phainon laughs, "No, no, I got that, I mean how do you, the real Mydei, choose which cute critter gets put in the dungeons?"

"Oh," Mydei says, then shrugs, "It's all the villagers I don't want on my island."

And that makes Phainon laugh harder. "Isn't that Raymond?" he asks, tapping at a bespectacled cat, "Didn't people start like, a black market for him? You got him in the dungeon?"

"I hate him," Mydei says, seriously, "I think he looks dumb. And I would dip him in hot tar if I could."

"Okay, *Jesus*. What's next?"

"*Here* is the Palace of Garbaniphoro with its seven twisting towers. *There* is the Grand Library of Garbaniphoro. You know, it burned down some two thousand years ago and its

believed that much of humanity's knowledge disappeared with it. It was a great cultural loss, and scholars think that it set us back quite a few decades… Hmm… Oh! Here come the Queen and King of Castrum Kremnos, draped in their royal regalia. They are preparing to initiate the Kremnos Festival."

"Aren't Rory and Rex both boys?"

"Work with me, Phainon, there's no lionesses in Animal Crossing."

Phainon feels impossibly fond. He presses closer to Mydei and leans his head on his shoulder. "Okay. Is there a Nikador?"

"But of course," Mydei says, and then goes looking for his Nikador, "Behold: The Savage God, The Mad King, The Sovereign of All Battles, Grand Artisan of the War Chariot, Father of Victory, Greatest of Conquerors—Nikador! The Lance of Fury!"

Phainon blinks. "…That's Tom Nook."

"On my island, that's Nikador."

Mydei *has* put a lot of effort into his silly island. It does have the vibe of an ancient city, and all of the villagers are dressed in old Kremnoan fashion; well, as close as he can get them. There are soldiers and gladiators and people in peploi. Mydei exhumes pride, and he puts on a whole *show* as he's showing him around. As is to be expected, his favorite villagers are all the Jocks, but he has a soft spot for more cutsey villagers. As Mydei is talking, all Phainon can think of is reaching over and stealing his breath with a kiss. He settles for leaning more on him.

After a while, he shifts away and gets up. "Oh, Mydei, I just remembered. We ran out of bread and eggs."

"Okay."

"…Let's go buy more."

"Mmm…" Mydei hums, "Don't wanna. Picking apples."

Phainon sighs. "Dude, come on."

Mydei grunts, displeased. "Picking apples."

Phainon tries again, tries to sound threatening and authoritative. *"Mydei."*

"Don't wanna. Picking apples. My wallet is on the kitchen counter. There, go get it and go shopping. Leave me alone."

Phainon gives up. Some fights cannot be won, especially not when his opponent is Mydei in his *Animal Crossing* state. Though, he will take him up on his offer, he's not enough of a gentleman to turn down free money. He grabs Mydei's wallet and his keys and goes to the small store next to his apartment.

As he's browsing the aisles, the sheer domesticity of it hits him all at once. It's not *'I've ran out of bread'* anymore; it's *'We've run out of bread'*. So many weeks have passed since Mydei started staying over, and he has become a nearly permanent fixture of his household. He shops for two now, and Mydei cooks yummy meals for him every day. Even when he's not staying over, he packs him lunch for work. He bought a new toothbrush specifically to keep at Phainon's place. A few days ago, he brought over an old, ugly, raggedy Simba plushie. It's an incredibly well-loved thing, and almost as old as Mydei himself. When questioned about it, he simply shrugged and said it's his comfort item and he would like to have it here. He keeps it by his bedside when he sleeps, and sometimes he pets it when he gets agitated.

Phainon is starting to think that, perhaps, this is a more *permanent* arrangement they've got going on. Mydei has slowly carved himself a beautiful place in Phainon's apartment, in his life. The sun seems to shine a bit brighter these days. He's eating better, and he keeps his place clean because well, he doesn't want to embarrass himself in front of Mydei. He doesn't ask why Mydei is staying with him; Mydei doesn't talk about it, either. He's not arguing with him roommates or anything, that's clear, because they play Minecraft together every day and they're always chatting in their group chat. Phainon leans his head against one of the shelves. Mydei is staying with him just because he feels like it. Because he likes Phainon's company.

The thought is as terrifying as it is exciting—and perhaps, it's terrifying *because* it is exciting. Because it's a little too sweet on the tongue, and it's a little too much, and Phainon is hardly worth of it. It is treading into a dark unknown; he does not understand it, whatever it is Mydei likes about him. The Sword of Damocles dangles. He wonders if it is selfish to enjoy this moment while it lasts, before it's ripped for him.

It *is* selfish—and it is unfair to Mydei. Inevitable disappointment looms on the horizon. He sees it coming; Mydei does not. He should warn him of the danger, let him know, tell him to run before it catches him unawares. He will tell him, when he gets home, because Phainon has to buy bread and eggs and he can't afford to be freaking out in the middle of the store.

So, he buys bread and eggs. Pays with Mydei's card. He rehearses, in his head, what he will say to him when he gets home; something along the lines of *"I like you a lot but this isn't going to work."* Or maybe, *"I need some space, permanently. It's not you, it's me."* Something that will let him down easy and gently; a small heartbreak is better than immense disappointment, Phainon reckons, and *immense disappointment* is all he has to offer. It hurts like acid inside his chest. Phainon cannot bear to part with Mydei, but it is the right thing to do—either way, this sort of pain is very conceited. All *me me me me.*

On the way back, he stops by a pastry shop and gets them both something sweet to snack on. When he opens Mydei's wallet this time, he catches a glimpse of something glimmering in it. It piques his curiosity, and here's the thing:

On one hand, whatever it is is personal property. On the other, Phainon is a nosy bitch. The decision hangs on a scale, and it's beginning to be heavily in favour of snooping. Phainon tucks himself in an empty alleyway and double checks to make sure Mydei hasn't suddenly appeared next to him. He digs around for it and pulls it out—

A single strand of hair. Pale and silver and shining prettily. Nearly translucent in the sun. Phainon squints at it, and then he realizes—*oh.*

It's his. His hair that he got from—somewhere? Maybe from his pillow? Phainon stares at it, enraptured like a fool, his lips parting over a sigh and his mouth is so dry all of a sudden. It's so dry and nothing can parch it, nothing except Mydei, the sight of him, the smell of him, everything that he has and is willing to offer. Mydei, lovely as he is, that kept a strand of Phainon's hair in his wallet. He cannot help but think of Victorian jewelry, lovebirds torn apart yet kept together by locks of hair. Phainon would very much love a lock of Mydei's hair, would love to inhale the pomegranate perfume lingering on it, to rub it against his cheek, to place it on his wanting tongue and swallow it whole.

It's too much and not enough altogether. Is it a good luck charm for Mydei? Does he think of Phainon when he looks at it? Does he stroke it as one might a lover? Jealousy brews in his stomach at that thought—it should have been him. He ought to be the one stroked by Mydei, loved by him, adored by him. His decadence knows no bounds—he feels, in this moment, wrathful at everything. At the world, most of all, but at himself as well.

Phainon doesn't want much, yet here are some of his simplest desires: he desires to be the sheets Mydei sleeps on, to be the water he drinks, to be the nectar dripping down his lips when he bites into a peach, to be the clothes he wears on his skin, to be the lake he bathes in.

Phainon feels warm all over; his chest, his tense stomach, his cheeks. He puts the strand of hair back to its rightful place and decides to not speak of it to Mydei. He'll let him keep his secrets, his small shows of adoration, and Phainon will keep his as well.

He unlocks the door to his apartment. Mydei is napping on his bed, comfortable, his face illuminated by the cool autumn sun.

There's no need to disturb his peace.

Mydei also learns some new things about Phainon during their stay together.

Namely, that Phainon has… Mydei calls them *"fits"*. They hit him hard and they hit him out of nowhere, and they completely and utterly disable him. Mydei can't tell what triggers them and Phainon is barely coherent enough to tell him.

He is having such a fit now. Phainon's been *off* the entire day. Agitated and anxious and trying very, very hard to hide it—failing, too, because Mydei can read him just a bit too well. After work, they were eating their dinner in silence when Phainon dropped his cutlery and simply announced: "I can't do this anymore. I want to kill myself." Mydei hardly processed what was said before Phainon got up and started walking towards the living room. Concerned, Mydei followed. Grabbed him by the wrist and pulled him back.

"What do you mean? What's wrong?"

That was the beginning of the tempest—the most gruelling four hours of the past year. Phainon runs hot like a furnace, his fury equal only to that of dragons'. The softness of his gaze is lost in it, sharpening into something mean and intense; hatred, Mydei reckons, though he cannot tell what it is directed at. Himself, mostly. The entire world as well. It simmers and

boils over and wants to raze everything that stands in its path—Mydei can tell how much Phainon is holding back, and how much it pains him.

It's magnificent to witness. Mydei is so unwell and so in love. He finds something raw and real in the muck of Phainon's feelings, something as sincere as a broken leg. Mydei watches in awe as Phainon blows over and yells to be left alone, biting down his fist to stay his tongue from being hurtful, then breaks into apologies. This is the first time Phainon has been truly honest, and it's painful for the both of them. More so for Phainon himself, poor thing. His sobs rip out of him like sharp swords, cutting across his chest.

He asks Mydei to hold him, and when he does, he asks him to go away. Mydei holds him nonetheless, even while Phainon struggles. He's starting to not make sense, babbling half-formed phrases, an amalgamation of *"I don't, I can't, leave, stay, please, I'm sorry, I don't know, I want to die"*. Mydei rubs his back through it. He cries so hard he forgets how to breathe and Mydei has to teach him how. Phainon yells to be left alone while holding into fistfuls of Mydei's shirt so tightly that he's afraid it might be ripped apart. It's an agonizing contradiction, and Phainon seems to be made of those, like a puzzle made of pieces that refuse to fit together. He doesn't know what he wants and Mydei doesn't know what to give him, but he gives him what he can nonetheless.

Towards the end, the fury is replaced with something murkier; a lazy. slow-dragging, sorrow. Woe that is found only in Shakespearean tragedies. His eyes are bloodshot red and puffy. His face is streaked with the trails of hot tears, and he cried so much that there are small burns in the corners of his eyes. He is hiccuping and dry heaving for air. At one point, they collapsed—Mydei cannot tell when, but now they are on the floor. Phainon is draped over his lap, Mydei is cradling his head, and so Mary held the dying Jesus. He's looking up at Mydei and choking on his tears, and there is something beautiful about him—something childlike, too, innocent and naive like a boy that does not know what to do when in pain. Mydei strokes his eyebrow.

"You have to breathe," he says low, peaceful, calming, speaking to Phainon as though he were a spooked horse, *"Breathe…"*

"I—I can't," Phainon manages to say through his teeth.

"You can," and Mydei's hand moves to his chest, over his heart. He finds it beating at a rabbit's pace. "Slowly. Big inhale—yes, just like that, that was good. You're doing good. *Oh, Phainon…*"

His face twists again, mouth curling into an uncomfortable grimace, eyes filling up with new tears. He's gasping for breath, laborious and burdensome, trying to swallow the world and everything else in it.

It isn't a cathartic sort of crying; it's ripping him apart like a wild boar, unforgiving. Mydei rubs and pats his back when he starts to gag and choke on his sobs, his grief coming out like bile through his throat. Mydei will clean that up later, but for now, he pats Phainon's forehead, slick with sweat, with the end of his sleeve. Cradles him like a scared babe. There's innocence on that handsome face, childlike fear too—something young and new and flayed naked. He's looking up at Mydei as though he holds all the truths of the universe, the answers

about life's meaning and its unfairness. He very badly wants to kiss him, wants to kiss the pain away, but not—not like this. Not now, when he's like *this.*

Phainon has settled into something less hysteric. Mydei offers him his shirt to blow his nose on, and he does.

"Phainon," he whispers, holding his head, "What's wrong? What's going on?"

"I don't—I—Cyrene—"

Mydei sighs. The old tale. He rubs under Phainon's eyes, across his wet eyelashes.

"What do you need?" he asks, and Phainon doubles over and groans at that. As if the very thought of relief was painful. He buries his head in the crook of Mydei's neck and grabs at the neckline of his shirt, pulling him forward and pressing him against his body; an odd sort of embrace, a centipede mother cradling its thousands of babies.

"I want—I need—I need to be forgiven, I-I want… forgiveness, I want this to be over, I can't—it's so hard, I can't breathe—"

Mydei peels Phainon away from him, holds him so he can see his face. "Forgive you for… what?"

"Everything," Phainon whispers, "Everything—absolve me—"

"I can't do that," Mydei says, "I can't give that to you, I'm sorry. You have to give it to yourself."

"I can't."

"You can."

"It's horrible."

"I know. But what else can you do, except move on?"

"Kill myself. End it."

"You tried. Was it worth it?"

"The *failure* wasn't."

Mydei thinks very carefully about what he says next.

"But I want to cook honeycakes tomorrow. You'll miss out on them."

"And the day after?"

"I'll cook them the day after, too."

"And the day after that?"

"I'll cook them every day."

"I'll get sick of them."

"Then I'll cook something else," Mydei leans in closer, "I have many things I want you to try. But you have to be alive for them, alright?"

There's many things Mydei could've said. He could have listed of all the good things in his life, all the beautiful things in the world, newborn birds and orange-pink dawns. But none of those matter to Phainon right now.

He could have told him that if he kills himself, then *Mydei* won't be able to forgive himself—thus, the cycle of suicide perpetuates itself, Ouroboros, a tree growing awry. But that would only make Phainon feel more guilty, and so make him even more suicidal.

He thinks of short-term goals. Something realistic. Something they both know Phainon likes. Something achievable.

Mydei watches as Phainon's eyes clear, giving way to something sharp and luminous. "Okay," he says, and Mydei can finally breathe, "Okay. Just—stay like this for a while longer."

Mydei would turn himself to marble if Phainon so much as asked; so, he stays. Holds him until he is boneless and pliant and exhausted in his arms. After a moment, long as an eon and short as a breath, Phainon speaks.

"This body is hateful."

"Still," Mydei rubs the nape of his neck, "I love it."

A small expression of surprised; a child on Christmas day. "My best friend lives in it," Mydei continues, "And I love him, so I love this body, too."

Later that night, Mydei crawls into bed next to Phainon. He is still and silent and watching the wall.

"Phainon," he says, "You need to go to a psychiatrist. I'm serious."

Phainon stiffens next to him, "I'm… ashamed."

"I was too," Mydei says, "I was very embarrassed at first."

"And? Is it better?"

"Yes, much better. I'm not angry all the time anymore. I don't cut as often. I don't think about dying anymore. I still feel guilty, but less guilty than when I was nine. I've found some better coping mechanisms, like cooking and going to the gym. I'm not… *well*, but I'm *better.* And that's good enough, I think. I'm trying, and that's what matters."

"It's not fair."

"It's not," Mydei concedes, "It's really fucking unfair and it's an uphill battle. Some days are worse than others. Some days, I still feel like a scared nine year old. It's silly, but every morning I wake up and I expect my dad to open the door with a belt in hand. Sometimes I hear you walking around the house and my brain is fully convinced it's Dad, and that I've done something wrong, and that he's really angry at me and coming to punish me. My nervous system is shot to hell. I'm constantly worried I'll walk out of the house and see my rapist. I feel guilty for never reporting him, really beat myself up over it. I have panic attacks almost every week. But…"

And he pulls on Phainon's shoulder, wordlessly asks him to turn around and face him. "Phainon, it *is* better."

"I don't know," he mutters, "It seems like a lot of effort. I just—I want to go to sleep. Forever."

Mydei hums, "Were you alone when you attempted?"

"Y-yes?"

"So?" Mydei cocks an eyebrow, "What happened? Why are you still alive?"

"I don't understand—"

"You cut your wrists, right? That's a slow way to go, you probably didn't know that, but you realized when you did it, right? And it gave you time to think. What did you think of then?"

"I was laying in bed," he starts, "And I was feeling very weak. And I started to feel really scared. I couldn't remember why I was doing it. Suddenly, I just thought this is stupid."

"So you called an ambulance."

"…I did."

"The view from halfway down," Mydei says, absentmindedly, before he can catch himself.

"What?"

"It's err—it's from *Bojack Horseman*. A monologue from a character that killed himself by jumping off of a bridge. It's a real poem he's reciting, I think, and it's—this is stupid, sorry, but it's really good—it's about a man who, well, jumps off of a bridge. But as he stars to fall, he looks down at the view below and becomes scared and panicked. He wishes he could take it back. The view from halfway down."

"Ah," Phainon shifts to look at the ceiling, "Yeah, something like that."

"Some people fall and they don't make it, and I think some people fall in the water and they do make it. And then they're just in the water. And they have to swim back and call for help.

And that takes a lot of effort, but you have to do it, because Phainon, I really don't think you want to drown."

Phainon chews on his lip. "…No, I guess not," he whispers, "Look, I'll—I'll think about it. Seriously this time. I'll actually think about it."

"That's good," Mydei says, "That's enough."

More silence.

"What did it? Why'd you get so upset today?" Mydei asks, and Phainon smacks his lips in response.

"It's, uh—My birthday's coming up. Cyrene and I, we're born a day apart, so we always celebrated it together and, you know…"

"It's your first year celebrating without her," Mydei finishes.

"…Yeah," Phainon sighs, "I didn't plan this far ahead. I thought I'd be dead by now."

"But you're not," Mydei points out, "So, what type of cake do you want for your birthday?"

Phainon turns to him and laughs. He cries too, a mix of snot and tears, but there is relief there, and that's what matters. The world—perhaps a bit lighter on his shoulders.

Still heavy, despite everything; but for now, he's alive, and it'll be his birthday.

It's a few days before Phainon's birthday, and they're gearing up to leave for work; him, Phainon, Castorice, Hyacine. Hyacine's car broke down, quite tragically and on the side of the road during a rainy day, so he's also gonna be her personal Uber today.

Mydei is about to open the door to his car and let in the whole Mental Illness and Pronouns Squad (MIPS for short) when he hears someone call for Phainon—when he turns to look, oh, it's Anaxa. The person he had his interview with. They're languidly walking over, not hurrying at all, cane clicking on the pavement, and they have a neatly wrapped package in their arms.

When they come over, they don't acknowledge anybody else *but* Phainon; doesn't even say *'hi'* or anything, they simply thurst the package into Phainon's arms. "There," they say, "Early birthday present for you."

"Oh!" Phainon flushes a bit, "Thank you, Anaxa, that's really thoughtful—"

"It's an antique lamp from the 1920's. It's hand-painted with a gorgeous lampshade—beautiful, really. Hyacine told me you like things like that."

"I do, actually! I want to get into collecting one day!"

"That's nice," Anaxa smiles, "Anyways, here's what I wanted to say—please pay attention. You, too, Castorice."

Mydei cocks an eyebrow and he sees, in the corner of his eye, Hyacine clicking her tongue and bracing herself for… something? Castorice approaches Anaxa obediently, intent on listening.

"Your sister is dead, or is going to die, and you can't do anything about it."

The mood instantly drops like an anchor sinking into the sea—Hyacine covers her face. Phainon's hands stiffen on the present, and Castorice tries to nod and smile; she fails.

"How—"Phainon stammers.

"I have internet too, you know, and we're friends on social media. I've seen your post about her. It's tragic, and I'm sorry for your loss. Here's the thing: there will never be a day you wake up and suddenly, you'll feel *okay* with the fact that your sister is dead. That hole you feel —and the one you're *going* to feel, Castorice— will never be filled. Both of your sisters are older, correct? My sister was older than me. One day, I woke up on my birthday, and I looked in the mirror and I realized—my sister is dead and I am now older than she was. I will never be her little sibling again."

This is bad, Mydei wants to intervene, but Hyacine grabs his wrist to stop him.

"Her name was Diotima and she was everything that was good in the world. She was kind and funny and beautiful. She was an accomplished woman, an academic, sharp as a whip. She had a wonderful husband and a bright future. They were trying for a child. One day, in the morning, she went to the bathroom and had a brain aneurysm. Fell over. Dead on the spot. She was thirty-five years old and the picture of health."

Their voice is stable, but there's a tremble to it. An old wound.

"And it wasn't fair," Anaxa continues, "It wasn't fair because she was ten years older than me and basically *raised* me. We were very poor, you see, and everything I have, everything I am, is because of her. Because of her effort and her love and her support. I was the sickly, disabled kid. I never thought she would die before me, but she did, and I could do nothing about it. I cried and pleaded and lost all faith I had in the world. I was angry at everything, but at myself, mostly. Told myself I didn't spend enough time with her, I didn't love her enough, I didn't thank her enough."

Anaxa shifts their weight, both hands on their cane.

"I wanted to die, I really did. I went down a very dark spiral and I'm ashamed of it; it weakened me. That was unlike myself. Grief does silly things to you and your mind. It makes you weird and mean and spiteful. Last year I turned thirty-six. That was the worst day of my life. I was finally older than her. I drank so much that day I didn't come to work, didn't answer my phone, didn't text back. Ask Hyacine—Aglaea had to come knocking on my door and she pulled me out of it."

"It's true…" Hyacine mutters.

"And by that time, it had been nine years. *Nine years.* I thought I was over it, but I wasn't, and that's the thing about grief—"

Anaxa shuffles a bit closer. Puts their hands on both Phainon's and Castorice's arms.

"It never goes away. It will never *fully* go away, but Phainon, Castorice—it *does* get better. The pain is there, but it's dulled, and most days I don't think about my sister at all. My life goes on as usual, and yet my sister is dead. Now, when I do think about her, I don't feel the despair of *she's dead.* I feel like she's just gone on a vacation very, very far away, and she's waiting for me to join her, whenever that will be. I go on about my life and then I see something that reminds me of her. A skirt. A pair of glasses. She liked elephants, so every time I see an elephant ornament or toy, I think of her. And it's sad. I get very sad, but—"

A small smile. Teary-eyed.

"That sadness, it's because I love her. Grief, I think, is just love. And it's wonderful that I still love her, even when she's dead. I have pictures of her all over my house. I don't pay attention to them most of the time, but when I do—it's bitter, yes, but it's also sweet. *There's my sister,* I think, and one day, I'll see her again. Or maybe I won't and that's all a bunch of bull, but it's still nice that she existed, though I wish she existed for longer. I think that matters. That she existed, and that there was love. And that the love is still there."

They step back.

"The wound of her loss is still there but it's closed up. It's healed. It hurts when touched but doesn't hurt at all most of the time, and even when it *does* hurt—it's bearable. And I think our sisters are worth bearing the pain of grieving them. Loss is just part of life. You can't prevent it. It doesn't discriminate, and it won't skip your loved ones over just because they're *your* loved ones. There's no use to think about *'what if'*. There is no such thing as *what if*; it's self-deprecating flogging, because humans are addicted to feeling bad. So, make peace with the thought. Accept the fact that you will never not be sad about your sister dying, and then move on. Time will wash it over. Your life won't be normal for a long time and then, inevitably, it will be normal again. Some days will be good. Some days will be bad. Most days will be just *fine*, and you will learn to grow around the hole they leave behind."

Nobody speaks. Phainon is stiff as a board and Mydei can't read him at all. Castorice is hanging onto his arm, equally as stoic; uncharacteristic for the both of them. Mydei looks between the two and Anaxa. Their face is red and there are tears in the corner of their eyes. Still, they smile. They take a deep breath and clutch their cane, "Well, that's all I wanted to say. Happy birthday, Phainon."

Phainon takes a step towards them. "D-do you want to come to my birthday party?"

Anaxa laughs. "No, I really don't, that's fine. I'd rather stay home. But I hope you enjoy your gift."

"I'll enjoy it," Phainon says, and then lower, "Both of them. Thank you for… telling me all of this."

"Thank you for listening to me," Anaxa says, "I've been thinking about it for a long time. And I'll take any chance I can to speak about Diotima. It keeps her present," they turn to look at Castorice, "Castorice, take care, okay? I'm leaving now."

And as soon as they came, like a wisp of silk—Anaxa is gone.

Nobody moves, except for Hyacine who lights up a cigarette. The sun is shining and the birds are singing. There is a tree above them that sends down a cool shade. It's a beautiful day. Somewhere next to him, a sob, and Mydei thinks it's Phainon at first but instead—Castorice.

She's weeping silently and prettily into her hands. Her shoulders are shaking.

"Cas…" Phainon whispers, rubbing her back, "Don't be sad…"

"I'm not sad," she says, shaky, "I'm not, really, I'm—I don't really know what I am, but I'm not *sad.* I don't feel bad, I feel—I don't know…"

"Relieved?" Hyacine pipes up.

"…Yeah. Yeah, something like relief, it's just—" Mydei offers her a napkin, "Oh, thank you, Mydei," she blows her nose on it, "It's good to hear, um, that it won't feel bad forever. That it will feel better and, maybe, sometimes, it'll feel bad, but it's… Maybe okay that it feels bad sometimes."

She goes to sit back down on the bench. Phainon follows, and Mydei and Hyacine are in tow.

"But I don't know, it kind of feels like, not real. A loss like that… I'm scared, I guess. I know I should be brave, but I'm scared."

Mydei feels the need to say something, so he does.

"Anaxa is right, uh…" he starts, "You don't know this, but… Tch. This is a bit hard."

"It's okay," Phainon says, "You don't have to."

"I want to. In 2009, my father murdered my mother. He tried to kill me, too, but I got away. My dad has always been physically abusive, both to me but especially to her, but… A few months earlier, he lost his job. He got sacked, you know, and he didn't want to be the bum unemployed husband. He was a traditional man. Wanted to be the provider. So he didn't tell anyone and we lived off of our savings, which weren't a lot, and my mom's paycheck. We had no idea."

He sits down next to Castorice. "When the savings ran out, he… thought the world was over. I guess he couldn't bear the shame. It's typical family annihilator modus operandi. One small hurdle and he decided to take out the entire lot. I got away, um, I ran to get help. She told me to, and I ran a few blocks away where my uncle lived—her younger brother. I still don't know why I did that instead of just going to a neighbor. I feel guilty about it. It took too long for

help to arrive and, when police entered the house, she was already dead on the floor. He strangled her and smashed her head on the tile, then ran off."

"Mydei," Castorice gasps, "That's terrible—that's horrifying!"

"Yeah, it is. It's awful. It's still so fucking awful and I still can't believe it actually happened. It's the type of shit you see on TV. And I was nine years old and I couldn't have done anything about it. I wasn't strong enough. Still, though, what Anaxa said—it's true. I don't think about it often anymore. It affects my everyday life in numerous ways and it's given me more mental illnesses than I can count, but when I think about it, I'm sad, but… I don't despair anymore. I don't feel *as* guilty. I understand that it wasn't my fault and I was just a kid. Tragedies just happen sometimes. It sucks. Time really is a miraculous bitch," he sighs, "Mom died to save me. I owe it to her, to at least *try.* Her name was Gorgo.″

Hyacine takes a drag out of her cigarette, "This isn't the same at all, Mydei, but when my grandma died, I thought the world was going to end. And then it just *didn't.* Her name was Jacyntha."

They all look at Phainon and he bristles where he's sitting. "I don't, I can't—"

"That's fine," Castorice says, and leans over to touch his hand, "You don't have to. But Phainon, I'm going to be very honest now, okay?"

She takes a deep breath and steels herself.

"I want you to tell me why Cipher has the keys to your place. And I don't want you to lie anymore, because—sometimes I feel excluded, and it makes me feel like there's something wrong with me. You were always so… into each other, I don't know how to explain it, and sometimes I felt like I was on the periphery of *your* friendship. And I don't want to feel like that anymore. And maybe it's not my business, but fuck it, I want to know. I feel like it's a burden and I want to share it."

"Castorice, look—"

She squeezes his hand tighter. "Phainon, *please.* Please. I can't bear to see you like this anymore. Just put it down. Some of it, at least. I don't care if I'm forcing you. Lay the damn thing to rest. It's clearly affecting both you and Cipher, and it's making *me* feel like shit too."

'Cipher has the keys to his house?' Mydei thinks and, yeah, that's pretty damn weird. Now his curiosity is piqued.

Phainon bends forward with his elbows on his thighs. He groans and mutters something to himself and runs his hands down his face.

"Alright," he says, "Here it is—"

(It was a good day with her cats and her wine. Late into the night. The sort of peaceful day you dream of, and then her phone rang.

It was the hospital. The kid from work, Phainon, attempted suicide. Slit his wrists and was bleeding out when they found him. He begged them not to call his parents, but they still had to let someone know, and she was the most recent contact in his phone. So, they called her, and thus placed a burden she was more than ready to bear on her back.

Cipher rushed to the hospital in a frenzy. They haven't known each other for long, but they were friends, and Cipher is nothing if not there for her pack. He had to get stitches and lost a considerable amount of blood so he needed a transfusion, but he was stable and not in a critical condition. When she came to his hospital room, he was mostly just embarrassed. Couldn't even look her in the eye.

He had one simple request; the EMTs left his door unlocked and if she could please go and lock it, because he's gonna be away from home for a while. Cipher, of course, laughed and said yes. She even ruffled his hair a little bit on her way out.

When she got there, she found a murder scene. She could track Phainon's movements by the blood left behind. After doing the deed, he walked out of the bathroom and towards the kitchen, then trailed back to his bedroom. There, she found a half-drank cup of coffee and a cigarette butt. The dude made himself a coffee while he was bleeding out, then he laid in bed and simply stayed there; he probably called the ambulance at that point.

The keys were on the counter, exactly where he said they would be. Cipher could've grabbed them, locked the door, and go about her life.

But that whole place? That wasn't livable. Blood aside, it was filthy and crawling with roaches. That wasn't a home, it was a slaughterhouse. It was a breeding ground for more suicide attempts. It wasn't homely and welcoming, it was hostile. And Cipher—Cipher knows hostility. She knows filth and parents too strung up on all kinds of drugs to cook and clean for her. She knows squalor and misery and she doesn't wish them upon anyone else.

This isn't her first fucking rodeo. Being an on and off drug addict since she was sixteen places you with interesting entourages. People die. Often. They kill themselves or they OD or they go to get more drugs and they never come back. They go to jail and she never hears from them again. Sometimes, they get clean. One day, maybe, she will too. For good. Point is: Cipher cannot bear another loss. She cannot bear another dead friend, not when there's something tangible she can do.

She goes out and buys cleaning supplies, the strong shit. Garbage sacks. Thick yellow gloves made out of rubber and latex and a fucking medical grade face mask, because Cipher knows, from many years of experience, that you don't fuck with blood. She texts Hyacine to pet-sit for her for a while. It's an emergency, she tells her, and when Hyacine presses further, she tells her to mind her business and that it's categorically NOT drugs.

It takes an entire day. The blood is cleaned first. Most of it is in the bathtub, but he's made a mess of the entire place. That part is the hardest. Cipher has a weak stomach, so she has to stop and throw up a lot. In the dim, flickering yellow light of Phainon's bathroom, she swears his blood glows gold as it goes down the drain. Wherever she looks—death. Looming and oppressing. She cries a lot during this part. Pain and fear and deep understanding. She's doing this for Phainon, Cipher tells herself, but she's also doing it for herself; a much needed

feeling of 'being good', of 'doing good'. Not being a fuck-up for once. She scrubs until every single red blood cell is gone, and then goes over it with bleach just to make sure. Wipes every single trace of sorrow from this house until it is squeaky clean.

There's a big red patch on his mattress. The entire thing is ruined and his landlord is gonna kill him—but Cipher has an ace up her sleeve, called "turn the thing over".

It's heavy. It's as heavy as she is, if not heavier, and it's hard. It's hard to flip it over just by herself. But Cipher can do it. She wants to do it. She has to do it, for Phainon's sake, and so she takes off her shirt and opens the window and starts battling with the mattress. It takes her twenty minutes—with a small break— and by the end her thighs are shaking and her muscles are aching. She collapses on it. The rest can be done tomorrow. She takes the day off.

She wakes up to a cockroach on her leg at the crack of dawn, and then it's back to work. Vacuuming, sweeping, mopping. Cleaning the windows. Washing the dishes. Getting in-between the hard to reach corners. Throwing the spoiled food out of his fridge. On her own, it's a herculean task, but she does it, goddamn it.

Cifera fucking does it and when she's done, it's 2 AM. There are owls hooting outside. She stands in the living room and looks over her good work;

This. This is a house worth coming back to. This is a house one might find love in, and peace, and happiness. Clean and smelling of lemon, a house that loves you back and takes care of you—and just for good measure, she goes grocery shopping for him. She can't afford it, she hasn't shopped for herself either, but she—

She wants to set him up for success. And even if he can't do it, can't keep it up, that's fine, because Cipher will come back and do it ten million more times until she's burned away to ashes. Her well being is inconsequential; she wants to leave something worth being proud of behind.

This—this is worth being proud of. When Phainon comes home from suicide watch, he cries in her arms and she holds him. He is so thankful, and Cipher only cracks some jokes about it to make him laugh.

A few weeks later, he gives her a copy of his keys—just in case.

'Yes,' she thinks as she gladly takes them, 'Of course. Just in case.')

Castorice shuffles her feet and speaks up first.

"That… was very kind of her."

"It was," Phainon says, voice raw, "It was very kind of her."

She looks at him, "I had no idea you attempted, Phainon. I'm really sorry. I know how it is, really, I do. And—I apologize if I strong-armed you into telling us this. I… didn't think it was… That."

"It's okay," he says, and lays his head on her shoulder. He's exhausted. "It feels better. Now that I've said it. I-it really does, that's weird, I feel—" he sighs, "I feel *fine*. I feel good, even."

Hyacine crushes the cigarette butt under her heel. "So it really *wasn't* drugs!" she exclaims, "Son of a bitch, I was convinced she went on a bender."

That makes Phainon laugh, and Mydei feels impossibly tired. Impossibly glad.

"Can we go home now?" Mydei asks.

"Yeah," Hyacine starts walking towards the car, and the rest follow.

'Home,' Mydei thinks as he opens the door to Phainon's apartment. Inviting and lovely, and one that he would like to stay in.

Phainon's—and Cyrene's—birthday comes and goes without much fanfare—which is surprising, considering that it's his first without his sister.

He is sad, of course. He cries a lot these two days. Mydei holds his hand while he does and admires how well they slot against each other, how the empty gaps between Phainon's fingers seem fit to house Mydei's. How gorgeous and pretty his knuckles are. In the morning, Mydei kisses his hand. In the afternoon, he washes his hair. And in the evening, he bakes him a chocolate cake.

Phainon specifically asked for a small celebration. He's tired and depressed and there's only so much he can handle before he breaks down. Hyacine, Castorice and Polyxia come over with gifts. Aglaea sends a gift through Hyacine, a beautifully tailored pair of trousers, and funnily enough, Tribios does the same thing—she sends a gorgeous leather bag and a drawing from her little daughters of them playing with Uncle Phainon. Hyacine gets him a heavy bronze statue of a woman with wings, and Castorice gets him a big white puppy plushie. Mydei notices her slipping some paper to Phainon as well, all sneaky, but he doesn't question them further about it.

(Polyester 🦋🪻

I finished your gift, by the way. But I don't know how to give it to you without Mydei noticing. It's a pretty big print.

Phainon

is it me and mydei making out sloppy style?

Polyester 🦋🪻

Hell yeah it is.

Phainon

lmfaoo

have castorice sneak it to me when he's not watching

i'll sleep with it under my pillow

Polyester 🦋 💜

LoL)

Phainon insisted that Mydei didn't get him anything. *"You're baking the cake,"* he said, *"And you—well. You're enough of a gift as is."* What a hopeless romantic, and yet not brave enough to do anything about it—still, it made Mydei blush prettily.

They eat junk food —to Mydei's dismay, but it's Phainon's birthday and that's what he wanted — and play board games and Cards Against Humanity. Polyxia beats them at everything. Then, they sing him *'happy birthday'* and cut the cake while Phainon preens like a bird of paradise. A photo of Cyrene, splendid and pink, is on the table while they eat. Phainon gazes over at it longingly from time to time, but he holds it together. Mydei is proud—he's going to let him know after everyone else goes home.

Castorice and Polyxia leave first, because Polyxia is getting tired and she wants to go to bed. Phainon kisses Castorice on each cheek, then leans down to do the same for Polyxia. Then he pulls them into an awkward half-hug. Then they are gone, and Hyacine hangs out for a little while longer.

"Oh, wait, that reminds me—Cipher got you a gift, Phainon."

Phainon blinks in surprise, mouth agape. "She…did?"

"Of course she did. She was crushed that she couldn't come. She, uhh, wants me to keep this a secret but… it's—you'd want to know. She got you a new mattress."

"A new—" Phainon nearly chokes on his drink, "A new mattress?! Is she crazy? That's expensive!"

"She saved up for it since your attempt. Said she doesn't want you to get in trouble with your landlord."

"Hyacine, that's ridiculous. I can't accept that."

"Yeah, well," Hyacine shrugs, "It's coming tomorrow, and you *will* accept it. For Cipher's sake."

Phainon's anxiety spikes, Mydei can tell that. He feels like a burden. Underneath it all, though—warmth. Happiness. A sense of ease that says, *'Cipher still loves me. She wants to be part of my life.'* What a silly fool he is. There is so much to love about Phainon.

"Oh, by the way—" Hyacine says a couple of hours later, as she's walking towards the door. "Mydei, Phainon, I want you in a video for my TikTok. Mydei, I have a beautiful dress your size. Phainon—I have a propeller hat and a big lollipop prop for you. This is non-negotiable. It's happening. Handsome men skyrocket engagement."

Mydei laughs so hard at that he keels over. Phainon is scandalized. "I'm sorry—" he starts, "Let me see if I got it right. *Mydeimos* gets a pretty dress, and I get the propeller hat?!"

"And a little boy sailor suit. C'mon, it'll be funny. You kinda have one of those faces."

Mydei is crying—what a sight! He can't wait!

"One of those—*one of those faces?!"* Phainon tries to feign offense, but he's laughing as well. "Jesus, Hyacine, are you serious?"

"Yep. Now walk me to my Uber."

They do.

The night is beautiful and they watch Hyacine drive off into the darkness. It's chilly, and Mydei purposefully didn't bring a jacket so that he could have an excuse to bundle up to Phainon. He laughs at that, and brings his arm over his shoulder.

"Let's take a walk," Phainon says and doesn't even give Mydei the chance to respond. He drags him along, moves to intertwine their fingers, and swings their hands as they walk. At one point, Mydei lags behind, and he catches a glimpse of the back of Phainon's head—and he thinks, dumbly, drunk on life, that he would love to spend his entire life watching the back of his head. Just that would be nourishment enough.

They stop by an unsuspecting alleyway, and Phainon takes out a cigarette. Mydei watches him with crossed arms.

"Look at you," he says, smiling, teasing, "You survived it. And you only cried three times today."

"And seven times yesterday," Phainon adds, shit-eating grin and all.

"Yeah, I know, I was there."

Phainon's face softens into something incredibly loving. "I know. Thank you for being there."

"Hmph. Of course. I can't trust you to take care of yourself anymore," and Phainon laughs, a sound as beautiful as the ringing of clear bells, his eyes crinkling with it. He comes closer.

"I can't," he confesses, "I really can't."

Closer still. He backs Mydei into a wall, and Mydei goes willingly. Warmth spreads in his chest, something like joy, and he touches Phainon's arm.

"Mydeimos…" Phainon whispers, the sound rich with yearning, "What are we doing? What is this?"

Mydei cocks a proud and defiant eyebrow. "I don't know, Phainon—*what is it?"*

What are we?

A battle is fought across Phainon's lovely feature. A furrow of the brow there, a grimace here. He grits his teeth and clenches his neck. *'Let go,'* Mydei wants to say, hopeful, hoping, *'Say it.'*

Uncertainty across his face, dancing like a ballerina, twisting and turning, plié-relevé-arabesque. He tenses up. Clenches harder and nearly drops his cigarette. He looks away, shy, a blush dusting his cheeks. Mydei rubs his arm. Encourages him, without speaking, to stop fighting with it. Stop fighting with himself. Allow yourself this; a simple joy of life. Wars have been fought over it, men have died, women, too—and still, despite it all, at the crossroad of every person's heart sits *this.* This one thing, small yet colossal.

Love, as the poets have called it.

The beginning and end of life, and the threads that weaves it all together. Phainon steps back, turns around. Smokes. Then turns back to Mydei.

When he speaks, his voice is raw. "Mydei," he starts, and Mydei's heart soars; with expectation, with fear. Suddenly, it's becoming a bit too real. He's always been bad at taking his own advice. The need to run is overwhelming.

But Phainon grounds him in place. "I've been thinking—these past weeks—together, it has been so… I've been very happy, and I know I shouldn't *count* on it and that I'll feel—I'll feel bad, eventually, and I really don't want to get used to it, um—being happy, that is, but I've been thinking and I was wondering…"

Be brave.

Don't be.

"Would you… like… to be my… um…" he looks like he's about to cry. His eyes are big and blue and so much like a puppy's, shining with tears, the perfect painting of a clear, crystalline lake. "My… uhh... *Boyfriend?*"

Mydei expected it—he's wanted it, even. He's wanted it like he wants food, like he wants water and a safe haven.

He has it now, and he doesn't know what to do with it; he hadn't thought so far.

He wants to. He wants to so bad. He's been so brave for so long, yet now finds himself disarmed under Phainon's loving gaze. He wants so many things, he wants to grab him and kiss him and fuck him, he wants a warm home and a happy marriage. All Mydei has ever done in his life is *want,* and all he ever got was *misery*.

He tries to steel himself, to restrain himself. His head swarms with questions; what if it's bad, what if it doesn't last, what if Phainon hurts him, what if he hurts Phainon, what if they're bad for each other. Doubt gnaws at him like flesh-eating beetles. He leans closer into the wall with a soft gasp, an *'oh'*, and his eyes are blown out like dinner plates. His hands start to shake, and he is nine years old and very afraid, and he is twenty-two and very afraid; the world is scary and he has to live in it.

Phainon grabs his hand. It's a gentle contact, his thumb over Mydei's knuckle, and yet it sets his nerves ablaze. Everything that he ever was, is, and will be is reduced to this point. Decision is imperative; yes or no.

His answer is so quiet that Phainon asks him to repeat himself. Mydei swallows and says again, louder this time:

"Yes."

He gives in to his wants, and if he will regret it later on, then that will be for Future Mydei to worry about; Present Mydei is busy drowning in this strange feeling that turns his legs to jelly.

"Oh," Phainon says, surprised, jaw slack. And then—laughter, spilling over like ambrosia. "I didn't think—I didn't think you'd say yes, oh, oh wow—"

"Haikas," Mydei reprimands, "Why did you think I would say no?"

"I don't know, it—" Phainon presses closer until their bodies are flush against each other. He speaks very hushed now, the whisper of a whisper, "It doesn't seem real."

"No… It doesn't, does it?"

Phainon chews his bottom lip. His hands are anxious to touch, and so his arms come to wrap around his waist, to pull him closer—the only way they could be closer now is if they became the same person. Merged into one being, glorious and beautiful and entirely *them.* This fucked up little thing they have.

Phainon glows in the moonlight, his head crowned by the moon like a silver halo. He's impossibly comely, like a fairytale prince come true. There is a stray eyelash on his cheek. Mydei picks it up and holds it up for him. "Make a wish," he says, and Phainon closes his eyes for a second. Then opens them and blows the eyelash away.

"Do you want to know what I wished for?" he asks, and Mydei scoffs at that.

"You're not supposed to tell. If you do, it won't come true anymore."

"I think it already has," Phainon whispers, "I wished for *you."*

He leans in closer, cradles Mydei's jaw, and lets his eyes fall closed. It takes a split second for Mydei to understand—then, panic like a drill siren, pounding in his head. He ducks and gets out a desperate *"No!"* before he covers Phainon's mouth with his hand.

Phainon looks at him, perplexed.

"No kissing, remember?" Mydei says, titling his head and freeing Phainon's treacherous mouth.

"Oh… Right, I'm sorry, I forgot—I'm really sorry, Mydei…"

"It's alright," Mydei smiles, tries to reassure him, "But really, no kissing. Let's just… let's take it a bit slower."

"Slower…" Phainon echoes, "I can do slower."

A blanket of silence. Comfortable and warm. Mydei's hand on Phainon's reddened cheek, stroking it with his thumb.

"Though… Can I kiss you on the cheek?"

"On the cheek?" Mydei blinks, then blushes, then chuckles, "Sure. *Yes.*"

And so Phainon cradles his head again, tilts it up, and places a small, warm kiss on his cheek.

"Can I kiss your forehead?"

"Yes."

Butterfly wings, gentle, there on the middle of his forehead. Phainon's kind hands on his heated face.

"Can I kiss your jaw?"

"Yes."

And here it goes again, like the sweetest drug, intoxicating and filling his lungs.

"Can I kiss your nose?"

"Yes."

Phainon smells so good. His perfume tonight is citrus-y and breezy. Mydei grabs fistfuls of his shirt. His mouth tickles the bridge of his nose.

"Can I kiss your eyes?"

"Yes."

'This cannot be real,' Mydei thinks. It must be one of those dreams where everything is just a little too good to be true. Phainon smooths his eyes closed with his thumb, touches his brow, and brings his delicate lips to them. He lingers on each eye, first the left and then the right, and caresses his eyelashes with his lips. Mydei could cry. His hands find purchase on the nape of his neck, tangling along the fine, sensitive hairs there.

When he opens his eyes, he finds Phainon staring down at him. The entire starry sky is in his gaze, and his smile is shy and small. They are so close, and Mydei wonders if the world still exists outside of *this,* outside of *them.*

"I'm very fond of you, Mydei, and you're very beautiful tonight."

Mydei puts his hand over his. "I'm very fond of you, too."

Chapter End Notes

hello! if you enjoyed please leave a comment~

over the past month, i've noticed that my fic got posted on twitter a few times, and i am very very thankful. im so happy that its reached so many people. i couldve never imagined! its a little scary, honestly, but im doing my best, and i hope you enjoy reading it.

Chapter 10: no kissing

Chapter Notes

Well. Hi. I promise I haven't forgotten about this, but I got busy writing 53k words for the Phaidei Secret Santa event, which you can read here . It's a Frankenstein AU and it's pretty damn good if I do say so myself. Please read it!

We hit 10k views while I was off going crazy over Frankenstein and I am both so proud and so touched. I never thought people would read my silly little fic ever, let alone over 10k people. Honestly, I probably wouldn't have gotten this far if it weren't for your guys' support. It really is all the nice comments and messages that make me want to write more and actually finish this. I haven't written so much for a single piece since I was 15, seriously, and the last time I wrote something was back in 2024, a fic that I never finished. I took a big break from writing before starting this and to this day I don't know what pushed me to start it. Phaidei witchcraft I guess. I feel like you can really read how much I improved my writing during this fic and I'm really proud of myself for sticking with it. Mostly I'm just honored and grateful that my fic has touched so many people and I hope that I continue to deliver the best I can for everyone.

!IMPORTANT

This chapter is Mydei-centric so it comes with a big **SA and CHILD ABUSE TW** as well as a smaller **SUICIDE TW.** Specifics below vvv

▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They walk back home hand in hand, and in silence.

It was beautiful, too beautiful. The night sky above them, painted with shining dots of light, seems as though drawn by the hand of an impressionist; blurry and unconceivable, romantic, yes, but ultimately not real. When they look up at that dark blue welkin, they both find it entirely too starry considering Okhema's air pollution levels. '*Must be a trick of the eye'*, one of them thinks, though it is impossible to tell who.

The realization of what just happened sets into their backs like spears. It sits on the precipice of *too much* and *too little,* which is shaping up to be the central theme of their life; longing for something too out of reach, breaking your legs to get it and, when it is finally in the palm of your hands, discarding it and running far away. It's a clever little paradox, and if there were still philosophers worth their name around, they might enjoy debating over this night. However, with no philosophers around, they are left fearful like two children wading through the dark, blind and seeing only with their hands.

Even so, hands are still held, tightly grasped between sweaty fingers. Once in a while, on their short trek home that now seems to span thousands of miles, one will throw the other a shy little look; the other while catch it and return it, and they will both smile and flush. If they are to fall, well, they might as well fall together—their grip on each other tightens, only a little bit.

Woe, two unlovable creatures, the chorus sang as such, *and behold, how lovely they still are.*

"I was thinking, uh," Phainon says as he opens the door, "What would you like me to call you?"

Mydei cocks his head and frowns. Phainon's been calling him correctly just fine until now? "Uh, you can call me Mydei, or Mydeimos."

"No, no, I mean—" Phainon takes off his jacket and hangs it, "I mean like, now that we're, erm… Together… What would you like me to call you? My boyfriend? My partner?"

He considers it—*boyfriend* is good enough, but it's wholly unromantic and has no drama or tragedy to it—Mydei has a bachelor's in Classics and has studied ancient history at *length*, so what's the point if there's no blood and sweat and open wounds? He's been called *boyfriend* by all of his exes, and look how that turned out. *Partner* is downright egregious. It's sanitized and unaffectionate; what, are they doing business together?

Mydei mulls it over in his head, and makes a show out of "hmmmm"ing and rubbing his chin. Just to be a dick.

"Well—" he starts, and Phainon perks up, "You can call me *boyfriend* when we're around others, but when we're alone, Phainon…"

—And Mydei presses very close to him, close enough to feel the breath escaping from him, trapping him against his body and the wall. Phainon gasps in surprise, a soft and darling sound, mouth opening almost as if by instinct. His eyes glaze over instantly, the heat rises to his cheeks, and in the blink of an eye, he's lovely-red like a ripe apple.

Mydei knows he's beautiful, that much he's certain of; it's kind of impossible to *not* be aware of it, not when a two thousand year old statue of Nikador is the fitness goal he's been working towards for most of his adult life. Point is, Mydei knows how to use it to his advantage, and bullying Phainon is a constitutional right of his; so he does what he knows works very well. Mydei bats his eyelashes and tilts his chin down, gazing up at his through his lashes with that smoldering golden look of his, and he rises his shoulder coyly *just* a little bit. If he could blush on command he would—alas, this will have to do.

"Phainon…" he says, low in his throat, wringing his braid around his finger, "When we are alone, I would very much like it if you called me your *lover."*

His prize for this performance is as such; Phainon whimpering and blushing an even deeper shade of red, his mouth pursing and twisting, his eyes getting all big and crazy. Mydei can

practically see him go cross-eyed and see the steam coming out of his ears. Phainon shoves his hands in his pocket and looks away for a moment.

"L—yeah, man, yeah, sure, that's cool, whatever, I'll do whatever y—Yeah no, yeah like no yeah, for sure, anything you want—*Lover?* Yeah, that's cool, I like—I like that."

Delightful. Mydei laughs and shoves his shoulder—Phainon just pouts. "Asshole, you're fucking with me!" He shoves Mydei back, and it makes him laugh harder.

They're standing in the hallway and their shoes at still on. Mydei feels impossibly warm on this October night. He tilts his head. "I am serious, though. I'd like if you called me *lover.* I think it's very romantic."

Phainon huffs a small breath. An incredulous laugh. "You sound like Cyrene sometimes. She liked stuff like that."

His eyes widen a bit—it's the first time he's really talked *about* her. "What stuff?"

"Romance and…" Phainon gestures vaguely, "Kind, beautiful things. When she was younger, she—Ah, nevermind."

"No," Mydei steps towards him, "I'd like to know."

"She would write a lot when she was young. Lots of fairytales and poems. They were beautiful, but she stopped one day."

"Why?"

"I don't know," he shrugs, "It was a gradual thing. She wanted to go to college for literature, but then decided to go into finance instead. Maybe she thought a future in writing wasn't possible? Then she started saying it's a silly thing for kids. She wanted to be a model for a while, though. She was very beautiful, but she had a hard time, I guess, because she was uhh… too old."

Mydei frowns. "How old was she?"

"Two years older than me."

"That's fucked up. She wasn't even thirty."

"No," Phainon sighs, "And she never will be. But she had a love for fashion and clothes and pretty pink things. She said she wanted a big platform so she could do some good things in the world. Have a bigger reach. She was a very popular girl, kind of a small-time influencer. She'd have these flights of fancy sometimes, about a life out of a fairytale, where money was never an issue. She'd talk about stained glass windows in the kitchen and a great big garden of flowers," he looks away, "I don't think she liked finance very much, though I don't know why she didn't just go back into writing. Nor do I know where this model thing came from. She was always a contradiction," he clicks his tongue, "I should've mentioned it to Aglaea, fuck. She would've loved to have a girl like Cyrene at her family's fashion house."

"I don't know her, but somehow…" Mydei tilts his head, "I don't think she would've liked that."

"Ha! No, she wouldn't have, I think. She wanted to be self-made and she was stubborn like a bull."

"Ah, so it runs in the family."

"What? I'm not stubborn at all!"

Mydei laughs, "You are, sometimes."

Phainon doesn't reply, instead grabs his hand, shy, and pulls him into the living room. He settles into the couch and pats the space next to him—naturally, Mydei takes it.

"So, I was thinking—"

"You've been thinking a lot today," Mydei grins, shit-eating, and it makes Phainon groan.

"Yeah, man, it's been a long day and a lot happened. We have some kinks to iron out."

He cocks an eyebrow, inquisitive, and gestures for Phainon to continue.

"So, right, you're my boyfriend when we're with others, and my l… Uh, my lover when we're alone," Mydei can't help but smirk at how flustered Phainon is, "But, what about pet names? Are you into those?"

This does stump him a little bit. *Is* he? He's always found them terribly romantic, ever since he first got his hands on his mom's bodice-rippers when he was ten, but… He's never liked it when his previous boyfriends called him *'babe'* or *'baby'*. It always made his skin crawl, like they were trying to forcefully bully their way under it. It was too close and impersonal at the same time. Like a bad play he was forced to be the face of. Frankly, it was just a little bit gross. Bland and fake. He likes a certain type of pet names, but they are embarrassing.

Phainon, though… he does seem like a '*baby'* type, but also a *'beloved'* type. A *'my love'* type or a *'sweetheart'* type. He blinks at him. Phainon blinks back and is seemingly starting to get embarrassed at Mydei's silence—he opens his mouth to backtrack, so Mydei has to speak up before Phainon spooks.

"I like pet names," he says, not sure how true that is, "We can do pet names."

"Oh, that's great!" Relief is evident on Phainon's face. "I was thinking—"

"The thinker…"

"Shut up. I was thinking we can each take like five minutes and write down some pet names we like being called? And we can read it to each other and like… Talk about it."

Mydei shrugs. "Okay. That sounds good."

"Yeah?"

"Mhm. Yeah."

They spend the next five minutes typing away on their phones. Mydei spots Phainon stopping to wipe the sweat from his brow at least twice, which is just *crazy* because these are *just* pet names.

"I'm done," he announces when the time is up—five minutes on the clock. He counted.

Phainon looks up at him. "Okay, nice. I'll start. Um, I like *dear* a lot. Like just *dear* or *my dear.* Your turn."

"I like *dear* too."

"You have to say another one, dude, those are the rules!"

Mydei scoffs. "*Rules.* Fine. I like *darling."*

"That's in the same vein as *dear*, though."

"No, it's not."

"Yes, it is."

"It's not and that's final. Your turn."

"Whatever. Uhh… I like *honey."*

"Honey? What, are you a husband from the fifties?" Mydei teases, and Phainon huffs incredulously at it.

"Dude, don't make fun of me, we're being vulnerable."

"Hm, are we?" Mydei cocks his head and gives him that smile he knows absolutely *disarms* him. A little sharp and wolfish and hungry. Phainon like his snaggleteeth so he puts them on full display. His lion's fangs, Hephaestion calls them. Phainon loses his breath so fast it's almost funny; he is so easy to blush, too, and he turns pretty pink all the way down to his chest. It's past midnight now, so not his birthday anymore—this means Mydei can tease him all he wants. He reaches his hand over and delights in the way Phainon searches his touch, already looking to nuzzle his cheek into his palm. Mydei denies him the satisfaction, and instead swipes his thumb across his sweaty forehead. He brings it to his lips and gives it a lick.

It's sweaty and disgusting, but the look on Phainon's face is worth it. Lips parted, cheeks flushed, eyes wide and pupils blown; he looks absolutely ruined.

"What the fuck is wrong with you?" Phainon's voice is raw as if he's thrown it apart. Mydei laughs at him. "That's yucky!" he continues, and Mydei laughs at him harder. "Let's just go back to the pet names please. It's your turn."

"Right," Mydei looks down at his phone, "I do like *honey* by the way. It's sweet. Ah, there, I also like *sweetling."*

"Sweetling…" Phainon echoes, "Okay. I like *love* and *my love."*

"Heart."

"Pet."

"The Lance of Fury."

Phainon sputters. "What?"

Mydei keeps reading. "The Sovereign of All Battles. Grand Artisan of the War Chariot. General that all the world shall heed. The Eternal Sharp Sword. The Law of Strife. Greatest of Conquerors, Greatest of Guardians, The Strong—"

Phainon does not laugh. Instead, he just stares blankly at Mydei, and then shoves him. "Take this seriously." he whines.

"I am." Mydei shoves back, and then it becomes a whole *thing*—next thing he knows, he's got Phainon pinned to the couch, arm on his throat. Phainon chokes and waves his hand around. "I yield, I yield!"

Mydei lets him go with a triumphant laugh.

"In all seriousness though," he says, "I like the names you picked. You've got good taste." Phainon grumbles stubbornly at that. "I also like personalized pet names. And you can also call me *'dude'*. And *Mydei*, obviously, you are also allowed to call me that."

Phainon shifts a bit where he is sitting and he simply *watches* Mydei. Eyes a little heavy-linden, lips a little pouty. He rests his cheek on the backrest of the couch, and blinks slowly.

He looks tired, very tired. He looks sad, and a little in love too.

"What's wrong?" Mydei asks, dropping his voice to a whispers.

Phainon sighs. "I'm just worried, y'know. About… us, I guess. About… I don't know. What if I'm not ready for a relationship? I'm kind of a fuck up, I have a dead end job and shitton of debt and I really don't feel like I have much of a future, and like, my mental health is bad—"

"Phainon," Mydei stops him, "I'm not letting you spiral on the first day of our relationship. Look…"

Mydei leans to him, brings his arm to the side of his neck and rests it right over his sun tattoo. Phainon immediately melts into the touch, as if he has been waiting for it the entire night—and how cruel Mydei is to leave his lover to wait so long for a caress! With his thumb, he traces the rays of the sun. His darling boy. Mydei is impossibly fond, and impossibly scared.

He shifts and moves on the couch, closer and close to Phainon until Mydei is sitting on his knees next to him, draped over him, holding his face and forcing him to look up. His long hair falls around their faces like a curtain, making this intimate, making this safe. It is just the two of them; it has always been, perhaps.

"We're only dating, we're not getting married or anything, so you don't have to worry about your job or your debt. It's fine, you'll pay it off one day," Mydei says to him, voice hushed as though it were a secret. "I knew all of these things when I said *yes* to dating you, so clearly they aren't a deterrent, if that's what you're worried about."

He bends down, touching the tips of their noses together. He feels Phainon's hand on his waist. "I have many reasons to like you. I even like you when you're unwell… I especially like you then, I think, because that's the only time you've been honest with me. Phainon, we can be fuck-ups together."

"Together…" Phainon repeats dumbly, and Mydei closes the distance between them.

He kisses Phainon's cheek and his eyelids, the bridge of his nose and his forehead. He kisses him all over his handsome face until he is breathless and giggling and red in the face.

"You worry as well?" Phainon asks, arms now wrapped around Mydei's middle.

"Yeah. I'm worried you'll find me unbearable or… too much. I'm worried that you'll hurt me."

Phainon doesn't answer, nor does he have to. Mydei gives him one last kiss, on the tip of his nose.

They break apart after that. Phainon goes to change the sheets, and Mydei goes to take a shower. He's still toweling his hair dry when he returns to the bedroom, and he sees Phainon in a staring match with his Simba plushie.

"Hey," he calls out, "Leave Simba alone."

Phainon grumbles unhappily.

"What, are you jealous of him?" Mydei grins, and Phainon just puts the little lion away.

After Mydei changes into clean sweatpants, he crawls under the sheets with Phainon. It's toasty and comfortable and they just look at each other for a while. Bartholos scratches at the door, unhappy with being left out, but Mydei cannot—he cannot bear to be around him, still.

Phainon breaks the silence.

"Mydei, I've been wondering, um… If we don't kiss, then what do we do? As a couple?"

—And whatever they have, shatters.

Mydei sits up and pushes the covers aside. Jolts of shame hit him like lightning strikes, quick and electric and spreading through him from his chest to his extremities. A familiar feeling bludgeons him over the head. Shame. He has known it well. Been spoonfed it as a child but

never understood its taste until he was twenty-two. His body is suddenly two sizes too small, too little to house whatever immensity is threaten to burst like a boil out of his stomach. In an instant, he is gone. His eyes glaze over and his tongue is thick in his mouth. It all feels hazy all of a sudden, like a terrible dream. When he looks at Phainon, he sees static.

"Mydei? I'm sorry, did I—"

"Uh…" Mydei manages, and sounds are acrid in his mouth. He understands the telltale signs of *shutting down,* and it makes him all the more ashamed. He wants to kiss Phainon, of course he does. Phainon is nice, sweet, funny and a little stupid. Phainon wouldn't take it too far, he never does. Phainon is good and gentle and not a rapist, and here is the point of tension: he wants to kiss him so badly, needs to kiss him like a hungry wolf needs a lamb. He wants to desperately, selfishly, *but he cannot.* The disconnect is too strong. His nervous system does not match up with his brain does not match up with his heart. He is in a cave, looking at the shadows on the wall, pretending it is love.

Phainon's hand comes to touch his bare shoulder and Mydei slaps it away. The sad little look on his face is enough to break his heart, poor Phainon, his Phainon. Bartholos scratches louder at the door, and the sound becomes unbearable.

"Make it stop," he tells him, but he does not recognize his own voice, "Make it stop!"

The bed creaks when Phainon gets off of it. He distantly hears him lead Bartholos to his food bowl and pour some kibble in.

God, he's broken. He's wrong, all wrong. Mydei looks down at his hands and finds himself unable to count his own fingers. He's going to have a panic attack. He tries to name five things he can see but truly, the only thing he can see right now is that twisted face, dry and cracked as though carved into the bark of an old tree, sweating and gritting its teeth above him.

Kissing—it's just kissing and God, he'd really like to do it too. Would like to wake up like any normal man every morning and not have to take a handful of pills, all carefully picked to make sure he doesn't keel over and die, and lean over to kiss a sleepy Phainon. He would like to push him against a wall and kiss him deep and nasty and, yes, he would also like to kiss him while riding him stupid. All those thoughts disgust him. Desire disgusts him. Why does he feel guilty? It was never his fault.

Why is Mydei unable to live while *he* is out there somewhere, all happy and none the wiser?

Phainon returns and stands in the doorway.

In this lightless night, he looks menacing. Mydei suddenly wonders if he could take him down if Phainon tried to lounge at him—the answer is yes, but he could've taken *him* down back then too, and he didn't.

"Look, Mydei, I'm sorry. That came out wrong, I didn't mean to, uh…" he steps inside and Mydei startles. He steps back. "I didn't mean to sound like it's an accusation or something? I mean like, you know, were a couple, and I thought we should do couple things, you know? I

really worded it badly, I mean, you know, we're lovers now, so I thought some things would… change."

Do they have to? Why do things have to change? Is what they have not good enough?

"No, no, it is. I love what we have now. I'm not disappointed or anything, I mean, I *do* want to kiss you, but it's alright if I don't, really I just like being around you, um, it's just—Look, I'm sorry I asked. I didn't mean to make you feel ba—"

He was kissing him back then and Mydei could feel his sweat on his lips. The tongue in his mouth was a terrible dragon—

"Stop, no, you don't have to tell me. Sorry, I understand, but please don't tell me any more. I can tell it's making you very upset. Listen, I can drive you home, do you want to go home?"

Home? His mother died in his home. He kept a piece of her scalp. It was by the oven. When he was giving his testimony everybody was looking at him. He doesn't want to go home. That's where he killed that small orange cat.

"What?"

His roommates are home. Peucesta said his boyfriend is coming over. That's too many people in one home.

"Do you need to, uh, be alone?"

He needs to be put down.

"Mydei, don't… don't say that. Do you need me to call someone? An ambulance?"

No. They'll institutionalize him again.

"Then, uh… I'll just, I'll sleep in Cyrene's room, okay? And you can sleep here."

He cannot be alone but he cannot be around people either but he does not want to be alone. He wants to be able to be so full of people that his skin can't quite fit all the love they give him. But he cannot be alone. And he cannot be around people. But he wants to be—alone. And around people.

"I'll… just let Bartholos in and I'll sleep in Reney's room. That way you won't be alone, but you won't be around, uh, people either."

He'll kill him.

"You won't. You won't even notice him, he's so good. He'll sleep by your feet, okay?"

Okay.

Phainon calls over the cat and Mydei kind of hears his small feet tapping on the floor. A weight jumps up and settles on the mattress by his feet. Phainon smiles at him, a little

awkward, and comes in to grab his phone.

He's ruined it.

"You haven't," Phainon looks at him, "You haven't. I'm concerned for you, that's all, dear. But I'm still very happy. And I'm very excited."

Mydei does not say anything else—has he been talking?—and Phainon leaves the room. He does not close the door on his way out.

He sits there for a while, blanket pooled at his waist, looking at the door with his mouth agape. He hears Phainon watching TikToks in the other room. Every once in a while, his phone pings a new message. Phainon's sent him a link.

He thinks it must be hours before he lays back down on his heavy back and tries to sleep. Bartholos is purring at his feet and he dislikes the sound, but he does not try to kill him, either. He reaches over and grabs Simba. Pulls him tight to his chest.

In his dream that night, Mydei is wandering the halls of his childhood home and he is naked. It is morning and the wooden floor of his living room is stained with blood. Light bathes him from every window, of which there is one on every wall. On the floor, there is a small, shiny black spike. He watches it with curiosity. He cannot tell what it is.

It rattles and stands up. Grows larger until it is much bigger that Mydeimos. He looks up at it. He is scared but he does not run. He is frozen. The spike breaks off into a hundred shards, sharp like onyx arrowheads. They are spear-tall and obelisk-thick and they try to force their way inside his mouth but he clenches his jaw and grits his teeth. It does not matter. They hit him and stab him until they break his teeth and they rattle like fractured pearls. Blood comes like a waterfall, and then they are down his throat and in his stomach, and they groove and sway and squirm inside him, poking him in all his bits, shaping him and deforming him while he is writhing on the floor. He does not scream nor does he try to claw at them. It is futile. They are already inside. When they settle, the pain dulls, but he knows they are still there and he knows he will have to carry them.

Phainon finds Mydei the next morning naked and standing to look out the window of his bedroom. The sight shocks him at first. Mydei's naked back, his buttocks, his strong thighs, bare for him to see. He averts his gaze.

"Mydei?" he calls, but Mydei does not answer him, does not flinch at all.

"Mydei," he tries again, and now he stirs. He turns his head to look at him out of the corner of his eye.

"Sorry. It was too warm when I woke up."

The house is freezing. The district mayor hasn't turned on the heating yet. Phainon spares a look at his face. He hasn't cried, but he looks exhausted and red-eyed nonetheless. He takes a

careful step inside.

"No, it's okay, don't worry. I wanted to apologize for yesterday. For the way I asked you that question."

Mydei scoffs weakly. "I forgive you."

Mydei moves, and Phainon looks down at the floor. He sits down on the edge of the mattress and covers his lap with the blanket. Stillness for a moment, and then Mydei beckons him closer—Phainon, bewitched, follows like a bloodhound hot on a trail. He stands in front of him, looking down at him, and Mydei sits, looking up at him. His face is not tumultuous, but it is not peaceful either. It's more something like *tired,* if Phainon had to give it a name. He clenches and unclenches his fists. Shifts his weight from one foot to the other.

"Are we still together?" he asks, barely loud enough to drown out the birds chirping outside.

Mydei laughs at that, full-mouthed and full-teethed. "Yes," he says, "I don't see why not."

His laughter lingers into a smile. Both of his snaggleteeth are peeking over his lips, like vampire fangs. Phainon is filled with such unshakeable affection. He wants to grab him and squeeze him and pepper his face with kisses and slice his tongue in two on those fangs. He steps forward, and drops to his knees in front of Mydei. He is looking down on Phainon, now, and Phainon is looking up at him. Whatever he sees on his face must be truly pathetic, because Mydei sighs deeply and pats his blanketed lap.

Phainon crawls to him on his knees like a sinner in church, seeking something untainted and untouchable. He rests his heavy head on his lap. Mydei's hands move to touch his hair, to card them through his pale locks. His thumb rubs his temple. Phainon closes his eyes.

"I'm trying to fix it," Mydei whispers down at him, "The broken thing inside of me."

He does not say anything, he just sighs. Phainon doesn't think anything about Mydei can be broken. Rather, he thinks of stained glass. Fractured, but in wholeness, beautiful.

"I can love you, but I can't love you in entirety. I'm missing something. But I *can* love you."

Phainon cracks open his eyes and looks up at him. What's staring back is strange—Mydei's handsome face, familiar and lovely, and a forced little smile tugging on his lips like hooks. One singular, lonely teardrop lands on Phainon's cheek and runs down off his chin.

"I think you can," Phainon answers.

"…Maybe one day, but now, there's some things that I desperately want to do, but I cannot. I can't give you what you want."

"Don't presume to know what I want," Phainon says, dulling the bite in his voice, "All I want is this. This is more than enough."

Mydei's hand moves to Phainon's mouth. His thumb caresses the corner of his lips. "I enjoy you a lot."

"I would crawl through broken glass to get to you," Phainon blurts out, and it makes Mydei laugh earnestly.

"Look, I…" he sighs, "We can cuddle. And you can kiss me anywhere but my lips. I would like that, and I would like to kiss one day, but not… right now, I can't. I'll talk with my therapist. Maybe we just need a new approach."

Phainon just hums in response. Rubs his head against Mydei's lap. He doesn't say what he thinks; that all the missing bits from Mydei could, maybe, fit all the missing bits from Phainon, and they could make a full picture together.

"I don't need to have sex, you know," Phainon says instead, "I mean, I would like to, but not because I want to get off. Just because I want to have fun like that with you, to feel… good with you. But if we don't do it, that's fine too. I don't care for sex that much. It's not very important to me… It's more about spending intimate time with you… Yeah, it's about the intimacy, I think. I've, uh," he looks up at him, "I've had like a bunch of hook-ups before and they were *fine*, but it always felt like something was missing, you know? But when I had sex with my exes, it was like… different. It felt right and authentic. And there's nothing wrong with hooking up, it's just—I don't know how to describe it. Just not for me, I guess? I think just, for me, it's not about the sex as much as it is about the other person and doing something, like… Special with them, you know?"

"No, I don't know," Mydei answers right away, "That doesn't sound familiar to me. I don't think I've ever enjoyed having sex. I think I enjoyed the attention, though. I always felt like, well…"

"Like you had to?"

"*Yeah.* I've just dated a bunch of assholes, I guess. I kept attracting them. I don't know why, but my therapist said abuse victims are more likely to be revictimized. I just don't understand how they knew. Do I give off victim vibes?"

Phainon scoffs. "You give off gay lion vibes." Mydei playfully pulls his ear, not hard. Then he blinks down at him.

"I never thought sex as something that could be *special.* It always felt quite dirty to me."

He wants to make a joke about showering first, but he restrains himself. "I've had some nice, special sex. It can be special."

"Now you're just trying to make me jealous," Mydei jokes, and Phainon nuzzles into his knee to kiss it over the blanket.

"I think this is more special anyways, because it's with you."

"Aren't you a little romantic?" he mocks and starts to scratch his scalp. "I'm not so easily wooed."

Phainon opens his mouth to make a smart remark, but Mydei cuts him off. "If we were having sex, what would it be like?"

"Hmm…" Phainon thinks. He feels that Mydei is treading a dangerous territory, what with him freaking out the other night over *kissing*. He decides to be a joker with it… To make Mydei laugh. Maybe that will make him be better. "Well, first, I would take you to an expensive restaurant that I really can't afford. Then, we go home and we kiss a lot and we hug and cuddle."

"That's already unrealistic. I wouldn't eat before bottoming."

"Just go with it, geez. So then, we get down to business and I make you come like… Uhh, four or five times before I actually like, penetrate you."

"Four or five—who do you think I am? Some sort of succubus?"

"Go with it! And then I finger you for approximately ten or so minutes."

Mydei opens his mouth to protests, then he just closes it with a sigh. "And then we have sex for thirty consecutive minutes. No, hm… An entire hour, yes! And it's like, loving sex, but I'm also like, hitting that shit *hard*, you know? And then we both cum at the same time—"

"Me for the sixth time, I presume."

"No, you'd come at *least* three times while I'm fucking you."

"Oh okay, so this is my eight orgasm in a little over an hour."

"Correct. So we come at the same time and it's really good and emotional and lovey-dovey. And then we get married at the end."

"Right. So, Phainon, I have a question: have you actually ever had sex before?"

Phainon doesn't answer, just closes his eyes. "I was joking, but it would go something like that," he says after a moment, "I'd like to make you laugh a lot, and I'd like to have your pretty face close to mine… And hold your hand… Kiss you lots…"

He's starting to fall asleep with the way Mydei is running his fingers through his hair. He feels him shift under his head, and he stirs from his half-daze to look at him. Mydei has brought his other hand to his mouth.

He presses his lips to his palm like a stigmata. He does it with a wistful sigh. Then, he brings that kissed palm to Phainon's lips.

Phainon kisses it back in earnest, tongue and all.

Mydei has taken the next three days off of work to gather his bearings. The reality of his decision hit him hard that night, and now expectations lay on him far too heavily for him to

handle. Simply put, he is overwhelmed, and he needs a break from it all. Away from Phainon, and his roommates, and their friends, and—everybody, really. He drives back to his place.

Talking about his roommates, he's gathered them in the living room, and is standing in the middle of it like a king about to give a speech to his army. Hephaestion seems to be the only one truly interested in whatever it is he means to say.

Mydei clears his throat to get the others' attentions. Perdikkas peaks at him from his phone. He's caught Peucesta at a bad time—he's in the middle of taping down his wig. Drag breakfast at some quaint little place, you see. He's looking furiously in his little handheld mirror.

"I wanted to tell you guys something," he starts, "And it's pretty important."

Leonnius grabs onto Hephaestion's arm. "The cancer is back," he breathes out, frightened.

"It's very much *not,"* Hephaestion says, wrenching his arm away, "And even if it were, why would I have Mydei say it instead of me? Are you stupid?"

"No, it's not Hephaestion's cancer, it's uh—It's Gayface. I'm dating Gayface."

The scream that tears out of Peucesta is loud enough to shake the very core of the earth. He gives one mighty yell, like a strong man struck down on the battlefield, and he falls down to his knees. Wigcap and all.

"Not Gayface, God, please, ANYTHING but dating Gayface!" he wails, running clawed nails down his face. "Not Gayface. Not that. Anything but that."

His tantrum is met with silence.

Mydei coughs.

"Peucesta, you're being dramatic."

"I'm a drag queen, goddamn it, my dick is tucked up my ass! *Drama* is my job!"

"Your job is tattoo artist," Ptolemy adds intelligently, and Peucesta glares at him.

"That's my day job. And that's besides the point. Out of every available bachelor, *Gayface?"*

"You like Gayface," Mydei points out, "You told me you liked him after Perdikkas' birthday party."

"I was drunk and seduced by his wiles."

Mydei blinks. "His wiles."

"His wiles! He's *awful!* I *hate* him!"

"That's enough, Peucesta," Hephaestion chides, "Don't upset Mydei. Mydei, mm…"

Hephaestion untangles himself from the couch and puts a hand on his shoulder. "That's great. I'm really happy you're putting yourself out there. I hope he treats you well."

"He'll answer to me if he doesn't," Leonnius chimes in.

Mydei shifts his weight awkwardly from one foot to the other. He looks at them. They all look cautiously happy, except for Peucesta, who is being entirely way too dramatic. That being said, he*'s* right; he *is* a drag queen, and being too dramatic *is* kind of his job. He expected more of a reaction, to be honest. At least *some* hoots and hollers; though, to be fair to his friends, he has had some monstrously disastrous relationships, and they don't even *know* the worst of it. Phainon has charmed them well enough at Perdikkas' birthday party, but so did *every single one of his boyfriends.*

He sighs and goes to his room, rummages through his closet to pull out his suitcase. He's going to spend the next three days in Kremnos, just… away, for a little bit. He's let everyone know that he needs some peace and quiet—and he told Krateros that he's coming over, too. He shoves just about everything that will fit into it, his toothbrush as well, his meds, and Simba.

The drive back to Castrum Kremnos is relaxing. Six hours of nothing but the empty roads connecting the two cities. He enters the city just short of 7 PM, and then it's about one more hour until he parks in his uncle's driveway.

Krateros waits for him on the porch, standing awkwardly like the fifty-one year old uncle with autism that he is. Awkward but giddy, with his hands on his hips, smiling from under his mustache. He stims when he sees Mydeimos, taps his feet rhythmically and grinds his jaw—Mydei's earliest memory of Krateros is of him doing just that, tapping his feet and grinding his jaw.

Krateros hugs Mydei hard and deep when he gets out of the car, just really squeezes him to his chest. "Hey, buddy!" he says, patting his back, "Missed you."

"I missed you too," Mydei says, and he forces a small smile.

His uncle seats them down for dinner. Mydei blinks at the bowl of stew. "Stifado? You're being fancy tonight."

"You told me you were coming so I ran to get groceries. It's a special occasion!"

They sit down to eat. It's lamb stew popular in Kremnos, nice and warm, with crunchy, sweet shallots and spicy cinnamon.

It's good. It's Krateros' favorite food, though it leans on the pricier side so he only makes it for, well, special occasions. Still, it reminds Mydei of his childhood spent in this house. Nothing has changed, his uncle least of all. Every furniture is as it was sixteen years ago; he cannot tell whether the thought comforts him or saddens him.

Hanging out with his uncle is easy because they have the same brand of autism. Krateros got diagnosed a little before Mydei's first birthday, well into his twenties, and he was the one that

talked Gorgo into getting him evaluated—lo and behold, it runs in the family. They both like being silent, which is a blessing, and they both like doing their own thing in the same room together. Krateros like low, "atmospheric" lighting just like Mydei does, and he likes everything to be *so, so* quiet.

That's all great and Mydei can finally unmask for a hot second. However, it *has* been a while since they've seen each other in person, and he has a lot he wants to talk about.

"So, uh…" Mydei tries as he wipes his mouth, "Are you… seeing anyone?"

He instantly hates the way he's started this conversation. He sounds like an annoying auntie.

"Oh, uh, actually *yeah,* I've been meaning to tell you—So I've been going to—Hold on, let me put it all in order," Krateros clears his throat and thinks for a second, "Okay, so, I've been seeing this therapist lady lately and she's been helping me out with my social skills. So I've been on dating sites for people my age and I met this nice lady… She's a couple of years younger than me and has two daughters in high school, we've been, uh, meeting up for a while and it's going pretty great. I really like her."

Mydei nods. Krateros nods back at him. He tries to think of another question to fill the air, but Krateros is quicker.

"Are you seeing anyone?"

"Yeah, I've just started dating this guy, Phainon, from work. Like… I *just* started dating him. Yesterday. He asked, I mean. Asked me to be his boyfriend."

"Oh, Phainon from work! You've told me about him. Is he nice?"

"Yeah, he's nice."

"That's cool."

When they are done eating, Mydei offers to clean the dishes, but Krateros lingers around him. "I'm really glad you're here, buddy, but I have to tell you, the therapist lady is coming over every day, and between that and work, I'm a little busy, so…"

"That's okay. We don't have to like, hang out or anything. I just needed some time away is all. I'm a little overwhelmed," Mydei smiles at him and winks, "You won't even know I'm here."

Krateros chuckles. "That's nonsense, you don't have to hide in your room like you're a kid again," he clasps him on the shoulder, "Really, kid, I really am happy to see you. I'm… ugh, I can't believe how big you've gotten. You're taller than me! When did you get so big? When did I get *so old?*"

Mydei is very fond of Krateros. Despite all of his failings, of which there are many, Krateros is just seriously a salt-of-the-earth guy. Sincere and reliable and honest. He just—he wasn't ready for a kid. Ready for *Mydeimos.*

(Krateros takes an entire day off from work to clean Mydei's goddamn room. It's a pigsty, and Krateros' first instinct is to be so overwhelmed he just burns the entire house down. His second instinct tells him, he's just a kid. He's a kid and his life got turned upside down and he went through the unimaginable: you lost your big sister, Krateros, and that sucks, but the kid lost his mom and his dad in one fell swoop.

He's not good with love or affection and Mydei is worse with accepting them now. He doesn't know what to do with him or where to put him. He never wanted to be a dad. There are very few things he can do for him on his paycheck. Clothe him, feed him, make sure he's not the frumpy, dirty autistic kid at school that gets picked on.

He can love him and he does, but only from afar. Mydei won't allow anything more. He's even bit Krateros once. Hard.

All that to say—the least Krateros can do is clean his damn room.

He's up to his ankles in wrappers and takeout boxes. The smell is disgusting. The kid hoards food and Krateros not sure why; it's never scarce here, and never has been at Gorgo's either. He hides it under his bed or his blankets and forgets about it. He doesn't seem to even notice the smell and Krateros doesn't understand how he can stand to live like this, but—he's just a little kid. Krateros can't expect him to clean after himself, not now especially. Personal hygiene is… difficult for Mydei. It's a battle every morning to get him to brush his teeth, and it usually ends with Mydei screaming at him and trying to scratch him. Taking showers is an actual nightmare. The kid won't go anywhere near a bath. They've settled on a wet towel that he pats himself down with. His hair, on the other hand… It's greasy and unwashed and has been so since Gorgo's funeral. They put it up in a bun and it's enough to hide how dirty it is from the other kids at school. He's having a hard time as it is already, he doesn't need to be bullied as well—though Krateros has an inkling that he is either way.

So, he cleans. Gives him the smallest act of love that he can. He picks up the spoiled food, the broken bits of Gundams—his heart breaks for them, all that money down the drain, but it breaks for Mydei more—, all the toys that he's chewed through.

He finds a hard piece of… something under his pillow. It's hard like a pebble but thin. Black and foul smelling. There's some strands of… hair or… something like that attached to it. Just two or three, fine and blonde. Krateros shrugs and tosses it away.

When Mydei comes home that night and sees that his room is all clean, he's quiet for a moment. Doesn't seem particularly happy, but he never seems happy about anything ever. He looks up at Krateros with tears in his big, golden eyes.

"…Thank you…" he says, small, "'m sorry…"

"No, buddy, it's okay, look, it's more manageable now, right? We can try and keep it clean a little bit every day, right? But please, stop taking food to your room, okay? I'm not mad, but if you're hungry or anything, I'd rather you eat at the dinner table. You can let me know if you are. Hungry, I mean, you know, I won't get mad."

Mydei sniffles and it's just—I mean, heartbreaking stuff. His face twists so miserably when he's about to cry and he's so, so small, he's smaller than the other kids, he's just—God, he's a baby. He cries so quietly, too, like he's afraid to be heard.

Krateros rocks him to bed that night and for the first time, he notices that Mydei sucks his thumb when he sleeps.)

After dinner, they both retreat to their own rooms. Mydei's room is mostly unchanged since he was eighteen years old. It's simple. Shows no sign of any particular hobby or interest. Just a bed, some furniture, and the starry sky wallpaper Krateros got for him as a kid. Only difference is that Nikador and Kokopo III's enclosures are here, and it's Those two ferrets are plump and well fed and the room has kind of became *their* room. There's all sorts of tubes and activities and other ferret shit all over. Krateros spoils them rotten and though they are both elderly, they're still in the mood for playing.

He is in the middle of tossing them around like rag doll, sitting on the floor while they paw at his thigh for more, when Krateros knocks on his door.

"Come in," Mydei says, and Krateros opens it and stands in the doorway.

"How are you, buddy?"

"Just playing with Nikador and Kokopo."

"Ah, nice, um…" he rubs his hands together. He's nervous, for some reason. "I have something kind of, uh, weird to say, but I've been thinking about it—well, it's two questions that I've been meaning to ask. For like, sixteen years."

"You're making me anxious. Is it serious?"

"No, no, don't worry, it's not like, *serious*, I'm just curious and, you know… We're both adults now, we're both… doing better, so… I though I'd ask."

"Go ahead."

Krateros shifts awkwardly where is standing. "I've always wondered why you used to hate showering so much."

…That's it?

"Oh, when I was a kid?" Krateros nods, "I was just depressed and scared all the time," Mydei shrugs, "Plus, Eurypon used to punish me by making me take really cold showers, so…"

"…Ah. I'm sorry, buddy. Look, if this is too much, I can just—"

"No, it's okay. You said you had another question?"

"Oh! Yeah, right, uh… Do you remember when I cleaned your room for the first time? You were like… Jesus, small. It was a few months after Gorgo's funeral, like, the trial was still

ongoing. They didn't even lock your dad up yet."

Mydei thinks. He does remember. It was the first time he felt cared for in *years*. "Mhm. I do."

"So, when I cleaned your room, I found this… black thing with hair on it under your pillow. I've always wondered what it was."

All of a sudden, Mydei is doused with ice cold water, just like Dad's showers. He freezes completely and his chest is seized by something stuck between a scream and a sob. He swallows it down. Runs his hands down his face and rubs deep into his eyes. He doesn't realize it, but he sways from side to side, slowly. He bites down his thumb and looks at Krateros, much like he did when he used to be a kid.

"Mydei?"

"…It's…" he manages after a while. He sighs, deep. "…It's really fucked up, Krateros."

"Fucked up? What? It's not a body part, is it, hah!"

Krateros is joking, but—

"Actually, it is. It's… *God…"* Mydei hides his face in his hands. This is far too shameful. "… It was a piece of her scalp. Mom's. When we came to—to get her and she was in the kitchen, uh, dead, I… I saw it by the oven. And I just, I don't know, I just picked it up and I kept it and I would, ahh, I would rub it before going to sleep and—when you… When you threw it away, I was *so upset—"*

He doesn't notice Krateros walking up to him. He hovers above Mydeimos for a second, unsure, until he gets down on his knees and wraps his arms around him. Mydei can't contain his sobs anymore, and it's horrifying, because he feels like a sad kid again. He's a sad, upset, hurt little boy again and he's crying in his guardian's arms. Krateros holds him tightly. Rocks him back and forth just like he used to when he was little and having night terrors. He caresses his hair and shushes.

"Oh, Mydeimos, my boy… Oh, my little boy, my sullen boy…" he kisses his temple, and it is not suffocating, it is not too much, it's just right. It has always been, when Krateros used to hold him like this and rock him like this—whenever Mydei allowed him. Mydei buries his face in the crook of his neck.

"It's okay, baby, I'm sorry—I'm sorry for throwing it away, Goob, I didn't know…"

It makes Mydei chuckle. *Goob.* That's what Krateros used to call him when he was young.

"It's—" Mydei pulls back a little, just enough to wipe his tears, "It's fine, it… when you threw it away, I think it helped me move on a little, I guess… Like, she was truly gone. Every part of her. Just… it's just embarrassing, and I'm just so—" It comes back again. That sadness that rips through his chest. His face twists the same way it did when he was a kid, and he's sobbing into Krateros' breast again. *"I'm just so overwhelmed all the time…* It's so hard and… I can't keep it together anymore, I—I don't want to…*"*

Krateros holds him through it. He's talking to him, but Mydei doesn't register it anymore. He cries for a long time. He cries until he exhausts himself. The ferrets have gone back into their enclosure at some point. When he's calmed down, truly calmed down, Krateros wipes his face with a napkin and brings him a cup of water.

He sighs as Mydei downs it. "You're doing so good for yourself, kid. I'm proud of you."

Mydei looks at him. "…Yeah?"

"Yeah… look at you, such a strapping young man, so polite, you always keep up with your treatment. You were dealt a shitty fucking card but you did the most with it. I'm… I'm really happy to see how you are now as a grown-up. You're a good kid. You've always been a good kid."

Mydei doesn't agree with him, but that's some inner child work bullshit that he has to bring up to his therapist. He puts down the cup. "…I'm sorry. I know I was difficult as a kid."

"That's nonsense. You were difficult, but you were a little kid. And it was my responsibility to take care of you. I… tried my best."

Krateros sighs, affectionate, and cups Mydei's cheek. "You're a good young man. She raised you so well."

"No, I think you get some credit, too, I mean, you raised me for a longer than she did."

"I know I failed sometimes," Krateros says, "And I'm sorry. I wasn't ready."

Mydei gives him a small smile. "Nobody could've been. You did fail sometimes, but it's—I forgave you already. It's okay. I turned out… well, I turned out the best I could, I think, all things considered."

Krateros doesn't say anything else. Just smiles and nods. They stay like that for a while, sitting around a small, warm point of contact. A little later, Krateros leave, and Mydei has managed to cry himself to exhaustion. He turns off the lights, thanks God that the ferrets seems to have settled down, and crawls into bed.

The day he spends in Kremnos are perfect. Him and Krateros only talk occasionally, whenever the two of them feel like it, which isn't a lot. One time, when he feels lonely, he walks into Krateros' Nerd Room and finds him painting Gundams. Krateros just silently gestures at his painting kit, Mydeimos silently shrugs back, and he sits down to paint them together. Red and gold, of course, his favorites.

He drives to a small lake one day and just sits for a few hours, watching a mama duck and her ducklings swim around. He takes a lot of pictures of the Blade of Fury to show Phainon. He eats at his favorite Kremnoan specialty restaurant. He buys little trinkets for all of his non-Kremnoan friends, including a horrible "I ❤ Castrum Kremnos" shirt for Phainon. He also buys him a traditional arm band, golden though not made of real gold, just something still beautiful but on the cheaper side. He also gets him a braided bracelet. And a small

replica of a Kremnoan helmet. And a small wooden carving of the legendary Kremnoan lion. And a new sweater, not Kremnos themed, just something that he thought he'd like. And—

Before he knows, he has an entire bagful of gifts for *mostly* Phainon. He looks down at his purchases with shame. What is this? It was supposed to be a leisurely walk through the market. He was supposed to just *look.* He's so embarrassed, but, weirdly enough, not in the bad way. He's embarrassed like… a giddy school girl caught fangirling over her crush. Something light and bearable that makes butterflies flutters in his stomach. Mydei hides his face behind his hands and he is *beet red.* He is blushing because he can't wait to drive back and show Phainon everything that he's gotten him. What the fuck? *What the fuck?*

On the last day of his stay in Kremnos, at around 11 AM, he facetimes Phainon. Mydei checked—it should be one of his days off.

He had a whole script that he's been rehearsing and everything, but when Phainon picks up, bright-eyed and smiling like the sun, all words are lost on Mydei. He sees himself fluster and falter in the small window of his phone. He looks like a fucking *idiot.* Phainon is so handsome today, freshly showered by the looks of it, wearing a crew neck top and slutty short sleeves and—Mydei, dumbly, thinks that Phainon must smell so good right now. The thought only makes him redder.

"Mydei!" Phainon exclaims, all pretty teeth, "Hey man, what's up? Dude, I've missed you so much! Oh, I'm hanging out with Poly and Cassie! We're watching Polyxia draw!"

He tilts his phone so he can see the girls. Castorice waves shyly at him and Polyxia groans in acknowledgement. Mydei manages a small *'hi'* to the both of them.

"I've missed you so much!" Phainon continues and gosh, there's no end to this guy's yapping. "We all have, right, hmm? Is everything okay in Kremnos? How's the weather like?"

"Uh…" Mydei blanks, "I actually wanted to talk to you about something serious so could you go somewhere private?"

Phainon blinks at him but his smile doesn't falter. "Yeah, yeah, for sure—Cassie, I'm going to the bathroom, okay?"

"Okay!"

He walks for a bit, giving Mydei a great view of his tits—why is he wearing such a tight ass shirt to see *Castorice and Polyxia?* Phainon clicks the door of the bathroom open, and that is when his entire demeanor changes. He gets really close to the camera and Mydei can feel, through the phone, how anxious he is.

"You're breaking up with me."

Mydei frowns. "Where'd you get that from?"

"I don't know, you said *something serious,* so…"

"So you thought I'd break up with you? You're so fucking stupid, Phainon."

"…So you're not breaking up with me?"

Mydei groans. Why does he keep entertaining him?

"No, haikas, Jesus Christ! No, I just wanted to say, I'm driving back today, and I thought—" Mydei sighs and pinches the bridge of his nose, "Look. We've been practically living together for like… a while now, and I really like it, so…"

Phainon's eyes (well, the one singular eye that Mydei can see with the way he's holding his phone) get *very* big. "You want to move in?"

"Yeah, okay, I guess that's what I'm saying. If it's too soon—"

"I thought you'd never ask! Yes, yes, that's—no, it's not too soon, it feels just right," Phainon exclaims and laughs, then he fixes his camera so Mydei can see his face properly. He's smiling, big and warm, "I'd love to have you all for myself all the time, hm…"

A poor attempt at being seduced. It *works,* but Mydei isn't gonna give this win to him.

"Don't let it get to your head. The landlord back at my place raised the rent, that's all."

"Yeah, okay, sureeee…" Phainon sticks out his tongue at him, "You're a bad liar, and the tsundere act isn't cute."

"I'm not a tsundere. I'm clearly more of a kuudere."

"I agree, which is why I said the tsuntsun act wasn't cute," he laughs. He's handsome when he laughs. "But, okay, in all seriousness, if you want to move in, I am so down. I'd love to move in with you, ehh… I guess it's a little fast, but I don't know, if it works for us then it's fine. Are you, uh, feeling better?"

"…Yeah, I am actually. It was nice seeing my uncle again."

"I'm really glad, dear," Phainon says, low, loving. Mydei's heart beats faster and he feels like a stupid boy with a crush too big for his body.

"Are *you* feeling okay?" he asks instead, trying to steady his voice.

"It's been lonely without you. I've gotten used to having you around the house. Even Bartholos misses you."

Mydei tilts his head. "I'm gonna leave soon, I should be there in like… six or seven hours."

"Betcha can't do it in five."

He blanks. "…Do you want me to crash my car or something, dumbass?"

"Oh, so you really *can't* do it in five hours."

What is this? A challenge?

"Bet you I can."

"Yeah, yeah, I don't believe you."

Mydei hangs up.

He makes it back to Okhema in *four hours and forty-five minutes.* And he probably breaks some traffic laws while at it.

The day Mydei comes back from Castrum Kremnos, Phainon hangs out with Castorice and Polyxia for a couple more hours and then he proceeds to run out and buy the prettiest bouquet of white lilies he can find; Mydei mentioned liking lilies once, so it feels correct. And then he goes home and tidies up the entire place and takes a shower and shaves his legs (?). He puts on his favorite male thot shirt, tight but not *too* tight, just right to show off his arms, paired with his favorite male thot shorts, tight but not too tight, and definitely not appropriate for the weather outside. He thinks, briefly, about going to the gym and working out for a bit so his muscles looked more swollen and plump, but then he gets lazy.

Phainon waits for Mydei in the living room, sitting like an idiot with his hands clasped, for like… Two hours or so. Just sitting, not even doing anything in particular. He scrolls down his TikTok like, one time, and the rest of the time he just sits there looking ahead at the black screen of his TV.

The second he hears the door click open and Mydei step inside, he… Well, rather, *his stomach* decides to start doing advanced gymnastics. Suddenly, he breaks out in a cold sweat all over, he hears his tummy lurch, and then it's just *over.* He runs to the bathroom and vomits all the yummy cookies Castorice cooked for him.

And it goes on. For a while.

Mydei stands in the doorway to the bathroom and just watches him. Coat still on, suitcase still in hand.

"Are you serious."

It's not a question, it's a *statement.* Phainon's throat is beginning to hurt and this is all just really ridiculous. He's so anxious, and not even in a bad way; he's… excited? Giddy? *Nervous?* It would be a good feeling if it didn't make him throw up his intestines.

Phainon vomits the last of it (he thinks) and then he looks up at Mydei with big eyes filled with tears. "Mydei…" is all he can manage to get out, and then he has to lean over the toilet bowl some more, because Mydei is looking so strikingly handsome today.

"There's no way I'm that ugly," Mydei scoffs, "Throwing up at the sight of me? *Really?"*

Ugly? Just hearing that word with regards to *Mydeimos* makes Phainon throw up some more.

"This is ridiculous, dude. There's no way you're a real person. I'm leaving," Mydei says, staying instead to pat his back.

When they sit on the couch that night, all huddled together like bunnies in winter, Mydei runs his hand down Phainon's bared calf.

He stops dead in his tracks and slowly turns to look at him.

"Did you shave your fucking legs?"

Phainon chokes and sputters. "Y-yes…?"

"…Why?"

He gapes for a bit, mouth opening and closing like a fish gasping on the surface. Why *did* he shave his legs? In the moment, it just felt right. What the fuck? He's literally never shaved his legs before. He used one of Cyrene's old razors. He used his dead sister's razors to shave his legs for, what, this special occasion of Mydei coming back home?

Phainon just looks at him. "I'm not sure. It just felt correct."

Mydei's eyes widen. "It felt *correct*?"

"Look, I just. I got in the shower to take a, you know, a shower, and I, you know, I saw Cyrene's old razors and I thought, huh, I should shave my legs. I don't know why, okay? It just made sense at the time."

"You nicked yourself, haikas. You're so stupid!" he groans, running his thumb over a small scab around his knee.

"Eh… I'll do it better next tim—"

Phainon whimpers when he's grabbed, roughly, by Mydei. He grasps his face in his hands, thumb and forefinger squeezing his cheeks together hard, and he pulls Phainon roughly into him. Half climbs into his lap and gets his face *really* close to his. Phainon can feel Mydei's warm breath on his lips.

"If you ever shave any hair on your body again, I'll kill you."

His voice is deep and rough the way it has always been. Phainon cranes his neck to smile at him, shit-eating and cocky.

"Yes, love."

Phainon has always thought that things would change between him and Mydei when they started dating.

Nothing *really* changes.

They have always been weirdly affectionate. Phainon, intellectually, realized a while ago that normal people don't dig into the mouths of other normal people that they met two weeks ago and they don't fall into weird domestic dynamics where they sleep in the same bed and very

much cuddle without, you know, actually dating. That being said, it always felt *right* with Mydei. It felt natural—hell, it *came* naturally to Phainon. Like his hands were made to hold Mydei's and touch his skin. Like his lips were made to kiss his brow.

Needless to say, whatever was holding the both of them back—that being, the boundary of *'we're not a couple'*—is no more, and whatever they have, *amplifies*.

Mydei fully moves in with him, clothes and trinkets and all. They spend an entire day together making space for his stuff in the closet, though it hardly matters, since they end up sharing clothes anyways. Their toothbrushes sit next to each other in the bathroom. Mydei fills his fridge with weird, exquisite ingredients. He cooks them breakfast, Phainon gets lunch at work, and they both work together on dinner. They eat across from each other in Phainon's cramped kitchen, though the space seems to stretch infinitely big around them. In those moments, without a fail, Mydei always brings his hand to rest over Phainon's. None bring it up, they simply let the touch exist, but when Phainon peeks at him from his plate, he finds the tip of Mydei's ears bright red.

Mydei is a toucher, that much is not surprising. He's always been a physical person, always longed to be near another human being, either by cuddling them or fighting them. Phainon is much the same, though he struggles at times. He does not want to give Mydei an unwanted touch, so he mostly waits for *him* to initiate contact.

Mydei brings it up one day.

"Do you hate touching me?" he says, while washing the dishes.

"I-I don't! Why do you say that?"

Mydei does not look at him. "You almost never touch me first."

"I just… I don't want to, uh, I mean—I'm not sure when you'd like being touched."

He turns to face Phainon, just a bit, just enough to get a look at him. "If it's just cuddles, then always. I'll tell you if I'm not in the mood. I want you to initiate it more."

That's like asking a starved man to eat, or a thirsty man to drink, or a sick man to take medicine. A base necessity for one's well being, and such is Mydei's warm body against his for Phainon.

Over the following days, Phainon starts initiating, and it's like Mydei told him; most of the times, it's pleasant. Sometimes, rarely, Mydei shrugs him off and tells him he's not feeling up to it.

Phainon is starved for touch. Mydei is, too. They feed each other.

If they are not actively doing something, they are touching. Cuddling or holding hands or leaning one's head on the other's shoulder. Mydei is prissy and demanding with his touches like a spoiled cat—*just* like a spoiled cat, actually. He follows Phainon from room to room, nonchalantly of course, and has the habit of knocking whatever Phainon is holding so he can

snake in his arms and sit in his lap. Phainon would drop the elixir of youth if it meant holding Mydei for three seconds, and so all of his activities are halted so he can hug Mydei and pet his hair and kiss the crown of his head.

A cat. Mydei is a cat. Mydei is Phainon's giant bitch catwife, who tends to be grumpy and stoic and sarcastic but still begs for pets, in his own way.

He headbutts, by the way. Mydeimos headbutts Phainon when he wants attention, just like a literal cat—Phainon cannot stress this enough, *Mydei is a cat* who crawls into Phainon's bed and literally headbutts his arm until he's held and pampered. He likes it when Phainon scratches his scalp and behind his ear and under his chin. He makes soft, pleased noises at it and closes his eyes. He has cute fangs and those striking amber eyes. Phainon wants to sew the two of them together, to conjoin themselves at the hip.

What else? Oh. Mydei does this weird thing, well, Phainon finds it both weird and endearing, but he sometimes asks Phainon to lay on top of him, full dead weight and all. He was unsure about doing it the first time Mydei requested it, but the guy insisted, splayed out obediently in bed, and he—he just looked at Phainon with that trusting, expectant gaze in his eyes. Phainon is weak, so Phainon lays on top of Mydei, all two hundred pounds of him like the world's heaviest weighted blanket. Mydei literally *groans* with relief. Phainon doesn't get it, but he'd do anything if it meant being close to Mydei.

That is not to say Mydei is the only recipient of affection. Phainon gets more than his fair share of it. When it's time for bed, now that the restrictions of "friendships" are out of the way, Mydei grabs his face and runs his thumbs across his cheeks, and he looks at Phainon with so much *love* that it is unbearable. His eyes are soft, gentle, feline. He rubs his brow and his eyelids and traces the straight slope of his nose, presses his thumb into the sharp point of it and giggles. He caresses the edge of his mouth, the shape of his lips. Presses into his bottom lip and, when Phainon obediently bares his mouth to him, open and wanting, he presses his thumb on his tongue. They stay like that until one of them falls asleep.

Mydei is an endless source of warmth and it is as though he's trying to share it with Phainon. He hugs him from behind when Phainon is cooking and bites his shoulder, playfully, just a nip. When they are watching TV, he absentmindedly chews on Phainon's fingers. He likes playing Animal Crossing from between Phainon's legs, resting his head on his thigh. Once in a while, he cranes his neck around to give it a kiss and a nip.

Most baffling of all, Mydei *likes* kissing. He loves it! He kisses Phainon's fingers, every knuckle, his palm and down to his wrist, lips brushing the old scar, and when Phainon returns to favor, he chuckles and blushes like a schoolgirl. He's demanding with his kisses, like Phainon has a daily quota of Mydei Smooches that he has to fill. He likes it when Phainon peppers his entire face with kisses. It makes him squirm and laugh and turn all peachy. He lets Phainon kiss his shoulders, the crook of his elbow, his jawline, between his chest.

One day, Phainon is acting like Mydei's weighted blanket, but he's too overcome with love to play the part, so he shifts and wiggles until he has full access to Mydei. They lay nose to nose, smiling.

First, Phainon kisses the bridge of Mydei's nose. That's probably his favorite feature of Mydei's face; well, *all* of his face is his favorite, but Phainon plays favorites with his nose. It's hooked and manly and regal and though he likes teasing him about his "beak", Phainon is obsessed with it. So, a kiss on the bridge of his nose, then another to both of his cheeks, one for each eyelid, one for each brow. Mydei is squirming under him, tickled, and the proximity is maddening; so close, pressed flush to each other, Mydei shirtless as he always is, Phainon wearing a shirt and just boxers.

He moves down. Small kisses all over the length of his jawline. Mydei makes a small sound at that, and Phainon's somehow supposed to keep it together. He insists on that point where his jaw hinges to his neck—the skin there is sensitive, for Mydei, and it always makes him gasp. He nips, licks, gives it open mouth kisses—Phainon imagines it was Mydei's mouth he was worshiping instead.

Mydei grabs a fistful of Phainon's shirt, not to stop him, just to ground himself. Against Phainon's thigh, a slight stiffness—Mydei *is* very responsive, he always is, which is great, because so is Phainon. He knows Mydei wants it ignored, and Phainon doesn't mind ignoring his.

Mydei's breathing picks up, and so does his heartbeat—Phainon can feel it through his shirt, where they are touching. He's red down to his neck already and heating up. Phainon takes this moment to step back a bit, rising just a little so he can get a full look at Mydei.

He's beautiful. He's always so *beautiful.* He looks *unreal.* Androgynous even, both man and woman, or rather something in-between, something that does not care for gender. He has his chunky golden hoops in, and his face tattoo makes him look like he's wearing eyeliner. His features are fine, manly in some places, less so in others. A strong nose, a hard jawline. Pouty lips, thick eyebrows but a high, elegant browbone. High cheekbones, flushed pink on his brown skin. Pretty, pretty crooked teeth. Mydei is dazed with Phainon's kisses, looking at him through heavy lids and thick eyelashes. His mouth is parted and he's breathing softly. Phainon gives a small mental prayer to Gorgo, says *'Mrs. Polemos, wherever you are, thank you for birthing your gorgeous girlson.'*

Phainon wants nothing more than to dip down and capture that pretty mouth into a kiss. To taste Mydei's Cherry Cola lip balm, to feel that tongue piercing against his own. He wants to lick and suck those snaggleteeth, and he wants to do it while Mydei is sighing and grinding against him, happy and content and willing.

He instead looks lower, to his neck. Phainon also like Mydei's neck, because it is long and elegant and powerful. He likes the way his Adam's apple bobs up and down every time he gulps. He likes how red his neck blushes when he's flustered. And he would like to put a mark on it.

"Can I kiss your neck?" Phainon whispers.

Mydei's brain is all mush, because it takes a while for him to answer, but when he does, he just nods slowly. "Yeah, you can."

"You sure?"

"Mhm. Yes."

"I want to, uh…" His mouth feels like cotton. He is *parched.* "I would like to… if you want to, I mean, I would like to suck a mark on it. Can I?"

"Like a hickey?"

"Yeah," Phainon feels as though he is about to combust, "I promise, I'll do it in a place people won't see."

Mydei barks a laugh at that, and he looks at Phainon just *so,* enticing with a gleam of a budding challenge in his eyes. He is blushed lovely, glowing golden in the sun. He smirks, bares his teeth, and says, "No, I want you to do it in a place people *will* see."

Phainon's brain short-circuits and he just nods like an idiot, managing to just dumbly say, "Oh, okay."

He dives down, wiggling until he is at eye-level with Mydei's neck. His Adam's apple bobs, just the way he likes it. Phainon picks a spot, somewhere on the on the side of his throat—somewhere people would easily notice. He's only going to make Mydei wear V-necks from now on, God.

Phainon runs his lips over his spot, testing it, tasting Mydei's salty skin. Above him, Mydei cards hands through his hair, neither yanking nor grabbing, but rather pushing him closer into his neck. Phainon's tongue lolls out—he tries a lick and hears Mydei gasp. He looks up at him. Mydei nods, hazy, and whispers a small *'keep going'.*

He can't get enough of this. Of the closeness. Of Mydei's smell, of the taste of his skin on his tongue. He licks and kisses, open mouthed, then puckers his lips and sucks, nipping. He imagines it is Mydei's mouth. Mydei wiggles under him, sighing, and Phainon feels like he is losing his mind. He is so soft, so pliant, so warm. He makes beautiful sounds, small and content. Phainon checks in with him often, just a look, and Mydei, who's eyes he finds always fixed on him, always nods and tells him to go on.

He does until the heat in his stomach threatens to spill out. When Mydei's throat looks sufficiently red, Phainon pulls back to admire his work. He is sweating. *Sweating*. From giving a hickey.

Mydei chuckles at him, weakly, and grabs his phone to turn on his camera and look at the hickey. He runs his fingers over the bruising skin.

"Was that okay?" Phainon asks.

"It was scary, but it was okay."

He pales. "…Scary?"

Mydei locks his phone and grabs his hand, drags him into an embrace. He rubs his nose against his cheek. "I was just nervous, that's all. But it was… nice, I enjoyed it even if I was nervous, and I'd like to do it again."

Phainon isn't convinced. He chews his lip anxiously.

"Oh, come on, don't be like that," Mydei laughs, "It was scary in the way trying new things are scary. I tried it and I enjoyed it. Aren't you supposed to be the one comforting me?"

Ah, he's right. He should be comforting Mydei! Phainon groans and gathers him in his arms, squeezing tightly and kissing his face until they're both chuckling.

The next day, they go to work sporting matching hickeys, and none of their friends are happy about it.

It is perfect. Life is perfect. Every second awake is perfect.

Phainon and Mydei do not kiss, not on the mouth, and they do not fuck either. They hold each other and they hug and they pepper kisses all over the other's face. They eat together. They sleep together. Phainon rests his head on Mydei's chest—Mydei rests his head on his lap. They do not fuck. Mydei sucks on his fingers at night while he is laid in bed with Phainon, his dangerous eyes fixed on him, big and sharp like a lion's. They do not fuck. Phainon sucks bruises into his jawline, right in the spot that makes him keen. They do not fuck. He fucks into his fist in the shower until he is coming and crying.

They do not kiss. Mydei presses his lips to Phainon's eyes. They do not kiss. Phainon leaves a trail of kisses from Mydei's sternum to his chin. They do not kiss. Mydei licks the corner of his mouth.

They do not kiss and they do not fuck and God, it is enough. It is enough—it is *more* than enough. Mydei's presence near him, sickly-sweet, his crooked smile, the way his eyes wrinkle. The great curve of his nose. Mydei laughs at his jokes, Phainon laughs at Mydei's. They fight, not out of anger, but out of play. They touch the tips of their noses together and sleep so interlocked that, if they were to die in their sleep, paramedics would find them growing entwined like tree roots against each other.

It is enough. It is more than enough. Phainon is full of it, bursting at the seams with it, glowing inside with a strange new light. He does not need more. He does not want more if Mydei does not wish for it. He wants to kiss and he wants to fuck, but if they do not, if they never do—it is perfect. He is, for the first time, sated. Whole. He has never had water before and has finally drank his first cup of it. He cannot ask for more—there is nothing *more* to ask for. Everything is warm and golden. He touches up the red tips of Mydei's hair with dye and tickles his sides just to piss him off and hear him laugh. Nobody knows him like Mydei. Nobody loves him like Mydei does. He has never felt this before. He thinks, stupidly, that they must have been one person split in two at some time and now that they are finally together, they are finally whole.

He learns the patterns of Mydei's tattoos by heart. He could trace them in his sleep, could do it blind. He lays his head on his soft breast and lets him rub circles into his back until they are both half-asleep.

"Are those things full of milk?" he asks, pointing at his tits.

"They're full of the fiery souls of Kremnoan warriors. Go to bed."

One day, Mydei buys them a pomegranate to share and teaches Phainon how to peel it. He makes a great big mess of himself, fingertips stained red, and while Mydei is obediently scooping out with a spoon, Phainon says *fuck it* and dives into it.

He holds up his half of the fruit and works his mouth against it, lapping at the plump seeds with his tongue, catching them between his teeth and popping it. The noise it makes is loud, fleshy, and he breathes heavy through it—the pomegranate is swollen and just ripe for eating.

When he is done, wet and messy around the mouth, he looks up at Mydei.

Mydei looks back at him, mouth agape, flushed down to his chest, pupils blown into blackness. He swallows thickly, gets up in a hurry, and grabs him by the collar of his shirt to lift him up as well.

"Let's fight," he commands, and Phainon can only comply.

They go to the living room and move the small coffee table aside. Then they do battle for some thirty consecutive minutes. They love fighting, it's their favorite pastime besides watching bad Netflix reality TV shows. They are playing but they do not play with their punches—they hit with the intent to hurt. They wrestle to the floor and grind against each other in their struggle for purchase and dominance. They bite. At some point, Phainon's shirt is torn off of him. Phainon gets Mydei in the nose and it makes him bleed; as an apology, he licks the blood from his philtrum. He pins him down, asks if he yields, and Mydei spits at him and twists them around so that *he* is the one pinned.

By the end of it, they are both shirtless and sweaty, panting hard on the floor where they lay next to each other, bruised and swollen and aching deliciously.

It is perfect. Everything is perfect.

On the second week of their relationship, Mydei drives a crying Phainon to the psychiatrist. He goes into the doctor's office, and walks out not even twenty-five minutes later with a diagnosis (borderline personality disorder and mild psychosis) and a prescription for Seroquel and Prozac.

"I thought he was going to ask me weird things about like… my childhood and shit," Phainon says when he gets in the car.

"Nah, psychiatrists don't care about that. Let's find a pharmacy on our way."

He becomes very sleepy and very hungry and his mouth gets very dry. Mydei practically has to drag him out of bed every morning to go to work and then to the gym. He goes through several bottles of water every day. His bones ache. He gets migraines. His tongue feels heavy in his mouth and it gets harder to talk. Slowly, though, he finds that the side-effects phase out each day, until they are bearable; the drowsiness persists, though.

"It's good to have it on paper," Phainon tells him one night, when they are huddled under the sheets, "A diagnosis, I mean."

Mydei just nods to him and kisses his forehead.

Stillness comes, though not entirely. This flight has stabilized, but there is turbulence nonetheless, but it is—manageable. He cannot do therapy. Not right now, he is not ready for it, but, Phainon thinks as he looks at the pills in his hands, he can do this. For a little while at least, until he *does* go to therapy, until he is brave enough. The hallucinations blink in and out of his life. Cyrene in the corner of his eyes, neck bent at an odd angle, pointing her finger at him. The walls that seem as though they are breathing. The static film that coats his vision. They do not disappear, but they take breaks. They go backstage for days at a time. When they do return, he finds their presence dulled, faraway. Not enough to catch his attention anymore, not when Mydei is resting at his side, snoring without a care in the world.

The fog in his brain clears but does not disappear. His anxiety still pounds in his chest but it is manageable. He does not want to kill himself anymore, not actively, but he entertains the thought sometimes, when it gets hard. He can hear his own thoughts louder over the noise. The first time he notices it's quiet inside his head, he runs to tell Mydei—Mydei just looks at him and laughs, says *'It's pretty great, no?'*

He misses Cyrene like a wound in his side. The thought of her still hurts and despite the medication, despite everything, thinking of her sends him tumbling down spirals. He screams and claims that he is unfixable. Mydei just shushes him and feeds him.

Phainon tells Castorice about his new meds and she tells him about her experience with medications. He never knew she was on meds—he never thought to ask. Hyacine mentions off-hand how Prozac helped her when she was feeling suicidal. Says she's glad that it's working for him. He looks at her like she grew a second head.

"What, do you think you're the only suicidal person in the world?" she says, laughing, taking a drag of her pink cigarette, "I'm trans, dude."

He looks at Castorice, a question in his eyes.

"Well, I mean, yeah, of course," she answers flippantly, "I was super suicidal as a teenager. I still feel like that sometimes, but not often, and I know I'm not gonna attempt."

Phainon sinks into the bench. He's feeling a little ashamed, honestly. He has never considered that they could also be struggling with mental health like *that*. There's something very obviously clinically wrong with Castorice, but she's just so… *good* and *nice.* And Hyacine just seems to have everything together. He can't imagine it. He knows they've been through some stuff, they must have been, but it's… It's a weird feeling. He's not alone in this. What was he so ashamed of?

He looks at Mydei and Mydei just shrugs back at him.

Huh. Ain't that a bitch. It was *that* easy?

"Oh, uh…" Castorice says as she is about to walk back from their break, "Can I ask you guys' opinion on something? Mydei, are you paying attention?"

"Sorry, Cas, yes, I am."

She shuffles a bit. Puts away her e-cig. "So, the temperature is dropping and flu season is coming, and I was thinking…" she sighs, "I was thinking about quitting my job and becoming a full time carer for my sister. I can't afford me catching something and passing it on to her, you know, and…" she puts a hand over her face, "I could work remotely, but… This job and my part-time just take up too much of my time. She's not doing well. They're talking about a feeding tube."

Phainon blinks at her. "But if you quit your job, how are you gonna get money?"

"It's uh, like a paid thing. The state pays me or something. I take some courses and then, yeah, I like… become a full time carer thing."

"How much do they pay you?" Mydei asks.

"About as much as FLAMECHASE does. Losing my second paycheck is going to suck though, but I was using it to pay for her carer anyways, it's just—"

"Hold on, let me stop you," Hyacine puts out her hand, "It sounds like your mind is made up."

"…It is," Cas sighs, "It's not… the money I'm worried about… I'm worried…" she just looks around.

"That you're not gonna see us anymore?" Phainon finishes for her.

"…Yeah…" her voice is small and miserable, "I'm worried that if I don't come here and stuff, we're gonna drift away and stop being friends. And I'm worried I'll get depressed if I'm inside the house all day… Don't get me wrong, I don't mind caring for Polyxia! I really like it, I feel like it would really fulfill me, I really do! But…"

"Cas, that's silly," Phainon grabs her hand, "We're your friends. Just cause you're not with us every hour doesn't mean we're gonna stop being friends."

"Yeah, but… You guys are gonna have like, new inside jokes and stuff and I—I don't know, I mean, I don't know. I don't know."

Holy shit, she's about to cry.

"I just don't want to—I don't want to feel excluded and—"

Mydei comes over and wraps an arm around her. Goddamn it, she's crying. She's crying before her shift.

"Cassie, oh, girl…" Phainon sighs, "I promise we'll call you every day, okay? And we'll keep you up to date with our inside jokes. Hell, we can mask and come over once in a while to see

you and Polyxia. Wouldn't that be nice?"

"It… It would be…" she whimpers, and she just sounds like a bleating fawn.

"Cassie, Cipher's been away for like, more than a month, and we're still friends with her, right? She's missed out on a lot,too, and she's not gonna be working here anymore, but she's still our friend!" Hyacine pipes up.

"That's—That's true…"

"We can all get one of those friendslop games and play them together. Polyxia could join in too. We'd get an accessible one!" Mydei says, and where the fuck did he learn the term *'friendslop'* from? Phainon rubs Castorice's hand with his thumb, and he keeps holding onto that hand until they are back in their chairs at work. She answers her first call in tears.

Castorice signs her resignation papers the next day, and Phainon feels as though a chapter is ending.

Oddly enough, he is not sad about that. He is just excited for the next one.

Set scene: a lazy, warm Sunday. The first month of their relationship; their first anniversary.

Outside, the sun shines, bathing the room in its golden glow, painting everything yellow and brilliant. Mydei lays shirtless on his stomach, comfortable on the bed, scrolling through his phone. Phainon, as always, is looking at his back. He thinks he could look at his back forever, if that were the only way to catch a glimpse of him.

He notices something he has not before, which is downright shameful of him.

A fine scar, several shades lighter than his bronze skin, running down his back and expertly hidden by his tattoos. It is straight as a spear, going from between his shoulder blades to his tailbone. Phainon splays his palm on his back.

"You have a scar on your back, did you know?" he teases.

Mydei doesn't dignify him with a look. "Do I, haikas? I had no idea! Thank God you told me!"

Phainon laughs and leans down to bite his earlobe; that always makes him good and pliant. Mydei huffs at him in exasperation, but he does not pull away.

"Where'd you get it?"

"Scoliosis," Mydei answers curtly, "Had it as a kid, got the surgery as a teenager. I don't recommend it. It's why my back keeps fucking hurting."

Phainon hums in acknowledgement. He cranes his neck to get a better look at it. It is beautiful, in a way, but he finds everything about Mydei beautiful. Pale like a snake in the grass, hiding between the curves and lines of Mydei's tattoos.

His back is beautiful. Broad and strong like an oxen, perfectly muscled, a woven tapestry. He loves his back. He loves everything about him, but his back most of all.

"Can I?" Phainon asks, putting his thumb on the tip of the scar.

"Go ahead," Mydei answers, shifting to give him better access.

He runs his thumb across the length of it, from his shoulder blades down to where his back dips down with his waist and hips, and stops at his tailbone. He burns the oddly smooth feeling of it to memory. Mydei hums when he touches him.

"Is it sensitive?" Phainon whispers.

"Yeah, a little bit."

Phainon has to bite down his tongue. He finds it intensely erotic and he is not sure why. Scoliosis scar. Intensely erotic.

He is suddenly seized by a great yearning, an uncontrollable yearning. His fingers itch with the desire to pull Mydei into his chest, through his skin, through his ribcage, and straight into his heart. They are not close enough, physically, they are never close enough. Phainon does not know how to close that maddening distance between them.

He leans over him like a guardian, hands on each side of his shoulders, hovering above Mydei. Mydei does not stir at it, rather he grows *more* comfortable with his position. Phainon slowly lowers himself, until his mouth is at his ear. "Mydei…" he mutters, "Can I—Can I kiss it? The scar?"

"The scar…?" Mydei echoes, turning his head so that Phainon's lips brush his cheek, "Yes."

Phainon rubs his nose against his cheek and kisses it. Mydei cranes his head just so, giving Phainon leverage to kiss the corners of his mouth, both of them, just the way he likes it. His favorite way of being kissed.

Phainon shifts again and tenses his shoulders as he dips his head to Mydei's back. A small kiss between his shoulder blades, tongue peeking out to taste the scar; it tastes sweet, rich, it tastes like Mydei, it tastes like life. He moves down, wiggling on the bed to reach the lower parts of Mydei's back. He feels the muscle relax under his lips with every lingering kiss. Mydei sighs and puts his phone away. Turns his neck so that he can catch a glimpse of Phainon behind him. When he reaches his tailbone, Phainon gives it a filthy, wet kiss, mouth open and warm.

Then, he traces his way back to Mydei's shoulder blades with his tongue.

Mydei grunts, reddens, hides his face in his arms.

There is something terrible inside Phainon, and it makes him fever-hot. He runs his forehead between Mydei's strong blades, grasps his shoulders with his arm and massages them. Mydei pushes up into him, buttock to crotch. Phainon allows himself to sigh into his ear, to nibble at his lobe, and press his lips to his nose.

He nuzzles into him. Runs a shaky hand through Mydei's hair and toys with his braid a little. The other kneads his waist. His mouth goes dry with a question that burns his tongue.

"Mydei," he says, breathless, "Can I kiss you?"

Mydei stiffens all at once. He looks at him, just one golden eye. "If I say yes, are you going to fuck me?"

"No," Phainon says immediately, as though there is no other answer to this question—for Phainon, there isn't. The possibility doesn't even cross his mind. "I'm not going to. I don't want to. I want to kiss you just to kiss you. Just… for the sake of it."

Mydei moves and gets up to sit, forces Phainon to do the same. He twists around so he is facing him.

He looks… drunk, flushed, dazed. Not unhappy, but nervous. He is playing anxiously with his hands. Mydei looks off to the side and chews on his bottom lip. He turns back to Phainon.

"In that case… if you promise—"

"I promise."

"Then…" Mydei bows his head a bit, tilts it. Looks at his hands. Looks at Phainon.

"Then… *yes.*"

Phainon did not think he would get this far. He did not think at all when he asked that question.

Yes. What a wonderful word, coming from Mydei's mouth.

They move awkwardly together. An off-beat waltz where the dancers keep stepping on each other's toes. Mydei shuffles closer to him, scooting on his butt, and once he is close enough, Phainon puts a hand on the side of his face. His cheeks are so hot. His other hand grabs Mydei's and intertwines their fingers. They are both shaking.

He tests this fragile thing by running his thumb across Mydei's bottom lip. Mydei swallows. Twitches away from the touch, and then leans into it. Phainon veers closer and when he sees Mydei close his eyes and tilt his head, he knows that he is completely lost and does not want to be found.

It is not a kiss, not entirely. It is terribly chaste, incredibly modest, and just a brush of lips against each other. A half of a half of a split second of contact. Warm, sweet, gentle. Phainon pulls back and looks at Mydei. They are both feeling very shy.

"Okay?" he asks. Mydei nods and closes his eyes again.

Phainon gives him a proper kiss this time, though it is still courtly, like a knight might kiss a noble prince. A fairytale kiss, if he had to describe it. Tender, delicate, and easy to shatter, yet still bearing the miracle of true love.

Mydei's lips taste as sweet as he has always imagined them. His Cherry Cola lip balm tastes *just* like Cherry Cola, and it takes a lot out of Phainon to not just lap at the taste until it is gone.

They break apart, but do not pull away. They sit impossibly close, forehead to forehead, and they look at each other.

Another small kiss. Then another. Phainon sighs into it, his thumb rubbing circles over the diamond tattoo on Mydei's cheek. The smacking of their lips makes an embarrassing sound, but it not filthy—rather, sweet. Cute, tiny kisses, obedient tongues locked behind closed mouths. Like schoolchildren, Phainon thinks.

Though Mydei kisses him back, he does not move at all. He is still as a board in front of Phainon, and it makes some of his confidence falter and crack. An ugly thought gnaws at the back of his head, and though he tries to ignore it, it grows more insidious.

Phainon pulls back all the way suddenly. Mydei chases after the touch and when Phainon looks at him, he finds him looking back, confused, frowning.

"Why did you stop?" he asks, voice raw and hushed and a little out of breath.

"You weren't moving so I… I thought—"

Mydei blinks, and then his features soften. He smiles and laughs a bit. Tucks a strand of hair behind his ear. His chunky hoops clink with the movement.

"It's okay, I like it," he says timidly, averting his gaze.

"…Yeah?"

Mydei just hums in response. He grins with all of his pretty teeth, his adorable fangs. He moves, then. Takes Phainon's hand and places it over his chest, lets it rest there. His heart is beating so fast, he is blushed deep and peachy, he is shimmering like a precious stone in the golden rays of the sun.

"You and I are Earth, 1661…" he says, trailing off. Phainon does not know what that means, that much is clear, so Mydei continues, "A plate that was found in a sewer had that engraved on it. It reminds me of us."

Phainon blinks. The two of them, Earth—that sounds about right.

Mydei cants forward and closes the distance between their mouths.

It is the same, the most they can manage. Tiny pecks, chaste, though now Mydei winds his arms around Phainon's neck and pulls him to his chest. Phainon, too, embraces him back, arms snake around his waist and so they kiss, like an entangled chimera, unnatural and a little crooked, but beautiful nonetheless.

They kiss until they are both out of breath and giggling, and when they are done for good, they lay down in bed together. Phainon's head on Mydei's chest, hearing the steady drum of

his heart. Mydei's hand playing with his fingers.

"Was that scary?" Phainon asks.

"Yes, it was, but I enjoyed it. Thank you for…" he sighs, "For being patient with me."

Phainon blinks. "I don't feel like I've been *patient.* To be honest, I haven't been waiting or anything. I was just… in that moment I felt like kissing you. So I asked. But I haven't thought of kissing on the mouth a bunch before this."

Mydei nods, though more so to himself than to Phainon. "I'm still scared of it. I'm nervous, you understand, my nervous system is just fucked. But… I'm not scared because it's actually scary. I'm scared because of… you know, stuff… I did enjoy it, really. I would like to do it again. I might just be a bit nervous during it, that's all. It's not your fault."

Phainon leans in and steals a quick kiss to his temple. "It's not your fault either, you know. I wouldn't change anything about you. About us. I love this, just the way it is."

Mydei is silent for a long time, so long that Phainon would think he fell asleep if he were not seeing his eyes be open. Then, he turns and looks at the window, directly at that big source of light. He squints, then gazes down at Phainon. "Look," he says, pointing at the sun, "That's you."

"…Me? The sun?"

"Yes!" Mydei laughs, loud, wild, a bit like a wolf's howl, head thrown back, "How lucky I am. I am holding the sun, and he does not scorch me at all!"

Chapter End Notes

every time i think im almost done with this fic i write like a gajillion more words. i dont know man! were in for the long haul! i had so many things to touch on this chapter and i touched on like. TWO of them. either way, i love this chapter, im excited to be back, and i hope you all enjoy it!! drop a comment or else bartholos gets puts down

mind you i have an exam i havent studied for at all on monday.

Chapter 11: he wants

Chapter Notes

This chapter was supposed to be longer, but this felt like a good place to end it. The rest of the scenes that I had planned for it were a bit too different tonally and they wouldn't have fit. Sorry it's a little short (and it still managed to be 11k words!!) and not much happens in this!

!IMPORTANT

This is a Mydei-centric chapter and comes with a **BIG SA TW** as it explores his trauma and his reactions to it throughout the entire chapter. There are also **CHILD AND DOMESTIC ABUSE AND ANIMAL ABUSE/DEATH TWS.** Specifics below vv

▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

To say that Polyxia is unhappy with her decision is an understatement—she is absolutely downright furious, and Castorice can tell by the blazing glint in her eyes and the almost imperceptible twist of her mouth. She turns to her screen and blinks and, with each blink, a hot tear falls down her face. She weeps like that, silently, proudly almost, until she cannot see her screen anymore, and therefore cannot talk.

Castorice kneels besides her and takes her cheeks in her hands. She has lost so much weight there, in her face, and for the first time in her life, the visage that looks back at Castorice is not identical to hers anymore; this too is a loss, she thinks, but one that she can bear. One that prepares her for the unimaginable.

She wipes Polyxia's tears.

"Don't be upset with me, please," Castorice says.

She holds her pretty face until she stops crying, but the anger within her continues to simmer. Polyxia flits her eyes to the screen, and blinks.

"I do not want your life to revolve around me, Castorice," is all she says and what a silly girl she is—does she not know that they are two astral bodies, orbiting around each other, burning up, burning out? Castorice smiles at her, and she is so taken with affection that she bullies her head into her lap. She moves her hand so that it is resting on her scalp. Castorice still remembers the day they recorded her voice for the monitor. She remembers how hard she cried, and how Polyxia wouldn't stop going off-script. She insisted on recording every word ever, including the ones she's never used, like quixotic.

"That's nonsense, Polyxia. Taking care of you doesn't mean my life revolves around you. It's just something I do out of love and something I'm passionate about. Is that so hard to believe? That I might want to do this?"

"You're saying it like it's easy."

Castorice blinks up at her. "It is easy."

"It's not. I don't want to be a burden for you."

Her, a burden? Is she ridiculous? Is the moon a burden to the sun? Is the rain a burden to the grass? The pollen to the bee? They are dancing around the cycle of care, and where it once was Polyxia taking care of Castorice, now it is Castorice's turn.

"You are my sister and I don't ever want to hear that out of you, okay? You are not a burden, you're just… burdened by something, and I want to help you ease it. I want to help you carry it. How could you ever be a burden to me? You are my sister."

Swallowing is becoming difficult and while her breathing is holding up for now, a ventilator is in their future. Whatever little independence she has is about to shrink even more. She is going to be very sad and very depressed, and she is will need friends around her more than ever; she will need love and companionship, and Castorice wants nothing more than to provide those for her. She is going to need around-the-clock care, more than they can afford and more than she's willing to trust a stranger with, even a trained professional. Above all, however, a selfish want—

"Whatever time we have together is terribly finite, Polyxia. I don't want to spend it at some stupid job I hate that makes me feel bad about myself. I want to spend it with you. I want to… I want to wash your hair and help you in the bathroom and help you eat. I do those things anyways, yes, but I want to do them all the time. And before you start—you know I can see what you type, right?—it's not duty. It's just care. That's literally just it. We've always been a team, why can't we be a team now, too?"

Polyxia doesn't answer. She slumps a bit and sighs. She looks off, away at a random door. After a while, she turns back to her screen.

"I am scared. I'm really scared all of a sudden."

"I know. I'm scared too. Let's just be scared together, okay? We can figure it out like that. I'll… I'll talk to the insurance lady, maybe it covers some sort of family therapy for this, you know? Maybe that will help."

Polyxia has been brave for so long. Unshakeable as though made of steel. Somehow, through her illness, she has still been Castorice's pillar—Castorice thinks that, now, it is time for the roles to change. She has to be the strong one, she has to be brave when Polyxia falters, and she has to catch her when she falls.

She remembers them as children, Polyxia fighting off the kids that bullied her. She remembers them as teenagers and the time Polyxia broke the nose of a guy that groped her. She

remembers prom, when two boys fought over who got to take Polyxia as their date, and Polyxia instead took Castorice as her date. She remembers their matching purple dresses, Polyxia's dark, Castorice's light. She remembers when she got her diagnosis, how they cried in each other's arms, and how in the end, it was Polyxia that assured her that everything will be okay.

Castorice kisses her hand. "I love you so much," she tells her, and she is bursting with it, falling apart with it, "Please let me take care of you."

She hears her gulp and swallow thickly. "Okay," she says and Castorice jumps to her feet to —carefully—wrap her arms around her.

"That's good, because I already signed the resignation papers, so…" she says with relief.

That makes Polyxia chortle a small laugh, which is an immense win for Castorice.

"You are ridiculous," Polyxia tells her and yeah, Castorice is ridiculous, she's silly and a little weird, but right now, she is just her little sister, eager to help.

"You are ridiculous too," she says back, "I guess it runs in the family."

Mydei is staring and his reflection and a stranger stares back at him. It is a stranger that wears his face, shockingly similar, yet foreign nonetheless. There are just… these little things that are off about him, like the length of his eyelashes, the color of his lips, the flush in his cheeks. The stranger's hair is done up in elaborate ringlets—is that a wig?— and dusted with glitter, and he is wearing this ridiculous frilly bonnet, like the old-school kind that wraps around the head like a cone. The stranger is wearing a beautiful red dress. Mydei squints at the mirror. Who is this? Who is *he?*

"All done, Mydei, oh, you're so cute I could just eat you up~"

So cute? *Eat you up?* Is that a threat? Somebody is talking to him. A girl. He and the stranger turn to look at the same time.

He finds himself face to face with a pink monstrosity, something exploding with ribbons and lace. His pulse picks up and he is wrecked with anxiety. Mydei is caught between reality and dream, unable to break away. She speaks to him and the more she yaps, the more the heavy fog lifts from his brain.

The sketch starts to take shape and color. An overly decorated cute room, the weird cooing of a pigeon, and the woman in front of him—she is pretty, fair-skinned, green-eyed, and has a gigantic pink wig on. Her nails are long and weighed down with charms, and her make-up is soft and doll-like.

"…Are you okay?" she asks, her eyes softening with concern. The pigeon, which must be the same as the one that was cooing, flies on her shoulder and gives her cheek a peck.

Mydei blinks once, twice, and—

Oh yes, this is Hyacine. And this is her TikTok room, and that's Little Ica, and they were supposed to film a video for her TikTok. They've been trying to set it up for like, a month, but something always came up.

"…Uh, I…" he manages, "I'm—disassociating? Why am I disassociating?"

She blinks at him. "Why *are* you disassociating?"

He turns back to the mirror and, oh God, that's no stranger, that's *him* in a bonnet and a red dress and dollcore makeup. Jesus Christ, he looks ridiculous. Mydei touches his cheeks and moves them around, then runs them down the corset of the dress.

"Hyacine, this fits me so well…" he points out. In response, Hyacine puts down whatever it was she was holding—looked like a makeup brush—and comes over to put a hand on his back.

"Fuck that, what was that about *disassociating?"*

Mydei's tongue is so heavy in his mouth that he fears he might choke on it. He tries to swallow around it and finds that it is impossible. He looks at her instead, and whatever she sees on his face worries her. "Alright, okay, let's just go out on the balcony, yeah? *Phainon, come out to the balcony!"* she calls out and, huh, Phainon must be with them too.

She grabs his hand and pulls him along to the balcony. Little Ica follows them, planted firmly on her shoulder. The cool November air hits him like a bag of bricks, like the shock of cold water. He parts his mouth a bit, just to take a small breath, to feel it burn down his throat and settle into his stomach. It is some relief, yes, not entirely but enough to ground him. He pulls out a chair and sits on it, vaguely registers Hyacine leaving and coming back with a glass of water. He takes it from her, thanks her graciously, and downs it in one go. Then wipes his mouth with his arm.

"Ah!!" she screams, "Oh, Mydei, you brute! You piss me off! You ruined your lipstick!"

Mydei looks down at his arm and finds a pink-ish red stripe smudged there. It smells good. And it's a little glossy. "…Oops," is all he says.

Hyacine groans. "I took so long doing your makeup!"

"I said *oops*," he repeats, as if that's supposed to make her feel better. She throws her hands up in defeat and sits down on a chair next to him. Weirdly enough, Ica is still on her shoulder and it makes no attempt to fly away. Mydei tilts his head as he looks at the pigeon. It's snow-white with a purple-green ring around its neck, pretty black eyes and chubby cheeks. It is nearly entirely spherical. Like, just a perfect… ball of feathers. He squints at it and makes a swift judgment: that thing should not exist. That is not one of God's creations.

Mydei feels… spacey, like he is floating through stormy clouds. Everything is slow. Words roll out of his mouth like wet bricks, heavy enough to weight him down yet soft enough to be crushed beneath his teeth. He asks Hyacine for a glass of water—he feels impossibly

parched. An ocean's worth of water could not sate him now, and yet he still drinks with absentminded futility.

A *dream* is the best way he can describe this feeling. That odd feeling where you know you're dreaming and yet cannot break away from it. Mydei tilts his head. It is not entirely unpleasant. At most, it's safe. It has kept him sane through the worst moments of his life. Finding his mother's body, testifying against his father, and those torturous, long hours where he laid in bed, staring at the ceiling, wondering *what happened* while his boyfriend was snoring away happily next to him. He looked down at his hands then, and realized he could not manage to count his fingers. He knew, logically, that there should be five of them, and yet when it came to the one, two, three of it… Oddly, that moment marked him about as much as the assault that happened earlier. That is all he remembers of that night—feeling scared and not being able to count his fingers.

Mydei thinks, briefly, that this is what it must have felt to be in his mother's womb. Overbearingly safe, but finite. He must be birthed at some point, and so too does the haze of disassociation lifts from him eventually, leaving Mydei to deal with all the consequences. And the consequences are always heavy, and they always end in some type of bloodshed. Dead cats and cut wrists.

When Phainon joins them on the balcony, wearing a ridiculous little sailor suit, Mydei realizes that this might be less of a *dream,* and more of a fucking *nightmare.* He is bursting out of those goddamn clothes. Hyacine got them a size too small, doubtless on purpose to show off his musculature, but it's like… A grown man with hair on his balls. In a sailor suit. Holding a lollipop the size of his head—actually, a bit bigger than that.

Weirdly, this whole look fits Phainon, little hat and all. His smile is luminous when he sees Mydei.

"Mydei, wow, you're so…" he covers his mouth and giggles, "You're so cute!"

"Don't make fun of me," Mydei grumbles.

"I'm not! You're really, really cute, wow, you really do look like a doll!"

Mydei's dress has these long billowy sleeves that he keeps getting his hands tangled into. He remembers Hyacine wanted to give him press-on nails but now that he is looking down at his hands, he finds his nails bare. He must've refused her at some point.

Hyacine blows a puff of smoke out of her cigarette and the smell is pleasant and sweet, kind of like cherries. "Mydei, you said you're disassociating," she presses on further.

"Uh… Yeah, I am."

Her face grows even more concerned. Phainon steals one of her cigarettes and lights it.

"Sometimes that happens to him if he looks in the mirror, and you *did* do his makeup, so…" Phainon trails off. He seems casual as he takes a drag out of the cigarette. Mydei likes that. He likes not being fussed over as if he's made of glass.

Hyacine is not convinced. "So it's, what, normal?"

"Hyacine, don't you have a degree in psychology?" Phainon teases, "You don't seem very well-informed~"

"I *am* well-informed, okay? I know what disassociation is, I'm also just worried about my friend!"

"It's fine, Hyacine, uh… It just happens sometimes, it's okay," Mydei says, reaching over to nudge her, "I'll be back to normal soon, just gotta… I don't know, wait, I guess?"

Phainon is right, this *does* happen to him sometimes if he looks at his reflection for too long. On his worst days, he has to cover every mirror and reflective surface in the apartment with a towel. Being reminded that he is of flesh and bone, that a physical body accompanies his thoughts and feelings, is jarring. Mydei catches himself staring in the bathroom mirror for minutes at a time, looking dumbly at his reflection as if he were a baby seeing himself for the first time. He cannot believe it, sometimes. That he is real. That he tangibly exists. That he takes up real space in the world, that he is made of atoms and carbon and connective tissue. Really, most of the time he just feels like a specter. Being reminded that he is not? Crazy stuff. No wonder he disassociates.

They decide to wait it out. Hyacine goes inside at some point, and that leaves Clown A and Clown B sitting on the balcony, dressed up in costumes.

"Are you feeling better?" Phainon asks after a long time. Mydei checks his phone; an hour has passed.

He *is* feeling much better, more grounded in reality, but he still floats. Mydei grumbles noncommittally, waving his hand around vaguely.

"So-so?" Phainon interprets for him, and Mydei nods. "Okay. How do we speed it up?"

Mydei shrugs. "I mean, there's some grounding exercises I do, but I'm like… not feeling up to it, honestly. Let's just wait it out."

"Hyacine's gonna kill you, dude."

"I'm more worried about that thing she calls a pet."

"Ica? Ica's got quite the story," Phainon says with a laugh.

"What is it?"

"I'll let Hyacine tell it. You *have* to hear it from her."

Mydei hums in agreement and then he turns to look at him, and he finds Phainon scrolling on his phone, cigarette hanging loosely between his lips—and he thinks that in this moment, at this time as the sun is starting to creep downwards into the sea, Phainon looks ravishingly handsome. Even in his stupid sailor suit and hat. His heart thrums in his chest as it picks up speed. Mydei will, possibly, never get tired of looking at Phainon, not when his features are

so fine and precise as though one of the great masters worked him from marble. Has there even been a more beautiful man? Mydei finds it hard to believe.

His jaw clenches around the cigarette as he pulls from it and blows out smoke; Mydei wishes he would've blown it down his throat. He likes the soft parts of Phainon, but he likes the sharp ones, too. He likes the intensity of his gaze, how in some lights those blue eyes seem dipped in gold. He likes the strength of his arm and the curve of his broad shoulders. He likes that he is tall, though Mydei dislikes that he is half an inch taller than him.

Most of all, he likes the forlorn look in Phainon's eyes. It reminds Mydei of his first true love, the first man he spilled his seed to; the Saint Sebastian himself, bound with rope to a tree and shot through with arrows. Nude, tensing, flexing, bending at the waist in surrender. In the painting that he was taken with, the Saint's meaty thigh was pierced with an arrow, and so was the great column of his pale throat. Most captivating of all was the look in his eyes, which Mydei often finds reflected in Phainon's. An agony that does not differentiate between pain and pleasure. Eyes rolled up to the Heavens, perhaps to invoke God's name through his torture, or perhaps to steady himself through the pulsing currents of an orgasm. His pretty mouth parted over a scream or a moan. Le petit mort as blood runs down his thigh; the imagery of deflowering. Suffering is good, suffering cleanses, and so in that painting, Saint Sebastian suffers on the precipice of climax—the divine agony reflected in his eyes is both pain and pleasure, beautiful and ugly, real and unreal, mixing together like myrrh and muck.

All of that to say—Phainon just kind of has that *look* in his eyes. The look of a suffering saint in the throes of God's trials, not knowing whether to bleed or come. That beautiful, detached pain that burns hot enough to reach the Mount Sinai and demand new commandments of God. Untouchable, dishonest, and terribly lovely. Mydei wants to break all of his teeth.

His cheeks feel impossibly hot. Phainon's eyes are wet and mellow like a lamb being led to slaughter. He has a lovely mouth, pretty cupid's bow, and it would be so easy to capture it between his sharp teeth and make him *bleed*. He would like to see if their blood is the same hue of red.

Mydei licks his lips and finds them tasting like lip gloss.

"Kiss me," he demands all of a sudden, and it catches Phainon off guard for a second. He coughs and sputters but composes himself quickly.

"Here, of all places?" Phainon rumbles low in his chest, clicking off his phone—Mydei catches a glimpse of Umamusume before he does—and turning to look at him. He rests his cheek on his hand, leans into it just *so*, and gives Mydei that *smirks* that he loves; it tries to be self-assured and cocky, but only manages to look *fake.* Mydei is only so enamored with it because he can see all the cracks of insecurity underneath it.

Mydei wriggles closer and puts his hand to the back of his head. He pushes Phainon closer to him and knocks their foreheads together; then he, too, gifts Phainon with a smirk of his own, though his is far more convincing. Phainon grunts, Mydei growls, and so they sit there, both baring their fangs, pushing and knocking their heads against each others like young rams in rut. He feels Phainon's hand rest on his nape. He feels terribly warm there, and doubtless that

he is flushed and peachy-pink like a maiden; well, given all of the make-up Hyacine put on him, his real blush is probably indistinguishable from the fake one.

"Yes, here, of all places," Mydei rasps and tilts his head up just enough to make his lips brush against Phainon's. The ghost-promise of a kiss.

Phainon falls for it immediately and closes the distance between them.

Mydei has learned over this past week that he really *does* enjoy being kissed for the sake of being kissed, when it's not just a motion he has to go through before sex. He brought it up to his therapist and Mrs. Sofia couldn't hide the look of triumph in her eyes. Then they talked about how he associates all affection with coercion and assault, and that's like… Super sad, so he's not thinking about it, because his lover is kissing him right now and his mouth taste sweet.

Phainon's been a little too fond of Mydei's Cherry Cola lip balm, and though he used about half of the tub, his lips are still chapped—he refuses to drink enough water! Mydei finds it pleasing, though, to lick his dry lips with his tongue and wet them until they are soft and moist with his saliva; Phainon finds that pleasing too, by the way he groans and shivers into his mouth.

Their kisses are always closed-mouth, but they have become less chaste. Mydei finds himself in a strange position; loving Phainon's hunger, being scared of it, too. Sometimes the fear is overwhelming and he has to take a step back. Other times—most of the times—he returns that hunger fearlessly. *'It's Phainon,'* Mydei tells himself as he chews and pulls on his bottom lip, *'It's just Phainon.'* And what has Phainon been other than painfully tame, incredibly gentle, and obedient like a good dog? Phainon with his lovely eyes and his elegant hands, with those killer collarbones and laughing mouth. He moans easily, Mydei likes that, and he relinquishes control quickly—Mydei likes that too.

As his lips find Phainon's mouth over and over again, heat coursing through him from his stomach to his ears, Mydei thinks, *I like this, I love him, I want to eat him whole.* He has missed out on so many kisses, and now he has to make up for it.

Mydei pulls back to admire his work. He finds Phainon looking at him with heavy-lidded eyes, his pupils blown out with just a ring of blue around the black (though, that might just be his new meds). Breathing hard, blushing all the way down to his neck. He looks *ruined,* he always does when Mydei kisses him. He always manages to leave Phainon sweating and panting like they've just fucked. Now though, most alluring of all is the red smudge across his lips, painting his mouth as though it were a gaping wound on his face. Mydei traces his bottom lip with his thumb, smudges the lipstick some more, all the way to the corner of his lips. He feels the iron grip Phainon's hands have on his waist, holding onto him like he's a lifeline. He smiles under Mydei, dumbly, dazed and happy, and Mydei thinks, *how obedient he is, how wonderful he is.*

"Stay still," he tells him, and Phainon complies, smirking up at him so slyly. He grabs his face, thumbs over those cheekbones, and in this dying sun's light, Phainon is boyishly handsome and pretty like a girl.

He kisses him again and again. Once on his lips, stamping them red, then his cheek, under his eye, then lower on his jawline, his neck, the dip of his collarbones, his soft naked breast, right over where he can feel his heart beat fast. He leaves a trail of blood-red in the wake of his kisses, Phainon bares his throat to him like prey and Mydei thinks, in the haze of this twilight, that he *would* very much like to tear his jugular out. To check his blood's temperature and see whether it is the same shade of red as his. He settles, instead, to licking a long stripe up the length of his neck, stopping to nip at his pulse point.

Neither notices the door to the balcony swing open, nor do they see Hyacine walk in.

"So, are you feeling better or—" Hyacine stops dead in her tracks. Mydei does as well. He looks back at her over his shoulder with a look stuck between shame and annoyance. Shame for being caught, annoyance for being interrupted.

She blinks at him. He blinks back. Under him, Phainon is shivering with barely-contained pleasure. He does not meet Hyacine's eyes, couldn't even if he wanted too—Mydei obstructs his view, and his sight is just red ribbons and lace.

"You…" Hyacine starts, taking out her phone, "You are so fucking *smart!* Oh my god, yes, yes, this is it, don't move—no, actually, *do* move, Mydei, get off Phainon!"

Ica flies to perch on her shoulder as she walks up to them. She pats Mydei away until he climbs off of Phainon, and then she grabs Phainon's wrist and pulls him to his feet. He is swaying with it, absolutely drunk on it, and Mydei is equal parts horrified and proud. What has gotten into him? He flushes and crosses his arms. "This is *perfect!"* Hyacine squeals, "You're gonna make me so much money, oh, I'm gonna be so *rich* off of fujobucks!"

By the time they are done, it is nightfall and Mydei is horrified.

He is horrified by how much he enjoyed it. They filmed a lot together. Silly TikTok dances and fujobait and some popular sounds. Some embarrassing couple's challenges (Phainon won most of them, but when it came to seeing who Ica would fly to, it picked Mydei). They kissed often, all cute and anime-y. Hyacine joined them in some videos and she's like, *really* good at this. He can see why 100k people are obsessed with her.

By the time Mydei changes into his regular clothes and takes off his makeup, the world has settled into the stillness of midnight. He is exhausted, boneless, but not in an unpleasant way. Just the exhaustion of a day well spent with people he loves. When Hyacine comes to the balcony with a glass of red wine and some snacks, he smiles up at her and thanks her politely. In return, she pats his head.

Hyacine is electric and never fails to make him laugh. That's what he likes most about her. Her never-ending energy, her brimming optimism, and the fact that she can talk to him endlessly without expecting him to reply. Really, he just enjoys listening to her voice.

"Can I keep the dress?" he asks her, and Hyacine replies with a shrug as she's lights her cigarette.

"Sure. It won't fit my *small petite fragile frame,*" she says, putting on a fake voice like an old Hollywood ingenue. He laughs at her joke and takes a sip of his wine.

Phainon joins them a little later, scrubbing his wet hair with a towel. Mydei wants to reprimand him, to chide him about going out in this weather with wet hair, about how he'll catch a cold, but he's far too tired for it. Instead, he just fixes him with a smoldering, disappointed look, and hopes that Phainon understands the message.

"So, Hyacine, y'know, Mydei doesn't actually know the Ica story," he coos, batting his eyelashes at her, "You wanna tell him?"

"Oh *God,* that whole fucking *thing…"* she groans.

Mydei blinks and tilts his head. The Ica story is a *thing?*

"Okay, so…" Hyacine crosses her legs and starts telling her story, "A few years ago, like two or so, I got *really* into pigeons. I don't know why or how but it happened. Anyways, I bought a dovecote so I could have my little pigeon army, right? Put it right on the building's rooftop. And like, yeah, I got some wild pigeons chilling in there, but what I really wanted was the fancy ones. Modena pigeons especially, I just love their look, but I got some others too. I was eating ice soup all month long because all my money went to pigeons with fucking pedigrees. So anyways, I buy a bunch of pigeons and I start taking *really* good care of them, and, to make a long story short, it turns out that pigeons are really easy to breed. You can breed genes in and out in generations, and I…" Hyacine sighs, stops for a bit, rubs her eyes.

"I had a vision, okay?" she continues, talking to them as if she's *defending* some vile action. "A pure white Modena pigeon that still had that purple-green iridescence. The only way to achieve that is to have the piebald gene, which causes white patches, but I wanted it to *look white*, do you understand? It needed to have *big* white patches everywhere except its neck. So… I… started to… breed pigeons. A lot of them," she looks at Mydei, fixing her with her gaze and in this moment, she seems distant and cold almost, *"A lot of them."*

Hyacine is telling this story with a severity that he really does not think is appropriate *or* needed. Behind him, Phainon is laughing. Is she joking? Mydei can't tell.

"It became a whole thing. It ate up all of my free time, actually. The pigeons I didn't keep for breeding were sold to other breeders. They were beautiful exemplars. All the money I made from selling them went right back into the breeding program. I was *obsessed,*" she takes a drag out of her cigarette, despondent. "A year and *two hundred and seventy-eight pigeons* later, my newest clutch hatched. I could tell that one of them was white, but he was too little to see if he had the iridescence. Four months later, he got his adult feathers. Pure white, with a ring of purple-green around its neck. He was perfect. Everything I wished for. The perfect Modena piebald. My Little Ica…" she coos, scratching under the pigeon's chin. "One of a kind. Totally unique. There is no other pigeon with the same genetic makeup as him in the entire world. He is the only one. I thought in that moment, after he had his first molt, that this is how Victor Frankenstein must've felt. I had engineered a *totally new breed of pigeon*. Named it *The Last Unicorn.* I had a blog detailing my pigeon breeding journey and it got *really* popular in the pigeon community. Had 40k followers at some point. I was pigeon famous."

She puts out her cigarette in the My Melody-shaped ashtray. Right over My Melody's smiling, innocent face. "Anyways, I fucked up the street's ecosystem a little. My pigeons drove out some of the local native birds. Gosh, there were pigeons everywhere and shit everywhere and the neighbors, uh, noticed. Having a dovecote is against the building's regulations, you see. Those *fuckers*, they called the cops on me and they shut the whole thing down when Ica was like, seven months old. They took all of my pigeons except Ica, only because I claimed that he is an emotional support therapy pet, fuck you, here's a letter from my psychologist saying I get to keep him."

Phainon couldn't possible laugh harder if he tried and Mydei doesn't really get what's funny because, honestly, he's a little scared. This woman played God with *pigeons*. She played with Mendel's laws of inheritance like they were checkers. He sits in stunned silence, watching as Hyacine casually takes another cigarette out of her pack.

"I get called to interviews by big pigeon breeding associations all the time. They want to talk about Little Ica and possibly start an official breeding program for The Last Unicorn breed," she waves her hand dismissively, "I keep turning them down because, honestly, I'm just not into pigeons anymore. It kind of came and went like a disastrous storm," she puffs smoke up into the sky, "I just want to keep doing my lolita TikToks for now. Maybe one day, though. Little Ica might need a friend or…" she trails off with a barked laugh.

For now?

Maybe one day?

Mydei shudders at the thought and regards Ica with a strange new understanding.

The ride back home is oddly tense. Not in a bad "we just had a public fight in an Ikea" way, but in a very, *very* good way. He feels Phainon's stare burn into him from the passenger's seat, equal parts hungry and timid. When the traffic permits it, Mydei sneaks a look at him. Holds his gaze for a second or two or thirty, then deprives him of it. By the time they pull up to Phainon's—*their*—apartment, Phainon's hand is tightly gripping Mydei's thigh.

He barely makes it through the door before Phainon is on him, his hands kneading on his waist, his lips to his jawline. It tickles him, Mydei is very ticklish, and so he laughs through it and caresses his hair. When he's gotten his fill, Phainon slumps in his arms like so, heavy like a big dog, all content and happy. His head on Mydei's shoulder, his face buried into his neck. After a second, Mydei peels him off of himself, makes him brush his teeth and take his meds.

Mydei *is* exhausted and Phainon is, too, but neither are exhausted enough to pass up on some good making out before bed—well, it's hardly, *truly* making out. In these past few weeks, they have not progressed past closed-mouth kisses. Phainon seems happy enough with it—Mydei, however, isn't. He ends up feeling more frustrated than anything, like a lion in a cage far too small. Like he is housing something great and terrible that has to burst our *or else.* He tries to unclench his jaw, but finds it sewn shut with wire like a corpse on the embalmer's table.

He thinks about it, sometimes—all the time. Parting his lips just an inch, a silent invitation, letting Phainon in, truly in. Parting his legs for him, on his back or on his hands and knees. Arching his back. He knows "good sex" from porn, so even at his big, embarrassing age, he thinks it must be something like that. Something wild and passionate like a whirlwind, cumming four times in a row and going for a fifth, until he is aching and crying. He thinks about it like that, when Phainon is at work and he isn't, as he forces his hand down his pants. He thinks that it must feel good and when it does not, he thinks that there's some switch God forgot to turn on in his head when He made him. Mydei would tug at his cock then, up and down, and walk out of the experience feeling no different than if he were fondling a piece of chicken breast.

One day, Phainon recommended one of Castorice's fanfics to him. It's a 300k word ongoing story about some two gacha dudes reimagined as tragic Chrysos Heirs in ancient Amphoreus. Mydei doesn't really get it, but it's well-written, well-paced and it's pretty good for a fanfic and as its own stand-alone piece of literature—though it does drag at times. She's got a knack for writing the little, intimate interactions between people, but she does not stray away from the coitus of it all, either. It was a bit embarrassing, at first, reading his friend's smut, but the more he dove into it, the more clarity he gained. The sex she wrote about was desperate and clumsy and not very sexy at all. It was, mostly, sad. Sad and melancholy and rolled between little laughs and shared looks. Intense, but not violent. Filled with sorrowful laughter, two people who knew the ending was coming and decided to go for one last embrace.

Mydei thought of what Phainon told him, then. That sex could be something that is very special. He wondered if special meant something like *this*. Something that could be hot but, maybe, also off-rhythm and imperfect and a little funny. He wondered if Phainon would laugh while fucking. He wished he would, bright and beaming and with two full rows of teeth, head thrown back while he thrusts.

He thinks about it now, too, with Phainon on top of him, drowsy from his meds, kissing him and humming against his lips. His hands bracketing Mydei's head, laying chest to chest and hip to hip. He can feel every twitch and shiver that goes through Phainon's body, like this. Every sigh. Every breath. The beating of his heart. He thinks about him naked, heavy with desire, and just the though of that is enough to make Mydei want to tear the skin off of his bones. But in this moment, he powers through the discomfort, just a bit, just enough to get him over the threshold. And he thinks of Phainon, flushed pink, laughing. He imagines his perfume mixed with the musk of sweat and sex. Something heady and fresh and intoxicating. He imagines the both of them a little shy, a little off-beat as though struggling to find the right rhythm.

He finds, horrifyingly, that this thought makes his heart tender. Fills it with warmth and tightens around it until it cracks, fragmenting in beautiful mirror shards, threatening to spill out the entire depth of his emotion.

Mydei does not hate it. Instead, it swirls in his stomach, coiling, solidifying, enrapturing him like a siren's song. He would like it, if it was like that. He would like it very much.

He unclenches his jaw.

Phainon pulls back from their kiss for a moment, just an inch, just to catch his breath, and then he dips his head back down for more—and finds Mydei's lips parted, open and willing, enticing, tongue resting anxiously in his mouth.

He opens his eyes, brilliant and blue, and the look of his face is as surprised as it is excited.

"Yeah?" he asks.

"Yeah."

They crash into each other like waves into rocks. The full weight of his desire bears down on him like a hydraulic press, and he swallows it all, swallows all that Phainon wants to give him, and finally, *finally*—Mydei can kiss him as deeply and as hungrily as he's always wanted to.

It's all teeth at first, and it's all very selfish, with the both of them taking what they want. Phainon groans into Mydei, grips him tight, one hand on his hip and the other on the back of his head, pulling him up into him, impossibly close as though he is trying to meld the two of them together into one being—as though that were possible, achievable, and just within reach of Phainon. He bites at Mydei's bottom lip, catches it between his teeth and pulls until it is swollen and bruised. Mydei allows it, would allow him anything, and in turn, he claws at Phainon's broad back, sneaking his hands under his shirt to drag his nails down his shoulders and leave pink marks behinds.

It's a desperate thing, a few months of repression clobbering the both of them over the head. Mydei makes needy, soft sounds he does not recognize, and Phainon eats them right out of his mouth.

He likes this part of him too, Mydei realizes. The lustful and hungry part. Phainon is smitten, he must be, because he hardly stops to breathe through their kiss, preferring instead to lick into Mydei's mouth, to slide his tongue against his, and—

Phainon grinds his hips down, sliding their clothed cocks together—a subconscious act that he seems unaware of. It makes the both of them moan at the same time, to Mydei's surprise. His chest instantly goes icy cold, while his stomach burns with a renewed warmth.

"Phainon," he groans when Phainon moves to lap at his jawline, "You're—"

"Hm?" Phainon gazes up at him, looking absolutely *stupid* with the heat of the moment, "Oh, did I—Sorry, I didn't—"

"No, it's…" Mydei grabs him, pulls him closer. Licks across his lips like a hungry dog, "It's okay, it's…"

His desire erupts out of him, unable to be restrained anymore. It feels good—it feels *good.* Phainon feels so good against him, so warm and soft, and he is so beautiful too, his pretty, pretty Phainon. He can tell he has been holding back all this time, has been *happy* to hold back, to wait for Mydei, but that he still *wants.*

Mydei wants, too. He wants like a bird wants the sky or the wolf wants the moon; he wants like it's natural, like it's primal. He is suddenly seized from the crown of his head to the tip of his toes by a great craving, an insatiable *need* to hear Phainon moan and keen for him, to feel how hot and heavy he is in his palm.

He wants. He wants. He wants.

"Phainon," he breathes out, pushing him off just a bit, just enough to see his face. He is luminous now, glowing golden with the yellow light of their shitty bedside lamp. The darkness of this feverish night paint him with harsh shadows, and so Mydei regards him, half obscured, half lustrous.

'Has anybody ever been more beautiful?' he thinks as he touches his cheek, the soft blushing skin there. Phainon takes to the touch like a wolf to meat, nuzzling into Mydei's palm, kissing it too.

"You're hard," Mydei continues, and his other hand hooks under his waistband, "Let me—"

Phainon snaps out of whatever lascivious reverie he has found himself in and looks at Mydei with eyes big as saucers. Suspicion is written on his face, a sort of hesitance uncharacteristic of him.

"Are you sure…?" he asks, cocking his head, "You don't have to."

"I want to," Mydei cuts him off, "Let me?"

Phainon grumbles a bit, looks off to the side, then back at Mydei. "…Alright, but… If you hate it, you're not allowed to be mad at me."

Mydei clicks his tongue and hits him on the shoulder. "Why would I be mad at *you*, idiot Phainon? Hop off of me, go lay down."

He does as told, laying with his back to the bed. His hands come to unlace his sweatpants and though Mydei would've liked to be the one to undress Phainon, he lets him do it himself anyways. "I hate this part, gosh, it's so embarrassing…" he grumbles under his breath loud enough for Mydei to hear, and then he pulls down his pants, just enough to free his cock. "Here's my dick, I guess, *Jesus Christ…"*

Mydei is, first of all, *delighted* that his hopes came true and that Phainon is, indeed, the sort of man to joke and laugh during sex. Immediately after delight, however, comes bone-deep dread. It all becomes suddenly all too real. The unbreathable, hot air of this room. Phainon's handsome, blushing face hidden under his arms. His cock, wanton and twitching for Mydei's attention, flushed angry-red and leaking at the tip. Phainon's breathing picks up, the result of the cold air on his sensitive skin, Mydei reckons.

His mouth goes dry with arousal and anxiety alike. Though he has seen Phainon waddle around in towels and boxers before, he has never seen him *truly* naked. His cock is exactly what he expected it to be; perfectly long and girthy, nothing intimidating, thicker in the

middle and curving to the left. He thinks, dumbly, that it looks like it *might* feel good inside him, but at this point, he's not sure what *good* is supposed to feel like anymore.

"Mydei," Phainon whines, and he's still hiding his face, "Say something… Do something…"

Mydei realizes he's been staring, and how cruel that must be for poor Phainon.

Despite every nerve ending in his body yelling at him to run, Mydei touches him. He rests his palm on his lower stomach first, where fine blonde hairs travel down. He lingers there for a second, then follows his snail trail lower still, inching closer to where he is hottest and most wanting. Phainon is ridiculous with his reactions already, kicking his legs and whimpering as if he were truly, wholly, *touched*.

Mydei does touch him. Grips his cock tight around the base. Phainon moans low in his throat at it, one hand flying to grab Mydei's wrist.

He wants, he wants, he wants—

It all withers at once, then goes up in flames. The point of contact scorches him, lights up every nerve ending in his body, and he pulls away like a man burned. It is all, suddenly, *too* heavy, and where it was heavy before, it was *pleasant*—charged, tense, filled with all the sexual frustration of two guys in their twenties. Now, however, it kidnaps him, takes him to a very far away place, and cracks his head on dirty kitchen tile. What spills out is ugly and scared.

"I can't," is all he can manage before he moves away from Phainon, twisting himself to sit up on the edge of the bed, head in hands.

Well, he's gone ahead and did it. He took a very beautiful thing and made it dirty. Smeared it with this sort of Mydei-brand filth that makes everything dull and gray and miserable. His hands are shaking on his face, and he bites down his tongue to stop a sob.

It's gone. The reality of the moment. Everything is the sea, lulling him to sleep, pulling him under, both comforting and cold. It washes over him in cold shivers down his spine. He feels the fear in his stomach, sucking everything that he has out of him into nice little pocket dimension where he keeps all the other things that belong to him; his mother's face, the smell of his father's cigarettes, and the capacity for normal sexual behaviour.

Mydei wants. He wants. It is so slightly out of reach, yet so impossibly far away at the same time.

Phainon does not talk, but he does hear him move behind him, probably to tuck his dick away. This is mortifying.

What is there to say? Somebody shattered Mydeimos three years ago and he is still trying to pick up the pieces.

They cut him when he does, though. Those fragmented pieces of him, all that he once was, all that he could have been but never will. They cut deep to the bone, severing muscle,

severing tendons, rendering his hand useless. They cut, so he drops them, he disposes of them, and trudges on as a third of a third of a man. A mere percentage, some 0.3% of a full human being.

There is a hollowness and it is cannibalistic. It eats him. He lets it.

"Mydei… Are you okay?" Phainon says, shifting closer, and Mydei can feel his warm hand before it touches him—it hovers just above his shoulder, unsure. Kind and patient and waiting for the consent to touch, and why does that piss Mydei off so much? *'Just touch me,'* he wants to say, *'Just take me.'*

Just hurt me.

Mydei remains silent. Does not approve or disapprove the touch, just to see what Phainon will do in this moment.

The hand retreats. Mydei cannot tell if he is relieved or ticked off. His jaw clenches, nonetheless.

Silence. It clears the fog in his mind, settles the lurching in his stomach, but not enough, not wholly. It is never enough. It is always there. He carries it with him like an oxen carries the plug—undignified, laborious, exhausting. A stupid beast of burden, yes, that's all he is. A beast of burden fashioned to endure all that is done unto him.

He hears Phainon stifling a yawn; his pills make him so drowsy, but he fights it and stays awake.

Mydei turns his head around, just a bit, just to look at him over his shoulder. He looks… comfortable, but concerned. There's something swimming in his eyes that's awfully close to *pity*, and Mydei mislikes it.

"Have you read Dune?" Mydei asks, and Phainon blinks at him.

"Uh… I saw the movie?"

Mydei shuffles on the bed, enough so he can lay down on his back with his legs hanging off the edge. He sighs, looks up at the ceiling.

"Rape is the mind-killer."

Phainon sucks in a breath at that, like it's painful. He lays down next to Mydei, too, and now they are standing in twin positions, legs off the bed, hands on their chest. He looks at him, but Mydei just looks at the ceiling.

"I feel tender," he admits, "Like a wound. I feel… I am… unhappy. I'm unhappy. I can't get rid of this… this pervasive unhappiness. With all the treatments, and the therapy, I can't get rid of it. I can only live around it. It's better. It's *fine.* But it's not good. I am always, *always,* a little bit unhappy, and—"

Phainon does not reply. He just listens. That only makes him more mad.

"What can I even say? I feel *radioactive,* like I'm sick and—dangerous and, I don't know. I don't feel like a person, I feel—I don't know. Like a stain. Like I am a stain that keeps growing and swallowing everything up."

Phainon shuffles closer to him and their shoulders touch. Mydei wants to scream at him for it, but he balls his fist. He is still looking at him. Mydei can imagine his big beautiful eyes, twisted in some sort of pity, something that says *"but MY dick certainly can fix you!"*. The mere thought of it makes him want to throw up.

"It's empty inside me," Mydei says, and maybe he is trying to convince Phainon of it too, maybe it is enough for him to pick up his things and run far, far away, "It's just hollow, like something has been *taken* from me. And I can't even tell when. Maybe it was when my dad first punched me in the throat. Or maybe when he killed my mom. Maybe it was when I was raped but honestly, I think I was already missing something at that point. I think that's why he did it. Maybe he saw the opening and wanted to make that hole bigger, for some reason, or—No, I don't think so. I don't even think he knew what he was doing to me. I certainly didn't."

Phainon comes ever-closer. Still silent, still warm.

"For a long time, I didn't know. I knew something happened, yes, and that it made me feel bad, but I didn't know it… counted. It didn't even cross my mind. He broke, fuck—" Mydei can't help but laugh at what he is about to say, because right now, it is *truly* hilarious, "He broke up with me a few days later, and then I went down this spiral. I dropped out of my master's program. Ancient Philology. I locked myself in my room and didn't leave the house for two months, not even to get groceries. I would stay up until 5 AM looking at people getting into car crashes. Something about seeing other people getting hurt comforted me. That's pretty fucked up, isn't it?"

Now, he turns to look at Phainon, and he finds him staring back, looking—serene. Not particularly upset, but he does have a furrow in his brow. His breathing is even. His eyes are kind and sleepy. He blinks slowly like a happy cat.

Something ugly claws at the walls of his chest, threatening to spill out. It's something that he has thought often, regarding Phainon, his seemingly endless patience, his easy laughter, his sickly-sweet kindness. Something that scares him when it hits him.

Something that spells, in red letters, *'Just do it already. Just rape me and get it over with. I am so easy. I would be so good. I wouldn't even cry.'*

Mydei whines as the letters sound out in his head. How distressing. How cruel it is, that it is trying to take the only good thing he has for him. Not even this—he is not allowed not even this. He is not allowed anything. An ascetic lifestyle like a monk, devoid of worldly pleasure, drink little, eat less, do not speak, do not kiss, do not fuck, do not love.

Phainon looks back at him with ease, like he's not looking at something disastrously ugly. That pisses Mydei off, too. What is he doing this for? Is this pretend? Why is he acting like it's *easy?* Like he is easy to get along with, easy to love, easy to be in the presence of? The more Mydei has talked, the more in love Phainon has looked. The softer his eyes got. He does not seem sad or disturbed, he seems… Happy in a way.

He wants to tell him. Wants to grab him by the shoulders and shake him hard and say *'rape me, please, just do it, the suspense is killing me!'*.

The words are just on the tip of his tongue, battling their way through his teeth. They want out like fish want water. They want to wipe that beautiful look off of Phainon's face. They want to hurt, to bite, to spill blood, to degrade him and bring him down to Mydei's level, so that they may revel in this misery together like pigs in a pigsty.

Mydei has to physically bite his fist to restrain himself from ruining this good thing they have. He bites down hard until his teeth leave angry red indents. It is then that Phainon moves slowly, and Mydei thinks, *'oh, oh, this is it, this is—'*

He puts his hand on Mydei's cheek and Mydei's heart jumps out of his chest like a spook prey animal. He expects *something,* he does not know what, but something that hurts. He is met with something entirely different, however.

Phainon rubs under his eye with his thumb and Mydei realizes, oh, he's crying. He started crying at some point, but he is not sure when. Perhaps he has he been crying since the beginning. He sniffles. Phainon moves to the next eye and, when he has deemed them dry enough, he leans over and places a small, careful kiss on his shoulder.

Mydei is a little dumbstruck for a moment, and then warmth returns to him in waves, nice and pleasant, filling him up. Phainon lets his hand rest on the center of his chest, where his heart beats fastest. His cheek finds its place on Mydei's shoulder and he sighs wistfully into it. Finally, he looks up at him with a small smile.

"Go on," Phainon says simply, "I'm listening."

Mydei is so in love. He is so in love.

"I…" he starts, "I didn't even know what happened or why I suddenly felt so bad," he whispers, hating how weak it sounds, "My therapist couldn't figure it out either, you know, why my mental health just took such a sudden dive. One day she just *asked* me to recall every event of the past however many months in detail, and I offhandedly mentioned it to her and—" he sighs, "I'm never going to forget her reaction. Her eyes got big and concerned and I thought… Oh, that must've been something bad that happened, and she—She told me she was sorry and that I was sexually assaulted and at first I didn't… believe her. Didn't want to. Honestly, I wanted to drop her as my therapist, but I stuck by it and—"

He runs a hand down his face. Looks away from Phainon. "The more we talked, the more I realized that it wasn't the… only time, I guess. I didn't know that… being nagged into it counted. Or just giving up so he'd stop bothering me about it—I'm sorry, this is a lot. It's not your fault, Phainon."

Phainon chuckles a little, then kisses his shoulder again. "I know. Oh, sorry—was that alright? The kiss?"

"...Yes."

"It's not a lot, it's—" and he brushes a lock of hair out of Mydei's face, "I just don't know what to say. I'm not very good at this. But I'm happy to just listen. I'm glad you told me. I get it, some of it I mean, that feeling of being empty and not whole… Yeah, I get it."

Mydei blinks at him. "Are you going to tell me about Cyrene?"

"Soon," Phainon answers with a twitch of his mouth, "Before her anniversary. I promise. I just—I just need a bit longer."

Mydei, weirdly, does not mind this. He thinks that Phainon is patient with him, so he, too, can be patient with Phainon. And just between him and God, he's put two and two together—the car accident, Cyrene's passing, Phainon's need to be forgiven. He just wants to hear it from Phainon. Mydei sighs, and recognizes the tell-tale signs of the death throes of a mental breakdown. The deep exhaustion and bone ache. The haze of disassociation saving him from all of it.

Phainon leaves his side and the room is suddenly much colder. He sits up and looks down at Mydei. "Darling," he coos, stroking his hair, "Dear. Beloved. Sweetheart. Lance of Fury."

He makes himself laugh at that, because he always laughs at his jokes, and it gets a chuckle out of Mydei too. "I'm going to take a bath, okay, love?" Phainon continues, "You can join me if you want to."

"Okay. I'll think about it."

With that, Phainon gets up from the bed, leaving it much lighter than it ever was and Mydei sinks deeper into the mattress.

He does think about it for ten or so minutes and decides that he does *not* feel up to bathing, but that he *does* want to spend some time with Phainon. He discards his pants, and he is already shirtless, so…

The walk to the bathroom does not feel real. Tiredness presses on his shoulders like a murder of crows looking onto a deserted battlefield, waiting, wanting. He can hardly keep himself upright. Every movement is slowed, as though he were covered in molasses and fighting against the current. He has to stop once, when he gets dizzy, before he can continue.

As tired as he is, and he is *exhausted*, the need to see Phainon is stronger. He wants to see him—he *has* to see him. Every moment spent with his eyes looking at anything *but* him is a moment wasted. If we are talking about pyramids of necessities, Phainon is at the very top, trumping them all.

Mydei cracks the door open and finds Phainon in the bathtub, doubled over on himself, knees to his chest. When he hears the door creak, he looks up. Looks at Mydei.

His eyes are puffy and red, like he has been crying, and if he *has* been crying—he has done so silently. What a beautiful weeper his lover is, *just* like Saint Sebastian, *just* like the Virgin Mary.

When he sees Mydei naked, *fully* naked in all of his bare glory, he quickly looks away. He seems a little embarrassed, and Mydei finds it very endearing.

"Phainon…" Words are hard and slow right now, and so they come out a little slurred, "Why are you crying?"

"Oh, uh…" The tips of Phainon's ears go red, "Nothing, it's just, what you said, I felt—It was sad, and I felt bad that it was happening to you."

Phainon, crying for him? What a fool. What an utter waste of hydration. Phainon should never cry, Mydei thinks, instead he should *laugh.* He loves his laughter, his ungainly snorts, the way it shows off all of his teeth and his gums. He should never cry, and especially not for Mydei of all people. He can shoulder the burden. They can do it together, maybe.

"You can look at me, if you want to," Mydei says, and it is barely the whisper of a whisper. What remains unsaid is: *please, please look at me.*

Phainon looks, turns his head slowly as though unsure. He looks at Mydei's face first, and then his gaze lingers down like a shooting star. His collarbones. The swells of his breasts. His strong, flat stomach, his narrow waist. Lower then, to his hipbones jutting out, the curve of his thighs and, finally, his flaccid cock between his legs. He stops there, looks at it for a moment or two. Tilts his head a little, breathes in heavy. They have never been naked before, not like this. It's freeing, in a way, and terribly intimate. Mydei finds that he does not mind it.

When he has gotten his fill of staring, and Phainon is *truly* shameless about this, he looks up back up at Mydei's face and meets his eyes.

In this sickly yellow light of this cold bathroom, Phainon is beautiful like a ghost, like something forgotten. Like a small prayer between lovers carved into a random wall, or the footprints of someone that has left long ago. He is as though a beautiful memory, unreal in its sincerity, and Mydei cannot believe that this moment exist, that it is tangible and in the physical realm, that he can stretch his arm forward and touch it. Touch him.

"I'm sorry for freaking out," Mydei says, "You've been very good to me. I feel like I haven't been—"

"You're the best thing that's ever happened to me," Phainon says immediately, cutting him off, his voice resonating off of the tile walls like an echo.

Mydei blinks, stunned. "I haven't done anything."

"Nonsense. You've helped me a lot. Before we started dating, I—" he groans, "This is a little embarrassing, but seeing you at work, it was kind of the only thing I was looking forward to. I had a massive crush on you."

Mydei smiles, bemused, and allows himself this, "I feel like I am meant to be here, with you. I feel like it's fate or something. I think… I would do it all again, if it meant meeting you. I would go through all of it again."

Phainon's eyes get big, "I would rather you didn't."

"I would, though, seriously. I would do it all again if it meant I would end up in *this* bathroom, on *this* night."

Phainon flushes, just the way Mydei likes it, and chuckles nervously like a schoolboy in love. He moves in the bathtub and it makes the water slosh around him. He makes some space for Mydei.

"Come in?"

He does not need to be asked twice. Mydei is pulled in by Phainon's gravitational force, like a planet happily orbiting the Sun. One leg in and then the other, and then he is sitting down and facing Phainon.

He looks at Phainon. Phainon looks back. He is reminded, briefly, of a similar position they have taken, millions of years ago, when Phainon was sick like a dog and Mydei was so full of love he could barely take it. Back when he confessed his feelings to him and Phainon, beautifully, returned them. What a happy night that was. What a happy night this is, too.

They look at each other and none speak. He does not mind being naked around Phainon. He loves it, actually. Loves how simple and primal it is. Two of them, one two, so simple, so easy to count. Naked, just like they were always meant to be, and this is certainly erotic, but it is not sexual. It is not threatening. Phainon is not threatening.

Mydei smiles at him and Phainon smiles back. He can hardly keep his eyes open, the poor thing, and the water is getting cold around them, but none want to step out.

Mydei opens his arms in invitation, says, "Come to me," and Phainon comes.

('Just like Cyrene,' Phainon thinks then. Just like in his dream, her on the rocks of a wrathful sea, calling him to his doom. Mydei calls him too, now, calls him to something sweet and, like a moon orbits the Earth, so too does Phainon orbit Mydei.)

He snuggles up in Mydei's arms, applying weight to all the right places, emptying his head of thoughts. He is so comfortable to hold, so soft, and Mydei wraps his arms all around him. Phainon finds solace in the crook of his neck, and Mydei buries his nose in the crown of his head. This is the most natural way to exist. Together, entangled, inseparable.

"I killed a cat once, did I ever tell you?" Mydei tells him, though he is not sure why, "It was after I first testified against my father. My uncle was called into work out of nowhere, even though he took the day off, and he asked one of the neighbors to look after me. She was a bit busy right then but ah, she said she would come as soon as she is done, and…" Mydei kisses his head, "While I was waiting for her in the yard, a cat came over. Orange and small. It rubbed on my leg and purred and I've always hated the sound of cats purring. It makes me want to cry. I was so… so mad. I was so upset. I was *so* upset, I can't even describe it. I felt like an infected wound, like… pus. I was pus oozing out."

He stops for a moment. Remembers. He picked it up, then, and—

"I didn't even know what happened until I was looking at its body. I didn't—I didn't mean to. I didn't want to do it. I kept thinking about my dad. About the way he pulled my hair and unbuckled his belt, about the way he would shove my mom into walls. I thought about her body. About how scared she must've been. About how much it must've hurt. I… I wanted to feel…"

"Strong?"

"…Yeah. Strong. It's my biggest regret. I can't even think about it. It hurts so much to think about it. I can't stand being around cats anymore. I think I'll hurt them. I'm not—I'm not the type that hurts animals. I like animals. I hate myself for it, I don't want to be someone that hurts animals, but—"

"I don't think you are," Phainon slurs in his arms.

"If I could change anything, it would be the only thing I would change. The cat didn't deserve that."

"No. Neither did you."

"Are you mad at me?" Mydei whispers, and Phainon makes a noncommittal sound.

"You did tell me you killed a cat before, remember? The night we started dating?"

Mydei does not remember, but he does not remember much anyways.

"I… Look, I'm not mad at you. You were a kid and you're not a cruel adult. It was a mistake. I've done worse."

"With Cyrene?" Mydei tries.

"Yeah, with Cyrene."

Mydei sighs and holds Phainon closer. "I'm not going to hurt Bartholos."

"No, you won't. But you could try being his friend. Who knows? Maybe he's the reincarnation of that cat and this is like, your chance or something."

"…I'll try."

Phainon kisses his breast then, and once more on his collarbone. "You're so… soft…" he trails off, sinking deeper, "Mmm… Soft Dei…"

They stay silent for a few minutes. Phainon's breathing slows more and more, until Mydei hears a low snore. He cracks his eyes open and sees Phainon, sleeping deep in his arms, comfortable and content.

He pokes his cheek and Phainon does not stir, and then he pulls some of his hair a little. He stays still through it.

After Mydei thoroughly makes sure Phainon is asleep, he leans down to the shell of his ears and stamps a lingering kiss there, something to warm him in his sleep. "I love you," he says, "I love you a lot."

It is an hour before Mydei finds it in him to wake Phainon up and drag him to the bed.

Chapter End Notes

at this rate i'm finishing this fic in my 30s. if you enjoyed please drop a comment or bartholos gets turned into cookies

Chapter 12: smaller

Chapter Summary

> If this chapter is disjointed, it's because it's the first part of a longer chapter. The full chapter is around 20k words and I thought that was far too long. Though it pains me, I have to break it into two parts. I'll post the second part right away :) Enjoy the earplay and the Mydei boobs.
>
> **!IMPORTANT**
>
> This chapter comes with **SMALL SUICIDE AND SEXUAL ASSAULT TWs**
> Specifics below vv
>
> ▶ Click me

Phainon is getting better.

He likes that. He likes the feeling of being at least a *bit* normal. He likes being functional. He likes being able to laugh with his entire mouth. He's surprised by how many things he likes, how the sun just seems to shine a bit brighter. He likes taking walks outside for no reason at all. He likes fresh fruit. He likes the taste of honeycakes. He likes talking to his dad, even when he rambles. Most of all, he likes being around being. Around his friends, Castorice and Hyacine and around his lover, Mydei, too. He likes making them laugh. He likes the sound of their laughter. He misses Cipher like a wound, but he enjoys listening to Hyacine and Castorice catching him up with how she's been.

He does not like looking at the little frame photo of him and Cyrene as children, but he does it, nonetheless. He looks at it everyday until, one day, the sight of it does not hurt anymore.

That he does not like.

Phainon puts down the photo back on the shelf and turns around where Mydei is playing on his Switch. Today has been one of those *Grumpy Mydei* days where he's not up to touching and cuddling, which is fine, but Phainon's fingers are itching in that similar, extremely suicidal way. He clenches his jaw.

"Mydei," he calls out, and Mydei does not answer him, "Mydei."

He gets like that, sometimes, it's fine, but—Mydei shifts around on the couch to lay down and bury half his face in one of the throw pillows.

"Mydei, I'm not—I don't feel well."

That gets his attention well enough, but he has that faraway look in his eyes, like he's not really *here*. What good timing Phainon has.

"…Why?" Mydei grumbles out, and Phainon can tell it's hard for him to sustain his attention like this.

This never gets easier. The verbalization. The shame seated deep in his stomach. Phainon shifts his weight from one leg to the other, tightening his fists then loosening them, and Mydei watches his, with tender, tired eyes.

"Is it… Cyrene?" he asks and at that, Phainon can only nod, stiff like a plank.

Mydei sighs, though not with malice—rather with a great effort as he lifts up from the couch. Heavy-boned, exhausted, he raises like a great beast out of the sea, and settles to sit on the couch. He pushes his legs together and pats his lap.

"Come to me," he tells Phainon, *come to me, come to me, come to me* and Phainon comes, he always comes—he is all but a simple moon orbiting around Mydeimos, tethered to his great, glorious axis.

He stands in front of him, for a moment, and Mydei looks up at him and he looks down at Mydei, and seconds pass nonetheless in the absence of Cyrene.

Then, slowly, Phainon sinks—sinks like has into depression, into psychosis, into alcohol. He sinks until his knees hit the rough carpet underneath him. Then he looks up at Mydei and Mydei looks down at him, and he opens his hands to Phainon, fingers splayed.

Phainon rests his head on his lap, feels Mydei's thighs underneath his head soft enough to be comfortable and firm enough to be stable. He feels the fine blonde hairs tickling his cheek. He bears down on Mydei like the weight of the world, like Cyrene's ghost pressed against his back, like the cross on Jesus' shoulder.

Phainon closes his eyes when Mydei's hand come to card through his hair, blunt fingernails scratching his scalp. Above him, Mydei breathes evenly.

"What's wrong?" he asks, and Phainon doesn't know how to tell him that the answer is *everything*. Everything is a little wrong. It's better. It *is* better, and he's not saying it just to convince himself. Everything is better. But it is also a little wrong.

"I don't feel…" Phainon tries, voice muffles by Mydei's shorts, "It's… I feel guilty, because… I don't know how to explain it. I looked at her picture—Cyrene's—and I feel guilty because I don't… She doesn't make me want to kill myself as bad. I don't feel as bad when I think of her, and that… That makes me really want to kill myself."

Mydei stops caressing his hair. It is enough to make Phainon crack his eyes open and look up at him. He finds Mydei staring blankly ahead at the framed picture of Cyrene, blinking slowly, half-asleep. Doubtless his tongue feels as heavy in his mouth as Phainon's does right now. His lips twitch over words, but they don't come for a long while, until finally Mydei seems to have understood what Phainon is trying to tell him.

"You want to kill yourself because you don't feel like you want to kill yourself enough? Like you don't… present an adequate amount of suicidal ideation?"

"Something like that."

"But, Phainon, isn't that… good?"

"No, it's—My sisters is dead. And I feel better."

"That's good."

"It's not—"

Mydei screws his eyes shut. Breathes out heavily.

"When will it be enough?"

Phainon stiffens where he is kneeling. He blinks. "Hm?"

"What amount of suicidal ideation will make up for Cyrene's death? When is your trial over? When will you be free? It's been almost a year since she died, God, Phainon—have you not paid the price in grief a thousand times over already? Do you have some sort of self-imposed KPI for self-flagellation?"

Phainon's mouth goes dry and he wets his cracked lips with his tongue. "No—"

"What use is it? It won't bring her back. Nothing will. And I don't think it's making her particularly happy, either. Would she want this? Is this honoring her memory? She's not even —you're not *celebrating* her!"

Phainon takes his head from his lap and looks up at him. In a way, he feels betrayed, and most importantly—he doesn't like the tone of Mydei's voice.

"Don't yell at me," Phainon tells him, and Mydei sighs at it.

"I'm not *yelling,* I'm just speaking with passion—Look, I apologize, okay…"

He stops and runs his hands down his face and, when he speaks up again, he sounds a great deal calmer. "I didn't mean to yell, or make it sound like I'm yelling," Mydei starts, "But Phainon, I—"

"You're running out of patience, is that it?" Phainon snarks.

Mydei grits his jaw. *"No,"* he answers quickly, "And don't speak to me like that, either. I'm not running out of patience."

Then, gentle and kind, his hands cup Phainon's face and Phainon—he immediately forgets what he was mad at in the first place. He melts into the touch, going limp in Mydei's hands, his eyes falling half-lidded and then closed. He breathes out a breath he did not know he was holding.

Mydei clicks his tongue. "Oh, my boy…" he whispers, "My sad, sullen, boy…" He rubs his cheeks his thumbs, right under Phainon's eyes, where the skin deepens and purples into dark circles.

"I'm not running out of patience, Phainon," Mydei repeats, "I'm *scared.* I'm very, very scared for you. Whenever I'm at work and you're at home, it's the only thing I can think about. That I might come home and find you dead. And I really, *really* don't want to come home and find another person dead."

Phainon nuzzles into his hands. "I don't want you to feel like that."

Though he does not see it, Mydei's eyes soften as he looks down at Phainon. "Then *try*. Just try a little bit. Not for my sake or for yours, but—for Cyrene's. Try for her. She doesn't deserve to be a wound."

"Doesn't deserve to a be wound…" Phainon echoes. He has not considered that. "She shouldn't hurt."

"She shouldn't," Mydei reaffirms, "It's not fair to the person she was. Do you not have a… favorite memory of her? Something that makes you happy when you think of her?"

Phainon tries to remember and fails. His last months with Cyrene are mired by turmoil. She was unlike herself, back then. On the edge and nervous and full of an anger that neither of them recognized. She would blow up often and though they've always fought, it was never like *that.* She insulted him on purpose and, by God, Phainon was no better. They found what hurt in each other and poured salt into those open wounds.

That was unlike the both of them.

He thinks harder. Goes back further in time. Nothing stands out as *particularly* happy. They were never fairytale siblings. They were simply kids, with all of the hardships childhood brings.

Finally, a glint—a shard of remembrance. A night, months ago, and a ghost wearing little Cyrene's face. Her blanket, her matching pajama set, her choppy blonde bob. She crawled into bed with him then, and God, she must've only been seven or so years old—Phainon a grown man, finally the bigger brother, finally in a position to breathe love back into her. That was a fabrication born out of a chemical imbalance in his brain, but there was a time when it was *real*. It feels so far away, so long ago. It feels like it happened ten thousand years ago, and they were both early Homo Sapiens or even a simpler life form, prokaryotes or—simpler still, they were children.

"After our parents' divorce…" Phainon starts, feeling his throat dry, "I don't know, I was so scared for a reason. I would have nightmares every night, I really don't know *why*. Maybe I just missed my Dad, or… Anyways, we lived with Mom, and she worked early in the mornings, so I didn't want to wake her so I would just… wake up from my nightmares and cry as quietly as I could."

Mydei does not say anything, but he hums in approval. Caresses his ears and urges him to speak on.

"Every night, without fail, Cyrene would come to my room. I can still see it, see her cracking my door and peek inside with her chubby cheeks and her big blue eyes. She always came over with her blankie, too, and she would say something like, *'Nini, I had a nightmare, can I sleep with you?'* and I remember thinking—*That's silly, how can Reney have a nightmare? She's so big, she's my big sister.'"* Phainon allows himself to breathe out a laugh at the memory. "I always thought she was so big and so old, but I was like, five, and she was *seven*. Thinking back she was… so, so *little.* She was just a little girl, and she would come to my room so we could sleep together whenever "she" had a nightmare. But… I think she was lying, now that I think about it. I don't think she had nightmares. I think… she knew *I* did and she wanted to comfort me in a way that still allowed me to feel like a big boy. That was, ah, a thing when I was a kid. I wanted to be a big boy so bad."

"That was very kind of her," Mydei says and Phainon agrees because yes, that was very kind of her and more importantly, there was not a bone in Cyrene's body that was unkind. She was made of kind stuff, like repeat text messages and thoughtful gifts and Disney princess pajamas. She was a thread pulled taut and when she snapped, she took everything good in the world with her.

'No, that's not right,' Phainon thinks as he looks up at Mydei, 'Not *everything* good' She left Mydei behind, and Castorice and Polyxia and Hyacine, Cipher and Aglaea and Anaxa as well, and Bartholos, yes, Bartholos too. She left her cookbook behind. And all the thoughtful gifts she gave him. She left a lot of messages and TikToks and memes too. She left her pink PC setup and all of her Hatsune Miku figurines.

She left… a hole, carved out into Phainon in the shape of Aedes Elysiae's sunsets. The hole is in his side. It pulses with warmth, but it does not burn. It pulses with life. It pulses with *her*

'We learn to grow around the hole,' Anaxa told him, and they said *'Our sisters are worth the pain of mourning them,"* too.

"I miss her," Phainon finally says, and it is a first time admission. In the wake of her passing, he has hurt himself, has bled, and has attempted suicide.

But was it *for her? 'No,*' Phainon thinks, *'It was for my guilt, which I will not burden Cyrene's memory with.'*

This, though, he does for her. He misses her *for her.* Misses her for the sake of her absence. Misses her companionship, her warmth at his side, all the love she had for him and all the love he had for her. He misses loving her. He misses making her laugh. He misses braiding her hair. He misses bleaching their roots together. He misses their friendship, and he misses sleeping in the same bed as her.

He misses her and through missing her, returns personhood into who *she was*, not what she became—not the ghost haunting him, not the memory of guilt.

"I know," Mydei tells him, "I never knew her and I miss her, too."

"I miss her for—for the sake of missing her, does… Does that make sense?"

Understand me, he wants to say, *Please understand me;* isn't that so very human of him?

Mydei gives him a small smile, exhausted but kind, "Yeah, it does."

"I loved her."

"Of course."

"She was my friend. She was my sister."

"I know," he tells him again, and so uses his thumbs to smooth over the crease in his forehead, then lingers them down to his eyelids, where he closes them. The rubs them, running them over the lines of eyelashes, and something settles in Phainon's gut, heavy but comfortable.

"I don't know how to mourn her," he admits.

Mydei sighs, "I can't help you if you don't tell me what happ—"

"A bit more time. A little longer. Please."

"Okay," Mydei says, and his hands move to the back of Phainon's head, "Alright."

They sit in silence for a moment. Mydei sitting, Phainon kneeling, his head cradled in Mydei's hands. They move just when absolutely necessary, like when Phainon cranes his neck to press wet, open mouth kisses to Mydei's thigh; he does that often because it tickles him and makes him laugh. Making Mydei laugh is, indeed, an absolute necessity for Phainon. He laughs now, too, though Phainon can hear how tired he is.

The moment passes in slow comfort, lazy like molasses. Phainon is certain that Mydei has fallen asleep where he is sitting, but then he hears him speak up again.

"If Sam could carry Mister Frodo up Mount Doom, then you you can do it too and I think, in this allegory I am Sam and you are Mister Frodo, and then the ring is your sorrow, and I *am* willing to carry you, too—but in the grander scope of burdens and grief, you are also Sam and the grief is Mister Frodo, and the ring is, um—well, you understand, y'know—"

Phainon snorts. "Do you get all of your pep talks and emotional checkpoints from popular media? First it was Bojack Horseman, then Dune, now Lord of the Rings…"

Mydei flushes a bit, though he keeps his proud demeanor. "Well yes, I am autistic, so it is easier for me to relate to you through media, because verbalizing is—Matter of fact, Phainon, I don't need to explain myself to you. Take my pep talks or leave them, it makes no difference to me!"

"Right, yes, hmm…" Phainon trails off, and he lifts his head from Mydei's lap, stretches himself up enough to place a kiss to his bare sternum. Mydeimos is allergic to wearing shirts and prefers to breast boobily when he's at home, and it is both a blessing and a curse. A

blessing because Phainon gets to witness his chest in its full, and a curse because *wow*, those things are bouncing up and down like crazy and he just wants to *fondle* them. He can't, however, because Mydei is not quite there yet, and that's alright. He is more than happy to kiss them. Oh, that reminds him, there's something he's been meaning to talk about.

"You know, I've been thinking—" Phainon starts, but Mydei cuts him off.

"There he goes, the thinker."

"Shut up. I've been thinking, uh, you know, the other night when you tried to jork my peanits —"

"Don't call it that, *please*."

"Just let me finish, look—If you want to start doing like, *sex stuff*, I've been thinking—maybe we should start small, you know? We could, uh, I don't know, look stuff up, think on it, make a list and then talk about it. About our lists, I mean."

"You really like lists…" Mydei mumbles.

"Of course I do. They keep things nice and tidy. What do you think? Do you want to try?"

Mydei closes his eyes and ruminates on it. Phainon can tell he's thinking hard, which is rare for Mydei, by the way his jaw clenches. Then, the tension eases, and he simply answers with, "Ask me again when I'm not half-asleep and disassociating."

"Okay."

"And make me something to eat. I want to take a nap."

"Okay, so… take a nap? What do you need to eat for?"

"The lion is hungry."

Alright, well, if the *lion* is hungry, then Phainon can only oblige. He throws some bullshit on a pita for Mydei and serves it to him on a plate, then he watches him eat in silence—the lion eats his food like there's a bigger, hungrier lion approaching. Just snarfs that whole thing down, doesn't even ask Phainon if he wants any (he doesn't, but it's about being *asked*).

When he is done, Mydei puts the plate aside on the small coffee table. Lays down on the couch and twists around until he is nestled on it.

"The lion is going to sleep."

There's no arguing with the lion when he's like this.

Later that night, Mydei joins him in their bed and snuggles up to Phainon. He lays his head on his bicep, the way he always like to do it. Phainon brushes a lock of hair out of his face and Mydei suddenly says, *"I do."*

"What?"

"The sex stuff and the list. I want to try that."

Oh—Phainon has forgotten to *'ask when he's not half-asleep and disassociating'*. He blinks, a little stunned, and then laughs. "Oh, nice. Then I'll think about it, and you think about it too, okay?"

"Mm. Okay. Goodnight."

And they share their little goodnight kiss.

Though Mydei prefers to be the little spoon, Phainon has complained and whined until he turned him into his very own personal custom-made big spoon. He likes being the little spoon to Mydei because Mydei is very warm and heavy, but he also tosses and turns in his sleep. So, every day he wakes up blissed out and nearly suffocated to death by Mydei—and that's just heaven on earth for Phainon.

This is how he wakes up today, pinned between the mattress and Mydei, his face stuffed into the pillow. Life is so fucking awesome when you have a giant lionwife to crush you to death.

Phainon wriggles his way from underneath Mydei, managing to wake him up in the process. It's really great to see Mydei wake up, because he's all dumb and grumpy and dazed. It takes him *so* long to actually, truly wake up, so there is this window of opportunity for a few minutes where Mydei is really stupid and really confused. He groans as he wakes, mouth agape, pillow covered in drool, hair a tangled mess. Not a pretty sleeper at all, but still the sweetest sight Phainon has ever seen.

"Good morning, Mydei~" Phainon coos, leaning over to kiss his nose.

"Gguhh…" Mydei gurgles back, and Phainon takes that as a *"good morning to you too, my beautiful handsome lover"*—or something along those lines.

"Hey, hey, what's 2+2, hm?"

"Mnngh…"

"What country are we in?"

"Ahh?"

Phainon slaps his ass and makes him groan. "Let's brush our teeth. Your breath stinks, stinky boy."

"Ehh?"

On their days off, it's always a bit of a drag. Mydei is on the perfect pill cocktail that makes an absolute *boulder* during the morning. Phainon has to quite literally *drag* him out of bed, and on days where his mental health is *really* bad, he has to help him brush his teeth and

brush his hair as well. Today, however, is no such day, which is a relief because they have *plans* today.

It's been a few days since they agreed to the Sex Lists as Phainon likes to call them (to Mydei's dismay, of course). They decided that *today*, given that they're both off of work, they will talk about it and try something. Phainon is excited, of course, but mostly nervous.

Phainon gurgles his mouth wash and spits it in the sink. Next to him, standing shoulder to shoulder in their small bathroom, Mydei is brushing his teeth.

"We should make a whole day out of it," Phainon says, "Go on a date or something. We've never really been on a date, have we?"

Mydei hums. "No, I guess not."

"So? What do you say? I have something in mind."

"Something stupid, no doubt."

"Hey, don't be so mean when I'm trying to ask you out!"

"Okay, *fine*," Mydei gives in, "What do you want to do?"

Ah, he fell for it, hook, line and sinker. Phainon gives Mydei his most charming, most *disarming* smile, the one he knows he likes so, so much. He grabs his waist and flips them around, pressing Mydei's back into the sink and leaning over him—he does this all so suddenly that Mydei is taken by surprise, toothbrush still hanging between his lips. He looks at his with big eyes, pliant as a lamb, and he is just *irresistible*. Phainon takes the toothbrush from his mouth, sets it aside, and graciously allows him to spit out the toothpaste before he kisses him once. Phainon pulls back, then kisses him again, deeper this time. He slips his tongue between Mydei's parted lips, and he *loves* that Mydei parts his lips for him now, that he can finally kiss him as fiercely as he's always wanted to. He makes such soft, sweet sounds into their kiss, and Phainon drinks them up like a man parched.

His favorite part of having his tongue throat-deep in Mydei's mouth is that he can taste Mydei's tongue piercing. He's thought about it on countless nights, ever since that day in the gym. He loves this piercing, loves feeling it while he kisses Mydei. He feels the cool metal against his tongue as it slides against Mydei's, feels it press against his lips. Phainon likes licking it, likes the metallic taste, and he often asks Mydei to say "ahhh" and stick his tongue out so he can lap at his piercing.

When he has deemed Mydei sufficiently kissed, he pulls back and inspects his masterpiece; Mydei, a little dazed, a little flustered, flushed like a ripe peach from the tip of his ears to his collarbones. His eyes are feline and mellow, his lips bruised purple and red, swollen from the kiss. He blinks slowly, as though in a haze, and Phainon is so full of affection that he does not know where to put it. He brushes a hand against his ear, rubbing the earlobe with his thumb, feeling the little hole where it is pierced. Mydei reacts immediately, his ears are awfully sensitive, and he leans into the touch.

"I want to go out," Phainon finally answers him, "Get something nice to eat for brunch and maybe some dessert. Then we go on a walk in the park, and then we can come home and talk about our lists. What do you think?"

Every time Phainon kisses Mydei with tongue, there is short stretch of time, less than a second long, where Mydei is pliant and good and obedient. You can see it in the way his eyes soften and his mouth parts. It's a good look on him but it never lasts long. Phainon watches as Mydei's senses come back to him, and his gaze sharpens.

"Sometimes I wonder why I entertain you," Mydei starts with a scoff, "But so be it, your little *'date'* sounds fun enough."

Fun enough is about as much as Mydei can ever manage and Phainon is, simply, overjoyed.

They get dressed and go out. Phainon knows a nice, intimate little place where they serve Luofu specialty food. It's the sort where the owner's kid is doing his homework at one of the tables. The food is great and Mydei ends up eating three entire bowls of winter melon soup. The older woman serving them notices, slaps him on the back and calls him a *"big boy"*.

"The biggest," Mydei answers her, "And bigger than him, no?"

"Oh, yes, much bigger!" she laughs as she walks away.

Mydei turns to look at him with a shit-eating grin plastered all over his pretty face. "Did you hear that? *Much bigger.*"

"She's only saying that so you buy more food and drive up the bill," Phainon says.

"Well, it's working. Auntie, can I have some yellow eel with rice?"

It's actually kind of ridiculous how much food fits into this man, but Phainon finds it endearing. He watches Mydei eat and finds himself overbrimming with love. He's so cute when he chews. Phainon wants to crush his stupid head.

Phainon insists on paying the bill and even though they have eaten a lot, the place is very affordable, so it doesn't put a hole in his wallet. Mydei buys them dessert—some banana and Nutella crepes from this food truck parked nearby. They're, eh, fine. Nothing special, a little dry, but still sweet. They walk all the way to a park to eat them, sat shoulder to shoulder on a bench.

The weather is nice. Sunny, but still a little chilly—the perfect weather for a jacket. Mydei is wearing his handsome leather jacket, and Phainon has this vintage flight jacket Cyrene thrifted for him years ago. They look quite good, a dashing pair of young men.

The park is reasonably close to Phainon's place and, while it's not the pinnacle of green urban spaces, it has its own charm. Most importantly, it has a small lake full of all sorts of birds, and he can't wait to show Mydei the—

"…Gay swans?" Mydei blanks at him, blinking dumbly. There's a bit of chocolate in the corner of his lips, which Phainon wipes away with his thumb.

"Yup, swans. That are gay. Gay swans."

"How do you know the swans are gay?" Mydei frowns, "Why are the swans here?"

"I mean, I don't know, the city brought them here, I guess? Maybe for like, biodiversity? And for us to gawk at. But yeah, the swans are gay."

"Okay, so how do you know the swans are gay?"

"Well, they're both boys and they like, court each other and stuff. The park people even gave them two swans egg to hatch and like, yeah, they're raising kids together now."

"I…" Mydei gapes, then turns his gaze downwards at his own hands. They clench into fists, then unclench. "I did not consider swans could be gay…"

"C'mon, I wanna show you the gay swans!" Phainon grabs his hand as he gets up, pulling him along to the lake.

When they get to the lake, the swans (who are gay) are nowhere to be found. Mydei grips the railing and looks on forlornly towards the horizon. He sighs.

"I guess they're sleeping…" he mumbles. Phainon comes up behind him and wraps his arms around his waist, chin resting on his shoulder.

"That's a shame, they're very cute—oh, I think I have a video of them, hold on—" Phainon fishes his phone out of his pocket, opens his gallery, and scrolls up until he finds a video from way back in the summer.

He shows Mydei. It is, indeed, a video of the gay swans. They are both black with beautiful, shiny plumage. They are swimming around each other while cooing, heads bobbing, and finally, at the end of the video, they meet in the middle and press their foreheads together, forming a heart.

Mydei watches the video and huffs bemusedly. "That's pretty cute," he says and Phainon, looking at him, agrees.

They walk back home hand in hand. Phainon swings their joined hands like they're a couple in a cartoon.

"Successful first date?" he asks.

"Eh, it was adequate," Mydei answers and he's got that cocky smile on him again, the one that makes Phainon want to bully him and wipe it off his face.

The closer they get the their apartment, the sweatier Mydei's hand grows. Phainon feels it cold and clammy against his and when he turns to check on him, he finds Mydei tense. His brows are furrowed, mouth twitching as though he's having an argument in his head.

"Are you nervous?" Phainon asks, and Mydei shrugs noncommittally.

"Like a fawn in a wolf's maw."

"Look, we don't have to do anything if you don't want to."

"I do want to. I'm also nervous. Those things can coexist."

"Okay, but *like a fawn in a wolf's maw* isn't a normal level of nervousness."

"It is for me."

Phainon leaves it at that. Mydei will let him know if there's anything wrong—hopefully.

The second he steps foot inside the apartment, Phainon is hit with such exhaustion that he's thrown off center. Holy shit, he's *really* tired and he's barely *done* anything. Is he getting old? Or maybe it's the meds.

"Mydei, I'm like, *really* tired," he says as he unlaces his boots, "I wanna rest before we do anything."

"Hmm…" Mydei hums, "Okay. I'm sleepy and full of soup. I can hear it slosh around in my stomach when I walk."

"What? Lemme hear," he presses his ear to Mydei's stomach. When Mydei starts wiggling a little, oh my God, *yes*, he can hear the soup in his stomach. That's ridiculous.

"Mydei… you are pregnant with our soup baby."

"Indeed. Our soup son will be mighty, and strong like twelve lions. He will conquer cities."

"And if it's a girl?"

"She will conquer cities nonetheless."

Mydei is so funny when he wants to be. He always makes Phainon laugh, and laugh he does now, too. '*What a wonderful day this has been,'* he thinks as he collapses on the bed and sets an alarm for one and a half hours from now. Phainon cannot remember why he has ever been sad.

Mydei lays his head on his bicep and his body radiates impossible warmth.

What bliss.

They both manage to sleep through the alarm, and now the sun has set outside.

After refreshing themselves and grabbing a quick snack, Phainon and Mydei find themselves sitting opposite of each other on the bed. Phainon fiddles with his fingers nervously. Mydei looks so tense that he might actually snap in two.

It's going great. This is definitely how normal people go about having some quick sexy fun.

"Phain—"

"I feel like throwing up."

"Jesus. Okay."

"I need to lay down."

"Okay? Lay down. You're on a bed."

Phainon lays down.

"This was your idea," Mydei intelligently points out.

"Yeah, I know, and now I'm nervous, okay? Let me be nervous."

"I'm not stopping you from being nervous," Mydei mumbles, shifting to lay down next to him. He takes his hand and squeezes it. "But what are you so nervous about?"

He runs his free hand down his face. "I'm nervous that you're going to hate it and not tell me."

Mydei hums. "I might freeze. I'm not entirely sure if I will because, I mean, I haven't done anything like this since then, but—I will do my best to let you know and… Just check in every once in a while. Pay attention to me. You'll know if I don't feel well."

"Yeah, I just—I want to make this good for you."

"Phainon, tsk—" Mydei clicks his tongue and rises up. He cups Phainon's face, hovering above him. "Even if it's not good, then… That's, I guess, okay? We're just trying stuff out. It's not a performance, just—You said it's supposed to be fun. We should have fun."

'Fun…' Phainon echoes in his mind. He cranes his neck to kiss his palm, and then presses deeper to nuzzle into it like a needy cat. Mydei sighs and pulls his head in his lap, calls him a *'big baby'*, and pets his hair.

"Are *you* still nervous?" Phainon mutters at one point.

"Yes," Mydei simply answers and Phainon thinks, *how wonderful, to be nervous together.*

They stay like that for a moment, Phainon's head in Mydei's lap, until he feels his nerves settle and calm.

"Okay, right, I'm—I'm feeling better, uh, my phone—" Phainon reaches on the nightstand for it. "Do you have your list?"

"I do," Mydei says, grabbing his own phone.

"So, okay," Phainon opens his notes app and finds his *'sexy stuff to do w/ Mydei'* list, "Right, so, here's my id—"

"I'll start first. Intercrural sex."

Phainon's mouth falls agape with a scandalized gasp. "Mydei, *no*!"

"Why not? I've always wanted to try." Mydei tilts his head, "It is how the Kremnoan warriors of old used to do it. They would do it right after battle. Wouldn't even wash the blood off of them. Don't you think that's hot?"

"Okay, yes, that *is* pretty hot, but—Mydei, we said we're starting *small.*"

"Is that not small?"

"Thighfucking is not *small*, it's huge! It's basically one step below penetrative sex!"

"Hm. I suppose that's right," Mydei locks his phone and puts it away, "Well, that's all from me."

"That's it? That's *all* you had on your list?"

"Yeah. Couldn't think of anything else."

"You're impossible," Phainon groans, and *God*, this man drives him absolutely crazy! What's worse, every time Mydei drives him to the edge of his sanity, Phainon falls a little more in love with him. What a bunch of stupid jerks they are.

Phainon glances through his list quickly and devises a battle plan. A strategy, one might call it.

"Right, okay, so here's what I'd like to do—"

Phainon touches Mydei's face, thumb on his lips, and he delights in how easily Mydei opens his mouth for him, eager to suck his thumb—Mydei is so good at it too, loves doing it. The memory of his piercing pressed into the pad of his thumb makes Phainon groan and, while he would love to shove his fingers down his throat, that's not what he wants to do with him now. As Mydei reaches to wrap his lips around his thumb, Phainon denies him the satisfaction and swiftly moves it to the shell of his ear. He's wearing his chunky gold earrings; he must've fallen asleep in them. They're big, dangling to his jawline and hanging from braided chains, round like plates, engraved with the face of some ancient king. They look like fat golden coins, expensive and luxurious. Phainon likes these earrings most of all, because they clink prettily every time he moves his head.

Phainon pinches his earlobe gently, there where the earring hangs. He finds the skin tender and warm to the touch, though he cannot tell if it's because of the earring's weight or Mydei's flush. "Your ears are so sensitive," Phainon breathes out, trying to keep himself from shuddering, and they *are*. His ears are some of his most erogenous spots. The reaction and instant and obvious—Mydei sucks in a sharp breath. "I would like to… play with them. Kiss them… See how they taste, and—" This part is a little embarrassing, "I would like to play with your chest, too. You could sit in my—my lap."

Mydei breathes out evenly. His eyes get big and wide for a moment, and then they settle into a comfortable half-lidded gaze. "Your lap?"

"Yes, that would be… Uh, easier, I think," Phainon says, "Do you—Would you like to do that? Hm?"

"Um…" Mydei pulls back a bit, though not enough to break their touch, "We can try."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah, that's—yes. I'll tell you if I don't, you know—if we should stop."

The air between them feels impossibly hot. Mydei's ears do, too. Warm and pink and lovely all over, that's how he always is. He looks at Phainon now, a little shy, a little unsure, yet eyes filled nonetheless with cautious trust. As such, he puts something very precious in Phainon's hands, lets him hold it, and the unspoken promise is that he will not drop it and shatter it.

Phainon finds that he does not know what he should do next.

"I don't know where to start," Phainon admits, hushed. He's been struck dumb all of a sudden, as if he hasn't tangled in bed with other people before.

Mydei tilts his head. "Kiss me."

The distance between them disappears.

It is not the hungry and lusty kiss that Phainon has expected. It's gentle, slow, a little awkward with the way neither know what to do with their hands. Mydei, quite surgically, places them on both of Phainon's shoulders. Phainon finds purchase on his waist, closes his eyes, and furrows his brows.

This is enough. Mydei is so soft under his palms. So warm. His breath is sweet against his mouth when they part from the kiss, and his lips are sweeter still when they dip back into each other.

"Do you want to take my shirt off?" he asks into Mydei's jawline and feels him nod against his lips.

They part and Mydei pulls off his shirt; Mydei is, as always, already shirtless. He feels his hand on the side of his neck, cupping his old tattoo, then it moves to trace the golden line across his chest with a thumb. "What's this tattoo about?" Mydei asks.

"Got it forever ago, I was nineteen. I was matching with Cyrene—she had a moon on her sternum."

"It's very pretty, but you need to get it touched up, it's faded. My friend Peucesta is a tattoo artist, I can talk to him."

"I thought Peucesta was a drag queen?"

"That's his night job."

"Oh, okay, yeah I mean, sure."

Phainon looks at him, Mydei looks back. He blinks. "We were supposed to…" Phainon starts, and Mydei makes a soft *'oh'* sound.

"Right, yeah, should I get on your lap?"

Phainon spreads his legs and opens his arms for him. He watches as Mydei tenses for a moment, shoulders stiffening, jaw clenching. He holds out out for him for a second, then two, then thirty, as Mydei makes his decision—

Then, beautifully, he comes.

Mydei crawls into his lap like a cat, twists around so they are sitting back to chest.

Here he is, in his arms, where he belongs. Trembling all over—from the cold, most likely, but perhaps also from fear. Phainon buries his nose in his hair and inhales. Mydei's cologne smells so good, like pomegranate and myrrh and blood, and he wears it all the time, too—it's just an intense smell, but everything about Mydei is sublimely intense. The dark gazes he casts upon Phainon, the way he grabs him, the way he kisses him like they're facing the end of the world—Phainon cannot get enough of him, of the rough way he loves.

"Comfortable?" he asks once Mydei settles.

"Comfortable enough," Mydei answers back, ever the grump.

Phainon hums against him. He moves a hand up Mydei's side, resting them on his waist, gripping softly—not enough to hurt, but enough to put pressure. The other hand moves his hair out of the way and bares his flushed nape.

He cannot resist kissing it, no man could.

Phainon places a soft, chaste kiss on his nape, feels how heated Mydei's skin is under his lips. Mydei breathes out at that and Phainon takes it as a sign to go further; to kiss the side of his throat, to lap at it with the flap of his tongue, to nip the spot where his jawline meets his neck, where he knows Mydei is very sensitive. He squirms in his hold, though he does not squirm *away*. Phainon brings his mouth to his ear, lets him feel his heated breath before he talks.

"Do you like having your chest touched?" he whispers, low.

Mydei shivers. "I think I do."

"Do you…" Phainon rests his palms over his stomach, "Play with them when you touch yourself?"

Phainon realizes, only after he's said it, that dirty talking is a bit of a risky move, and he should've asked Mydei beforehand. He is just about to do that when he feels Mydei let out a

small, nearly imperceptible, sound, cute and needy. He feels him push himself deeper into his lap. This might mean he *likes* it, but Phainon should still make sure.

"I, uh, don't really touch myself anymore, because, you know, but when I used to… Yes, I did."

Phainon bites down his tongue at that because, I mean, holy *shit*, what an *image* Mydei has planted in his head. Mydei, perhaps on his back, writhing on the sheets in the throes of his pleasure, one hand stroking his cock, the other pinching his nipples. *Wow.* Phainon's feeling lightheaded.

"Do you like it when I speak to you like this?" Phainon asks, peeking at Mydei from the side.

"I don't know," Mydei whispers, awfully honest, "I… think I do, but—"

"It's embarrassing?"

"Yeah."

Phainon laughs, though he does not laugh at him. He simply loves how sincere his Mydei is. "I can stop, if you want to."

Mydei scoffs at him. "You're doing an awful lot of talking, anyways. You can keep doing it, but—" he chastises, but then he cranes his head around and catches Phainon's gaze. Phainon finds, in this look of his, an awful lot of vulnerability, some fear, and a glimmer of hope that pleads: "Don't be too crass, *please*."

"No, of course not, oh—" Phainon babbles, suddenly entranced by all that he is given; Mydei's faith, his trust, and his vulnerable heart. "Oh, Mydei, my Mydeimos, my *love*..."

Phainon wraps his arm around his head, turning it around so he can steal a heated kiss from him. They both groan into it, and then Phainon's hands inch higher up, not quite touching where they need to but rather resting under his breasts, cupping them as if holding them up. They are heavy in his palms, rising up and down with Mydei's quickened breaths. The way he always hitches his breath when he is touched, Phainon thinks, makes up for all the suffering in his life.

"Mydei, *Mydei,*" he groans when he pulls apart, and gives his lover but a moment to breathe before he is on his ear, lips to his lobe. He runs the flat of his tongue over the sharp earring wire. It stings him sweetly, nearly scrapes a scratch on his tongue and yet, weirdly, that only works to make the moment thicker and heavier for him. He grasps the steel back of the earring between his teeth and pulls until it slides free. With it, Mydei's earring falls down under its own weight, landing somewhere on the bed. One of his hands finds his other ear, removes the earring there, then runs a thumb over the gentle spiral of his ear shell. He feels the tiny, very fine hairs there, and Mydei breathe out heavy against him.

"Mydei, oh, your ears are so sensitive, you are so—you're such a dream," Phainon babbles and he is already half-hard in his pants just from the excitement of caressing Mydei's bare skin.

His hands are everywhere they can reach—so are his lips. His hips and his stomach, the long column of his neck, his elegant jawline. In the wake of his machinations, Phainon leaves marks, little bruises and small red marks where his fingers gripped too tight.

He lingers on his ears, nipping the lobe, craning his neck to lick long across the curve of his helix. Mydei seems to love it; he wiggles and leans deeper into Phainon's touch, stretching his neck to give Phainon better access to his jugular, breathing laboriously but not quite *moaning* as Phainon would like him to.

"Mydei," Phainon exhales, lips to the back of his ear where it connects to his head. He finds the skin warmed and red and Phainon can't help but nose into it, inhaling his smell; Mydei always make sure to dab some cologne there, and now Phainon is swimming in that scent, like an old, haunted church. Phainon can't help but bring his teeth to this place, to nip and pull at the skin. Mydei is *especially* touchy here, it seems, if the low groan he lets out is anything to go by. "Mydei, Mydei, is this okay?"

"It's—yes, it's fine, I think. You can go on. Didn't you say you were going to touch my, ah, my chest?"

Phainon grins and has to physically stop himself from grinding up into Mydei. "Oh, darling, are you eager?"

He thinks, for a moment, that he is going to have to work for it, that he's going to have to pull Mydei's sincerity out of him like a dentist pulls a rotten tooth. Instead, Mydei takes him by surprise, and simply blinks at him before saying, "Yes, I am."

It works to both hone the fire of his lust and pour honey over his heart. How sweet his Mydei is, how sincere, what a wonderful day today is, and how good life can be! Phainon kisses him, a quick peck on his lips. "You are eager? Is that true?" he asks dumbly, as if his ears are not to be trusted with what they hear.

Mydei adjusts himself in Phainon's lap, his ass pressing down against his reaction. Phainon grunts at it and is immediately ashamed of himself. What, is he a teenage boy? Mydei has not touched him at all and he is already painfully hard. At the same time, however, how could he not? Mydei is beautiful and soft and perfect in every way. He is as pleasing to the eye as nature or a painting are. Sublimely conceived, from his golden-brown skin to his strawberry blond hair, his amber-brown eyes and the red tattoos streaking him from face to feet—*those* he finds painfully erotic, as if Mydei's sculpted body was caressed and bound in red rope. Phainon wills the image away from his mind with quickness, lest he cums in his pants untouched like an idiot.

"Yes, it is true, why would I lie?" Mydei answers, and Phainon has been so lost in his lust that he's forgotten what he asked him in the first place. "Phainon, you're, um…" Mydei's gaze shies away, "You're *hard*, let me… I want to do something to you, too."

"No," Phainon says immediately before he can even think about, though even if he did, the answer would've been the same, "I don't want you to do anything to me for now, okay?"

"Whyever not?" Mydei frowns. He talks so strangely sometimes; who even says *'whyever'*. "It's not fair if you're not getting anything. Are you afraid I'll freak out?"

"First of all, yes, a little, and second of all—it's not about being *fair*, we're not going tit for tat. Fun, remember? Is this—are you not having fun?"

"I am," Mydei admits, looking at Phainon through his long lashes.

"Just stop thinking then and have fun." Phainon does not recognize the commanding tone in his voice. He nuzzles into Mydei's hair, lips mouthing little kisses at his lobe, and then he puts teeth to helix, bitting down and pulling. He tastes cartilage, feels the heat of Mydei's desire in his mouth and Mydei finally, *finally* rewards him with an open mouth moan, a beautiful *'ah'* that will, certainly, haunt him for days to come.

Phainon can hardly stand it. His dick is leaking and throbbing in his pants and Mydei keeps moving against him and he is so *beautiful*, it is all so beautiful, and—it's slow. Phainon likes that it's slow. He likes that they're not hurrying, that they're taking their time. He likes the way Mydei melts into his touch and his kisses, chest rumbling with little gasp and groans as though he were a purring kitten, and he likes the way Mydei looks at him, a little fearful and a little hopeful.

He takes his time with him and purposefully holds off from touching his chest. He wants Mydei even more turned on, even more desperate for it—and Mydei, bless him, delivers.

He is so worked up just from having his ears played with a little. His heavy breaths turn to groans turn to little gasps, and sometimes they become moans every time Phainon runs the flat of his tongue over his shell or when he blows on it. A few times, Phainon makes needy little sounds directly into his ear, low whines and small moans, just to see how Mydei kicks his feet with lust. *Note to self: Mydei is auditory person, use it to your advantage.* He talks to him through it, tells him he is doing *so good*, he is so beautiful, asks if he's doing alright, if he wants to stop or continue or change anything.

"Phainon..." Mydei whines and turns to face him.

Phainon is stunned as he stands in the face of absolute beauty; the visage of Mydei's pretty face colored peachy-pink with eyes gleaming like a lion's in the dark, pouting with his eyebrows furrowed and his lip jutting out. His mouth is shiny with drool, swollen red by kissing, and awfully inviting. Phainon kisses him quickly before he can say anything else.

"Phainon," Mydei mumbles into the kiss, and then he pulls away, "You said… *My chest.* Touch it."

What a demanding little bird Mydeimos is, Phainon thinks, and for a moment he has half a mind to indulge in the cruelty that streaks through him, that which tells him to deny Mydei for a little while longer, to draw out his pleasure and to make him ask *nicely*. He considers it for a moment. He would very much like to hear Mydei beg, to have him say *'please please please oh please'*.

But they did not discuss it, and he does not know if Mydei would enjoy it at all. He will not spring it on him; that would be very unkind, and Phainon does not wish to be unkind, not ever, but especially not to Mydeimos of all people. So he decided that he shall not do it, and instead give his lover all that he wants.

In the time it took for Phainon to ponder his next move, that half second spent in thought, Mydei has shifted around in his lap enough for his pretty, luminous face to look at Phainon fully. From this angle, he is even more beautiful, like a sweet dream. "Come on," Mydei says, "Do it. You said you would—" and he grabs Phainon's face with one hand and pulls his down, enough to close the little distance between them.

Mydei's pierced tongue lolls to lick into Phainon's mouth, the metal ball clinking against his teeth with a lovely sound. This small, hungry kiss steals his breath away, and when Phainon is pushed back, he finds Mydei looking up at him with a dazed, happy smile. "Your eyes are very beautiful tonight, lover," he tells him, and Phainon feels as though his skin was lit on fire.

Phainon dips down for another kiss with a moan and an accidental buck of his hips. Mydei must've felt it, he certainly did, because he tensed all over before melting into his mouth.

Finally, after being asked *so* nicely and after Mydei has been *so* good, Phainon touches his chest.

Phainon has dreamed of this moment many times, and on that same note, he's fucked his fist to it and soiled his sheets with cum to it, too. He has thought about it since the moment he has first laid eyes on Mydei, that inconspicuous day at work when Miss Aglaea introduced them to each other. Mydei is broad and full of breast and he is proud of them, too. Phainon knows that better than anyone, for he had to sit through Mydei infodumping about chest workouts on multiple occasions; though, to be honest, during those talks Phainon was not really listening and instead just staring at his tits. Mydei boasts about them, has admitted to wearing tight shorts so he can show off all that he has to show off. He's even pierced his nipples out of vanity.

All of that to say, Phainon cannot be blamed for fantasizing about it. He's wondered, over these past few months, how his breasts might feel under his hands, if they would be soft or firm, if Mydei would keen or grunt when he played with them.

As Phainon brings his hands to fully cup Mydei's breasts and squeeze, all of his questions are answered all at once—

First of all, they are soft, very soft, which takes him by surprise; he has expected them to feel as firm as his do. Phainon's breath is cut short by the sight and the sensation of groping Mydei—he watches, with raised eyebrows, how easy that brown skin yields to him and spills between between his fingers.

Second of all, Mydei does not keen *or* grunt, rather he gasps and groans and doubles over on himself. Phainon follows the curve of his body as he bows, encompassing his back as if he were a blanket. Phainon has not done anything at all, and yet Mydei had has reacted so strongly and with so much lust. Phainon knows he, too, is hard, can see his pants tenting from

where he is stood. His instinct tells him to reach over and wrap his arm around Mydei's cock, to milk it to completion and then a bit beyond that, while playing with his nipples—his good sense tells him to not do that at *all*, and so he wills his hand to be good and behave.

Phainon starts to massage his breasts, to roll them in his hands, applying pressure where he is softest and hottest. His fingernails occasionally scrape against a nipple, though not on purpose; Phainon withholds this from Mydei, too, just to see him whimper a little more.

"Mydei," he says in a hushed, low tone, tongue finding his pretty lobe again, "Do you like this? Is it good?"

"It's—okay," Mydei answers with a huff, but Phainon sees the way his stomach tightens in lust and deems that this must be a little more than just *'okay'*.

"Do you feel good? Do you want to take a break?"

"Break…" Mydei trails off, "I did not know we could take breaks. Yes, I would like a break."

So they take a break. Phainon brings them two bottles of water from the kitchen, drinks his and then watched Mydei drink. He wipes off some of the water that got on his chin and Mydei gives him a small smile at that. "Thank you," he says.

"Do you want to continue?"

To that, Mydei just sheepishly nods in stead of a reply. They wiggle around on the bed for a bit as they assume their previous position, Mydei on his lap, back to chest, and they kiss while doing so for as long as they can. He is back on his breast as soon as Mydei settles into him and at this point both of their underwears are, undoubtedly, stained with their precome; Phainon can feel his seep through fabric and he can only be grateful that Mydei cannot see. This kindness, however, is not allowed to Mydei, who is open and exposed to him.

Phainon watches with rapt attention as the first pinch of a nipple makes Mydei's clothed cock throb and bob. What a wonderful body his lover has, so well-shaped and so sensitive besides. "You're unreal," he groans, hazy with it, and rewards Mydei for his prettiness with a hot tongue to his ear. "You're so—good, so *soft*, I can't—I love it so much, I love all of it."

It is all true. He is so wrapped in love that he does not know what to do with it, and so he spills it forth in Mydei's ear, gasping and groaning and letting him know exactly how much he, too, is enjoying this.

Phainon gives Mydei's nipples all the attention they deserve, for they are as lovely as very other part of him, and such a pretty color as well—dusky and dark brown, yet blushed still with a rosy peachy pink hue, the same that now colors Mydei's cheeks and shoulders. They are beautiful and terribly enticing, and so Phainon lavishes them the best that he can with his hands; pinching them and rolling them between thumb and forefinger, pulling and flicking, scraping them lightly with his nails. Mydei grows slack in his hold, though not entirely—he keeps his core tense, on guard, and Phainon does not blame him for it.

"Your fingers—" Mydei says between heavy pants, "Wet them, it f-feels better if you wet them, oh—"

And so Phainon does as is requested of him and brings his fingers to Mydei's mouth, lets him lick them until they are shiny with spit and so moist they drip into his lap. He goes back in then, and now it is all a but more filthy, the drag more delicious, more slippery. If Mydei loved it before, he seems to love it even more now, with the way his back arches to push his chest harder into the touch.

"Good?" Phainon asks at some point, though he cannot tell when exactly anymore.

"Yes," Mydei answers with some difficulty, "It's okay."

'Okay' Phainon scoffs to himself and feels his ego a little bruised.

"Say, Mydei…" he purrs instead, bringing his tongue to lick the corner of Mydei's lips, "Do you think you can come just from this? Have you ever?"

"Uh, I don't—I don't know. I don't think I can cum because, ah, my meds, you understand?"

Phainon does, but he is still going to indulge in the fantasy.

"But would you like to?" he presses on, squeezing a nipple between pointer and middle finger and rubbing it with his thumb. He presses into it with a blunt fingernail and it makes Mydei let out a small, weak moan, as though he were embarrassed of himself.

"Now?" Mydei breathes out, "N-no, not really, I don't—just a little bit more and then…"

"Then all done?"

"Yeah, then all done."

Phainon, in a brief moment of clarity, realizes that they probably should have talked about this, whether this is something that they would like to do until *completion*. It is good to know that Mydei does not wish for it, does not even know if he *can*, and that they are soon nearing the end. "You'll tell me when to stop?" he asks, feeling a crack of insecurity running through him.

Mydei just nods, his lip caught between his teeth, eyebrows furrowed, face flushed. What a sight—what did Phainon do to deserve it?

His heart, where Phainon can feel it under his hands, is beating very, very fast. A bead of sweat drips from his neck, to his Adam's apple, over his collarbones and finally disappears between his breasts. Phainon finds it enticing and awfully erotic, yet his ever-thumping heartbeats worry him. "Mydei, are you… scared?" he asks, and Mydei turns to look at him from the corner of his eye.

"Of course I am. I'm terrified," he admits, and Phainon does not know if that means he should stop.

"Why didn't you tell—"

"I am going to be scared. I cannot help it. This does not mean I don't, ah, enjoy it—I can do it scared. I want to do it even if I'm scared." Mydei places a kiss where he can reach, on the sharp edge of Phainon's jawline. "Just keep going."

Phainon has no other choice than to trust him on this, and so he bends at an odd angle to press his lips to his.

A few more minutes pass before Phainon's wrists between to cramp and though he loves this (oh, how he loves it!), he knows when he is reaching his limit. Mydei's nipples have been thoroughly worked out, bruised and swollen and shining with spit as they are now after Phainon's played with them to the very edge of his ability, and Mydei's pleased little gasps and moans start to take on a more… *Frustrated* tone. It is when the first *'ow!'* comes out that Phainon stops and rests his hand on his stomach.

"Done?" he asks, and Mydei hums approvingly.

"Yes, I think so. Done, yes."

They stay like that for a while, Phainon hugging him from the back, Mydei catching his breath. He is so hard it hurts, but he can withstand it for a bit longer if it meant carrying Mydei's through this.

When they have calmed down, breaths evening out in tandem, Phainon moves to take a good look at Mydei.

He finds him looking out and away at the window, his gaze far and distant, lost as though unseeing. He bites at his lip anxiously and Phainon can tell that something is not quite *right*.

"Mydei?" He brushes some hair from his face. "Are you okay? Was that good?"

"Yes and yes, it was."

Phainon knows it to be a lie, or something like a lie, by the way he slurs his words. He thinks he might be disassociating, or on the precipice of it. "You are lying," he says, and it is not an accusation, but just something he sadly points out.

"Allow me this lie, then. For my sake, if not for anything else. I wish it to be true." comes Mydei's answer, but Phainon is not satisfied with it at all. He rubs his cheek. The flush has gone away from it, and what remains now is a bit pallid.

"Tell me what went wrong or what I did wrong. I want to avoid it next time."

Mydei heaves a great big sigh and rolls from from Phainon's lap, taking his usual place on the bed. He curls up with his back to Phainon and does not answer. Phainon, however, does not allow it. He grabs Mydei's shoulder and shakes him gently.

"Look at me, please," he says, "We have to talk about it so it is right next time."

"It's not, ugh—" Mydei groans in frustration but does, in fact, turn to look at him.

Phainon finds something scared staring back at him, terribly vulnerable like an eggshell cracked open and spilling out. *He* is spilling out, and his eyes are red and puffy with tears that threaten to shed. Phainon clicks his tongue, lets out an *'Oh, Mydei…'* and his heart becomes so tender he is afraid it might fall apart. His hand hovers over the crown of his head, waiting for consent and when Mydei gives it with a curt nod, he rests it among his golden locks.

Mydei presses a little closer to him, then a little more, until his head is on Phainon's lap—thankfully, at some point, his erection has gone down, which makes this whole position more comfortable for the both of them. He rubs his cheek and his jawline, his eyelids and the line of his eyelashes too, and he combs out his hair with his fingers. It has gotten a bit long, though Phainon likes it and Mydei does not think to like it.

Mydei grows more complacent like this, and when he next opens his eyes, his gaze is a bit sharper. "Tell me," Phainon whispers, thumb under his eye.

"You didn't do anything wrong. Nothing went wrong. That is precisely the issue, everything… Everything was great, so then why do I feel so empty now? I feel…" Mydei closes his eyes, "Guilty, as though I've done something wrong, and dirty as if… again, I've done something wrong. I don't know why I feel like this."

Phainon does not know what to say. He never does, in these moments. He wishes he had Mydei's talent at finding the right words to soothe, but alas, he does not and he feels quite worthless for it. He wishes he could comfort Mydei in any way that counted. Instead, he caresses his bicep and says, "I'm sorry."

"You don't have to apologize. It's not your fault."

"I know. I was not apologizing, I meant I'm sorry as in, I regret that you feel this way and I wish you would feel… better."

"It's very frustrating to… to want something very badly and not be able to get it," Mydei continues, burying his face deeper into his lap. "And I have enjoyed it, you must believe it, which is why I am so…. I feel so…" he sighs, "Disappointed. I'm disappointed. I hoped it wouldn't feel like this."

Phainon pinches his nose and squeezes it tight and makes him sneeze. It seems to work for a moment, as he looks up at him, equal parts confused and pissed off. "But was it fun? While it lasted?"

"While it lasted… Yes, it was."

Phainon claps and gives a whoop and while Mydei is still a little confused, he pushes himself up and off the bed.

"Mydei, look, watch this!" He waves his hands around wildly and, when he is certain that he has gotten Mydei's attention, he breaks into a sort of… Interpretative dance, one might call it, and the interpretation is of a very drunk girl having the time of her life at her birthday, or

perhaps her bachelorette party, but then he adds a drop of that dangly robot arm move to it, just to spice it up.

Mydei watches him with his jaw slack, looking neither pleased nor unpleased. Just a bit bewildered. Phainon finished it all off with a *'Tada~'*.

There is a long stretch of time where silence reigns supreme. Mydei's brows furrow, his jaw tightens, and he tilts his head. "Are you… trying to distract me from my trauma?"

"Pretty much."

"Well, you have not distracted me, but you have managed to stun me… Though, I suppose through doing that, you have achieved your goal…" Mydei hums wisely, "Nicely done, Phainon."

Phainon bends over to kiss him and rubs their noses together. He grabs his face and smushes it against his, standing perfectly close to each other, and he says, "Look, Mydei, our noses complete each other~ Your hook and my delicate, petite curved one—"

Mydei hits him in the shoulder and makes him wince. "Haikas, you are an idiot and a rascal to boot. If you want to make me feel better, run me a bath and, hm, join me, yes… Join me and wash me."

Mydei quite enjoys being naked in a bath with him, Phainon realizes, because he demands it often.

Phainon, of course, obeys like a good little dog and makes a nice bath for Mydei, bubbles and bath salts and all. They join together in the tub and Phainon scrubs him clean, though he is not dirty at all. He is very clean, very beautiful, blameless of most sins and though guilty of some, they are not something that demand damnation. They simply make him more whole, like a ripe apple might house a cute little family of worms.

He washes his hair and brushes it out, then goes over it again for good measure before he conditions it. The air fills with all the fruity scents that Mydei likes, pomegranate and mango and strawberry, and though the tension does not ease from his shoulder and his eyes remain a little hazy, he seems content enough. He even sketches a small smile for Phainon. What a beautiful gifts for all of his efforts!

Phainon feels awfully in love and, momentarily, he is very happy. He deems this day an absolute success overall. He went on a first date with Mydeimos and he has kissed him lots. What more could a man want?

They change into clean pajamas and Mydei turns the bedside lamp off. They do not sleep for a few more hours, instead they just putter around in bed on their phone. Occasionally, one will tap the other on the shoulder to show him a funny TikTok or a cute animal.

Phainon finds a picture of two bees sleeping in a flower together, shows it to Mydei and says it's them. Mydei smiles his cocky, handsome smile and says, "Very cute but I would not be a

bee, I would be a lion." Phainon then finds a picture of two baby lions playing, one pulling the other's tail, and shows it to Mydei.

"Yes, that is more like us, and you are the one biting my tail."

When the drowsiness of his meds hits him like a truck and he is nearly asleep, he feels Mydei cuddle up to him and lay his head on his bicep. ″You are very beautiful tonight," Mydei tells him again in a hushed voice, as though it were a secret between the two of them, an echo of what Phainon once told *him*, "And I am very fond of you."

Sometimes in the middle of the night, Phainon is jostled awake by Mydei pressing impossibly close to him. In this half-asleep, half-stupid state, he can vaguely register him trembling against him. Phainon, groggy as he is, does not have the cognitive capabilities in this moment to truly assess the situation, and so all he can do is wrap his arm around Mydei and hug him closer to his body. He feels his face in the crook of his neck and he knows that he is crying, though he does so silently and makes no sound. With one foot in the waking world and the other in dreamland, all Phainon can muster is a slurred, "Mm, maybe we have to start… even smaller…"

And then he falls back asleep.

Chapter 13: ode to ∞

Chapter Notes

And here's the second part. This is my love letter to Cyrene.

S/o to my beta reader Gael who wrote the part starting with "Born with teeth." and ending with "He is still that little boy, grown tall". My favorite writer ever ♡ They also helped me edit Cyrene's poems!

!IMPORTANT!

This chapter is Phainon and Cyrene-centric and therefore comes with **SUICIDE AND ABUSE TWs** Specifics below vv

▶ Click me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Since getting on his meds, Phainon's performance at work tanked. He used to be FLAMECHASE's top performer across all departments and all projects, with the best call time, customer satisfaction percent, best survey results and most feedback from sweet old ladies that he's thoroughly charmed. It used to make him feel like he was *worth* something, though Cipher never really understood why he was trying so hard and she used to call him out on it.

("Y'know, Phainon, you're not gonna get paid more for good performance."

"And YOU aren't going to be paid more for selling products to confused old ladies but here we are, aren't we?"

"...Touche.")

Now, however, he *physically* cannot. He is always a little sleepy. His thoughts come slower to him, flowing like thick molasses. His words are sometimes slurred and customers have to ask him to repeat himself multiple times, which didn't happen before.

There is another component to this decline in performance, however: Phainon simply does not *want to* anymore. One day, when the fog of his brain cleared up and left behind burning clarity, he thought: *hold on, why the fuck am I trying so hard?* Because really, *why?* Good performance doesn't raise his salary, it doesn't pay off his debts, it only makes him tired and burned out. Good performance does not soothe his soul or mend his hurt, it doesn't even make him *happy*. It doesn't even make him feel fulfilled or important or like he's *good* anymore. It just makes him tired. So why, really, is he trying so hard for the same company that limits his bathroom breaks to three in nine hours and makes him announce to the entire Google Teams chat that he's going to take a shit on top of it all. Why is he trying so hard for

the customers that yell at him, berate him, hurry him and quite literally treat him like he's *lesser*—over vacuums and air fryers, for God's sake!

Another player in his newfound laziness is Mydei. It's hard to concentrate when Mydei is right next to him, warm and radiant and as handsome as the sun, his voice low and honeyed while he talks to the customers. He is polite at work, calm and gentle alike, and there's simply this *tone* to his voice during calls that distracts Phainon. It's… self-assured and stable, like he knows what he is doing, boyishly confident. He works while leaned back on his chair, playing with his headphones' wire and looping it around his fingers. He does it like it's *easy*, like he was made for this, like it's no effort at all. Phainon knows, however, that it is actually a *lot* of effort, a herculean amount of effort—that makes it all the more attractive to Phainon. How good he is at pretending, how beautifully his jawline sits, and how gorgeously he glows like polished bronze in the light.

Dating your coworker and desk-neighbour isn't exactly hard or much of a nuisance. They act like they always did, playfighting during their breaks and driving Hyacine to the edge of her sanity. Sometimes, however, after a call, Mydei will slide his headphones off and grab Phainon by the back of his head with no warning at all, pulling him across his desk into a searing hot kiss. Mydei is shameless. Mydei kisses him at work often and, when they find themselves in FLAMECHASE's breakroom, he insists on sitting half on top of Phainon, legs splayed in his lap as he lounges like a lazy lion on the couch, and demands that Phainon feed him grapes. This is not appropriate work behaviour. But, er, Phainon still does it, because he cannot deny Mydei anything. Mydei shoves him into bathroom stalls and kisses his neck until his breathing is heavy, leaving a trail of fresh bruises for *everybody* to see.

It gets to a point where they are called into HR and have to sit across from Hyacine, now HR Lady On The Clock Hyacine and not Friend Hyacine.

"You can't keep doing this," she says, a little exasperated, "It's not appropriate for work."

"Did anybody complain to you?" Mydei rises an eyebrow.

"No, but somebody might so I am warning you to *stop*, because I don't want to go all HR on you."

"Ah," Mydei shrugs, "Okay."

He does not stop after that, but he gets more subtle about it. He plays with Phainon outside on their breaks instead, biting him and licking his lips until they are both half-hard in their pants.

Now that Cipher and Castorice left, their breaks are spent mostly with each other; Hyacine only joins them occasionally, if their breaks happen to match up. Phainon *does* miss dicking around with the girls as he did before, and he especially misses buying lunch for Castorice. Phainon tells Mydei this and he simply cocks his head.

"You can still do that. She lives pretty close by, doesn't she? We can get lunch for her and Polyxia and drive to her place."

Genius!

So, they spend their lunch break with Castorice and Polyxia. They both seem overjoyed by the company and, mostly, by the food. Castorice inhales her giant burger, almost the size of her head, and then helps Polyxia with her food.

"Mydei, you are looking handsomer every day," Polyxia says with a sly smile, *"Phainon… You're also here."*

"Polyxia!" Phainon whines and pouts, "You used to tell *me* I'm getting handsomer by the day!"

"Then simply start getting handsomer. Mydei, show me those biceps."

Mydei preens like a bird of paradise and starts showing off to Polyxia. He poses in all sort of ways to show off his muscles and then starts performing fucking *feats of strength,* like lifting up the couch and fixing their leaky sink—wait, he can do that? He's some sort of *electrician mechanic handyman whateverdude* on top of being handsome, kind, and soft with big tits?

Phainon watches with dark, brooding envy.

"Oh, by the way, I talked with Cipher today," Castorice says as she wipes her face of Mysterious Burger King Sauce, "She'll be out next week. She's been talking about you a lot."

Phainon can't help the streak of cold anxiety that runs down his spine. "That's… nice. All good things, I hope?"

"Yeah, she's excited to see you again."

Before Phainon can open his mouth and show how truly anxious, worried, excited and ashamed he feels, Castorice continues. "Oh, uh, I wrote a new chapter and I want you to beta read it, okay?"

"Oh… okay."

Phainon has gotten into this *habit* of taking naps after work—it works to off-set the drowsiness from his meds and makes it more bearable.

So, after he beta reads Castorice's new chapter which is *just* two dudes going at each other (*"it's pretty good, but they should get tested for STDs" he texts her, and she replies back with "? its the 1800s"),* he clicks his phone off and rolls over in bed for a nap.

He does not dream of Cyrene, not really, but he dreams of a house that is very alike his childhood home, but different in some ways—it is bigger and darker, sprawling, dead. It is scary. Phainon does not see himself, but he knows that he is little, maybe eight or nine years old. He is looking for something, he does not know what exactly, but he cannot find it. He runs from room to room in a panic, looking for this thing, and each room is identical. It is the living room; old bijar rug clogged with dust, dark brown leather couch, his grandma's rocking chair, small boxy TV above the fireplace with a doily—also Grandma's—on top of it. Every times he opens a door, the room loses a defining feature. The deeper he goes, the more

abstract it becomes until, finally, he is standing in an empty sickly-yellow room. The walls and the floor are indistinguishable from each other, and so is *up* and *down*. He steps in and the door shuts behind him.

That is when Mydei wakes him up. He shakes him awake and Phainon rises from slumber with a loud gasp, reaching out to grab his arm. *"What?"* he yells out, "What is it?"

"Why didn't you tell me your sister was odetoinfinity?" Mydei says matter-of-factly, as if that's supposed to *mean* anything to Phainon.

"Sorry, uh, what?"

"Your sister," Mydei repeats himself, voice even and monotone, "Odetoinfinity."

"What sister? Cyrene?" Phainon asks like an *idiot*, still dragged down by the stupidness of sleep.

"Are you perhaps hiding a stash of sisters from me? Yes Cyrene, who else?!"

Phainon rises up to a sitting position, rubbing his eyes and with it, trying to rob his sleep away. He feels weighted as though by an anchor, and both his head and his eyeballs hurt and sting. He looks back at Mydei.

"Start from the top. What is odetoinfinity?"

"You… you have no idea?" Mydei says, mouth a little agape, and Phainon is a little *too* sleepy to entertain this. Being woken up and questioned has made him grumpy.

"I clearly don't, Mydei, which is why I am *asking*. I don't know what you're talking about and I'm not very happy about being woken up."

Mydei sighs and joins him in bed. He shows him his phone. The Tumblr app is open to a certain blog, url "odetoinfinity" and title "As I've Written". Phainon looks at it for a moment. The theme is minimalist, neat, mostly white with a bit of pink—not "cute girly" pink, though, but more like… Meat pink. Pink like a disease. The description is short and a little cryptic, it simply says "*i look through the shard of divinity and do not recognize myself*".

He looks at Mydei for answers. Mydei provides them. "Odetoinfinity is a pretty popular Tumblr poetry blog. It's… really popular actually, I mean, at least in the community. I *loved* it —Cas is a big fan of it, too. I really, really liked the author's poems. I've been following it for… six years now? I've even sent some anons complimenting their writing. They suddenly stopped posting a year ago and I was pretty heartbroken, but I figured they just… moved on or ran out of inspiration or something, but no, it's—It's Cyrene."

That's not possible. It's not possible because Cyrene stopped writing *years* ago. Phainon knows that for sure because she *told* him and stopped showing him her poems and her short stories. Phainon hands back the phone to Mydei and tells him exactly that.

"No, listen, it *is* Cyrene, do you—Have you not checked her Instagram account like, ever?"

"Uh… I mean, not since she died and before that I had like, no reason to," Phainon shrugs, "Mydei, if this is a joke, it's not a very good one. It's making me upset."

"It's not a joke, haikas, ugh! Let me show you, here—" Mydei switches apps to Instagram, where Cyrene's Instagram page is already open. Phainon tears his eyes from it with a big gulp of air as though he's seen some sort of gore or other disturbing image. Seeing her like that, alive and smiling and moving, is far too painful, and so he has avoided her page entirely. Mydei, however, does not allow it and pulls on his sleeve, telling him to *look*. "There is a Linktree link in her bio and if I click it—" and he does, "It brings up some other social medias that she's linked, including Tumblr, and if I click on that—" and he does, again—

Odetoinfinity.

It brings up the odetoinfinity Tumblr page, but that's not—that can't be, because Cyrene stopped writing, she said it was for stupid little girls. Mydei starts to scroll through the blog, telling Phainon to *look, look* but Phainon, though his gaze is on the screen, is unseeing. He does not see, and does not wish to see. He is faraway, distant, and his blood runs ice cold through his veins. His fingers start to itch and his breathing picks up in tandem with the beating of his heart. He is going to have a panic attack.

His gaze only sharpens when he spots a familiar shape. There, as an answer to an ask wondering what book the author is reading at the moment, is a photo of a hand holding up a book. He does not care to read the title of the book because instead he is focused on the *hand*. Dainty fingers, olive skin, elegant long nails, and there on the wrist hangs a bracelet.

'It is not possible,' he thinks, *'It cannot be her.'* Yet still, if the fact that the blog was linked by her was not proof enough, this is—a Pandora bracelet decorated with three charms: a quill, an open book, and a Mem.

That's the one he got for her birthday last year and what could possibly be the odds? Maybe she just linked the Tumblr blog on her Instagram because she was a fan of it too, but this proves it is no coincidence—it *is* Cyrene. That Mem charm was limited edition. Only one hundred were made and he managed to get one just for her.

It cannot be anybody but Cyrene.

"Cyrene…" he says, taking the phone from Mydei again, "It is her. She—she said she stopped writing, she said it was for stupid little girls."

Mydei shakes his head. "But no, she didn't. Her last poem is from November of last year."

Phainon is hit with the cruel realization that, maybe, he does not know her at all. That maybe they were strangers to each other, and just so happened to spend most of their lives together. He wonders why she might have lied to him. He wonders what else she has been hiding from him. He wonders what made him unworthy of her poetry. He likes poetry. He is good at interpreting poetry. He enjoys memorizing poetry and he enjoying finds new poets. They used to talk often about poetry, debating which poet was more of a "chad" (answer: none of them).

So why, now, is he peeking into this intimate, secret life of his sister without her consent and knowledge? Why does she have one in the first place? It was cruel to exclude him from this. He wanted to read her poetry, why didn't he get to? Why did all of these *strangers* do it and not him?

Ah, but he never really looked for it, did he? It was always right there, right on her Instagram, but he never checked because he never had a reason to. When she was alive, if he wanted to see Cyrene, he could simply knock on her bedroom door and look upon her pretty face. After her death, any sight of her was far too painful, like his heart was forcibly being wrenched from his chest.

Why would she do this to him? She knew he was always touchy about being excluded so why now, in death, is she excluding him.

"I don't… I don't know what to say…" Phainon whispers, transfixed by the photo of her hand, "I don't understand why she wouldn't tell me."

"Maybe she didn't want to worry you?"

"Worry me?" he shoots Mydei a look, "Why would a *poetry Tumblr blog* worry me?"

"Well, it's… Her poems are a little… *sad*."

Sad…? He does not remember her poems to be *sad*. She wrote about flowers and trees and warm sunlight. There was nothing sad about them.

Though, now that Phainon thinks about, the poems that she *did* share with him were a little… Impersonal. They seemed to be about what a *child* thinks a poem should be about. They simply were not really about anything of, and may Cyrene's soul forgive him, *substance*.

He looks back at the blog and scrolls all the way to the top. The last post on the blog is as such,

Anon asks: hey!! whats ur favorite poem ever? :)

odetoinfinity:

def "Looking Back" by Ursula K. Le Guin. im also a big fan of "a wizard of earthsea"!!

"Remember me before I was a heap of salt,
The laughing child who seldom did
as she was told or came when she was called,
The merry girl who became Lot's bride,
The happy woman who loved her wicked city.
Do not remember me with pity.
I saw you plodding on ahead
into the desert of your pitiless faith.
Those springs are dry; that earth is dead.
I looked back, not forward, into death.

Forgiving rains dissolve me, and I come
still disobedient, still happy, home."

Whatever engulfs Phainon at this moment is dark and furious and unkind. He grips the phone tight and raises it over his head as if to throw it—he almost does it too, until Mydei's even voice cuts through to him and says, simply, *"Please don't throw my phone".* He lays it gently on the bed instead.

'A heap of salt'... It strikes him now that this is what he has made her—a heap of salt, unmoving, unfeeling, stuck in time, unreal in its similarity but not very similar at that. The Cyrene he remembers is hazy and blurry as though shrouded by a veil and the Cyrene he sees, that vengeful ghost, is a monster. In his mind, Cyrene was good and blameless and always kind. She never got angry, she never yelled, she never spoke hurtfully—he knows that is not true. He remembers very well a moment where she was awfully unkind to him and awfully cruel, but the memory speaks too painfully and it plays in his mind like teeth on a dashboard. Like death.

Has he ever known her? Now that he thinks about it—*no.* Not very well. A part of her was stubborn and elusive and secretive. A part of Phainon never wanted to pry. Sometimes, he thought there was a great big moat separating them. Now he realizes it *is* true but the moat is not a moat, rather it is an ocean drowning in oil and filth. She has been a stranger, and they have been strangers to each other.

"I, uh…" Mydei starts, though Phainon can hardly hear him over the blood rushing in his ears, "I've been following her for a very long time and I could tell that she was… unwell. Sometimes I would—this is a bit embarrassing, but I would send her anon asks telling her to get some help but she never answered them. I don't think she kept this from you on purpose, I think she didn't want to concern you."

"That's not *fair,*" Phainon bites back, "Maybe I wanted to be concerned. Maybe I deserved to be concerned for her. She was—she was always concerned for me. I've never been *well* before, I've been suicidal since I was *nine*. And she was always there for me. And I deserved to be there for her, too."

The tension in his head threatens to burst. When he looks at Mydei he sees him, for the first time, at a loss for words. His thick eyebrows are furrowed, bottom lip caught between his teeth. There is tenderness in his eyes, but it look awfully close to *pity* for Phainon's liking. The air is cool and fresh. Outside the window, the world is grey. Inside this room, it is black.

"Would you… like to read some of her poems? They are… sad, yes, but beautiful."

Would he? In this moment, Phainon does not want for much. He only wants to kill himself and reach the afterlife, then find Cyrene wherever she is and demand some answers out of her. He wants nothing. He *is* nothing. Whatever the pills and the general good trajectory of his life have stayed off comes back now, and he feels like he did back when Cipher and Castorice cleaned his pigsty. He feels like the shame of the moment is worth a thousand suicides.

Why is he so mad? Why is he so *ashamed?* Phainon cannot make sense of it but he feels it nonetheless.

His emotions are a typhoon. Anger and shame and fear, uneasiness and nausea, and among them all, grief reigns supreme. He is sad. That is all. He is sad and he misses her terribly. He is incomplete without her, like lyrics with no melody. Senseless, off-rhythm, and ugly.

Phainon vaguely registers Mydei clearing his throat next to him.

"This is my favorite. It is… more prose than poetry, but still," Phainon looks to him and sees him holding the phone, *"I am become the cracks in the wall, and though I am small, I hope you find me and look upon me with love. I am become the plankton of the sea, and though I am small, I hope the waves carry me gently to bluer waters. I am become the woman in the corner, the burned shadow of Someone Who Once Was, and though I am small, I hope you raise your eyes to the shape of my body and recognize me. And I hope that in your eyes, there goes kindness, and there goes fondness, and there goes the recollection of Who I Once Was, and I hope you find me beautiful."*

Phainon listens, though he does not have much choice. Cold water gets thrown onto the fire of his fury. What is left behind is small and childish and tight in his chest. He does not name it. Naming it makes it real. "Did she write that?" he asks instead. Mydei nods.

Phainon finds it structurally weak, but very sincere. Honest like a smiling, toothless kid, innocent like one, too. He blinks.

But it does not sound like the Cyrene she knew. For her to feel like… Someone Who Once Was. No, that is not how he knew her. He knew her as awfully present. Was she the sort to beg for kindness and for love? She needn't have. Phainon loved her immensely but, perhaps, it wasn't enough. What a revelation. He has loved her in half-measures or not at all, or even more upsetting; he has loved her just enough and she never felt it.

Phainon sighs and leans down in bed. This feels like an intrusion. It feels forbidden.

So be it. Let him be an intruder.

"I find it childlike almost, but beautiful and very melancholy. That was sort of her style, yes… She wrote with a sincerity becoming of a little girl, does that make sense?" Mydei says.

A sincerity becoming of a little girl… does describe Cyrene well, he supposes, but it is not exactly right. "I think rather than a little girl, it is more like… a fairytale. How even awful things are described beautifully in fairytales," he says and Mydei makes an *'ohh'* in response.

"That is quite a good assessment, Phainon. I did not think of it like that. A fairytale… yes, exactly. All of her poems are incredibly romantic. The romance in them… is almost oppressing, like how a corpse smells so sweet it makes you sick."

Phainon blinks. "You think of her that way?"

"Not *her*, I did not know her, but of her poems… Hm, yes, I do. They are very sweet even when they are sad. They are quite heartrending."

Phainon opens his mouth and the words escape without his consent.

"Read me more," he says and clenches his jaw shut the second they leave him. He dreads what he will find, but is awfully curious too. He thinks of Cyrene as a beautiful painting hidden behind varnish, and he wants to know what the original colors looked like.

Mydei finds another poem to read.

Oysters
Dead and harvested; the pearls
Shine brightly, my love, like your eyes when
You look at me with disdain, teeth glittering behind
Your pink lipped sneer.
Jewels glitter purple and blue
Across my wrists, across my neck, my thighs;
Salt crusted, dead, harvested,
You look at me, and
Leave your scarf behind. A wisp of dying smoke
A trail to follow, the morning after,
Another gift, another reason to
Call you in the morning, to see you, to supplicate to you with my hands
As I give it
Back.

And another.

The grocery store shelf on which I sleep is cold and comfortable.
Wrapped in cling wrap, it clings to me, cutting off
My airways, flattening my wings, tangling my hair. I watch
People pass me by, myriad of many faces, shards of glass broken and scattered,
Smiling children shining like stars, fathers wrapped in tinfoil, mothers like sea salt.
I am that which I Am—
—The parchment on which God has written the words of Woman; nose, eyes, fingers, pierced and sacred heart. You have
Forgotten to make me whole. You have forgotten to make me whole. You have forgotten to make me whole.
Malformed, they have caught me, gutted me, took from me that which I must have never owned,
Debased me
And now—
The grocery store shelf on which I sleep is cold and comfortable.

And—

Allow me back in the narrative. Allow me back in the narrative. Allow me back in the narrative. Allow me back in the narrative.

Allow me back in the narrative. Allow me back in the narrative. Allow me back in the narrative.
Allow me back in the narrative. Allow me back in the narrative.
Allow me back in the narrative.
Allow me.
I want to go back to the narrative. I want to go back to the narrative. I want to go back to the narrative. I want to go back to the narrative.
I want to go back to the narrative. I want to go back to the narrative. I want to go back to the narrative.
I want to go back to the narrative. I want to go back to the narrative.
I want to go back to the narrative.
I want.
Please let me go back to the narrative. Please let me go back to the narrative. Please let me go back to the narrative. Please let me go back to the narrative.
Please let me go back to the narrative. Please let me go back to the narrative. Please let me go back to the narrative.
Please let me go back to the narrative. Please let me go back to the narrative.
Please let me go back to the narrative.
Please let me go.

They go on. Tens of poems, maybe hundreds, spawning back years. The words blend into each other like a melody, thus becoming song. Mydei reads well. His accent is pleasant, his voice is like honey over a raging river. Phainon is half lulled to sleep by this entire ordeal, yet the ache in his chest keeps him awake.

With each poem, he peels back another layer of Cyrene. To indulge in his own lyrical sensibilities, he thinks of this moment as a lotus flower blooming petal by petal, opening up like a giving hand, and in the middle of that sweet-smelling bud—there stands Cyrene as he knew her in his youth, a little toothless, all dirty blonde hair and scrapped knees. And this little Cyrene, who must be no older than twelve, looks at him with brilliant blue eyes, smiles big and wide, and starts wailing with sobs.

Phainon knew her to be a social butterfly, full of life, adventurous, impulsive, and prone to flights of fancy. He thought of her often as a princess from a fairytale and, that is to say, *flawless*. The sacred child, hailed as blessed, to whom the duty of *'symbol'* is assigned and whose right to personhood is denied. He thinks that is unfair to her. Unfair of him. His earliest memory of Cyrene is of her bouncing him and feeding him puree. That memory is strange to him now. *Where were his parents?* If he was three, she must have been five.

How dour.

He sees her now as she was, perhaps, lest this too is one of her many masks—he sees her sad, sensitive, insecure and terribly, terrible *lonely*. Has she always been so alone? Has he not been enough? Guilt eats at him and, for the first time in nearly a year, it is not guilt over her death.

It is guilt over her *life*.

Lived in half-measures. Unknown to all. She must have been so sad, the poor thing. He should have tried harder. Should have broken through that barrier and grabbed her.

"Phainon?"

Ah, yes. Mydei is here. Phainon looks at him and finds him looking awfully worried.

"What is it?"

"What do you think of her poems?" Mydei asks.

"…She is no Maya Angelou," Phainon answers simply, "But she does have her way with words. She leaves… a lasting emotional impression, yes. She has made me very sad. I suppose that does make her much like Maya Angelou. And a good poet."

Mydei shifts closer to him and regards him with those burning amber eyes. "That is not what I meant. What do you think of what she wrote?"

"…I am sad," Phainon repeats himself, "I am sad that she felt in such ways. And I am sad that I was not there for her. I would… ask but she never…" he sighs deeply, long-suffering, "She would never tell me. She always said everything is alright."

He reaches for his water bottle on the nightstand. "I am… It's so… I miss her. I never knew her. That is so upsetting. I miss her so, *so* much. I can't bear to part with her, I can't—it's like missing an arm. I am missing my sister. I can't live without her."

"Lots of people live without arms," Mydei points out like an idiot, "And she lives on, in these poems."

Phainon laughs, cruel and disdainful. "A very sad and unhappy version of her."

"But her nonetheless. I like you even when you are sad and unhappy."

He whips around to look at Mydei. "And if I were to die, you would remember me as sad and unhappy?"

Mydei blinks. "I would rather not think about that, given that you have edged suicide for, apparently, the past two decades of your life. But if you were to die, I would like to remember you as you were. That means sad and unhappy, too."

His lover is gracious and Phainon is far too small for this, far too ugly and broken. Still, when Mydei's warm hand goes to touch his cheek, Phainon accepts it like an abused dog, leans into it, nuzzles into his palm.

"Phainon, tell me about the night she died," Mydei whispers.

Phainon does not have the strength for an emotional response anymore. He simply slumps. He hates this. He hates himself. Hates his life. Hates the way every good thing has to end, even this one, this bud of light he has with Mydei.

He is tired. He is so tired. He needs to go to sleep forever, encased in a tomb, and never wake up. He needs to be staked through the heart like a bloodthirsty vampire. He needs to be clubbed over the head with a blunt object or shot through the mouth or forced to his knees and beheaded. He needs to get a terminal disease and waste away for months. He needs to—anything. Anything to put an end to his.

"You'll hate me for it," Phainon says with very little strength left.

"I won't."

"You will. It's horrible."

Mydei grabs his hand. Intertwines his fingers. "I love you when you are horrible, too," he says, a little cheeky and flirty.

The confession, '*I love you'*, does not register to him. What does, is the darkness. The jet black persuasive darkness that he has carried around for a year. This burden, like Jesus and the cross, and Jesus and perfect death.

'I wish you would let me carry some of it,' Castorice has once told him. She did not know what she was asking for. Neither does Mydei. There is so much blood, so much unwellness, so much badness. It is sick and rotten.

Without realizing, Phainon starts to speak.

"It was Christmas and—"

And they were going to a party. They were going to a party and Cyrene was very excited. The party was hosted by one of *her* friends, not any of his. He didn't really have any friends back then. It's not much of a story. They got there at 8 PM and left shortly after. Cyrene drank. A *lot*. She had never been one for alcohol but that night, she picked up bottle after bottle. It wasn't long before she stopped being coherent.

(Phainon sees her swaying on her feet and grabbing onto a wall. She's trying to get… somewhere, and so he walks over and grabs her shoulder. That makes her whelp and jump and turn to face him with all the fury of the sea. Her eyes are dark, tempestuous, disturbed. Her hair is a mess, her bra strap is hanging off of her shoulder. Phainon fixes it for her.

"Are you good?"

"Get the fuck off of me," she bites back, hissing like a snake, "Leave me alone. Mind your f-guh, fucking business, you—" and she points her finger at him in accusation. Phainon notices one of her nails is gone. She must have broken it sometimes during the night.

"Uh…" he tries. He never knows what to do when Cyrene is like this. She's been like this often, lately. "Where are you going?"

"Are you a fucking cop?"

"Okay, you need to actually stop—"

"Or what? Hm? Are you gonna hit me? Hit me, come on! Hit me!" she yells, and Phainon has to physically grab her to shut her up. The music is loud, but not loud enough.)

"She was like that lately…" Phainon tells Mydei. "She was so… mad all the time. So upset. She would always start fights with me and then she'd—she'd get all in my face and scream. *hit me, hit me!* I don't understand it. I *never* hit her before, Mydei, I never laid my hands on her. And neither did our parents. I don't know where she got it from."

("What the fuck is up with you?" Phainon barks back, "People are looking. You need to stop."

"Get the fuck off of me," she groans, slapping his hands away, "Stop touching me, stop, just—go away! Leave me alone!"

"Cyrene, you're not—" Phainon sighs, but he does back off, "Let's go home, okay? You're drunk."

"I'm not drunk." Cyrene clenches her jaw. Her eyes are filled with tears and her mascara is smudged. "Fuck you. I don't want to go home. I'm partying. And I'm going to the bathroom. Get the fuck out of my way."

Cyrene pushes her way past him and starts going down a hallway to, presumably, the bathroom. He watches her leave. Sees her stumble as she has to hold onto walls to stay upright. She nearly falls, but Phainon does not follow, because he can't fight with her right now. He does not want to. He turns around to refill his soda.

Not even ten minutes later, there is a yell coming from the bathroom, loud enough to shake the very foundation of this shitty studio apartment he is in. Phainon immediately recognizes it as Cyrene and, in blind anxiety, he goes after her.

He finds her crying so hard she is choking and holding onto the sink for support.

"I CAN'T DO THIS ANYMORE!" she screams, "I can't—No, no, I don't want to do this anymore!"

Phainon reaches for her like a moth to fire. Like two atoms crashing into each other. He grabs her and embraces her and holds her up. "Let's go home," he whispers into her throat. She is sweaty and clammy and shivering all over. "Oh, Reney, come on, I'll drive us home, okay?"

"I can't… Oh…" Cyrene looks up at him with clarity for the first time this night. Her make up is ruined, but she is still beautiful. She could never be anything else. She sniffles and her face twists into a sob. "I don't want to do this anymore…"

"I know," he says, not knowing what she is talking about. Phainon just knows that she is hurting. He recognizes that pain. He holds her tight to his chest and right now, she seems to small in his arms. So fragile, like a pinned butterfly. She blows her nose on his shirt.

"Oh… Nini…" Cyrene slurs, nuzzling closer, "I want to… I want to…"

"Shh," he shushes her, brushing out the knots in her hair, "Let's go home, okay?"

"Home… yes… Let's go home, please…"

She is so tired. His big little sister. Phainon loops his arm around her waist and starts to lead her out of the bathroom. Outside, five or so people have gathered. Phainon frowns at them. They should not see Cyrene like this, nor judge her. "Enough of that," he tells them, waving his free hand about, "Show's over, fuck off."

The second they step into the living room, it's as though Cyrene remembered she was supposed to be mad. All of a sudden, she plants her feet down and refuses to move. "No, no, NO!" she yells, "I'm not—I don't wanna go home, I want to stay!"

Phainon has to physically force her outside as she kicks and screams. Once the cool December air hits her face, Cyrene doubles over and starts vomiting. Phainon holds her hair and pats her back through it, cooing at her and shushing her and trying to bring some comfort.)

"And then we got in the car. And she was… A nightmare. I don't what got into her. It was as if she could not decide if she was mad at me or apologetic or something. She kept yelling at me, then apologizing, then crying, and then she would yell some more. She—"

("Fuck you, you always thought you were the boss of me."

"You're being ridiculous, Cyrene."

"I can't fucking wait until you move out and leave me the fuck alone. I'm so tired of you. You're always in my business!"

"Oh shut the fuck up, you have no business for me to be in. You're not the Supreme Guardian of Belobog."

"Fucking loser, you're so mean to me all the time!"

"Do you hear yourself? When have I ever been mean? No, no, tell me ONE time I have been mean to you."

"Get the fuck out of my face. Pull over, pull—pull over, I'll walk."

"I won't fucking pull over for you, Cyrene."

"Ahh! Get me out of this car! I don't wanna be with you! I wanna be alone! Why do I always have to be with you?!"

"Oh cuz I wanna be with you all the time, huh. Shut up, stop yelling at me!"

"If you don't wanna be with me all the time, why are you always on my ass like a dog?"

"Nyeh nyeh nyeh, that's what you sound like. You sound stupid. You're such an idiot."

"Move out and go no-contact with me if I'm such an idiot, then! You're a loser!"

"If I'm a loser, then you're a loser too, Cyrene. It's not like you're amounting to anything any time soon.")

"She would—" Phainon swallows thickly. This is where it hurt most. "She would get all up in my face. I was driving and she would almost like, climb onto me, and she'd do that thing where she'd like… Push my head? And she would thrash in her seatbelt like she was possessed. And she… I hated when she did that. She did that a lot lately. She would push me. Not hard and it didn't like… hurt, but it made me sooo mad. Gosh, it pissed me off like nothing else. So she did that to me. She pushed me and then kind of grabbed me and I…"

Mydei squeezes his hand.

"I took my hands off the wheel. I was so angry with her. I took my hands off the wheel so I could push her back to her seat. And…"

Tires screeching. A yell. So little time to react. They spin. He tries to get the car under control but cannot. They roll over three or four times. Pain spreading from his shoulder to the rest of his body. The crunching of bones. A groan of pain, not his, and then—Darkness.

When he comes to, her teeth are on the dashboard.

Phainon gags at the memory. His shirt clings to his body with sweat. The room is suddenly too small, too warm, to suffocating. His hands shake like a bag in the wind.

"I killed her, I—Oh God, I killed her!"

It all comes out of him through bile and vomit. Phainon barely has enough time to bend over the edge of the bed before he is spilling all of the badness inside him onto the floor below. "They didn't—" he manages through wheezes, "They didn't announce black—black ice on—the forecast…"

Phainon feels a hot hand rubbing his back and holding back his bangs. His heart thrums hard against his chest like a beast trying to break free. He is afraid it is going to swallow him alone. He moans and groans where he is doubled over, and then the hand on his back moves up and up. It cups his nape, and then comes more unimaginable warmth, and then—a soft, gentle kiss to the back of his head. "Come on," a voice says, "Get up."

And then he is manhandled and straightened up until he is laying down on the bed. His tearfilled eyes are blind, and yet they still search for the source of this warmth. He sees Mydei, blurry like a ghost, rising from the bed and going to the wardrobe. He pulls out one of his shirts and returns to pat Phainon's face with it. He cleans his face of vomit and sweat and tears, and then he throws it aside. Sits on his legs and grabs his face.

"You're okay."

"N-no, I—You have to, you—" Phainon hiccups, "You have to cut it out of me. Cut it—cut it out, please, please, you have to, you *have* to—"

He grabs Mydei by the shoulders, shakes him hard and well. Mydei tries to shush him. "Cut, stop that, cut what?"

"M… My heart, my—my guilt, you have to take it out of me, I can't—I can't live with it anymore, *please*. Please, I love her so, *so* much, I cannot bear to be without her, my… my sister—"

"You have to calm down," Mydei says, grabbing Phainon's hands and pinning them down to his chest.

"I can't."

"You can. You have to breathe. Look, after me, come on—*breathe*."

Mydei leads him through it, like Cipher once did. Long inhales. Longer exhales. He counts the seconds as Phainon holds his breath and rubs his chest when he exhales.

It washes over him, slowly. The exhaustion sets deep into his bones. He is tired. He wants to go to bed. He wants to go back home. Mydei kisses his brow when his breathing evens out.

Then they look at each other.

Mydei does not leave. He doesn't even look particularly scared. He looks… Concerned, and awfully sad. There is a sorrowful pinch in his brow. Phainon would rather he was yelling and accusing him. He dislikes this kindness. It is unwarranted.

"I killed her," he whispers, just in case Mydei didn't get it.

"I suppose I understand why you came to that conclusion, but Phainon, I—That's it?"

"That's it?" Phainon spits, "My *sister* is *dead*!"

"No, no, sorry, I didn't mean it like that, I meant…" Mydei looks off to the side, then back at him. "Phainon, that was… Really, a series of unfortunate events. Everything that could go wrong, went wrong."

"What?"

"I mean… Her distracting you, you taking your hands off of the wheel, *the black ice*? I cannot believe you think the blame is entirely yours."

Phainon cannot believe it. He blinks at Mydei like a stupid animal.

"What?" he says again.

"She shouldn't have done that. You know, pushing you. Who does that to someone that is driving? That's inappropriate. And dangerous. But she was drunk, so, of course she didn't—"

"It's not her fault."

"I mean, it is. It's not just her fault, though, it's also your fault. You should have never taken your hands off the wheel, you know, but you were frustrated. You weren't thinking. Honestly I thought that entire ordeal would be you drunk driving and crashing the car. I didn't think it would've been so… Accidental."

"I wasn't drunk," Phainon immediately says, "You have to believe me. I was not drunk at all."

"I believe you," Mydei says simply.

Why is he so calm? Why does he not *blame* Phainon? Why does he not hate him? He hates himself for it. He hates himself for many things, but this most of all, he—

"I'm not going to blame you just because you want me to," Mydei simply tells him. Has Phainon been thinking aloud?

"…Why?"

Mydei shrugs. "It was an accident and a tragedy."

"That's not—no, it's too simple when you put it like that—"

"It is simple," and Mydei grabs his hand and places it over his own chest. "Phainon…"

He sighs and his eyes fill with an ocean's worth of empathy. Kind, soft, gentle. "I'm sorry that happened to you. And you have my condolences."

"N-no, that's not—"

"You cannot change my mind. You will never change my mind. It was an accident. You both made mistakes, and… They should have announced the black ice. That, by the way, is grounds to sue."

"S-sue?"

"Yes. That was irresponsible of the city's weather station to not announce. They were *supposed* to. If you had known, you would have driven safer, no?"

"Maybe, but it's still not—"

Mydei squeezes his hand again. Painfully.

"You are not celebrating her," he tells him, "And that is unfair to her. She is naught but death to you, but she was—much more. You've seen, today, from her poems…"

Phainon looks to the window, and sees this year's first snowfall. A slow dance of snowflakes, lazy as if they have nothing to do but fall. They have carpeted the ground in so little time. It is white and bright outside. Beautiful. Cyrene loved to play in the snow when she was little.

"I don't know what got into her," he murmurs, "For months… She wasn't herself. She was angry and anxious all the time, like a… Like a lion in a cage pacing about. She stopped

eating. Got really into counting her calories. I thought she was just trying to be healthy, but… Her shine was gone. Something… something happened. Something happened to her."

Mydei breathes out. "I've been reading her poems for a long time. Phainon, do you… think she was being abused?"

Phainon screws his eyes shut and grits his jaw. "I don't know," he admits, "Maybe. I don't know. I think… She changed when she met this girl, Anna. I have no idea where she met her. I don't know if they were dating, but… Yeah. No, she hasn't been herself since meeting her. But I don't know, I don't—"

"It sounds like she was," Mydei says, hushed, and *that* hurts more than anything ever did. That hurts like a knife through his chest. He cannot help the pathetic whimper that rips out of him. His sister, his Cyrene, hurt like that—he cannot bear it. This pain he cannot bear. This knowledge is too cruel.

And yet, what else could it be? The mysterious bruises. The sudden clumsiness. The constant anxiety. The anger. *Hit me*, she would yell, and Phainon did not know where she learned that from.

He thinks he knows now. He wants to rebuke it, say it is not real, live in the comfort of ignorance.

And yet, could he not do it? For her? Can he not face it? Is he that much of a coward?

Phainon turns his head and looks directly into the maw of the monster.

Cyrene has been abused and her life was cut awfully short.

What misery.

"My sister…" he sobs, "Reney, oh, Cyrene—poor, poor Cyrene, that is so… so awful, oh, my little girl, she was—my sister, and they hurt her, and I couldn't—I wasn't there for her, I'm such a—"

"No, Phainon," Mydei shushes him. Caresses his hair. "She spoke of you often, on her blog. You were very dear to her."

It only makes him cry harder. His hands go to wipe his eyes, and he does not hear Mydei unlocking his phone again.

He clears his throat and reads—

I am happy today because I have a little brother.
He was born with teeth and gave my Mom an awfully big scare!
I love the boy who is my brother, I love him because he has blue eyes like me!
I love him because he is not like other boys.
He does not stink or yell and he plays puppets with me.
I want everybody to see the boy who is my brother!
He is my brother and I love him so much.

Phainon cracks his eyes open. "That sounds like a child wrote it."

"A child did write it," Mydei points out, "She said this is her first poem, from when she was eight years old."

"Her first poe—" Phainon is so taken aback that he cannot help but laugh. He laughs, mouth open, hearty and from his gut. He laughs until his sides hurt, and then he cries some more, and he covers his face with a pillow to stifle his sobs. He is laughing and crying and laughing yet again. What a farce! What joy! The bipolarity of his life leaves him breathless. He wants to rip his skin off and become one with the earth.

"That is not, haahh, not a very good poem at all!"

"She was *eight*, dude," Mydei points out, "And she loved her brother very much."

He clears his throat.

> *I had a good day today. I went to the zoo with my brother and we fed some goats. Sometimes I feel like he is all I have in the world. I love him very much. He is my best friend and awfully handsome. And also stupid.*

"That not a poem," Phainon frowns.

"Well, she didn't just use the blog for poetry. That was just one of her personal posts."

"I remember that day," Phainon sighs, "She was enamored by every animal she saw. She made me pose with each and every one of them, but she wouldn't let me take pictures of *her* and the animals. Hah, I remember, she—she got too close to the monkey enclosure and one of them stole her hat right off her head."

Mydei joins him in laughter. "And what else?"

"One time when she had her anger spells, she was yelling at me and pacing around the kitchen, but she—she forgot that she opened one of the cabinets and she ran right into it. Smacked her right in the forehead!"

Mydei laughs even harder. Phainon does too. His cheeks hurt. "Another one," he demands.

"When we were little, my dad bought this big sack of salt and left it in the kitchen. I saw it first, then ran to her and told her it was sugar. Told her to eat a big scoop of it before Dad gets back. She grabbed like, two fistfuls of the thing and shoved it in her mouth. When she realized it was salt, she started crying and ran to tell on me to Mom!"

"Did you get in trouble?"

"Yes, I got an earful."

Mydei chuckles and kisses him. "Tell me more,"

"One time, I was riding my bicycle outside while she was at school. I was maybe twelve. Somehow, I managed to fall in a ditch. Dude, I fell *hard*. I was all scrapped. I couldn't get out so I spent like, thirty minutes just yelling for help. Then, I heard her chatting with her friends and coming my way, so I started yelling *'Cyrene, Cyrene, help!'* She came running to me all out of breath, saw me in the ditch, and laughed so hard she started crying. Then she and her friends started throwing *mud* at me!"

"Haha, what the fuck? What was wrong with her?"

Phainon hums. Comes off the high of a good laugh.

What remains is hollow.

Scraped dry and left in the sun to dry and bleach.

His sister. Abused. Somebody could have hurt her—probably *did* hurt her. Laid their hands on her and inflicted pain. Made her cry. Made her sour. Made her angry. Made her count her calories. They made her into something she was not, something scared and anxious, entirely lovable but hard to reach.

Right now, he finds that he cannot cry. He wades, instead, through a river of tears shed by Cyrene. How scared she must've been. How much it must've hurt. Why did she never ask for his help? He's strong. He could kill whoever hurt her. He wants to, now. He wants to see bone and blood. Did she think she didn't deserve it? Did she think what was happening to her was right?

Phainon wants to ask Mydei to break all of his teeth. He should beat him to a pulp until he is all purple and blue so that he may understand a fraction of the pain. He wants for violence. He wants catharsis. It will never come. He wants to hug her. It will never come. He wants to lay her head on his lap and stroke her hair until she falls asleep. It will never come. He wants her at home, safe and happy and well-fed. It will never come.

The pain persists. The suffering is endless. There is no place for it to go.

"I don't know what to do with it," Phainon whispers, "With this knowledge. With this… this suffering…"

"You live with it," Mydei says, "There is nothing else you can do."

"That's not fair. She didn't get a happy ending."

"…No, she didn't," Mydei sighs. He rolls off his legs to sit next to him on the bed. There is a deep understanding in his eyes. A heavy sorrow. "Sometimes, they don't. That is… the horror of this. Sometimes it is deadly," and his voice trembles. The next he speaks, it is very small, and very vulnerable, "He killed my mother. She never got to get away."

Phainon's chest cracks with it. "What do we do about it?"

"We love them," Mydei says, "We love them the best we can. We remember them. People like them, the people that hurt them, they *want* them to be forgotten or to be remembered as

scared little things. We have to remember them as they were. We have to remember them beautiful and happy."

Mydei touches his arm. "The point of violence is to erase a person off of the face of the Earth. That is why it is poison. There is no revenge. There is no making it even. My dad is in prison and my mother is still dead. All it did was make me an orphan. And I have a lot of pain for it. I miss my mom. I miss her a lot. Her abuse made her unkind sometimes, but she was brave and beautiful and I loved her. I try to remember her like that. I try to tell people about when she took me to the water park or got me an expensive gift for my birthday. I tell people about how brave she was, how intelligent she was. She liked bunnies. She was one of those moms that decorated the kitchen like a farm and the bathroom like an aquarium," Mydei laughs, "And I love that memory of her."

Mydei sighs. "Phainon, sometimes the suffering means nothing. It is just suffering. And it is not grand."

"That's… awful."

"It is. It's awful," he rubs some tears from Phainon's cheek away, "So do not let it define her. She was not awful. You have to tell people about how amazing she was. You cannot let her be suffering. *She cannot be a wound.*"

"I wish I had more time. I wish I could have helped her. I wish I could have told her I loved her more. I wish we didn't get into that fight. That was a stupid fight."

"Siblings fight. Even I know that and I'm an only child. If there wasn't an accident, you would've slept it off and been best friends in the morning again."

"Ha! Yeah, probably…"

"Your guilt is awfully self-centered. It should not be about you. It should be about *her*. And I think she would prefer that her brother, who was born with *teeth*, be a little kinder both to himself and to her," Mydei boops his nose, "You have suffered enough. If you need to hear it, then here—it was an accident, and I absolve you."

Born with teeth. He wants to bite a chunk out of the world, dig it into the dirt and pull Cyrene from her grave, devour her, absorb her into himself, so she might live again. So she might take his body and do better things with it than he ever could. So he can watch from whatever void is waiting for him and smile and nod and know it was the right choice. Instead, he feels some raspy, hollow noise crumple in his throat.

Mydei holds him until he learns how to cry.

'It would be better if she was here. I wish she was here. I wish she didn't die,' he repeats in warbling tones, off-key, waterlogged. All hideously juvenile statements, but he says them anyway, feels like a boy anyways—clinging to his stuffie, climbing into his big sister's bed, asking her to teach him how to be brave with all the monsters in the world. That he got bigger and broader and, one day, older than her means nothing. That is still his big sister. He is still that little boy, grown tall.

At some point, the crying exhausts him to the point of sleep. Mydei messages Tribios and takes a day off—unpaid, goddamn it—for Phainon.

The next morning, the pain is still there. Hollow and dull, but it exists nonetheless. It must be as Anaxa said. It never goes away. There is a hole and he must grow around it.

He decides that there is no option but to grow. Cutting it at the root kills the last person that knew Cyrene as she was; smiling, mischievous, cheeky at times, intelligent, sensitive, and awfully funny. He checks in with his debt collector. He's still got at least two more years to pay for her funeral. It's no matter. It's a small price to pay for giving Cyrene a beautiful send-off; though, Phainon suspects, she would've much more preferred something more intimate. Sorry, Cyrene. That is simply what he thought was most fitting in the moment.

It feels less heavy, in a way. Not in any particularly *comfortable* way, but, *as Anaxa said*, our sisters are worth the pain of mourning them.

There is no revenge. Her abuser is anonymous. They have tried to wipe the memory of her clean, as if she never existed. Instead, she left ripples behind, small and weak but indisputably *there*. Phainon finds the reflection of his younger self in those ripples. She is next to him. He carries this as he carried her coffin; nobly, with dignity, and sober grief. She is worth it. She has always been worth it.

Her poetry blog… What a beautiful legacy. He calls Castorice and asks if she can bind a book for him like she does her fan fictions.

"Of course I can!" she says, her face a little too close to the camera, *"I can even get Polyxia to draw a cover for it! Would you like that?"*

"Yes, I would."

"What do you want the cover to be?"

"Hmm… A quill on an open book. And one of those Mems from that one fairy cartoon, you know the one?"

"Oh, yeah, totally, I do! Did'ya hear that, Polyxia?"

"I did. You want a book on a book cover? I mean, sure, whatever floats your boat. I'll do it for a cigarette."

"Polyxia, NO! Phainon, sorry, I have to go—message me what you want bound!"

The video call cuts off and Phainon chuckles fondly. He hears Mydei snore in the bedroom.

Phainon takes a sip of his coffee and, as he walks around the living room, he stops to look at the framed picture of Cyrene he holds on a shelf. He grabs it and brings it closer.

This photo is three years old. She's wearing a white summer dress, spaghetti straps and all, and her olive skin has been kissed by the sun. Their first and only beach vacation. Phainon took that picture. She is holding a cocktail in her hand, fancy glass and swirly straw and

orange slice, and she is smiling ear to ear. Her gaze is not at the camera, but rather to the side. Phainon captured her well. The freckles on her shoulders, the dimples they both have, the crow's feet in the corner of her eyes which only showed up when she smiled. The wrinkle in her straight nose, her acne scars, her bushy eyebrows. Her hold on the glass is delicate but firm, and she seems to be half-heartedly playing with the straw. It is an *incredible* candid. Her blue eyes glitter with all the streetlights, a million little pinpricks of light as though the starry night sky above itself was reflected in them.

Phainon loves this picture of her. He looks at it for a long time.

For the first time ever, this unmoving still, this slice of a life shortly lived, seems to be looking back—and in her eyes, now alive, there is a clever, impish glint.

Chapter End Notes

i think this is the only chapter that i cried while writing it. enjoy the 22k word feast.
comment or else bartholos, uhh... idk man. Idk. i miss cyrene

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!